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THE STRUCTURE AND NATURE OF TRADITIONAL INDIAN SOCIAL SYSTEM

VARNA

In the Hindu social system the concept of 'varna' has deeply influenced the interpretation of the 'ethnographic reality' of caste. Varna has been the model to which the observed facts have been fitted. The 'Varna' is a complex term. The layman is unaware of its four groups, viz., Brahmana, (Brahmin, traditionally priest and scholar, Kshatriya (ruler and soldier), Vaishya (merchant) and Shudra (Peasant, labourer and servant). The first three groups i.e., Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya are 'twice-born' as the men from these groups are entitled to undergo sacred thread at the vedic rite of Upanayan, while the Sudras are deprived of it. The fourth division i.e., the untouchables are outside the varna scheme. The layman's view of "Varna', says Srinivas, "is a comparatively late view and 'Varna', which literally means colour, orginally referred to the distinction between Arya and Dasa'. He says further, 'in the Varna scheme of the Vedas there are only four orders and the untouchables have no place in it. But there are references in the Vedic literature to groups such as the 'Chandala', 'Nishada' and 'Paulakasa'.

The term 'Varna' is derived from Sanskrit root 'Vri', which is evolved by Shri Yaskacharya in 'Nirukta'. 'Vri' literally denoting colour, originally referred to the distinction between 'Aryavarna' and 'Dasavarna'. Varna has also been used for choice of occupation. According to Prof. Ghurye... in the Rig-Veda the word 'Varna is never applied to any of these classes i.e., Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaisya etc. It is only the Arya Varna or the Aryan people that is contrasted with the with the Dasa Varna. On the other hand, the Satapatha Brahmana describes the four classes as the four Varnas. 'Varna' denotes 'colour' and perhaps such a concept of Varna springs out of the contrast between the arya and Dasa, referring to their fair and dark colours respectively. However, the colour connotation of the word was so strong that later on when the classes came to be regularly described as Varnas, four different colours became associated with different castes. According to such as interpretation of Varna on the basis of colour, the Brahmins are associated with white, the Kshatriya with red, the Vaishya with yellow and Sudra with black colour. Ghurye held the view that the Rig-Vedic distinction between 'Arya' and 'Dasa' later gave place to the distinction between 'Arya' and 'Sudra'.

However, the Rid Vedic literature gives a description regarding the the division of society into three orders, namely, Brahmin, Kshatriya and Vaishya.

The Brahmin and Kshatriya represented broadly the two professions of the poet-priest and the warrior-chief respectively. the last order was a group which comprised apparently all the common people. It is only in one of the later hymns, in the clebrated purushasukta, that a reference has been made to four orders of society as emanating from the sacrifice of the primeval being. Taittriya Samhita ascribes Varna to four limbs of the creator.

The name of these four orders are give as Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra. Bramha, the creator, said to have been created these four orders from different organ of his body, the Brahmin came from the mouth, Kshatrya from the shoulder, Vaishya from the thighs and the Sudras from the feet of the Creator. The status of a Varna in society is associated with the particular limb of Lord Bramha and its importance. Of course no such interpretation is directly give in the hymn. As regards the traditional assignment of duties to these four orders, the Brahmins are associated with worship and teaching, the Kshatriya with fighting and defending the motherland, Vaishya with trade and commerce and the Sudra with the service of all the preceeding varnas.

Interesting the Rig-Vedic literature mentions three orders in society, but does not have a particular term to describe them. A term which is originally used to maintain the distinction in colour and appearance between the conquerors (Arya) and the conquered aborigines (Dasa) was used later as the basis of hierarchical division of the society.

The untouchables are not covered within the four-fold division of the Varna scheme and as such the fifth division consists of the untouchables. So they are called 'avarnas' or 'panchamas'. But the Vedic literature contains the descriptions of 'Ayogava', 'Chandala', 'Nishada' and 'Paulkasa', who are not covered within the varna scheme and who seem to be despised. It appears to be more reasonable to hold that 'Chandala' and 'Paulkasa', were the sections of the aborigins who were particularly despised by the Aryans due to some reasons. On the contrary, the Nishadas, seem to have gained the likes of the Aryans, probably because of their amenability to civilized notions. The vedic expression 'panchajanah' is explained by tradition, to mean the four Varnas and the Nishadas. It becomes apparently clear that the Nishadas had, towards the later part of the Vedic period, became quite acceptable to the Aryans. Briefly speaking the three classes of the early part of the Rig-Veda were later converted into four groups which became relatively compact. Alongwith that three to four groups which became relatively compact. Along with that three to four other groups were separately found. These

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social divisions were not considered rigid classes during the Vedic period, membership was not based on heredity. Individual's 'guna' (natural traits) and 'karma' (deeds) determined his membership. The Bhagavadgita contains the sayings of Lord Krishna in this regard, "Chaturvrnyam maya Sratham guna, karma vibhagashah." The Mahabharat also mentions the same idea regarding the determination or one's Varna. It says that a person's deed will determine his varna and therefore hereditary occupation should not be followed rigidly. The choice of occupation should be made upon. In the like manner, no restriction prevailed in matters of food and social intercourse among the Aryans. Due to such flexibility in the system, 'varnas' during the Vedic period, were considered 'open classes'.

Manu, the great Hindu law giver, holds the traditional view of divine origin of the 'varnas' from the four limbs of the Supreme being. he considers the Brahmins as the supreme creation. But manu does not support the view that there is a fifth 'varna' in Hindu society. He finds out difference between the two concepts of 'varna' and 'jati'. He attributes the causes of origin of jatis (castes) to the consequences of inter-marriages among the original varnas which were only four in number. During the days of manu, the traditional pattern of stratification became very rigid. Therefore he formulated separate rules for each varna and accorded punishments for violation of these rules. The higher classes got special rights and prerogatives. At the same time they were given special responsibility corresponding to their authority. It becomes obvious when we take into consideration the provision of punishments accorded by the penal authorities. Manu is of the opinion that the retribution made for theft should be of the value of eight times in case of Shudra, sixteen times in case of a Vaishya, thirty two times if the person is a Kshatriya and even one hundred times in case of a Brahmin.

The Varna Vyavastha was a functional pre-requisite for the Hindu social system because of decentralisation of power. The power of knowledge, power of arms, power of wealth and power of labour were distributed among the four varnas in accordance with their position in the hierarchy respectively, i.e., among the Brahmins, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Sudra respectively. Such as arrangement of doing away with the concentration of power in the hands of a particular class served as an antidote to exploitation and despotism. Thus the possible evil consequences of centralisation could be prevented due to Varna Vyavastha. Alongwith the decentralisation of power, rewards were also distributed in different forms. Whereas the Brahmins were rewarded in the form of resepct, the Sudras, at the other extreme, were rewarded in the form of rest. The Kshatriyas and Vaishyas were rewarded in the form of authority and welath respectively. Such a distribution of rewards in the Varna scheme sealed the possibility of localisation of power which is experienced in the present day society. Thus the Varna Vyavastha exhibited a fine blend of the fundamentals of Hindu social organisation, the most significant being division of laobur, decentralisation of different aspects of power, assignment of duties, provision of rewards and the correct position of different values. The system was neither hereditary nor severe. it acknowledged the inherent qualities and tendencies of individuals. Simultaneously, it also had a psychological base, But gradually it became hereditary and rigid, lost its good qualities and degenerated into the caste system.

CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE OF VARNA SYSTEM

Originally the word Varna is derived from the Sanskrit root 'Vri' meaning to 'choose'. Hence, Varna has reference to choice of something relating to occupation. But in the contemporary society Varna System takes its shape of caste form. Choice of occupation based on ability was the basis of 'Varna', but no-a-days caste system is based on birth.

Secondly, we find that originally there were only four Varnas. But in contemporary society, the earlier Varna system has come to be influenced by the 'Jati' or caste. Under caste system the society is divided into a number of small social groups and various strata and sub-strata have come into existence. Thus the fourfold division of 'varna vyavastha' has lost its significance. Originally 'varna' was based on choice of occupation and this choice was also related to the ability caused due to the 'Gunas'. These were classified as : 'satvika'; 'satvika-rajasika'; 'Rajasik-tamasika' and 'Tamsika'. These are said to be represented by the Brahmins, the Kshatriyas, the Vaishyas and the sudras respectively. In the modern context the caste system, which was based on birth, has lost its importance alongwith the concept of 'Gunas'. Of course achieved status is gradually replacing ascribed status.

Thirdly, in the 'varna vyavastha' broad categories of 'varnas' represented the Hindu society. But it had serious shortcomings as it excluded numerous untouchable castes which, in real terms, formed a part of the Hindu society. In the mordern context the scheduled castes are given much importance. Constitutional provisions have been made for their upliftment so as to bring them at par with the other sections of Hindu society. In the 'varna vyavastha' there was no restriction on its members regarding food, drink, marriage and social intercourse. Soon after its degeneration the rigid caste system imposed severe restrictions on these aspects of social life, but gradually that rigidity is breaking down. People are now eroding the restrictions regarding commensality and as regards connubium the intercaste marriage is gradually gaining momentum.

Originally the 'varna vyavastha' was flexible in the sense that it was possible for a person to change his 'varna' by changing his occupation. In ancient period, persons succeeded in changing their varnas. The 'varna vyavastha'

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was an open system and because of that reason upward or downward mobility was possible. Gradually mobility was checked due to caste system and 'varna-vyavastha' lost its importance. Now-a-days change of occupation is allowed but change of caste is not recognised which was possible during the prevalence of 'varna vyavastha'.

Thus, it is found that the 'varna vyavastha' has no relevance in present day society.

ASHRAMA

Hindu Sastra-Karas advocated the idea that mna's life and conduct is influenced by four factors, such as, 'desa', 'kala', 'srama' and 'guna'. 'Desa' is otherwise said to be the regional approach to the study of society; 'Kala' or time constitutes the historical approach to the study of society. Srama (effort) takes into account man with reference to his nurture and development in the contemporary environment, and lastly 'guna' or natural trait, implies the natural inherent psycho-biological equipment of man.

Although the Hindu thinkers have already recognized the importance and significance of 'desa' and 'kala' in the activities and behaviour of man, they have failed to visualize and anticipate all the probable variations of 'desa' and 'kala' which a human being is likely to confront. On the other hand they have outlined a detailed description of 'srama' and 'guna'. The Hindu sages were univocal on the presumption that any scheme of social organization which aims at the best functioning, must, in the first instance, take account of human beings from two aspects. First, the scheme must consider him as a social being with reference to his training and development in the natural and social environment, so that he will be able to achieve the ultimate goal of his existence; and secondly, this has to be co-ordinated with another scheme which visualises man with reference to his natural endowments, dispositions and attitudes. The first of these is the problem undertaken in the scheme of the 'ashramas'.

The word 'ashrama' is originally derived from the sanskrit root 'srama' meaning 'to exert oneself'. Therefore ashrama means (i) the place where exertions are performed and (ii) the action performing such exertions. Literally speaking, an 'ashrama' is a resting or halting place. The 'ashramas', are regarded as resting places during one's journey on the way to final liberation which is the ultimate goal of a Hindu. Each 'ashrama' is conceived as a stage of life in which an individual has to train himself for a certain period and exert himself within the circuit of the same in order to qualify himself for the next. As such every 'ashram' is a step in the long journey towards the ultimate goal. Therefore, Vedavyasa has described in the mahabharat that 'ashramas' are the four rungs of a ladder which takes man in the direction of Brahma.

According to the ashram scheme, taking man's average age to be 100 years, life is divided into four stages of twenty five years each or there are four ashramas such as

(i) 'brahmacharya'-life of a student for first 25 years,

(ii) 'grihastha'-life of a married man from 26th year to 50th year, the householder,

(iii) the 'vanaprastha' -retired life in the forest from 51st years to 75th year,

(iv) the 'sanyasa'-life of an ascetic from 76th year to 100th year of life.

Actually in the beginning, there were only three 'ashramas'. Originally the 'sanyasa' and 'vanaprastha', taken together constituted only one order and later these two ashramas came to be differentiated from one another. Chhandogya Upanishad mentions three orders of life according to dharma; (i) the order of perpetual or life long student residing permanently in the teachers' house; (ii) the householders' order, where the 'grihastha' is expected to perform sacrifices, charity and study; (iii) the order of recluse, where one is expected to perform penance.

However, it was not enjoined that these three stages of life must necessarily be followed one after the other. But it seems that a man could enter the life of a householder only after completion of the process of learning. He may also simultaneously lead the life of a householder as well as student or he could directly become a hermit after completion of his studentship, thus skipping over the 'grihasthasrama'. From the above we may derive that the stage of 'sanyasi' need not necessarily be preceded by the 'grihastha' stage. It is found in the later Upanishadas like the Jabala that four stages of life persist in sequential form. According to jabala the studentship stage must precede that of the 'Grihastha'. the 'Grihastasrama' must be followed by the order of the hermit, while the order of ascetic must necessarily be preceded by those of the grihastha (householder) and the hermit (Vanaprastha).

According to the Hindu Dharma-Sastras every individual should necessarily pass through these four phases of life, in sequential manner, and if he desires to attain salvation, he must have to live in them according to sastric provisions. In order to get moksha one must pass from one ashram to the other, should offer sacrifies with senses under control, give charity to others, should practise deep meditation and become blessed.

The first stage of life of an individual is Brahmacharya-shrama. This Brahmacharyashrama is marked by the intiation rites or upanayan ceremony. Brahmacharya literally means the leading of life according to Brahma. Therefore through the Upanayan ceremony the novice is introduced into the

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Brahmacharyashram because prior to initiation life was undisciplined and unregulated, a meaningless one. It is called so because man follows his inclinations in behaviour, speech and eating. Life of a man become disciplined only after he undergoes initiation rites i.e., 'Upanayana' ceremony which gives the spiritual birt. There is also provision regarding the particular age at which the individual gets initiated. A Brahmin is initiated at the age of eight, Kshatriya at the age of ten and Vaishya at twelve years of age. However, it may be postponed to twelve in case of a Brahmin, to fourteen in case of Kshatriya and to sixteen in case of a Vaishya. But in any case, they will have to undergo 'Upanayan' ceremony within these age limits.

The students stays at the teacher's house, 'Gurukala', which marked the beginning of schooling in the Vedic texts. The student not only performs his study, he is also asked to perform various types activities assigned to him by his teacher. Such activities include collection of alms for his teacher, looking after his cattle, collection of fuel etc. The teacher was impressed only when his student succeeded in pleasing him by performing his activities perfect. When the teacher was convinced that he had evinced a real desire for study in his student, he unfolded the 'Vedas' to him. As 'Vedas' embody the cultural traditions of the Aryans, it was thought necessary that these traditions should be transmitted from generation to generation. The study of 'Vedas' was given so much importance in man's life that an old person was not considered the senior member of the family rather a child who learned the Veds was believed to be the father of the uneducated father.

In the Brahmacharyashrama, the most striking aspect of disciplined life of a student was his high reverence for the teacher. The student used to go to bed after and get up before his teacher did. He should have to sit carefully in his presence. it was believed that if he failed to please his teacher in the daily rounds of duties he would become an ass in his next birth; and by falsely defaming him he would become a dog. The main reason behind such behaviour-pattern between teacher and student was to restore a deep sense of regard in the mind of student to his teacher.

Dharmasastras and Manusamhita prescribed a number of rules and regulations concerning a student's daily routine activities and a list of qualities that fitted him for studentship. A student had to get up early in the morning before sunrise. If he was asleep when the sun rose, he had to utter the 'Gayatri' and fast for the whole day. He was restricted to take his meals only twice a day. Overeating was avoided. The student was not allowed to take meat, honey, salt, sweet things or betel leaf or food that was stale. he should go about without carriage, without shoe or umbrella. he should refrain from anointing his eyes and embellishing his body with ornaments and should never use scent. he should maintain a clear distance from the women.

In Brahmacharyashrama, the individual has to surrender his life of sense, mind and intellect i.e. all the itellectual and emotional apparatus-to-the handling and moulding by the teacher. During studentship one was taught to restrain his senses. The control of the sex-instinct was prominently stressed in the control of his senses. As such every individual going through this stage was expected to observe complete celibacy. Therefore this stage of life was called Brahmacharyashrama. During this phase of life, the students are marked by certain characteristics, such as, growth of the body, emotional stability, the development of sexual functions and stimulation of sexual activities. Hence, this is the period of stress and strain of impulsiveness of strong self-expression. Owing to this reason, the Hindu sages chalked out plans to regulate the life of a pupil in such a manner that would be conducive to balanced development of the adolescent. Proper discipline was prescribed for the mind as well as body. The pupil used to learn to engage his mind in more worthy pursuits. He was discouraged to think in terms of bodily decorum and comforts. He was expected to direct his energies to purposeful activities.

The student was always taught that the spiritual side of life was more important than material aspects in the early stage of life. Therefore man should learn to mitigate the material needs as far as practicable.

Differences of opinion prevailed regarding ages at which one is expected to enter into each ashrama and the period of life he is expected to spend in it. after the completion of prescribed education in Brahmacharyashram, in the first twenty five years of life, the youth enters the grihashrama, that is the time when he is fit to marry with the aims of 'Dharma', 'Praja' and 'Rati' - meaning religiousity, procreation and satisfaction of sexual urges respectively. Although personal gratification is one of the ends of marriage, it is given the least importance. Due to this reason, it should not be the guiding principle of life. The major aim of Hindu marriage is 'dharma'. To fulfil his 'dharma' the married man performs five mahayajnas (five great sacrifices) in the sacred fire enkindled at the time of marriage. According 'Manusamhita', these great sacrifices to the Brahman was made by the recitation of the Vedas, Pitras by 'Sraddha' (offering of water and food), Gods by burnt oblations, butas by 'bali' offerings and man by reception of guests.

In the beginning entertainment of guests was considered a moral obligation. But at a later stage entertaining the guests was give a high honour because the guests were equated with god. But it was Manu who looked it upon as yajnas.

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Various duties were assigned to the householder in his daily round of routines. The householder provided food to persons and animal. he was supposed to give gifts to Brahmins, fees to students, alms to an ascetic, medicine to the sick and donation to the poor. he was expected to feed the guests, the newly married women, infants, sick persons and pregnant women. "It is because men of the other three orders are daily supported by the householder with gifts of sacred knowledge and food that the order of the householder is the most excellent order.

According to Manu, the other three ashramas attained fulfilment through the Grihasthasrama and lived on its help just as all the big and small rivers became fulfil upon meeting ocean. he also held that just as all begins subsist on air, so do all being take life from the Grihastha ashram. Gautama Dharmasutra also maintained that the Grihastha ashram is the foundation of all the ashramas. This was considered so because the obligations of a householder embraced to considered so because the obligations of a householder embraced to the wider groups of persons and beings rather than confined to his family.

The sacrifices which a householder perform in the domestic fire have different implication and meaning. These are directed in the interests of wider community rather than concerned with personal gain of the sacrificer. By performing 'Panchamahayajnas' the Grahastha broadened the scope of his social obligations. Dharma and praja, the more important aims of Hindu marriage, reminded the householder, how much more he had to live for others than for himself and that the proper utilisation of wealth consisted in distributing a part of it to serve the needs of his fellow beings.

The grihasthashrama is given a high place of honour of all the four ashramas. All obligations of life, including the individual and social as well as all there 'rinas' (Debts) the debt to the gods (Deva-rina), the debt to the ancestors (Pitra-rina), the debt to the sages (Rishi-rina) could be satisfied by a person living a full life in grihastha.

Smitris, also bestow the highest praise upon the Grihasthashrama. It is so because all the ashramas subsist by receiving support from the grihastha and due to the fact that men in other three ashramas are daily supported by the householder with sacred knowledge and food, the grihastha's is the leading ashrama.

Alongwith the glorification of Grihasthashram in terms of its absolute superiority over all the others, it forms a particular position which that ashrama grihastha is exalted on the grounds of its lending support to other three ashramas, the practice and cultivation of all the three Purushasthas, viz., 'Dharma', 'Artha' and 'Kama' as well as of its direct contact with society and the consequent direct contributions made by it to the society. So in 'Grihasthashram' alone can three purusarthas be practised together and the three 'rinas', such as the paternal debt, debt towards teachers and debt towards gods could be repaid.

After the completion of the householders duty ad fifty years of age, man entered into the third stage of life i.e. 'Vanaprasthashrama'. At this stage of life man began to perform the five 'Yagnas' or sacrifices according to his ability in the forest. As regards the performance of duties this stage is more or less similar to that of the householder.

However it is very much different in respect of discipline. Discipline was given much more value in the 'Vanaprasthashrama'. It is the discipline that prepared a man for achieving the renunciation of familialities and social relations through a gradual process. He must satisfy his hunger by eating roots and fruits available in the forest. In case of non-availability of roots or fruits, for sometime, he will live on water or air. He should not touch sweet things or meat. The hermit should expose himself to heat of the fire in summer. he should live under the open sky and should wear wet clothes in winter. For his clothing he will have to use the deerskin or the bark of a tree. "He should make no deliberate attempt to obtain bodily comforts. The hermit must maintain celibacy, sleeping on the floor, residing under a tree, without any attachment to where he happens to reside. He should not accept charity from others. Alongwith the disciplines of the body which was thought necessary for the sublimation of his instinctive and intellectual life, he should widen the scope of sympathy from narrow family bounds and village to humanity at large. In addition, he should utilise his time in studying Upanishadas and Vedas and practise penances for purging of his body. The qualities and virtues he needed to cultivate as a hermit were self-restraint, friendliness, charity and compassionate attitude towards all creates. The presence of the wife in the forest was permitted in order to facilitate the performance of his social duties. the hermit through his duties ceased to be a members of family, village and home but above all he was considered as a member of wider society. he may not participated. his life was dedicated to the welfare of community at large, as disinterested and detached individual. It is a life devoted to meditation and contemplation, a life of enquiry and searching. In this 'Vanaprasthashrama', 'dharma' and 'moksha' become the main concern of life, 'dharma' occupying the highest position.

In the last, stage, after twenty five years of conditioning in the 'Vanaprasthashrama' the man enters the 'sanyasahrama' i.e. life of an ascetic, casting off all attachment with the world. Manu enjoined that the men enter this stage immediately after the 'grihasthashrama'. Quoting from jabala Sruti, Kullukabhatta said "one should complete

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'brahmacharya' and enter 'grihastha's order, after that he should enter 'vanavarastha', and then he should take to 'sanyasa' or else, he may take to 'sanyasa' directly after 'brahmacharya', or after the 'grihastha' stage is completed. A person is also allowed to enter 'sanyasashrama' either after 'vanaprasthashrama' or directl after 'grihasthashrama'. At the time of entering this ashrama, a person takes the vow that "I have completely, from this day, bidden fare well to all desires and anxieties regarding son, wealth and the world." All living beings may be made fearless by me." As regards the practise he should beg once in a day. He must not want to get a large quantity of alms. He should go to bed when people have finished their meals, when no smoke ascends from kitchen, when the remnants in the dishes have been removed. He should not feel unhappy when he canot obtain something or rejoice when he obtains something. He should not insult anybody and should have patience to bear hard words. He should not become anyone's enemy. he should have cordial attitudes towards others. he should not tell lie and always utter truth. He should not show anger against an angry man. He should care neither for living nor death. By restraint of his senses, by destruction of love and hatred and by abstention from injuring creatures, he becomes fit for immortality. A person recognises the supreme souls by deep meditation. By passing through the 'sanyasashrama' all the sins of man are washed away and destroyed. Through meditation and contemplation man attains the ultimate end or goal termed as 'moksha'. According to Gita, 'Moksha' can be achieved by cultivating detachedness to wordly things. The man in this stage was mainly concerned with his own realization of spirituality.

So it can be concluded that the ashrams are, as a school of life at various phases of human existence, devised and organized, towards the best likelihood for the individual to attain 'moksha' in accordance with the theory of the ultimate nature of human beings. The functions of group and individuals differe from each other in different stages of life. So in the first stage i.e., 'Brahmacharyashrama', the function of the group is to look after the individuals. In the second stage i.e., 'grihasthashrama', the individual has to look after the group, he is the trustee and manager of the social estate, of the social mores and of the three rinas. The third ashrama is, once more, a largely neutral phase from the point of view of the individual, as well as of the group. The feeling of separation from the ultimate or god begin to make itself felt at this stage. And in the last stage, the individual who is now completely free from any social obligation has to help himself in the search of the 'self'.

IMPORTANCE OF ASHRAMA SYSTEM

The ashrama scheme of life deals with various stages of life and describes that certain actions are to be performed at difference stages of life. The ashramas are the resting places where exertions are made and the prescribed duties are performed. The ashrama vyavasthas indicates that the journey of life is very long and an individual needs different stages for resting in his long journey, towards the ultimate goal of life i.e., the salvation or attainment of 'mokhsa'. Thus the ashrama system, in its social implication, tells us about the ultimate goal of life. In the 'Mahabharat' the references have been made to the duties in 'ashramas'. Kautilya has also mentioned that it should be the duties of king to see that his subjects follow the four 'ashramas' and Kautilya has also made provisions to be followed in case of violation of the code of conduct of the 'ashramas'. He apprehended that the society would come to an end due to chaotic situation. Therefore, people should follow the code of conduct as laid down in 'ashramas'. Then only the world will progress. P.H. Prabhu holds, in this regard that "the ashrama system should be considered as not only the means to further the best ends of organizational stability but also social progress." The Hindu Ashrama scheme thus entails an integral approach to human life. It provides the base for the realization of all the purusharthas such as 'dharma', 'artha', 'kama' and 'moksha' in one's life. It makes provision for the all round development of moral, material, emotional and spiritual aspect of an individual. Upholding this view point Vastayan says that a man should gain knowledge in childhood, sex satisfaction in youth and thereafter attend to duty and strive to attain liberation in old age. The whole ashrama scheme deals with the nurture or training of the individual and the purpose of training is such that man is able to discharge all his social obligations effectively and at the same time be in a position to enable himself to attain moksha or salvation.

CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE OF ASHRAMA SYSTEM

Ashrama scheme of life maintained the balance of social and individual development. In the history of human society and as the most unique system it has an eternal value. But looking at the scheme in our contemporary society it becomes apparently clear that the scheme has lost its relevance.

In the present day society, it is not possible to impart modern education through the traditional 'Gurukula' system of education. It is impossible on the part of a 'Guru' (teacher) to impart modern education in all its highly developed and specialised branches in such a large scale as required by modern society.

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The student may not be expected to be like the one contemplated in Ashrama scheme of life under the impact of sensate culture and stress and strains of modern society. In contrast to traditional 'brahmacharin', the modern student is more volatile, less disciplined and has less self control.

In the ashram scheme 'dharma' and 'moksha' were given highest place. The Hindu, householder was advised to regard 'Artha' and 'Kama' as means and not ends. But, today, due to the influence of materialistic culture, 'artha' and 'kama' appear to have been the ultimate goal in life.

Much importance was given to 'dharma' in the ashrama scheme of life. But now-a-days it is very difficult to attach much importance to it for a modern man. Under the sway of sensate culture and cut-throat competition, people become more and more materialistic day by day.

Religion played an important role in the minds of man in the 'ashrama' scheme of life. But due to advancement of science and technology man is becoming more and more secularised. The modern man bothers less about attainment of 'Moksha'. There is a change in the priority of Purusharthas in present day society. 'Artha' and 'Kama' are the main goals of life rather than 'dharma' and 'moksha'.

In modern urban-industrial matrix a man cannot undergo all the four ashramas. Modern man may experience two ashramas only such as, Brahmacharya and Grihastha. He has lost sight of other two Ashramas, namely, 'Vanaprastha' and 'Sanyasa'.

So it can be concluded that the Ashrama scheme of life has lost its relevance in modern society. Modern man has become more concerned with sensual pleasures and material possessions than with religiousity and salvation.

PURUSHARTHAS

The Purusharthas are described as the psycho-moral bases of Ashram theory. They are concerned with the understanding, justification, management and conduct of affairs of the individual's life in relation to the group in and through Ashramas. These help the individual in getting psychological training and preparing himself to deal in the actual society. According to this theory four purusharthas are there as aims of life, viz., 'dharma', 'artha', 'kama' and 'moksha', 'moksha' represents the end of life, the realization of an inner spirituality in man. 'Artha' refers to the acquisitive instinct in man and signifies his economics- wealth getting activity. It stands to express human prosperity. 'Kama' refers to the instinctive and emotional life of man and provides for the satisfaction of his sex drives and aesthetic urges. 'Dharma' provides a connection between the two, the animal and the god in man. The fourfold aims, thus, seek to co-ordinate and balance the activities of man for the realization of his spirituality. These 'purusharthas' are considered psycho-moral bases of 'ashram' system because along with the provision of psychological training through different stages of life in terms of lesson in the use and management of aims of life, the Individual also deals with the society by translating these lessons into action.

The first and highest aim of life is 'dharma'. it is a comprehensive concept which comprises all the forms of human activity. The word 'dharma' is derived from the sanskrit root 'dhri' meaning 'to hold together, to preserve, to support, to bear', 'to nourish.' The social implications and meaning of dharma as a principle for maintaining the stability of society is brought out by Srikrishna in 'Mahabharat'. In 'Mahabharata', Srikrishna tells Arjun what 'dharma' should be. He explains that 'dharma' is created for the well being of all creatures. he also further stated that 'all that is free from doing any evil to any created being is certainly 'dharma', for indeed, 'dharma' is created to keep all creation free from any harm." Srikrishna also gives a comprehensive view of 'dharma'. "He told that 'dharma' is so called because it preserves all that is created. 'Dharma', then, is surely that prineiple which is capable of preserving universe'. According to the Bhagavadgita "Dharma Rakshati Rakshitah". He who follows Dharma is protected in turn by Dharma.

'Dharma' knows that 'Kama' and 'Artha' are means and not ends. A life that is dedicated to the unrestrained satisfaction of these urges is undesirable and even perilous. Therefore it is essential that the institutional should be regulated by the ideal of spiritual realization and that is exactly what dharma is required to do. By regulating the acquisitive and emotional drives in man, it makes the enjoyment of life consistent with man's spiritual progress. Dharma is the central concept of all our social institutions. It signifies the totality or entirity of privileges and obligations in different stages of life. According to the Hindu view, Dharma exists more essentially for the community and most of all for that universal self which is in each of us and all beings.

'Artha' refers to the satisfaction of acquisitive instinct in man. In general it relates to wealth and material well being. According to Zimmer "It includes the whole range of objects that can be possessed, enujoined and lost and which are required in daily life. The Hindu thinkers have rightly viewed the persuit of wealth as legitimate human aspiration and have accorded the place of 'artha' as a scheme of life. Kapadia holds that 'by recognising 'artha' and 'kama' desirable for man, the Hindu sages indicated that man unfolded his spirituality only when his life was not economically starved or emotionally strained". Again the reality of the world preached in the Upanishadas loses its significance if these temporal interests are not fulfilled and asceticism or

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renunciation of this world and things wordly are applauded as in Buddhism. But acceptance of sex instinct, emotional urges and economic drives as necessary and even desirable, never undermines the supreme goal of life. The ultimate end of life, 'moksha', is always held high and anyting coming in its way must be abondoned. Prabhu holds the view that 'Artha, is to be understood as referring to all the means necessary for acquiring worldly prosperity, such as wealth or power. Kautilya has considered 'Artha' as the main among Trivarga. According to him, in Trivarga 'Artha' is the most important, since both 'Dharma' and 'Karma' depend upon it. 'Artha' is desirable because a man has to maintain the household and perform the dharma as a householder and therefore temporal interests were allowed for the smooth running of day to day life. Thus 'Artha' plays a stellar role in maintaining human life and 'dharma'.

'Kama' implies desires in man for enjoyment and satisfaction of the life of the senses, including the sex drive. The desire may also mean the desire for early possessions. Pleasure is given a place in the scheme of Hindu life, but the pursuit of pleasure when unbridlled, can be detrimental to the individual as well as society.

According to Prabhu 'Kama refers to the native impulses, instincts and desires of man, his natural and mental tendencies and finds its equivalent, we may say, in the use of the English term "desires", "needs", "basic or primary motives" "urges", or "drives" and the collective use of the term "kama" would refer to the totality of the innate desires and drives of man. In its broader sense it is used to include socially acquired motivation too.

Kama as the satisfaction of the instinctive life is recognised as one of the aims of marriage along with dharma and praja. It is given the least importance in marriage. It is said that sex is the first to go if one is to be renounced. According to Radhakrishnan "The Hindu ideal of marriage is essentially a fellowship between man and woman, who seek to live a creative life, a partnership for the pursuit of the four great objectives of life." Bertrand and Russel holds in this regard, "the essence of a good marriage is mutual respect for each other's personality combined with that deep intimacy-physical, spiritual-which means a serious love between man and woman, the most fructifying of all experiences". 'Kama' is given the lowest place among the valuable ends of marriage, because sex finds its meaning in procreation. Kapadia holds the view that "Kama does not mean only instinctive life, it means emotional and aesthetic life as well. The aesthetic in man expresses itself in both creation and appreciation of all that is fine and sublime. man is by nature creative, and the best part of his personality is stiffed if he is not give an opportunity to the creativity in him. The appreciation of all that is beautiful expands and enriches man's life. Repression of emotional expression recoils on the health and sanity of the individuals. The healthy development of the personality calls for the expression of the emotions. For proper channelling of this the theory of Pururthas does by prescribing the modes and measures of their expression.

These three Prusarthas, already discussed, are known as 'trivarga'. 'Dharma', 'Artha' and 'Kama', are respectively known as moral, material and mental resources, accessories and energies available to man. From the 'trivarga', 'Artha' and 'Kama' refer to two of man's earthly belongings. But 'dharma' stand on a higher level. At the lowest level of abstraction, 'Kama' is understood to be in the sense of pure sex drive. But at the same time it is essential both for the production of children and for the continuity and perpetualness of the race. Importance is also given to 'artha', as without it the human being cannot maintian his life which constitutes the material means of living, Yagna and sacrifices can also be possible only with the help of wealth. Wealth is also required for attaining knowledge and immortality. Therefore the exact quality and quantity, the place and the time of 'artha and 'kama', ought to be determined. But the proper functioning of 'artha' and 'kama'. In this regard Vidura in 'Mahabharat' says "It is by the help of dharma that the sages have been able to cross the world." It is the balancing factor. The stability of the universe rests on 'Dharma'. 'Artha' and 'Kama', too, depend upon Dharma is the foremost of all; artha comes next in the order of 'Trivarga' and 'Kama', it is believed, is the lowest of the three. Therefore, human beings ought to conduct their lives with self-control; keeping in view the dharma.

The ultimate end of the life of Hindu is said to be 'moksha' or the liberation of the soul. It represents the end of life, the realization of an inner sprituality in man. It refers to the appeals of the inner man to the individual, unaffected by the group. According to K.M. Kapadia 'Moksha means that the true nature of man is spiritual and the mission of life is to unfold it and to derive thereby the meaning of joy of it." P.H. Prabhu holds, "from the final purpose and meaning oflif,e Moksha alone would prove to be the best guide. The purification and perfection of the 'atman' by pious acts and devotion to God is the aim of man in this world. Moksha or spiritual freedom is possible by inquiry into the true nature of the 'atman' and by founding the whole life of power and truth of the 'atman'. The trivarga becomes the means for the varied facets of human nature, such as, instinctive and the intellectual, the economic and spiritual and the emotional and aesthetic aspects. Therefore they have attempted to coordinate the material desires and spiritual life. These various interests in man may apparently appear to be contradictory and inconsistent but

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their expression is much needed for unfolding truely human qualities. The Hindu aesthetic view of life pre-supposes that "the material hopes and aspiration, the instinctive urges, the emotional and aesthetic outpourings stand in the way of man's attainment of salvation or realization of inner spirituality." On the contrary, the Hindu thinkers have accepted man's satisfaction of sexual urges, his love of power and prosperity, his thirst for aesthetic and cultural life alongwith his hunger for the rention with the Supreme Being. They have recommended the fulfilment of such urges for the healthy development of man's personality. The Hindu thinkers donot consider those as barriers in the way of man's striving for realization of 'moksha'. "The Hindu thinkers view that the struggle of life consisted, in evolving a harmonious blending of these different colours; a melodious symphony of these diverse tunes. This harmony constituted the integrated personality. The normal life was conceded its full expression and the attainment of spiritual progress was sought by assigning proper values to each of them and by prescribing the mode of its expression."

'Moksha' literally means deliverence. Thus it is deliverence from all types of pans and sufferings, both worldly as well as other-worldly. It is a pure bliss. It is the liberation of soul from the cycle of birth and death. it is the achievement of other-worldly welfare and the unity of the 'Atman' with 'Brahman'. it is the realisation of an inner spirituality of man and therefore is of the highest value. The Hindu thinkers attempted on a scheme and proper mode of process through which the spirituality of man is unfolded. Indian philosophy maintains a harmony in metaphysics, epistemology and axiology. All these aim at the same reality which is 'Atman' in man 'Braman' in cosmos and liberation as value. While all other aims are relative, 'moksha' is the ultimate end. According to P.H. Prabhu, 'Moksha, on the otherhand seems to be concerned mainly with the individual. It refers perhaps to the appeal of the inner man to the individual, unaffected by the group. it is perhaps too personal an outlook than defines the struggle and hope and justification within the individual for 'moksha'. This mystic realisation has been in the Mahavakyas of the Upanishads such as Tattvamasi, Aham Brahmasmi etc. it is the state of identity between Atman and Brahman. "The goal of moksha does not possess the narrow individual outlook, for the Hindu. Nor it is to be pursued exclusively and directly by an individual unless and until he has duly satisfied all his social debts or obligations." Forgetfulness of this truth is ignorance which results in the bondage. Bondage is the cause of pains and sufferings. Emancipation from this bondage depends upon the realization of the original truth of the identity of 'Atman' and 'Brahman'.

THE RINAS

The Hindu social organisation has laid emphasis on the concept of Rinas or debts alongwith the aims of life (Purusharthas) and stages of life (Ashramas). It is believed that after taking birth each and every individual undertakes certain obligations. An individual has obligations towards his parents who bring him up from his childhood after sormounting all the difficulties. One is also obliged to ones teachers and sanits, etc. who guide the course of life of a child by imparting knowledge to him and making him capable of doing all work efficiently in this world. A person is also burdend with the debts towards the gods. Thus the Indian thinkers have accepted mainly three types of debts, such as

(1) Parental debt (Pitri Rina)

(2) Debt towards teachers and saints (Rishi Rinas) and

(3) Debt towards gods or (Deva Rinas).

As regards the repayment as the debts. 'Pitri Rinas' can be repaid by way of begetting children and looking after them in the way they were looked after. The Hindus should treat the children very nicely and extend their guidance, love because the offsprings alone will continue the race or otherwise the race will be totally extinct. In the like manner, each and every individual, the seer and teachers are to be remembered because they are the makers of life. They would make future course of his action in the desired manner. Therefore every individual should express his obligations by respecting the Rishies and teachers. The repayment of debt also includes the study of the Vedas and obedience of laws of Brahmacharya Ashrama. 'Deva Rina' or debt towards gods can be paid off by performaing different yagnas and offering sacrifice in accordance with the provision of Dharma.

After coming into this world, every Hindu owes these obligations and cannot hope for liberation unless the repays the debt. The concept of debts conveys the lesson of unselfish discharge of duty and sense of responsibility. P.H. Prabhu holds that "the one who fails to carry out any of these obligations due in him during the first three Ashramas is not entitled even to try to attain moksha" Manu, the great Hindu law giver, is of the opinion that "he who seeks moksha without fulfilling his duties in the first three Ashramas will sink low to damnation."

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CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA

ORIGIN OF CASTE SYSTEM

The exact origin of caste system remains a matter of surmise. Therefore in spite of the prevalence of a number of theories, no one properly explains it, some scholars state that caste system has been mentioned in the records of the Indo-Aryans culture for the first time. The Indo-Europeans or Indo-Germans, they unprised the Anglo-Saxons, the celts, the Romans, the Spanish, the Portuguese and the Iranian among others. It is belived that a branch of these people came to India about 2500 B.C., known as Indo - Aryans.

Many a western and non-Indian scholars have described the Origin of Castes in their own ways. Whereas Herbert Risley has attributed the racial differences to have been the cause, Nesfield and Ibbeston explained its origin due to occupational factors. Abbe Dubois stressed on the role of the Brahmins in the creation of caste system. J.H. Hutton referred to the belief in 'Mana' as the Origin of Caste. In addition, various theories of the Origin of caste system have been formulated. Some important theories are :

(a) ***Traditional Theory :*** This theory owes its origin to the ancient literature. It belives that caste has a divine Origin. There are some references in the Vedic literature, wherein it is said that castes were created by Brahma, the supeme creator. He created different castes for the harmonious performance of various social functions for the maintenance of society. According to the Purushasukta hymn of the Rig Veda, the Brahman is supposed to have been born from the mouth of the Supreme Being, the Kshatriya from the arms, the Vaishya froOrim the thighs and the Sudra from the feet of the creator. The emergence of four castes from different parts of Brahma's body is only a symbolic description and is indicative of the work performed by each of them. It considers caste as a natural determined organisation of social functions and explains one's birth in a particular caste in terms of the doctrine of Karma as well as dharma. Since the Brahmin has come out of the mouth, the seat of speech, his duty is to serve society as a teacher and also to preserve his Cultural heritage. Arms symbolise strength. Hence, the duty of the Kshatriya is to defend the society from internal and external aggressions and rule the land. The duty of the Vaishya who comes out of the thighs is to provide food for the members of society and look after its economic well being. The feet serve the body. So, the prime duty of the Sudra who is born out of the feet of 'Brahma' is to serve the members of other castes without grumbling or grudging. Thus the purpose of creation of each caste is to perform specific functions according to the creation of God "brahma and as such castes cannot be changed due to human will. The supporters of the traditional theory of caste cite instances from the Manusmriti, Puranas, Ramayana and Mahabharat in support of their argument of four-fold division of society. As regards the origin of a number of castes, it is belived that those have been formed as a result of the hypergamous or hypogamous marriages between the four original varnas The 'Karma' and 'Dharma' doctrines also explain the origin of caste system. Whereas the Karma doctrine holds the view that a man is born in a particular caste because of the result of his action in the previous incarnation, the doctrine of Dharma explains that a man who accepts the caste system and the principles to the caste to which he belongs, is living according to Dharma It is believed that the person living according to his Dharma is rewarded. On the contrary, the violation of one's own dharma yields punishment. Confirmation to one's own dharma also remits on one's birth in the rich high caste and violation gives a birth in a lower and poor caste.

Attempts have been made to explain the caste on the basis of qualities or 'gunas' which are interpreted in terms of two Mfts 'gotrika' and 'namika'. The 'gotrika' quality is concerned with heredity. The individual, on the basis of his birth, inherits from his lineage, which is commonly found among all other consanguinous kins. The 'namika' qualities are the individual's own specific qualities. Thus the 'gortika' relates an individual with a particular group and determine his ascriptive status. This ascriptive status accords him membership in a particular 'jati' or caste.

This traditional theory has been criticised on three counts. First it attributes the origin of human beings of four varnas to a divine being and thus considers it as a supernatural phenomenon which is biologically wrong.

Secondly, it treats four 'varnas' as four castes, which implies that caste system and varna system are all the same. This conception is wrong. In this regard M.N. Srinivas holds that the idea of caste as the four fold division of society represents a gross over simplification of facts. The real unit of caste system is 'Jati' denoting an endogamous community with more or less defined ritual status and occupations traditionally linked to it.

Thirdly, the tracing of the origin of caste to miscegenating or 'Varna Sankara' is also misleading. It is possible that some castes have been formed as miscegenation, but it is not correct to say that all the castes have been formed due to miscegenation.

(b) Theory of Cultural Integration : This theory has been propounded by Sarat Chandra Roy, Roy is of the opinion that caste is an outcome of the interaction between the Indo-Aryans, varna system on the one hand and the tribal system of the Dravidian on the other. Thus S.C. Roy holds that

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caste system evolued as a result of integration and assimilation of different cultures like the Aryan's. 'Karma' based varna system and the tribal system of the Dravidian occupational division of society etc ; As the number of etnic groups increased the caste system began to grow more complex.

(c) Occupational Theory : Nesfield regarded Caste system as the natural product of the occupational division of Hindu Society. In his own words "Function and function alone is responsible for the origin of caste system". He holds the view that in the beginning when there was no rigidity, each individual was free to have occupation of his choice. But gradually with the rigidity in the system, occupational changes came to a halt. Castes were identified on the basis of fixed occupation. Persons in noble occupations, such as educating the people, fighting in the battle field, trade etc. were considered as members of superior castes. The others were treated as persons belonging to inferior castes, such as the Sudras. In support of his theory, Nesfield cited the example that the occupation of artisans working in metals is ranked higher than basket makers or some other primitive occupations which do not involve the use of metals.

However, this theory is not free from criticism. The line of attack is that occupation is not the sole basis of causing caste differences. Wide variations are also marked in respect of the position of agricultural castes in different parts of India. Whereas in the South these agricultural castes are rated lower, they are regarded as relatively higher and respectable in North India.

(d) Political Theory Some thinkers are of the opinion that not race but political convenience and manipulation by those wanting to retain authority resulted in the origin of caste system. The Brahmins were solely responsible for creating and maintaining this system so as to retain authority. In the words of Dr. Ghurye "Caste is the Brahminic child of Indo-Aryans culture cradled in the land of Ganges and hence transferred to other parts of India by Brahminic prospectors."

Abbe Dubois thought that the caste system is an ingenious device made by the Brahmins for Brahmins. Brahmins imposed restriction on food and social intercourse to preserve their purity necessary for the sacerdotal functions. They also accorded high status to themselves and declared all others inferior to them. The Brahmins also held that "Whatever a Brahimin says is a social norm and the entire property of the society belongs to the Brahmins." The salvation of individuals or society lied in the performance of religious rites by the Brahmin only. The Brahmins even added the concept of spiritual merit of the king, through the priest or purohit in order to get the support of the ruler of the land.

However Hutton has made scatching attack on the Brahmanical theory of the origin of caste on two counts. First, it is not possible to accept this theory unless it is confirmed that Brahmins must have got the political power to implement such a scheme. Secondly, such a deep rooted social institution like caste could hardly be imposed by an administrative measure. Of course both the arguments of Hutton appear to be illogical because Kshatriyas have ruled over the land through the entire period of history and furthermore imposition of superiority over others by the Brahmins may not be possible through administrative measure. The best explanation may be the appeal to the religious sentiments of the people.

(e) The theory of Mana : J.H. Hutton has propounded the theory of 'Mana' in the formation of castes. This has been supported by Roy, Rice and Swart also. 'Mana' is a supernatural power whirtfcpossesses the capacity to do good or bad to people. The tribals belive that 'Mana' is attached to objects, places and even to individuals. The tribals also believed that this myterious impersonal power can be transmitted through contact and social intercourse.

Tribal belief in 'Mana" is always accompanied by the belief in value of taboo. Each 'Mana' has its corresponding taboos. Taboos arc required to provide protective measures. Taboos are imposed on comnenselity, inter-marriage, interaction, etc. to save the members of one tribe from the 'Mana' of the other tribe. Tribals consider the food of the other tribe perilous due to the belief that food and contacts may be infected with the dangerous soul matter of others. Hutton's argument is that caste elements were existent in India before the Aryan invasion. In his study of certain tribes east of the Naga Hills, Hutton found that in this area each village was an independent political unit and occupations were distributed by villages. Some villagers were adepts in pot-making. People belonging to other villages were weaving cloth. Some villages were having blacksmiths. The villages had interdependence on each other through barter system of their products. Hutton suggested that this has probably been the state of affairs throughout pre-Aryan India. The exogamous clans started migrating from one village to another due to political, social and natural disturbances. The villages also welcomed such migration because it was benificial for them in respect of the non-availability of particular trade. The migrants were not allowed to practise the profession of the village, where they got settled, because the professions were tabooed.

The tribals believed that if the strangers were allowed to practise the ancestral occupation of the villagers, that would displease the ancestors. Since the ancestors were believed to have possessed the 'Mana', they would destory the crops and fruits of the earth. Hutton has also cited the 'Mana' principles in other religions like Buddhism, where it appears as 'iddhi'. In Islam such beliefs are known as 'Kudrat'. In Hinduism it is analogous to 'Shakti.'

Thus, Hutton has come to the conclusion that the fear of 'Mana' led to the restrictions on occupation, food, drink

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and marriage, because it is believed that 'Mana' would be transmitted through such contracts. As a result caste system originated.

Criticism : The theory of 'Mana' has been criticised on two counts. First, India is not the only country where the belief in 'Mana' existed. But in no other parts of the World it created the caste system. Hence the belief that the theory that 'Mana' produced caste system appears to be misleading. Secondly, there is no evidence supporting the existence of caste system hi India alone.

(f) Racial Theory of Caste : Herbert Risley is the most ardent exponent of racial theory of the origin of Caste System. Other jupporters of this theory are the scholars like Ghurye, Mazumdar, Westermarck and others. According to this theory caste system came into existence due to clash of cultures and the contact of races. The Aryans came to India as conquerers, because of their better complexion, physical appearance and built up of the body, in comparison with the non-Aryans, the Aryans placed themselves as a superior race over the non-Aryans. Thus the Aryans considered the natives as inferior to them and maintained their own ideas and ceremonial purity. The Aryans got married to the non-Aryan women, but refused to give their own daughters in marriage to the non-Aryans. The offspings born out of such marriages were called the Chandal. The Chandals had the lowest position in society. Thus the irregular unions between races and racial superiority were held responsible for the origin of caste system in India.

Risley has mentioned six processes of development of caste system.

(i) ***Change in traditional occupation :*** When a caste or a sub-caste changes its traditional occupation and adopts a different one, it ultimately develops into a distinct caste.

(ii) ***Migration :*** In the past the transport and communication system was not developed. Therefore whenever a section of caste migrated from one region to the other, it faced difficulties in maintaining contacts with the earlier place. In course of time it was delinked with the parental caste.

(iii) ***Customary changes :*** From the earliest times, the formation of new castes was based on the rejection of old custom and usages and acceptance of the new practices and habits.

(iv) ***Preservation of old practices :*** Some caste groups are interested in maintaining their old traditions and on those bases they separate themselves from the rest of society who follow relatively new customs and traditions. The caste groups preserving old patterns may take up anew names. This results in the formation of new caste.

(v) ***Getting into the folds of Hinduism :*** Certain tribes or the section of the tribes enter into the rank on Hinduism by *(a)* changing their lineage, *(b)* by accepting the tenets of any school of Hindu religion, *(c)* by joining Hindu religion and by establishing relations with the Hindus without changing its name. Thus the tribes transform themselves into castes. The examples of the Rajbanshies of Bengal and Maria Gonas of Madhya Prwlash may be take ne in this regard.

(vi) ***Role of religious enthusiasts :*** Separate sects are created by the riligious enthusists. They preach their doctrines and attract people towards them. Gradually their followers develop into a new group. Kabir was be taken as an example in this regard.

Ghurye's view : G.S. Ghurye also traces the Origin of caste system to race. He has associated caste system with Brahmanic system. The system originated in the Gangetic plains due to the conquest of the Aryans. According to him the conquered race began to be considered as Sudra. The Sudras were excluded from all religious and social activities of the Aryans. The Aryans did not allow them to participate in Indo-Aryans social activities. According to him "the Brahminic variety of this Indo-Aryan civilization was developed in the Gangetic plain. I, therefore conclude that some of the important aspects of caste originate in this region." He writes, "Multiplicity of groups and the thoroughness of the system was due to the habit of the Hindu mind to create categories to carry things to their logical end, a characteristic manifest in the literature, philosophy and religious creeds." Ghurye believed that it is this multiplicity which has resulted in the formation of castes and sub-castes. In this regard he adds, "the various factors that characterise caste society were the result in the first instance of the attempts on the part of the upholders of Brahminic civilisation to exclude the aboriginals and the Surdras from religious and social communication with themselves.

Risley's View : Herbert Risley held the view that the caste system originated due to the emigration of Indo-Aryans from Persia. In Persia the Indo-Aryans were divided into four classes and the migrants in India wanted to retain the same class structure. At the same time they wanted to maintain distance from the non-Aryans because they considered the non-Aryans inferior to them, both in cultural and racial features. They practised hypergamy with the non-Aryans, but did not allow hypogamy with them. Even then more stray cases occured. Thus three distinct classes emerged in society : *(a)* Endogamous marriage of the Aryans *(b)* Hypergamy and (c) Stray cases of exogamy. Such marriage practices resulted in the origin of castes.

Majumdar's View : According to D.N. Majumdar the origin of caste system may be traced to the 'varna' or complexion. Initially there were only three classes on the basis of

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complexion. These three classes were formed out of the inter-mixing of Pro- Draividian and Proto-Meditrranean races. The intermixing of different races arose out of the acquisition of Dravidian wives and the desire for a settled life. D.N. Majumdar writes in his book, "Races and culture in India." The actual mention of caste system in Avestan literature as comprisiming of the priest, the charioteer, agriculturists and the artisans and an identical division of society in ancient India may point to common origin of the caste system, specially, because the Indo- Aryans are only branch of the same race which moved towards Persia." In course of time the higher castes took to certain professions and the lower caste abstained from practising those professions of the higher castes. Restrictions were imposed on marriage. Gradually the superior castes maintained social distance from inferior castes. The inferior castes got themselves organised to stake their claim in the caste hierarchy. The formation of hierarchy became the basis of origin of caste system.

Criticism : Racial theory cannot be accepted as the exclusive theory of the origin of caste system in India. Caste system should not be confined to India. It should be found in all such societies which have experienced the conquest by other racial groups.

Secondly, it is quite natural that whenever two or more distinct races come into contact, some sort of segregation results. But this may not always lead to untouchability.

Thirdly, the practice of hypergamy may be a reasonable factor contributing to the formation of the caste system. But this is not the sole reason. If we relate the origin of caste exclusively to the race, it will neglect many other possible factors.

(g) Evolutionary theory : Denzil Ibbeston has presented this evolutionary theory of Origin of caste system. The theory implies that the caste system did not come into existence all of a sudden. It is the consequence of a long process of social evolution. The caste system emerged slowly and gradually. The factors which contributed to it, included desire for purity of blood, devotion to a particular profession, theory of Karma, conquests of one army by the other, geographical location and isolation.

However, this theory has failed to provide a correct explanation for the origin of the caste system, for, though the same condition existed in other parts of the World, caste system did not evolve there.

Thus a multiplicity of theories have been advanced from time to time, explaining the origin of caste system. But no theory has been completely convincing. This is due to the complexity and fluidity in the caste system. Hence, it is safe to conclude that the Indian caste system cannot be explained through mon-ocausal theories. It is the natural result of the interaction of geographical, social, political, economic and religious factors.

FUNCTIONS & DYSFUNCTIONS OF CASTE

FUNCTIONS OF CASTE

1. ***It helped in maintaining purity of blood :*** Members of each caste follow endogamic restrictions in marriage and as such purity of blood is maintained. This is perhaps the reason that even today pure Aryan race is found in India.
2. ***It resulted in efficiency :*** In the caste system, members of a particular caste followed their ancestral occupation. Therefore, from the very beginning a person tried to attain utmost efficiency in his occupation, which he was to follow throughout his life. Furthermore, he enjoyed the benefit of accumulated experience which the ancestors had acquired after being engaged in the occupations for a very long period of lime.
3. ***It helped preserving culture :*** Each caste had its own customs, rituals, traditions and ceremonies etc. and took pride in maintaining those cultural aspects. The cumulative effect of it was that the nation was in a position to preserve its culture and civilisation. It will not be wrong to say that if India is today in a position to preserve its ancient culture, it is primarily due to the caste system.
4. ***It created division of labour :*** The rationale behind the origin of the caste system which will be very close to scientific theories about the origin of the caste system is that it helped in the division of work. Each caste was required to perform the work assigned to it. The Brahmins were engaged in teaching, the Khatriyas in defending the land, Vaishyas in trade and commerce and the Sudras in serving all higher castes. Thus division of labour was the mainstay of the caste system, which greatly helped the smooth functioning of the traditional social system. The lower castes had to be contented with their occupation due to the doctrine of Karma, which held that one's deeds in the previous life were responsible for his present birth in a particular caste.
5. ***It enforced discipline :*** The caste system resulted in the maintenance of social and professional discipline. Thus was the apprehension that if social discipline was violated, one would earn the displeasure of difference castes. Again the members were affraid of the fact that if professional discipline was not cared for, they might earn the wrath of the professional community. Due to this reason they had to abide by the disciplinary regulations and the caste system, thus, helped in enforcing social as well as occupational discipline.
6. ***It provided a basis for civilised society :*** Prior to the introduction of the caste system, there was no discipline in the society. It was only due to caste system that discipline prevailed. The people began to lead a regulated

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life with respect for proper conduct. Thus the caste system laid the basis of a civilised society which ultimately became reponsible for the growth of disciplined and well-established order in the social system.

7. ***It developed the spirit of cooperation :*** The members of each caste developed a sense of unity for their own caste group. The feeling that any invasion by other castes on their superiority or any attempt at degrading their customs, rituals and traditions etc. will be disastrous for the caste unged them to work in close cooperation with one another. In this manner the caste system developed a sense and spirit of cooperation and this provided the infrastructure for the advancemeent and betterment of the society.
8. ***It produced good citizens :*** It made an individual well-behaved, well-disciplined, and cooperative. It intilled in him the spirit of mutual help and made him ready to perform his work and discharge his responsibilities properly. Thus it provided all the attributes of a good citizen.
9. ***It preserved the society :*** Due to the rigidity of the caste system the members of different castes did not like to take a risk either by mixing with outsiders or by having contact or communication with them. Establishing relations with outsiders was avoided. Thus the system checked infiltration of all outside cultures and preserved our social system despite many invasions and pressures on our culture and society.
10. ***It saved wastage resulting from competition :*** In order to be established in a better vocation or profession, people waste much time in competitions. In the like manner time is also wasted in adjustment of life. But the caste system conferred a fixed social status on the members of different castes and thus one was well-established in accordance with one's birth in a particular caste. Hence no one was required to decide the occupation to follow in future life. As such no time was wasted in competition and the energ}' so saved was used for constructive purposes.
11. ***It raised the standard of living :*** Due to the caste system, members belonging to different castes made great -efforts to maintain their superiority and position and thereby the caste system raised the standard of living of the people belonging to a particular caste. This, in turn, raised the standard of living of each caste which was of great help to the society.
12. ***It generated the panchayat system :*** Under the caste system, each caste had its own panchayat and a disputes arising among the members of a particular caste were decided by caste panchayat. In course of time this system became very stable and contributed to the evolution of the panchayat system. Even today, this panchayat system has been accepted as the ideal system in India due to its agrarian and rural structure.
13. ***It maintained political stability :*** The caste system acted as the political stabilizer in the sense that despite several changes and political upheavals, no significant influence could be exerted on the Hindus. The cultural pattern was preserved irrespective of the changing political set up and S.C. Hill has said in this regard that the caste system prescribed and determined a form of social order which was entirely independent of the form of political government. Another reason for political stability was the fact that there was no motive on the part of the ruled to seek an alternation.
14. ***It fixed the social environment :*** Another advantage of the caste system was that it provided a fixed social environment wherein one's own behaviour was controlled by premanent association. It also helped the selection of the lifepartner within one's own caste. Moreover, the caste system provided employment by fixing up the traditional occupation and thus fulfilled the economic needs. In toto the system fixed the social environment and generated a feeling of security for the individual.

DYSFUNCTIONS OF THE CASTE SYSTEM

Though the caste system initially performed its positive functions well; in course of time it became degenerated and instead of doing social good it caused a great harm to the society.

1. ***It hindered national unity :*** The caste system developed a parochial feeling and made the people unduly conscious of their own castes. Many a time caste interests were given priority over national interest. Thus the whole system stood against the very concept of national unity.
2. ***It stood against democracy :*** The caste system ran contrary to the democractic spirit. Democracy presupposes human equality, but the caste system believed in inequality and there was a hierachical arrangement wherein the Brahmins were at the top, whereas the Sudras were at the lowest rung of the ladder.
3. ***It resulted in suppression :*** In the caste system the lower castes were suppressed and repressed by the higher castes. The Sudras were very ill-treated and they were not allowed to come to the public places. Even their shadows were considered profane by the higher caste people. Inter-dining and inter-mixing with the lower castes was not allowed. Thus the system was solely based on exploitation of the lower castes.
4. ***It hampered national development :*** Under the caste system only a few got the scope to control the national life and the others were engaged in serving the higher castes, like the Brahmins and the Kshatriyas. In the national interest it is essential that all the sections of

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the society should contribute to the social welfare, but the downtrodden sections did not have any voice in national development and advancement.

5. ***It resulted in treachery and the ultimate fall of the Hindus :*** In a traditional caste-ridden society, the Sudras were fully aware that they could not prosper in the Hindu society. As a result, at the time of invasion by outsiders, some of them leaked out the strategic secrets to them. They also cooperated with the invaders instead of their own people. Their treachery ultimately became responsible for the fall of the Hindus.
6. ***It resulted in religious conversions :*** The dominance of Brahminism became intolerable on the part of the Sudras, who were the most neglected people in the Hindu society. They were easily allured by the ideology and philosophy of Islam as well as Christianity. Many of them embraced the new faiths. In this way the caste system contributed to the expansion of Christianity and Islam in India.
7. ***It undermined the ability and aspirations of the people:*** Since in the caste system one's status and role are fixed up from the time of one's birth, one's ability, personal endeavour or diligence became meaningless in order to bring about any transformation. Acceptance of one's own hereditary status became mandatory and unquestionable. Thus the aspirations and ability of people were relegated to the background in the caste system.
8. ***It created a false sense of prestige among higher castes :*** The higher castes believed that they had the monopoly of wisdom. They felt that all other castes should consult them and work for them. This created a wide gulf between the higher and the lower castes.
9. ***It resulted in the creation of a class of idlers :*** The Brahmins, being at the top of the caste hierarchy, were supposed to teach and preach religion. But in course of time they became apathetic to their avowed profession and did not devote themselves to this task. They knew it very well that they would not be thrown out of their castes, despite their insincerity. As a result, they began to live on the labour of other castes without any useful contribution to the society. Thus a class of idlers came into existence in the Hindu social system.
10. ***It resulted in the introduction of untouchability:*** The worst aspect of the caste system was untouchability. The untouchable suffered from various social, economic, political and religious disabilities. In the name of religion, they were throughly exploited in the most inhuman manner. The lower castes were placed in the category of untouchables. Their children were never allowed to be educated and they were compelled to take unclean occupation. The Sudra women were prohibited from wearing dresses in the manner the Brahmin women dressed themselves. They were not allowed to use public well, ponds, places of worship etc. The fear of the wrath of God and religious conventions made the lower castes follow all the religious prescriptions and proscriptions.
11. ***It gave a lower status to women :*** In the caste system, the women were utterly neglected. They enjoyed a very conservative and traditional type of status. They were denied the privilege of higher education. They could not voice their opinion in public affairs. The women belonging to the higher castes led a still more precarious life due to the practice of child marriage and prohibition of widow remarriage.

    In desire for a male child, women produced more and more children which affected their physical and mental condition. Sometimes the lower caste women were sexually harassed by the higher caste males but they could not protest against them due to the prevailing social pattern. In a nutshell, women enjoyed a very low status in the caste system.

CHANGES IN THE CASTE SYSTEM

Changes in the caste system can be viewed from various angles, such as the structural change, the functional change, the attitudinal change and changes relating to caste restriction.

STRUCTURAL CHANGES

Structural changes pertain to the changes in the hierarchial arrangement, *i.e.* the supremacy of the Brahmins and the suppression of the untouchables and other backward classes.

1. ***Decline the the supremacy of the Brahmins :*** In the traditional caste system the Brahmins were at the apex of the social and religious spheres and thus they enjoyed supremacy over others. But due to the processes of secularization and westernization, the authority of the Brahmins gradually declined and they ceased to enjoy the traditional respect and honour in the society.
2. ***Changes in the caste hierarchy :*** Traditionally each caste was maintaining its own style of life and the higher castes maintained a better life than the rest. But in course of time the process of sanskritization started. Sanskritization is a process in which a status group aspiring for upward mobility in the system of social stratification tends to emulate the life style of the higher castes and its acceptance within the great tradition of sanskritic norms and varna system. The lower castes followed sanskritization to bring about a change in their social status. In Northern India, many Sudra castes demanded a higher status. After sanskritizing themselves, they wanted to put on the sacred thread in order to register themselves in the census as members of the Kshatriyas or Vaishya Castes.

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3. ***Safeguards to the Harijans and OBCs :*** A policy of protective discrimination has been accepted by the Govt. of India. This aims at making various provisions for the Harijans in the spheres of entry into educational institutions, getting into jobs, representing in the legislature etc. That apart, the practice of untouchability, in any form, is banned. As a result, the position of the Harijans is gradually improving in the social, economic and political spheres.

FUNCTIONAL CHANGES

Changes in the traditional functions of castes

1. ***Changes in the fixation of status :*** The status-indicating function of castes has undergone changes due to the process of secularization, westernization and materialistic attitude of individuals. The ascriptive status based on caste and birth has lost its ground and the achivement pattern has gained momentum.
2. ***Occupational changes :*** In a caste-ridden society occupations were hereditary and an individual's birth into a particular caste determined his occupation for ever. But when the rigidity of the caste system broke down, occupational changes were also marked.
3. ***Changes in the sphere of culture :*** The impact of the west and the process of sanskritization acted as the external and internal forces of cutltural change in the traditional Hindu society. This manifested itself in the changed style of life of different caste groups, their modes of living, patterns of worship and performance of rites and rituals, customs and traditional practices.
4. ***Changes in eugenics :*** The rigidity of endogamic rules in marriages has undergone changes due to the changed attitude of people, legal support, romantic fallacy etc. the caste barriers have broken down and inter caste marriages are practised, resulting in heterogenous composition and inter-mixture of different castes. Thus, a fundamental function of the caste system, i.e., to maintain purity in blood, has lost its significance.
5. ***Changes in the commensality :*** Changes have also occurred in the commensality aspect of the caste system. People are no more confined to their places of origin. They have migrated to different places and so it becomes very difficult to stick to the restrictions relating to the food habits. Particularly in the urban places where the strangers dine in hotels, it is impossible to maintain the restrictions. The cook and the co- diners may not belong to the same caste. Hence persons from different caste groups come together and eat by breaking the rules of commensality. In various offices and work- organisations, the same relaxation is evident. The employees get together and allow interdining.
6. ***Attitudinal changes :*** Changes in the attitude towards castes have been noticed within the system. This relates to loss of faith in the ascriptive pattern and justification of the system itself.

The following are the attitudinal changes.

1. ***Loss of faith in the ascriptive status :*** Under the sway of rapid social transformation, people have changed their attitude towards life and have started questioning the old values, which are of no use for the social system, at present. People are no longer prepared to accord a fixed status on the basis of birth which is the sole criterion for determination of one's caste. The question of ability, aptitude, talent and efficiency has haunted the minds of people. As such the very existence of the caste system has been threatened.
2. ***Suspicion of the justification of caste :*** The traditional belief that the caste system has a divine sanction has been lost. This is also due to contradictory views in the Shastras as well as recognition of efficiency and talent. Panikkar holds the view that the tour-fold division of the society as a divinely-ordained institution has remained at the level of a myth of fiction.

FACTORS INFLUENCING THE CASTE SYSTEM

The caste system is still existing in our society, but it is not as rigid or irrational as once it was. A number of factors are responsible for brining about changes in the system. These factors include –

1. ***Industrialization and Urbanisation :*** The twin forces of industrialisation and urbanisation have far-reaching consequences in our society. The process of urbanisation operates at two levels. First, it draws people from villages to urban and industrial centres through the migratory current. Secondly, there is a shift in the occupational sphere-from agricultural to non-agricultural pursuits. That apart, urbanisation also produces social heterogeneity, secondary and tertiary occupations, tolerance, secondary control, social mobility, voluntay associations, individuation, spatial segregation, etc.

   Industrialisation refers to the processes wherin production of goods with the use of hand tools is replaced by changes in the technology of agriculture, transport and communication and by changes in the organisation of trade and finance. The process of industrialisation results in specialised division of labour, development of the machine mode of production, concentration of economy and the growth of class system.

   Industrialisation and urbanisation, taken together, produce far-reaching change in the socio-economic life of people in the following manner.

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(a) The ascriptive status loses its importance. In the industrial urban sector the low caste people hold higher positions and vice versa. Thus people belonging to the high castes work under them and accept the supremacy of the lower castes.

(b) In the industrial colonies, the residential accomodation is usually so allotted that there is no distinction between high and low caste people. Thus they have social intercourse through inter-mixing and inter-dining. This strikes at the roots of caste system.

(c) The educational institutions do not impose any restriction on the basis of caste. Children of different castes read in the same school, play together and take part in common prayer.

(d) The frequent mixing of a large number of people inside and outside the factory broadens their outlook and develops a rational approach towards the social issues. They also question the validity of caste system itself.

(e) Due to modern means of transport and communication, people belonging to all the castes travel in the same public vehicles and railway compartments. The question of the shadow of a person belonging to a low caste defiling a Brahmin or a person of some other high caste has automatically lost its significance. Similar is the situation in the places of work, markets and other public places.

(f) Open competitions for getting into jobs in many factories and industries have shown that many a time people belonging to the low castes establish their superiority over the so-called high caste people. Thus the superiority of wisdom and knowledge claimed by the high castes cannot be maintained.

(g) In the industrial urban matrix the status symbols of both the higher and lower castes change, food habits and dress pattern become more or less uniform and the high caste people do not hesitate to host lunch and dinner in honour of well-established persons and holders of superior official positions of other castes.

2. ***Westernization :*** The term westernisation was used by M.N. Srinivas to describe the changes in the Indian society during the British rule. The changes were observed in the spheres of dress, food habits, style of eating, manners etc. Westernization brought very important changes in the field of education by introducing English as the medium of instruction and the introduction of secular subjects of study. Moreover, the schools were thrown open to all and so people belonging to the lower castes could send their children for study. This came as a blow to the supremacy of the higher castes, especially the Brahmins, in matters of acquisition of traditional knowledge.

By learning English, young men belonging to different caste groups could enter government services and take up jobs in other commercial organizations and banks started by the Britishers. Thus westernisation also brought occupational changes cutting across the caste barrier.

Westernisation also resulted in promoting egalitarianism, secularism, rationalism and a critical outlook towards various social issues and problems. All these offer a striking contrast to the traditional belief pattern promoted by the caste system.

The most significant impact of westernization on the Indian society was that it promoted a humanitarian outlook among the westernized elites and some of them led the social reform movement against child marriage, taboos against widow remarriage, seculsion of women, untouchability, restrictions on inter-caste marriage, commensality etc.

Thus the process of westernization weakened the traditional caste system and brought about a great change in the Indian Society.

3. ***Sanskritization :*** Sanskritization as a process of change is the mobiliy concerned with positional change in the caste system. Srinivas defines "Sanskritization" as "the process by which a low Hindu caste or tribal or any other group changes its customs, rituals, ideology and way of life in the direction of a high and frequently "twice-born" caste. By changing the customs and rituals, people belonging to the low castes claim a 'higher' position in the caste hierarchy. According to Srinivas "A low caste was able, in a generation or two, to rise to a higher position in the hierarchy by adopting vegetarianism and teetotalism and by sanskritizing its ritual and pantheon."

As regards changes in the system through Sanskritization, S.K. Chatterjee holds the view that "the progressive Sanskritization of the various pre-Aryan people in their culture, their outlook and their ways of life, forms the keynote of India through the ages." And in the course of this" Sanskritization "the affected people also brought their own spiritual and material aspects to bear upon the Sanskrit and sanskritic culture which they were adopting and thus helped them to modify and enrich it in their own cirlce."

Sanskritization is an illustration of the operation of the "reference group" process which is used to evaluate one's attitudes, customs, rituals etc., depending on the prestige of that group in a particular society. Therefore Srinivas remarks, "the best way of staking a claim to higher position is to adopt the customs and the way of life of higher caste" But the caste system being a closed

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one, membership in the reference group is impossible. Nevertheless the lower caste people have a slight shift within the varna and move up slightly in the scale of 'Jatis' within a particular varna.

4. ***Secularization :*** Secularization also disintegrates the caste system as it displaces the religious beliefs, rituals and sense of community from the moral life of the society. People's routine invocations of the sacred lose importance and the "major institutions in society become legitimized primarily by secular ideologies and formal legal doctrines rather than by religious ethics."

Thus the process of secularization diminishes the religiousity of tradition-bound people and simultaneously promotes rationality, scientific attitude and differentiation. As such, the validity of the caste system and its very basis relating to birth, occupation and the concept of purity and pollution fail to withstand the severe challenge posed by secularization. As a result the system undergoes a process of transformation. Prof. M.N. Srinivas has rightly pointed out : "What was previously regarded as religious is now ceasing to be such and it also implies a process of different creation which results in the various aspects of society, economic, political, legal and moral, becoming increasingly discrete in relation to each other."

5. ***Legislative Measures :*** Law has two important functions to play in a society, first, to reinforce social control and secondly to bring about a social change by influencing the behaviour, values and beliefs of people. India is a bright example of imputing legislative measures to initiate changes. The framing of the Indian Consitution was the first step in this direction. By making provision for the principles of equality, freedom, justice etc., it created a series of reverberations in the Indian social structure. Institutionalised inequality, which was the basis of caste system, came under attack. Caste-based education and occupation became meaningless and traditional social forces were struck by radical changes in the law of this land.

A variety of social legislations are being introduced in the post-independence era. Those which relate to the changes in the caste system cover legislations to safeguard the interests of the down-trodden, to eradicate untouchability, to facilitate the social and economic development of the depressed castes and making the provision of reservation for scheduled castes and other backward classes.

The Untouchability (offences) Act, 1955 provided for punishment against the practice of untouchability. Articles 14 and 15 of the Indian Constitution provided equality before law as a fundamental right. The Hindu Marriage Act of 1955 abolished all caste restrictions as a necessary requirement for a valid marriage, inter-caste marriage became valid. In the pre- independence days various legislations such as the Special Mariage Act, 1872 was amended to make provision for intercaste marriage. The caste Disabilities Removal Act, 1950 was also enacted. All these legislations and constitutional provisions are slowly but surely making their impact on the caste system.

6. **Reform Movements :** Whereas the effective legislative measures are mostly post-independence phenomena, the social and religious reform movements dominated the Indian scene early in the twentieth century. Protest against Brahminical supremacy, formulation of new religions of conversion to other religions were not unknown to India. Nevertheless towards the end of the 19th century, with the rise and growth of National Movement, the Backward Classes Movement emerged among the various depressed caste groups. Social Movements attacked Hinduism and wanted its followers to come out of the Hindu fold, whereas some other reform movements aimed at attacking Hinduism from within and sought relief for the depressed castes within the Hindu framework.

On the basis of the objectives and directions of caste movements, these movements may be classified as : (a) status mobility movements, (b) caste unity movements and (c) caste welfare movements.

The social reform movement launched by Mahatma Gandhi early in the 20th century advocated the abolition of untouchability and social discrimination on the basis of caste.

Thus, the social reform movements refined the concept of caste and caused an awareness among people against the evil system.

Changed World View : Due to the belief of the doctrine of 'Karma' and the belief in salvation and rebirth, the people had to accept their fate on the basis of birth and did not question the basis of religion. Western education changed their attitude towards life. Religious interference in the social activity came to a halt. The Hindus became more concerned with this-worldiness rather than the other-worldiness. Gandhiji and Pandit Nehru propagated the ideology of action and people became more and more oriented towards the changing world view.

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VARNA - CASTE

VARNA	CASTE
1. Literally 'varna' means colour and originates from the world 'Vri' meaning the choice of one's occupation. Hence varna is concerned with one's colour or occupation.	1. Caste or 'Jati' originates from the root word 'Jana' which implies taking birth. Thus, caste is concerned with birth.
2. Varnas are only four in number i.e. Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Sudra.	2. Castes are very large in number. Castes also have many subdivisions known as subcastes.
3. It is an all-India phenomenon.	3. There are regional variations mostly based on linguistic differences.
4. The hierarchical pattern of varna shows the concept of purity and pollution as the basis of division of society and placements of groups into higher and lower classes i.e. varna-class correlation is mostly positive.	4. Caste-class correlation is not always positive, There may be variations in the placement due to economic, political and educational status of various groups.
5. As regards the mobility pattern varnas are relatively flexible, compared with the castes. With the aquisition of talents and virtues, an individual may improve upon his previous status and vice-versa.	5. Caste system is based on rigid principles and mobility in the ladder is checked. It is based on a closed type of stratification.
6. Varna may be described as an abstract classification of people of a mythical origin. The religious explanation of the varna system is derived from the Purushashukta and the Rigvedic hymn which describes the creation of priests (Brahmins) warriors (Kshatriyas) traders (Vaishyas) and menials (Sudras) from the mouth, arms, thighs and feet of the Creator respectively.	6. Caste, by contrast, is a concrete grouping based on ritualistic and occupational criteria.
7. Varna system is free from socio-economic and political disabilities as well as restrictions.	7. The caste system imposes many restrictions on the members.

DOMINANT CASTE

In the agrarian Indian society, an understanding of land owning dominant castes in rural India is necessary to have some idea about the process of social change in India. Despite rapid industrialization ownership of land is still the main source of wealth, status and political power. In a path breaking research paper titled *Dominant Caste in Rampura* published in 1959 in *American Anthropologist,* Srinivas put forward the concept of Dominant Caste. It gave some new insight about the process of social change in India. Since then many sociologists and social anthropologists have been applying themselves on the various aspects of dominance in rural India.

Srinivas asserts that to be a dominant caste, a caste must have the following characteristics:

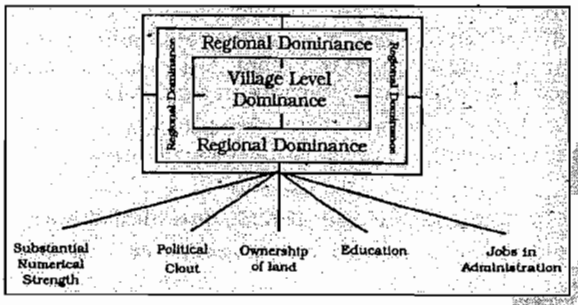
1. It must own a sizeable amount of cultivable land.
2. It must be of considerable numerical strength.
3. It must enjoy a high place in the local caste hierarchy.

The ownership of land has traditionally been vested in a few castes only. With these land owning castes have been aligned a number of artisan castes and landless labour. Even after four decades of land reforms, about one third of scheduled caste population is still landless and the remaining population has small land holdings.' Moreover, the 'Green Revolution' has further enhanced the price and importance of cultivable land with the result that many trading castes are focussing their attention on the ownership of land; they are investing more and more money to procure land.

Despite all these factors mere ownership of land, numerical strength and high place in ritual hierarchy are no more the only determining factors in conferring the status of *dominant caste* on any particular caste. Western education, jobs in administration and political clout and contacts are the new and additional factors of dominance. Therefore some castes which were earlier dominant no more enjoy dominance. Moreover, introduction of adult franchise and democratic decentralisation *(Panchayati Raj)* have provided leverage to many middle level and lower castes. The status of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes has improved due to reservation in State and Central legislative bodies. Spread of education among these erstwhile depressed groups has further altered the yardstick of dominance.

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Due to immense expansion in transport and communication village level dominance is no longer enough to make a caste dominant caste. Instead-regional dominance seems to be a better criterion of dominance. This situation may further be explained. A particular caste maybe numerically, economically and politically dominant in a particular village. However, if it is surrounded from all sides by other castes with antagonistic interests the village level dominance of that particular caste does not carry much weight. Hence dominance spread over a vast contagious tract of land is more important.

Significantly, the model of Sanskritization for lower castes is not always the Brahmin. Instead in most of the areas the dominant caste serves as the model for Sanskritization. For instance, if a Kshatriya caste is dominant in a particular region the model for Sanskritization will be Kshatriya; likewise Vaishya, Brahmin and so on. This dominance is so all pervading that in regions where non-Brahmins are dominant castes even Brahmins are looked down upon and often treated with contempt. For instance in certain areas of eastern Uttar Pradesh the dominant *Thakur* landlords make the Brahmins cook food except their *Kulguru* (family priest). Likewise in many villages of Punjab the *jot* landlords consider Brahmins as their servants.

The dominant caste usually keeps a distance from others in the village and -the whole region of dominance. It considers Itself as the protector and watchdog of culture. It sets certain norms of behaviour the violation of which is dealt with severely. The whole value system of a particular region carries the stamp of dominant caste.

The Dominant Caste plays important role in the settlement of disputes through the traditional village and caste council. The influential members of the dominant caste settle disputes not only between members of different castes, they are also frequently approached by members of the same caste for the settlement of their intra-caste disputes and problems.

S.C. Dube and Peter Gardner raised serious objections to the very concept of dominant caste. Pinpointing an empirical aspect of the situation Dube comments that it will be meaningful to speak of a ' dominant caste ' only when power is diffused in the group and is exercised in the interest of the whole group or atleast a sizeable part of it. When there are pronounced inequalities of wealth, prestige and power between different individuals in a so called dominant caste, and where dominant individuals exploit the weaker elements in their own caste as well as the non-dominant castes it will perhaps be inappropriate to think of it as a dominant caste. Unity and concerted action in terms of caste interest, therefore, must be assumed before we locate dominance in a caste on the basis of criteria specified by Srinivas. The fact that a number of dominant individuals occupying most of the power positions belong to a particular caste is, by itself, not enough £o characterize the caste as dominant. Further intra-caste unity and articulation in terms of power are essential for it's emergence as a dominant caste. Where these conditions exist a caste can become dominant. In their absence, however, the community power structure can be better understood in reference to *dominant individuals, dominant faction* and their complex alignment.

In his rejoinder, Srinivas says that " although Dube concedes the existence of 'dominant individuals' and 'dominant faction' he is hesitant to go the whole hog and concede the existence of -dominant caste. Here M.N.Srinivas' basic contention is that both 'dominant individuals' and 'dominant faction' owe their dominance to the fact that they are a part of the dominant caste. It may be observed here that most, if not all, of the leaders of the ' dominant faction ' hail from the dominant caste except in areas where there are two rival castes each striving to establish its dominance." The dominance of the dominant caste is not a local or village level phenomenon. As mentioned earlier in this discussion the village level dominance of caste does not carry much weight. The dominance shall be complete only when it is spread over a substantial region. If this is the case then even a family or two in a village, belonging to a dominant caste, shall count locally because of the network of ties binding them to their dominant relatives and fellow members of the caste. In such situations others in the village will always be aware of this nexus or network and hence the affairs in the village get conducted accordingly.

Talking of the possible diversity of interests and still putting up a united front on the part of the dominant castes, Ghanshyam Shah (1985) points out the formation of caste associations- an important innovation introduced by the 'dominant group' of a dominant caste to maintain harmony among the various economic strata within the caste structure.

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It thereby maintains it's hegemony as well as protects it's own ' class interests'. The history of caste associations go back to the late 19th century, although their number has increased after independence. The Sardar Kurmi Kshatriya Sabha of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the Nadar Mahajana Sangam in Tamilnadu, the Gujarat Kshatriya Sabha in Gujarat are some of the examples of powerful caste association. 'These caste associations projected economic interests of the dominant group as the caste-interest. In order to win over the support of the poorer strata of the castes concerned, the associations generally adopt two strategies. Firstly, in the beginning the leaders of the associations invoke the caste ideology based on the concept of purity and pollution. Caste members are exhorted to maintain or improve their caste status. Legends are created glorifying their past. A sense of ' weness ' among the caste members is promoted around rhetoric such as 'economic backwardness', ' economic development', etc of the caste members. Secondly, in order to bind together the caste members, the caste associations occasionally pass resolutions ventilating grievances of the exploited strata of the caste against the government."

When one views caste, both theoretically and empirically, one finds that Srinivas never claimed that the concept of dominant caste provided the total explanation for the phenomenon of power in rural India. Moreover, the unity of a caste, particularly that of a dominant caste, is not something static and constant, but dynamic and contextual. It emerges especially in relation of oppositon to the other castes. With the increasing emphasis on the popular participation in the implementation of welfare schemes and schemes of economic development through democratic institutions, the role of dominant castes has assumed cricical importance because of their ability and capacity to control and manipulate these institutions. In this fierce competition to control economic and political resources not all the members of the dominant castes may be receiving' power' directly but they as a collective whole are definitely exercising the powers. Thus, the political process and economic development at the micro and meso levels definitely carry the stamp of the respective dominant castes.

JAJMANI SYSTEM

VARIOUS STUDIES ON JAJMANI SYSTEM

(1) Oscar Lewis's study of jajmani system in North Indian villages

(2) Opler and Singh's investigation of jajmani system in Eastern U.P. in 1948 and 1955 respectively.

(3) Kolenda has studied the Khalapur village. This study revealed that the village belonged to the dominant castes of Rajputs.

(4) In Karimpur village of Moinpuri district, Wiser studied the system of inter-caste exchange.

(5) In his classic study, 'Indian village' Prof. S.C. Dube, revealed the jajmani relation in Hyderabad. Katheline Gough, Darlin and D.N. Majumdar studied the jajmani system in the village of Tanjore, Punjab and Lucknow respectively.

The Jajmani system is characterised by permanency of relationship between the jajman and the kamin, hereditary relationship, payment of goods against service, peace and contentment difference in scope of work etc. These characteristics may be described below.

1. ***Permanent relationship between jajman and kamin:*** One of the most significant features of the jajmani system is that it is based on a permanent relationship between jajman and kamin. It makes certain essential services available to farmers. Due to this system certain individuals or groups of them needed to meet the essential requirements of the agriculturists. The jajmans inhabit permanently in their villages. The departure of the kamins from the village does not hamper services to the jajmans because when the kamin leaves a village he provides for his substitute. But the most striking feature of the system is that jajmani rights are not sold, even exchanged or transferred, because a kamin never likes to leave his own village to go to some other village. Everyone likes to reside in the same village in which one was born so that there may be no disruption of services available in a village and the availability of certain essential services is ensured. Thus a permanent structure of economic order and relationship among various classes in the villages is provided ensured and continued by jajmani system. S.C. Dube has pointed out that not only a kamin had no right to desert his jajman but also the jajman has no right to replace his kamin. This striking spirit behind jajmani system enables both the jajmans and kamins to maintain a permanent, fixed and life-long affinity.
2. ***Jajmani System is Hereditary :*** Another significant feature of the jajmani system is that it is hereditary. The caste based stratification of Indian society is based on ascriptive pattern. Therefore, the occupation or profession is based on birth. Jajmani rights are considered to be proprietory and are passed from the father to sons. When the family is disintegrated due to separation of brothers, these rights are also divided among them. In case no son is born to a family and daughters are there, the jajmani rights pass onto the husband of the daughter. Due to hereditary practice the son inherits the profession of father. Jajmani rights may split among male members in a family when their number increases gradually.

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3. ***Goods against Services :*** Under the jajmani system, the kamin receives his payment in kind. Cash payment is not made against the services rendered by the kamin. The relationship between jajman and kamin is not like that of employer and employee. The jajmani provides goods such as grains, like wheat, rice etc. to the kamins which he needs the most. The jajman also provides kamin with clothing and accommodation. The jajman always looks into the welfare of the kamin and the kamin reciprocates it through his devoted and dedicated service to jajman. The relationship between jajman and kamin is not purely economic one but also human.
4. ***Peace and Contentment :*** The striking aspect of jajmani system is that it provides peace, tranquility and contentment to villagers. Jajmani system also provides a sense of security of professions to the kamins in a village. As a result they develop professional competency in their respective tasks. They become well prepared for these tasks and derive peace and contentment.
5. ***Difference in the Scope of Work :*** The jajmani system does not provide uniform pattern of activity to all the kamins. A kamin is not confined or restricted to provide his service to a single family or even a single village. He may render his service to more than one family or even more than one village. As for example, a family needs the services of a washerman once or twice a week. Furthermore, he may not serve for the entire day, but for an hour or two. So, the Dhobi may be able to fulfil the needs of a few families. The nature of activities performed of any kamin depends upon the range or scope provided under the system. Therefore all the castes may not be able to operate in more than one village. For instance, a barber may be able to provide his services to more than one village, but a sweeper can hardly afford to do that. The range or scope of activity also depends upon the nature of supply and demand. A self-sufficient and prosperous village may be having a number of shop-keepers but a hamlet may not have more than one shopkeeper.

FUNCTION AND ROLES

Jajmani system serves to maintain the Indian village as a self-sufficient community. "Jajmani system is the exchange of agricultural produce for menial and craft services". Jajmani system regulates and maintains division of labour of castes.

Leach (1960) in his analysis of the function of the Jajmani system, has mentioned that the Jajmani system maintains and regulates the division of labour and economic interdependence of castes. According to Wiser, the Jajmani system serves to maintain the Indian village as a self-sufficient community. Harold Gould (1987) has said that Jajmani system distributes agricultural produce in exchange for menial and craft services. Beidelman (1959) is of the opinion that Jajmani system maintains higher caste prestige.

In Jajmani system the rolss of jajmans and kamins are involved. The kamin castes render certain occupational, economic and social services to the jajmani castes and receive payments from their jajmans. This payment is made at fixed intervals or on special occasions. Thus the jajmani relationship is based on a reciprocal exchange. However, all castes do not essentially take part in this reciprocal exchange. For example, it is normally found that the oilman is not involved in the exchange of services system. Kamin's clientele is not restricted to his own village. It may include the members of other villages.

The jajman kamin role relationship is strengthened by the giving of various concessions, like free food, free clothes, free residence, rent free land, casual aid, aid in litigation, etc. and protection of kamins by jajmans during various exigencies of life. However, the jajmani system is not reciprocal in all villages. Kolenda's study revealed that dominant castes swing the balance of power in their favour in such relationships in many villages in India. Yogendra Singh (1973 : 187) has evinced changes in Indian villages today in respect of economic institutions, power structure, and intercaste relationships, A major source of economic change in villages may be attributed to land reform which has been introduced through abolition of intermediaries, tenancy reforms, ceiling of landholdings, redistribution of land, development of co-operative farming and religio-economic movement for gift of surplus land by the rich to the poor etc. bring a desired change in economic situation. These measures have far reaching consequences on interaction among castes, jajmani system, and the social system of the villages.

CHANGES

Since the jajmani system has its inter-connection with caste system, religious system, system of landownership and the political structure in the rural society, consideration of any transformation in these arrangements will have corresponding effect on the jajmani system too and vice versa. The caste system, is on its way of disintegration, the religious system is weakening due to secularization, system of land-ownship has undergone the process of transformation due to land reforms and the modern polity has shattered the old pattern. Therefore the jajmani system has been affected. A number of causes may be attributed to it. Reduction in the powers of the elders in the village council, industrialisation and its impact on the quality of service rendered by the purjans or kamins, laxity in the rigidity of caste system, spread of education, impact of western

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education, rural to urban exodus in search of jobs and material amenities, abolition of the zagirdari system, introduction and implementation of land reforms, better job prospects in urban centres, availability of modern transport causing better market transactions etc. are among the causative factors on account of which the jajmani system is on the decline and in many a case it has become completely extinct in many jillages. The practice of goods for service is gradually losing ground and now-a-days some artisans prefer to get money for their goods. The dominant castes take recourse to politics and hardly seek assistance from the kamins for their support. The landowning castes depend upon market for purchasing qualitative things through cash transaction. In their study in five villages I.Karve and Y.Damle found that 202 out of 326 respondents were in favour of jajmani system because of economic benefits whereas the kamins favoured the system due to the availability of ritual services the jajmans preferred the support by the landowners at the time of factional struggle. Protection given by the patron in exigencies also impressed the kamins. Another study by Bose and-Jodha in Barmer district in Rajsthan revealed that 111 out of 120 were also infavour of prevalence of jajmani system due to similar reasons.

Notwithstanding such opinion surveys depicting villagers' favourable opinion towards jajmani system, it can be well maintained that the traditional jajmani relation have been weakend in recent years. The capability of a caste specially to support the members of a 'jati' varies with the demand for the products of the craft or the service in question. "E.A.H. Blunt, in his analysis of qastc system in the northern State of Uttar Pradesh, used the statistics from the 1911 census of India and showed that between 60 and 74 percent of confectioners, grain purchasers, and washermen, 76 percent or more of sweepers and goldsmiths; and 50 to 59 percent of carpenters, weavers, oil- pressers, barbers and potters were working at the speciality of their caste. Thus he noted the variability among castes in the proportion of members who actually took to their ancestral occupations. In contrast, under 10 percent of leather workers and wine dealers worked at their professions and under 20 percent of brahmins worked as priests. Blunt was of the opinion that decline in the number of members of a particular caste following their caste occupation was due to a decline in the demand for handicrafts and traditional services. They preferred to work in agriculture, labouring or acting as domestic servants. There was no restriction in following agricultural occupation because it has always been permitted as an alternative occupation for all, but some castes take to agriculture as their ancestral or traditional occupation. Such castes are generally known as the cultivators.

Changes have also been marked in craftsmanship and the original work done by members of specialised castes. In his study of Khalarpur, Joseph Schwartzberg, has shown that traditionally the chamar's occupation was leather tanning, the Teli's ancestral occupation was oil-pressing, the barber's wife and grain parchers were engaged in hand-grinding. But on the basis of data obtained from 1951 census of India, Schwartzberg, revealed that a sharp decline was marked in respect of those employed in vegetable oil pressing and refining. It showed a sharp decline from 483,000 persons in 1901 to 250,000 person in 1951. In the like manner the employment of "hand pounding of rice, flour grinding, manual dehusking and milling of cereals and pulses" showed a decline from 1,245,000 in 1901 to 526.000 in 1951. The number of leather workers, workers in industries making leather products, and footwear workers also came down from 1,143,000 in 1901 to 760,000 in 1951.

Dumont has also stated that the jajmani system has been restricted to a considerable extent in modern times, due to a shift from religious to personal approach. Even some specialists have been completely extinct in the system.

Several reasons may be attributed to the decline of jajmani system in rural India. In Khalarpur it has been effected by the sugar mills. Prior to the establishment of sugar mills, the local Rajput landlords pressed much sugarcane themselves, and the servants got much home produced unrefined sugar; and also sweeper's got much waste scum for their pigs. But with the establishment of sugar mills, the Rajputs developed interest in planting sugarcane in a greater proportion of land and crops in a smaller proportion which adversely affected the servants, in a couple of ways. First, the servants got less home produced unrefined sugar and the sweeper got less waste for their pigs. Secondly, small amount of foodgrains were given to the kamins in half yearly payments. In the past, in pre-marked economy or non-monetary economy, the food produced was consumed and not sold. So the surplus amount of foodgrain collected by the farmers was distributed among the dependent landless people. Thus in a Khalarpur, due to the introduction of sugarcane as one of important cash crops, the jajman-kamin relationship underwent the process of change. The jajmans changed from being generous to becoming greedy.

The jajman-system was also undermined due to some other reasons. As for instance the service rendered by the water carriers became unnecessary due to the installation of handpumps within the courtyards of high caste womens' quarters. The factory made metal dishes and utensils replaced the potter's clay products and this hampered the potter's trade in the village. The crafts of shoe maker, barber and weaver were undermined in the village due to availability

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of items like shoes, and textiles in the nearby market towns. In shaving sets the opinion of some anthropologists the village communities are gradually losing the ground in respect of self-sufficiency, as various tradesman, artisan and servant castes migrating to towns.

In some places, the jajmans no longer give weightage to occupational monopolies and inherited clienteles. Now the patrons are ready to take to such occupations which were done by servants before, as for example in Rampur village the jajmans began to shave themselves and engaged in carpentry. In many a case they ignored the authority of headman or elders or caste council in setting different matters.

The breakdown of jajman-kamin relationship resulted in the engagement of the kamins in various occupations, other than their traditional ones. Joseph Holder has made one of the few studies regarding the later occupation of kamin, after their release from the jajmani network and the past security of the jajmani system. It was found in Rajapur in U.P. that out of 186 men in Jati's previously employed in a large number in jajmani relationship, only 7 worked for full time for their jajmans. Six of them were carpenters and only one was barber. These who were working as part-time jajmani servants engaged themselves in cultivation in the remaining time. Elder's account shows that 12 barbers, 2 cotton carders and 2 oilpressers who worked as jajmani servants part time, 74 kamins now worked full-time for farmers, 47 worked at the new sugar mill nearby, 6 worked for the railroad etc. It is presumed that the shift to other types of work was due to unusual conditions in providing the kamins and artisans with land and agricultural work in Rajapur.

In many Indian villages where such alternative assignments are not available so readily for so many people due to migration of the servicing caste towards urban centres, shifts from the jajmani network may occur in respect of occupation.

Now-a-days, the Indian Society is witnessing a gradual change in the jajmani system. Rigidity in caste system strengthened the base of jajmani network. But when the breakdown of caste system occurred and was marked by groupism and class struggle, the jajmani network slowly disappeared from the Indian scenario. Due to man's diminishing faith in religion and laxity in the performance of rites and ritual, jajmani system is gradually disintegrating. Moreover, owing to decline of Brahminical supremacy, the jajmani relation has suffered a serious setback. Modern means of transport and communication has enabled people to go to the market easily and sell their products in market places. Professions are no longer based on hereditary principle. People are no more bound to take to their ancestral occupation.

Intergenerational educational mobility has enabled them to enter a variety of occupations according to their ability. That is why people of different castes are engaged in different professions and a major change has occurred in the occupational structures. Not much of the village economy is now carried on through jajmani arrangements. Money is replacing the traditional method of payment of newly produced foodgrains to various kamins. Agriculture is no more the monopoly of any particular caste. The agricultural occupation is open to all the castes. Even some kamins have accepted it as the additional occupation. Various reform movements have also affected the jajmani system. In a nutshell it may be stated that all the factors, responsible for the breakdown of caste system, may be attributed to the decline and disintegration of the jajmani system in rural India. Since the caste system is in the melting pot now, the jajmani system is also in the process of rapid transformation. Therefore Biedleman has doubted the survival of the jajmani system in the years to come.

SACRED COMPLEX

Dr. L.P. Vidyarthi studied the sacred city of Gaya located in the ancient cultural zone of Magadh. In this study he developed a set of analytical concepts and descriptive terms to describe a sacred city as a part of Indian civilization. The city has been described in terms of three analytical concepts namely *sacred geography, sacred performances,* and *sacred specialists.* These three concepts conceived collectively, are termed a Sacred Complex.

In his study *The Sacred Complex of Hindu* Goya (1961) Vidyarthi came out with his three constituents of a sacred complex with the help of some hypotheses formulated by him. He says that the sacred complex of a Hindu place of pilgrimage reflects a level of continuity, compromise and combination between Great and Little traditions. The sacred specialists of place of pilgrimage maintain a distinct style of life and transmit certain elements of the Great tradition to the rural population of India by popularising certain texts, by organising pilgrimage and by officiating as the ritual and temple priests. The sacred specialists in particular have been in the process of modification and transformation as a result of general development in the large universe of Hindu civilization of which they are a part.

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The classification of the sacred phenomena i.e. sacred geography, sacred performances and sacred specialists is applicable not only to Gaya but, Indeed, to all the sacred places of Hindu pilgrimage. Both Vidyarthl (1961) and Cohn & Marriot (1958) have considered these places and the network of pilgrimages functionally important in the integration of Indian civilization.

Among the three basic components, the sacred geograpy has been further classified into zones, segments, and clusters of sacred centres. Gaya contains a complex of hundreds of sacred objects and places located within this sacred *Kshetra* (region) revered by all Hindus. Both in space and time the sacred geography demonstrates the continuity of India's Great and Little traditions. It also exhibits several kinds of combinations between Hindu and Buddhist traditions at different levels. However, due to drastic changes in modern times the secular zone of Gaya has been expanding at the cost of the shrinking sacred zone. This is discernible at the sight of many old and dilapidated sacred objects where rest houses, parks, restaurants, etc. have come up. Besides so many sacred performances the main one for which Gaya is revered in the Hindu world is an elaborate form of sacrifices to ancestral spirits. This is known as *Gaya Shraddha.* All the sacred performances are led by the *Gayawal* Brahmins— an orthodox priestly caste following a highly ceremonialized and sanskritic life style greatly influenced by the Hindu Great tradition. The relationship of this sacred complex with the outside world is not one sided. The sacred complex survives mainly on the sustenance derived from the latter. The *Gayawal* priests have *jajmani* relationships with well to do patrons located in various parts of the Hindu universe. The construction of sacred buildings was financed mainly by rich persons from all over the country. The same persons provide a livelihood to the sacred specialists by holding elaborate sacred performances and giving them valuable gifts.

The sacred complexes are the centres of civilization where pilgrims from different regions of India, from different levels of culture interact; Saraswati (1982) raising a pertinent question asks whether these heterogeneous pilgrims who interact in a sacred complex share in common the Brahminic concept of sacred which has laid the foundation of these centres, and do all of them interact fully and equally with the sacred phenomena operating at the sacred centre? In Semitic religions, all those who interact at a place of pilgrimage, say Mecca or Jerusalem, may belong to diverse linguistic regions and cultural strata, but they hold a common concept of sacred and participate equally in sacred performances. This does not seem to be true with the Hindu places of pilgrimage, and yet they serve importantly to integrate diverse cultural traditions into a common bond of civilization.

Taking lead from Vidyarthi a group of younger social anthropologists was attracted towards this new field of research, Saraswati has made prominent contribution to this field through his studies like *The Holy Circuit ofNimsar (1965). The Temple Organization in Goa (1962),* and Kashi: *Myth and Reality of a Classical Cultural Tradition (1975).* Saraswati is of the view that the concept of sacred' is essentially based on man's desire to communicate with the spiritual world, usually, in order to attain *moksa.* In his significant study of Kashi, Saraswati has concluded that although the sacred complex of Kashi may appear as predominantly a Brahmin complex, it is indeed a complex of a much bigger organization of traditions, known as Indian civilization, which makes the Brahminic temple of Visweshwara and the non-Brahminic shrine of Agiyabeer to co-exist, the textually learned *Karmakandi,* and illiterate untouchable Domto conduct sacred performances together and a *Nastik* Brahmin touch the feet of an *Awadhoot* who eats carcasses. This kind of arrangement at sacred places of pilgrimage demonstrates and reminds the pilgrims coming from different cultural traditions again and again that they must not be too egoistic in upholding their own traditions as the superior most.

Among other contributions are Jha's, *The Sacred Complex of Ratanpur (1978),* Mohapatra's *Lingaraj Temple: Its* Structure and *change,* Morab & Goswami's *Chamundeshwari Temple (1975)* and Chakravarti's Tarakeshwari*Temple* (1974). Apart from his intensive study of Janakpur, following the theoretical model of Gaya, Jha also tested certain hypotheses raised by Redfield. Singer, Vidyarthi and others. While Vidyarthi developed the concept of Sacred Complex for studying the places of pilgrimage as a dimension of Indian civilization, Marriot and Cohn developed the concepts of' Network and Centres' (1958) to study the channels of integration of Indian civilization. Thus, in Indian social anthropology, the concepts of 'Sacred complex' and 'Networks and Centres' have become very popular theoretical models for studying the traditional cities and places of pilgrimage as dimensions of Indian civilization.

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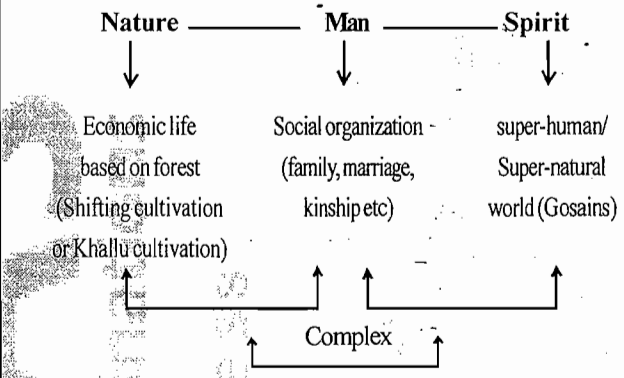
NATURE - MAN - SPIRIT COMPLEX

The concept of Nature-Man-Spirit Complex is an important contribution by L.P. Vidyarthi for applied anthropologists in the formulation and implementation of development programmes in tribal India. This concept is based on cultural ecological approach in anthropology which explains the constant interaction between man and nature.

Culture may also be viewed as the human response to the local environmental conditions. In other words culture may also be described as the man made part of the environment. In this arrangement some external or outside factors are also very relevant. This arrangement between man and his environment helps him on individual as well as collective level to fulfil all the practical requirements of life. Man has got an amazing capacity to adapt himself with his ecology. But the adaptation model is not uniform throughout the world. It varies from region to region because of environmental and other factors. That is why cultural ecologists are always in search of cultural-adaptation models or patterns. In fact the distinctiveness of the culture of various human groups lies in the variations in the cultural ecological models.

The concept of Nature-Man-Spirit Complex is an attempt to Understand the adaptation of the socio-cultural institutions with the local environmental conditions. It has been observed that constant interaction goes on between the social organization, ecological conditions and religious complex in the whole of tribal India. It's results and adaptation process has been studied by L P Vidyarthi with special reference to the Maler (Mal Pahariya)-a primitive tribe of shifting cultivators inhabiting the Rajmahal Hills of Bihar. The Malers believe in different types of spirits. The influence of these spirits is all pervading in various spheres of life of the Malers. The spirits they behave in may broadly be categorised into two; the benevolent spirits are responsible for health, wealth, increased productivity in agriculture and so on while the malevolent spirits cause sickness, abortions, death and natural calamities with the presiding spirit *Gosain or Gosaiyyan* governing over all the spirits. Thus propitiation of various types of spirits becomes one of their preoccupations. To achieve this objective they resort to various types of rites and rituals. Since the presiding spirit *Gosain* serves as the bridge between the Malers and their concept of super human, and supernatural, it is held in highest esteem. They do not do anything worthwhile without the 'approval' of the Gosain.

In this way the spirits, the social institutions and their principal economic activity viz. shifting cultivation known as Khallu in the local dialect form a complex.



The 'nature' and 'spirits' exert profound influence over Maler life and these three interrelated factors are in constant interaction with each other.

The utility of this concept may be observed when it serves as an important aid or tool for an applied anthoropologist, during the formulation or implementation of developmental programmes among the primitive tribal communities. It has been seen several times that the primitive tribal groups resist or reject totally any attempt on the part of the development administration to rehabititate them anywhere else or introduce radical changes in their life. This resistance or rejection may be explained in terms of their despair or anger at the disturbance in the equilibrium of nature, man and spirit. This Complex highlights that these tribals can be disturbed radically and abruptly by introducing innovations in their life without preparing them sufficiently for this change.

This concept tells an applied anthropologist to be very sensitive and receptive to any such change that threatens to disturb this equilibrium otherwise the target group or the potential beneficiary of any programme may not accept it and the scarce resources may go down the drain. This hardly means that the primitive tribal groups or simple peasant groups should be left to their fate with all the vistages of statusquoism. The purpose and objective of this caution is to ensure that the schemes for their welfare and development help such groups achieve 'development' with happiness. This concept further tells us that the 'little traditions' are not only resilient and capable of perpetuating themselves but may also reject the 'great traditions' without getting overawed by them. Such a concept may prove very useful especially in the rehabilitation planning for the iood-gathering-huntlng tribes, shifting cultivators and other simple societies. ■

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IMPACT OF BUDDHISM, JAINISM, ISLAM AND CHRISTIANITY ON INDIAN SOCIETY

JAINISM AND BUDDHISM

The 6th century B.C. constitutes an important landmark in the annals of Indian culture. This century is equally remarkable in human history for spiritual awakening and religious upheaval. It was an age of extraordinary mental as well as spiritual unrest in several parts of the earth. For example, it was during this period Zoroaster in Persia, Heraclitus and Permiaides in Greece, Confucious and Lao-Tse in China propagated their new religions. In India too Mahavir Jina and Gautama Buddha raised their voices against prevalent practices of Hinduism and ultimately brought changes in the form of Jainism and Buddhism.

Both Mahavira and Buddha led protestant movements against the existing system and they succeeded to some extent.

CAUSES FOR THE GROWTH OF PROTESTANT RELIGIOUS REFORM MOVEMENTS:

Religion has always played an important role in the lives of the Indians. This tendency of the Aryans had prompted them to lead a simple but noble life. The simple and sacred life of the Vedic Aryans continued to influence their cultural heritage for many centuries. But with the passage of time this pristine purity began to decline. The causes behind this decline were many.

The old Vedic tradition gradually became loose and ceased to be a strong force. By 6th century B.C. the prevailing social order nad already come under the control of the Brahmanical class. The Hindu religion with its caste system and social hierarchy became the order of the day. In the name of *Karmakanda* of the Vedas, the Brahmins exploited the people through various religious practices like *Yajna,* sacrifices and other ceremonies. Further untouchability, performance of costly and elaborate rituals, monopoly over Sanskrit language and above all the control of education made the life of common men very miserable. Moreover, in the name of religion various corrupt practices, dogmas and superstitions crept into Hinduism which made it more confusing.

The Upanishads had initiated the speculation into the fundamental truths of life. New ideas, new philosophies, new modes of achieving salvation became the craving of the society which led to the establishment of numerous religious sects. We come to know that by 6th century B.C. there were about 62 such religious sects based on local customs and rituals.

Many preachers of the new religious ideologies expressed their open disapproval of the Brahmanical supremacy and ritualistic practices. Superstitions had surpassed the spirituality of religious faith. Numerous religious ceremonies and meaningless costly practices dominated the conduct of the Hindus.

Now arose the murmurings of protest against the Brahmanical rigidity and supremacy. The leadership was now taken up by the ruling caste of kshatriyas. Next to the Brahmins, they were socially prominent and natural leaders of the society. With their social standing and political and economic support they now raised their strong voice against injustice of the Brahmins. They protested against the corrupt practices and rigidity of Hindu religion.

Such challenges appeared in the form of two religious movements called Jainism and Buddhism.

"Both Mahavir and Buddha urged their followers to give up their vices and follies and to practise that purity of conduct and sincerity of belief which is the essence of every true religion."

JAINISM

Jainism has great antiquity. According to the Jains their religion originated in the remotest ages. They believed that Mahavira, the last, Tirthankara was preceded by twenty-three other prophets. Mahavira was the twenty-fourth one. The historicity of the first twenty-two Tirthankaras starting from Rishabhnath to Neminath is doubtful. They are all shadowy figures wrapped up in mythology.

The twenty-third Tirthankar Parsvanath seems to be a historical personage. He was the son of king Asvasena of Benares who had abandoned the royal life to be a sage. His teachings gave a formal shape to Jainism.

The twenty-fourth Tirthankara of Jainism, Mahavir, followed his predecessor Parsvanath after 250 years. But he definitely placed the religion on a firm footing. He improved upon an already existing faith and made it very widespread and influential. His message endeared him to the heart of the people.

MAIN TENETS OF JAINISM

Many religious movements have contributed their different hues to the multi-coloured canvas of ancient Indian culture. Among those religious and philosophical streams Jainism occupies a prominent position for its rational approach. The main tenets of Jainism are as follows —

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PANCHAYAMADHARMA

Vardhaman Mahavir accepted the four doctrines of Parsvanath, the 23rd Tirthankara of Jainism. They are –

- Non-injury to living beings
- Speaking the truth
- Non-possession of property
- Not stealing.

To these four principles Mahavira added a fifth one, namely, celibacy. By following these five doctrines one can attain eternal bliss or Self-realisation.

Out of the five doctrines Ahimsa or non-injury is the most important one. Mahavir emphasised the need of Ahimsa in every walk of human life. To develop the practice of non-violence one should try to give up thoughts of worldly attachment.

TRI-RATNA

The practice of the above five principles or *Panchayama dharma* depended to a great extent on a pure and spiritual life. So to make life more sanctified Mahavir prescribed ways to observe three qualities which are better known as Triratna or three jewels of Jainism. They are –

- Right faith.
- Right knowledge.
- Right conduct.

Practice of these three qualities purifies the heart. The practitioner becomes conscious of irrelevant worldly attachment.

DUAL EXISTENCE

The Jain philosophy centres round the philosophy of dual existence of soul and matter. In other words human personality comprised of material and spiritual matter. Material things will perish. But spiritual things are eternal. These two things in a way cover the entire existence in the form of *Jiva* or conscious and the *Ajiva* or unconscious.

The *Jiva* corresponds to soul which itself is imperceptible, but its presence can be felt by the qualities of a material body. The *Ajiva* corresponds to matter whose essential characteristic is that of lack of consciousness.

The link between *Jiva* and *Ajiva* is the doctrine of *Karma*. It is the *Karma* or action which decides the future of the soul. If man does not perform the right *Karma* in his life time, then he will face an unending cycle of rebirth. But through severe austerity and self-mortification one can reduce the influence of bondage and move towards liberation.

The entire universe functions through interaction of living souls *(Jiva)* and five categories of non-living *(Ajiva)* entities such as –

- Akasha (Space)
- Dharma (Principle of Motion)
- Adharma (Principle of Rest)
- Kala (Time)
- Pudgala (Matter)

The ultimate aim of the Jains is to achieve *Nirvana* or Salvation. According to Jain ideology, a layman cannot attain *Nirvana*. To attain *Nirvana* or salvation of the body one must abandon all wordly attachments, even one's own clothing; observing fasts, ascetic discipline and self-motification. Thus by severe austerity final liberation or *Nirvana* will come. Hence monastic life is essential for salvation.

Stress on Morality :

Thus caste system, authority of the Vedas and Vedic rituals were set aside by the Jains.

In addition, to make human life more disciplined and regulated Jainism recommends the rejection of thirteen sins in the life of its followers. The thirteen sins are :

- Violence
- Lies
- Masturbation
- Stealing
- Intoxicating drinks
- Anger
- Speaking ill of others
- Pride
- Rage
- Jealousy
- Quarrel
- Covetuousness
- Levying charges

Thus Jainism is more a moral code than a religion in modern sense of the term. It affords an example of one of the most reformed rationalised religious faiths. In the 6th century B.C. it had protested against the, existing religious structure and brought into existence a comprehensive ideology including Indian religion, philosophy and culture.

For this spirit of accommodation Jainism has still survived in India today whereas Buddism had to look for its shelter elsewhere.

CONTRIBUTION OF JAINISM TO INDIAN CULTURE

Jainism had royal patronage and the spread of Jainism in different parts of the country seems to have taken place for quite sometime. It took its deep roots in the soil of India through several ages. Even in the 21st century Jainism has stood firm in the religious firmament of India.

A religion with such remote antiquity and rich heritage had its natural influence on the culture of the sub-continent of India. Jainism has enriched the cultural tradition of India in many respects.

LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

Jainism has played a very important role in the linguistic development of the country. Jain community was smaller in size but bigger were its contributions in the field of literature.

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Prior to the advent of Jainism, Sanskrit was the medium of expression. Even during the same period the Buddhists preferred pali language. The Jains deviated from this norm. They preferred the regional languages for better understanding among the common people. Thus they utilised the prevailing languages of different places for religious propaganda and sacred literature. In this way they gave an impetus to the development of Prakrit language. Even they gave a literary shape to some of the regional languages for the first time.

Mahavir himself preached his teachings in a mixed dialect called *Ardha-Magadhi* so that people speaking *Magadhi* and *Sauraseni* languages could understand him properly. In the initial phase these two languages were very popular. Later on Jain literature was composed in Prakrit language.

Of late a rich treasure of literature produced by the Jains has come to limelight. It is known as *Apabhramsa* literature which forms a link between the classical languages like Sanskrit and Prakrit on the one hand and modern regional languages on the other. Even in early Kannada and Tamil literature we find traces of Jain influence. Further the Jain texts of twelve Angas, twelve Upangas, Agama and Kalpasutra were written in Sanskrit.

Thus Jainism indirectly helped the growth of literature of different types in Indian languages.

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Jainism has played a greater role in the development of artistic tradition of the country. It is true that the Jains did not believe in the existence of God. But at the same time it created a galaxy of deified men who were spiritually great. To pay reverence to these souls Jains all over the country erected several stupas. These stupas created in the honour of their saints are valuable gems of Indian architecture.

The accessories of stone railings, the decorated gateways, stone-umbrellas, elaborate carved pillars and numerous statues of the stupas evoke the appreciation of the observer for their artistic charm even today. Early specimens of Jain stupas are found at Mathura whereas Bundelkhand is full of Jain images of IIth and 12th century A.D.

The huge statue of Bahubali, known as Gomatesvara at Shravanbelgola (120 ft. height) is a marvel by itself. The stone carvings of Khandagiri and Udaygiri in Orissa give the impression of symbol-worship. The Jain *Ashtamangala* or eight auspicious signs such as a *Swastik,* a mirror, an urn, a cane seat shaped like an hour-glass, two fishes, a flower garland and a manuscript carved on the pedestal bear Jain artistic taste.

The Jains also built cave temples in rocks. The Jain cave temples at Udaygiri and Ellora and the Dilwara temple of Mount Abu are beautiful specimens of Jain architecture and sculpture. Junagadh, Junar, Osmanabad are other places where Jain art is preserved.

The numerous Jain places of pilgrimage such as the Parsvanath Hills, Pavapuri, Rajgir, Girnar and Palitana possess temples and other architectural monuments of different ages.

The Jain images include a long list of Indian divinities such as *Sri-Lakshmi, Dikpalas, Kubera, Navagraha, Saraswati* etc. In the Jain temples the images of Saraswati are not rare. Even one special Jain festival called *Jnana-Panchami* or *Sruta Panchami* is celebrated by the Jains in the honour of goddess *Saraswati.*

NON-VIOLENCE

Jainism influenced the Indian life style to a great extent. Its basic tenet of *Ahimsa* or non-violence has firmly been established as a rule of life. In the words of, A.N.Upadhyaya -

"Jain literature includes myths, fairy-tales, proverbs, popular stories, model behaviour, patterns and moral exhortations, all of which unanimously denounce cruelty to living beings. All these have done much to discourage animal sacrifice. Most of the Indian religions have casually preached *ahimsa.* But nowhere except in Jainism is the basic creed so systematically worked out to pervade the entire moral code."

Even in the twentieth century colonial India the apostle of non-violence Mahatma Gandhi, who gave a new lease of life to this principle, was greatly influenced by Jainism rather than any other Indian creed.

Jainism and Buddhism have been foremost in upholding the doctrine of *ahimsa* and Jainism has held firm to its original ideology more closely than that of Buddhism. Thus in a way in the Indian cultural field the most important contribution of Jainism is the concept of *ahimsa.*

SOCIETY

In the words of A.N.Upadhyaya :

"Numerous traces of Jain influence on Indian life can be detected. The worship of idols in a refined form, the building of temples, the founding of charitable lodges for men and animals, the preservation of rich libraries and manuscripts and the distribution of food and other necessities to the poor – these are some of the outstanding features of Jain society and to a large extent they have been imitated by other Indian religious groups."

As a community the Jains have been strict vegetarians and wherever they are found in large numbers they have influenced the social circle around them. To lead a life with minimum necessity, to bear no ill will towards anyone, to take recourse to fasting for self-purification, to undertake long tours on foot, to make contact with the people are routine affairs in a Jain's life. These various aspects of Jain routine have had deep impacts on Indian culture.

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RISE OF TRADING COMMUNITY

In the beginning Jainism was very popular among the traders and businessmen. The mercantile community was attracted by the rigorous asceticism and religious life of the Jains and adopted Jain way of life. Being bounded by a sense of fraternity they formed business guilds for smooth conduct of business. These wealthy merchants patronised Jainism to a great extent.

With the increasing social recognition and status, the rich merchants came closer to the ruling class. Jain laymen now began to play an important part in the political activities. This happened specially in Rajasthan during the Mughal period. Even during the time of English East India Company, Jain business families like the Jagatseths and the Singhis acted as state bankers and naturally weilded great influence in the society.

Jainism is still a living faith in some parts of India. The number of its followers is more than two million. But its contribution to India's cultural heritage is far more significant than its numerical strength. The tradition of art in India, enrichment and preservation of Indian literature and cultivation of both Aryan and Dravidian languages in a way show Jain influences which are really praiseworthy. The religious instincts of the Jains have also lasting impressions on Indian life style.

To conclude with the words of Prof. Radhakrishnan:

"When the storm of persecution swept over the land, Jainism simply took refuge in Hinduism which opened its capacious bosom to receive it and to the conquerors it seemed an indistinguishable part of the great system."

BUDDHISM

Among all the protestant religions, Buddhism became very popular for its mass appeal with its message of compassion, love, self-restraint and non-violence. It extended practically all over Asia and still continues to be a great force in the Far East. Unlike the Jains, the Buddhists never claim a remote antiquity behind their religion. Rather this religion with its strong social base and rational philosophy played a dominant role in the 6th century B.C.

TEACHINGS OF LORD BUDDHA

The teachings of Buddha were extremely simple and practical. The fundamental principles of Buddha's teachings are represented in his Four Noble Truths. Buddha keenly felt about the pain and sufferings of human beings. So in his very first sermon he mainly addressed to the basic causes of such sufferings and to find a way out for their end.

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS

The Four Noble Truths constitute the very essentials of his teachings illustrated by these four terms :

(i) Sufferings – that the world is full of sufferings.

(ii) Its Causes – that there are causes of sufferings.

(iii) Cessation of Sufferings – that these sufferings can be stopped.

(iv) The Way – that there is a path leading to the cessation of sufferings.

For Lord Buddha, the root of all sufferings lies in desire. Sufferings can stop with the annihilation of all desires. Those who want to get out of the clutches of suffering and want to achieve the ultimate end of human life, i.e., *Nirvana,* must follow a path.

ARYAN EIGHT-FOLD PATH

The path advocated by Lord Buddha to reach *Nirvana* is known as the Aryan Eight-fold path that comprises of eight important ways of life. They are :

1. Right Speech
2. Right Action
3. Right Means of livelihood
4. Right Exertion
5. Right Mindfulness
6. Right Meditation
7. Right Resolution
8. Right View

Buddha then summarised the whole process by dividing the human body into three parts - *Sila, Chittaand Prajna.* The observance of the first three principles lead to the physcial *(Sila)* development. By observing the second three, there occurs mental *(chitta)* development. The last two principles of right resoultion and right view bring about the development of intellect *(Prajna).* Thus, an all-round development of the human being can be made by following the above eight-fold principles. Then only can Nirvana be achieved - the eternal state of peace and bliss which means freedom from birth and death.

DOCTRINE OF KARMA

The philosophy of Buddhism was extremely rationalistic. It believed in the law of *Karma* and re-birth. One's present stage is determined by his past action. Otherwise he reaps the consequences of his own actions done in his previous birth. Since birth is the cause of all human sufferings and sorrows, it is by virtue of one's own *Karma* or action that

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man should try to get rid of birth. In fact, the Buddhist theory of *Karma* is like that of the Hindus and it contradicts the philosophy of Jainism which refutes the theory of action.

DOCTRINE OF AN-ATTA OR NO SOUL

One of the specific contributions of Buddhism is its doctrine *of an-atta* or no-soul. Dualistic Hinduism, Islam, Christianity and even Jainism postulate the existgnce of a soul behind the changing states of consciousness-in every individual. This soul is the I- making principle in every person that differentiates him from others. According to Buddha, as it is impossible to locate the flame of the lamp after the wick and oil have been consumed, it is similarly impossible to search for a soul after the dissolution of the human body. The concepts of continuity and transmigration can be better explained without postulating anything like soul or ego.

DOCTRINE OF NON-EXISTENCE OF GOD

Buddha is silent about the existence of the Creator or God. For this he is sometimes regarded as an atheist. He was primarily concerned with the sufferings of human beings. So he thought it futile to ponder much about the mystery of creation arid its Creator. Rather like a rationalist he paid more emphasis on the good and evil deeds of human beings. For him, vices and sufferings, virtues and happiness were related to the performance of one's duty or deed.

EMPHASIS ON PRACTICAL MORALITIES

Because of its practical and pragmatic approach Buddhism had a mass appeal. It was regarded as a welcome relief from the priest – dominated and caste-ridden rigours of Brahmanism. Buddha freed religion from the elaborate and costly rituals and opposed the infallibility of the Vedas. Further, he made religion more lively and acceptable by laying stress on practical moralities of life that were essential for a common householder. It inculded the following :

- Ahimsa or abstinence from killing.
- Respect for animal life.
- Reverence for the superiors.
- Service to the humanity.
- Relieving the sufferings of mankind

Futher, Buddha made the life of the community happier by abolishing caste - systems. The status of those belonging to the lower orders was raised for attainment of social and spiritual freedom.

These are in brief the main teachings of Lord Buddha. A critical analysis of the doctrines reveals that Buddhism, like Jainism, was originally a moral code rather than a metaphysical or religious system in the western "Sense of the term.

The dying words of Lord Buddha to his disciples, "To be lamps unto themselves as there is no other light", reveal the very essence of his simple teachings.

CULTURAL CONTRIBUTION

Buddhism remained a powerful force in the socio-cultural set up, of India for almost one and a half thousand years. It was nm merely confined to India. Within a short span of time it reached /the soil of various Asian countries like Myanmar, China, Japan, Indonesia, Cambodia etc. During its long journey over the Indian sub-continent itself, Buddhism influenced the Indian cultural heritage to a remarkable extent. The cultural assimilation of Hinduism and Buddhism have been manifested in different manners. The following accounts of the Buddhist cultural contributions speak for themselves.

SIMPLICITY AND NATURALITY

Buddhism presented itself in a simple and natural manner. Common people could understand the essence of religion in a very lucid style. It was devoid of Vedic complexity, complicated and meaningless rituals and the predominance of the Brahmanical class. The very simple ethical code of the religion, emotional elements, popular methods of teachings, natural way of worship and prayer etc introduced a personal element to the religious belief of the people. People liked it and appreciated it and there arose a natural tendency among them to accept the religion without any external force.

INFLUENCE ON HINDUISM

Although it may sound strange, Buddhism has influenced Hinduism in a number of ways, especially in the fashion of image-worship of the Hindus.

As a matter of fact, after the departure of Buddha, Buddhism was divided into Mahayana Buddhism and Hinayana Buddhism. The Mahayana Buddhists developed the system of the worship of the image of Buddha. Inspired by this Mahayana practice The Hindus too developed the system of worshipping different images of gods and goddesses. They began to erect temples in the honour of these deities. Prior to Buddhism, Vedic Hinduism consisted mainly of sacrifices and yo/nas in the open air. Further the complex rituals of Hinduism admitted into their fold the Buddhist way of prayer and meditation.

In addition, the doctrine of ahimsa or non-violence which constitutes a very important aspect of Buddhism became a part of Hindu religion. The emphasis on the life of animals, pity, compassion and respect for life in all forms, negative attitude towards animal sacrifices had made Buddhism more popular and acceptable. These lofty ideals were highly appreciated by the scholars and pundits of Hinduism. They

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incorporated these ideals into their writings. Gradually this led to the rise of a particular phase of Bhagavat religion which completely believed in the principle of non-violence.

MONASTIC SYSTEM

A new feature of Buddhism was its monastic system that later became a part of our culture. Monastery is an organisation of devotees of a particular order based on discipline and community life. The monastic order is built around a democratic system. When the number of Buddhist monks, nuns and followers increased they used to stay in various monasteries in groups called *Sangha.* In due course these Buddhist *Sanghas* became a very important part of Buddhism for general spiritual uplift. The Hindu saints and sages of later years were much influenced by this monastic system. The growth of Hindu *Mathas* owe their origin to this Buddhist concept. Like Buddhist monasteries, these *Mathas* were actively engaged in moral and spiritual pursuit.

LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

The birth and growth of Buddhism have left behind it a rich heritage in the field of language and literature. In the initial stage, Lord Buddha used to preach in Prakrit, Magadhi and other dialects for the general public to understand his teachings/ Later he also used Pali. Therefore, the Buddhist literature that came into existence were in Pali and other dialects. During the reign of Kanishka Sanskrit became the medium of preaching. But only the Pali version of Buddhist literature has survived in its entirety.

All the postulates of Buddhism have been recorded in the Pali version *oiTripitaka.* They are *Vinaya* (Conduct) *Pitaka, Sutta* (Sermon) *Pitaka* and *Abhi'dhamma (Metaphysics) Pitaka.* Besides these *Tripitakas,* a vast non-canonical literature developed mostly as commentaries to explain the canonical texts of the Buddhist monks outside India. The Sri Lankan monks took the lead in producing vast volumes of such non-canonical texts.

Both these canonical and non-canonical texts were written in Pali language. In the Buddhist monasteries and *viharas* the beginnings of vernacular Pali literature were made which later developed into lengthy volumes. The attempt of the Buddhists to spread their messages through various languages has not only enriched the literary heritage of the country but has also set the academic tradition on proper footing.

Buddhist literature like Jataka stories, scriptures like the Pitakas, philosophy of Nagarjuna, Asvaghosh, Tantric texts of Vajrayan, logic of Mahayana Buddhism, chronicles of Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa are invaluable gems of Indian culture. Indeed, Buddhist philosophers and writers added a new and glorious feather to the cultural spirit of our country.

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Apart from literature, Buddhism also left its indelible mark on Indian art tradition. Prior to the birth of Buddhism the Indian art tradition was confined to the construction of pandals and *mandaps, yajnasala* (place for fire sacrifice), *yajnaved* or altars etc. In other words, Indian architecture was at its rudimentary stage. Under the patronage of Buddhism different areas of art like architecture, sculpture and painting began to prosper.

From the time of the Buddhist king, Ashoka, stones began to be used in sculptural works. The early Buddhist monuments at Sanchi, Bharut, Bodhgaya, Amravati, Dhauli, Jaugad, Rumindei etc are examples of Buddhist art treasures.

The system of making *stambhas* or pillars bearing religious emblem was a novel concept. Further, construction *ofstupas* over the relics of Buddha and the *Bodhisattvas* added a new artistic dimension. A number *ofviharas* came into existence as a heritage of Buddhist art for giving permanent abode to Buddhist monks.

These different manifestations of Buddhist art had its reflection on the continuing Indian style. Ashokan pillars, *stupas* at Sanchi, cave temples of Kanheri and Karle are brilliant specimens of Buddhist architecture.

Two masterpieces of Buddhist sculpture, the standing Buddha statue of Mathura and the seated Buddha of Sarnath, show the sculptural excellence of Buddhist artists.

Even painting did not lag behind. The cave paintings of Karle, Bagh, Ajanta and Ellora display the maturity in style and finish of the Indian painters.

The subject matter of Buddhist art revolved around themes of compassion for nature, attachment for the life of animals and love for mankind. The current of life flows in a majestically lively way in these artistic works that the artists had left for posterity. Buddhist art of Gandhara and Mathura have left behind an everlasting impression on Indian culture.

POLITICAL UNITY

Buddhism has come a long way in establishing itself in the pages of Indian history. Its cardinal concept of non-violence profoundly influenced Ashoka, the third'king of the Mauryan dynasty. After the horrors of Kalinga War in 261 B.C., he was converted from Ashoka, the Ogre, to Ashoka, the Virtuous, from *Chandashoka* to *Dharmashoka,* under the influence of Buddhism.

The violent march of Indian history not only received a jolt but it also changed its course in a non-violent, pious and benevolent way. Ashokan policy of winning human hearts by love and compassion, paternal form of governance, charity for all forms of life added new dimensions to the rich cultural heritage of the country.

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Even in the colonial period the great exponent of truth and non-violence, Mahatma Gandhi, gave a fresh orientation to this age-old Buddhist concept which went a long way in achieving freedom from the British.

Buddhism spread to every nook and corner of the land. The very spread of Buddhism within one geographical unit of Bharatavarsha created a sense of unity among its follwers. The idea of national unity, solidarity and integrity of the soil was thus facilitated by this religion. The message of equality, fraternity, the voice of protest against caste-system, emancipation of women as nuns of the Buddhist order, literary awakening etc were hugely responsible for the growth of political unity over this vast land.

MESSENGER OF UNIVERSALITY

Buddhism became the cultural messenger of India to China, Mongolia, Korea, Japan, Burma, Indonesia and Ceylon since the days of Ashoka. In the words of Arnold Toynbee,

"... at the religious level, India has not been a recipient, she has been a giver. About half the total of the number of the living higher religions are of Indian origin. About half the human race today adheres to either Hinduism or Buddhism."

Thus not only in India but also abroad Buddhism took a leading role in spiritual awakening which constitutes the very essence of Indian culture. The vastness and richness of Indian culture and its universal appeal were reflected in Buddhist way of life and were made known to the outsiders. They came to know about India through Buddhism, saw India through Buddha and realised the Indian spirit with their grasp of Indian culture.

As a religion, Buddhism had a widespread influence on different aspects of Indian culture. It manifested itself in various ways - paleographic, linguistic, literary, religious, philosophical, social, ethical, artistic etc. Patient study, careful observation and prudent judgement are required to understand the vast significance of this religion.

Buddhism has remained a vital force, an inspiration and above all, a guidance to our traditions and customs. In sum, its unique contributions in the various fields of culture has greatly enriched Indian cultural heritage, apart from adding to the religious diversity of the land.

IMPACT OF ISLAM ON INDIAN CULTURE

Islam as an independent religion made its emergence in the first half of the 7th century A.D. Prophet Mohammad was the founder of this religion. He gave a cultural and spiritual unity to the people of Arab who accepted this new religion. The followers of Islam are called the Muslims.

The Arab invasion of Sindh in 712 A.D. was a notable event in the annals of Indian history because for the first time the Muslims attacked India under the leadership of Muhammad Bin Kasim.

Consequently the Muslims acquired political supremacy over the land and continued to rule over India for about five centuries. Of course, this was not the first foreign rule in India.

Long before the arrival of the Muslims, foreign rulers like Indo-Greeks, Sakas, Indo-Parthians and Kushanas had ruled over significant parts of the Indian sub-continent. Though these outsiders ruled India politically, soon they were influenced by the socio-cultural traits of Hinduism. Hinduism with its all-assimilative force Indianised these alien invaders and brought them into its fold. As these early foreigners lacked a clearly defined religious system, on their arrival in India they readily embraced the spiritual ideals of the country. They were never proselytised to accept Hinduism but became indivisible members of this great religion without any hesitation.

The situation, however, was different with Islam. It was a full-fledged religious faith with proper language, script, laws, customs and even a theory of state. Naturally with the growth of Islam, the other pre-Islamic states of central Asia came under the powerful spell of Islam and they were all Islamised.

In India, therefore, Islam remained as a unique exception to the strong assimilative force of Hinduism. The idea of absorption into Hinduism became quite ineffective when it came in contact with Islam. These Muslim invaders remained as a distinct unit being conscious of their own identity. The Muslim rulers maintained their courts, officials, bureaucracy, legal system, language, practices, customs and beliefs in their own style. The Sultanate period, ranging from the 13th century till the advent of the Mughals in 1526 A.D. was very eventful. During this period due to the influence of Islam two religious movements, namely Sufi and Bhakti, brought about a tremendous change in the socio-cultural scenario of India.

It is *a* fact of history that whenever two communities with separate backgrounds, civilisations and cultures stay together for centuries, it is quite natural that they influence each other mutually. History is replete with such phenomena. However opposing or different their outlooks may be, a cultural interaction does take place. Exactly the same process took place in the medieval period of Indian history.

The Sufi saints from the Muslim community and the Bhakti preachers of Hinduism tried to bridge the gap by asserting the oneness of two religions with emphasis on devotion and true piety. They asserted the effectiveness of two religions, which were but different paths leading to the realisation of the same invisible power-God or Allah. **Sarkar and Dutta** rightly remark, "The Hindus and the Mohmmedans

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of India had come to be considerably influenced by each other's thoughts and customs and mutual toleration was taking the place of medieval fanaticism."

Both the communities now began to imbibe each other's thoughts, traditions and customs. This Hindu-Muslim unity left tremendous impact on the cultural domain of India.

LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

One of the most significant results of Hindu-Muslim co-existence was felt in the realm of language and literature.

During the time of Muslim rule in India, the rulers introduced their own languages like Arabic and Persian into Indian administration. The existing Indian languages such as Hindi, Bengali, Marathi, Tamil, Gujrati etc were considerably influenced by Persian, Arabic and Turkish languages of the Muslim community. In this process of linguistic intermingling, the literary tradition of the country underwent a sea-change. Many books in different Indian languages were translated into Persian and Arabic and the vice versa.

The court language of the Muslim rulers in India was Persian. So much importance was given to the writing of history of India in Persian. Further, the rulers patronised the growth of Persian learning and arts. As a result, monumental historical accounts were compiled during this period that serve as invaluable historical sources even today. Prominent among them are :

- *Taj-ul-Maasir* by Hasan Niazami
- *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri* by Minaj Siraj
- *Tarikh-i-Firujsahi* and
- *Fatwah-i-Jahangiri* by Ziauddin Barani
- *Tarikh-i-Firujsahi* by Afif
- *Futuh-us-Salatin* by Isami
- *Tarikh-i-Mubaraksahi* by Yahya Sirhindi
- *Khajain-ul-Futuh* and
- *Thugug Nama* by Amir Khashru

Besides such historical accounts, noteworthy Sanskrit works too were translated into Arabic and Persian. They are:

- *Tutt Nama (Book of the Parrot)*
- A collection of Fifty-two short stories by Zia Nakhshabi
- Translation of *Bhagavat Parana* by Raja Todarmal
- Translation of *Atharva Veda* and *Ramayana* by Mullah Abdul Qadir Badani
- Translation of *Panchatantra* by Ibn-ul-Muquaffa
- Translation of classical works on mathematics of Ulibati into Arabic by Faizi
- Translation of certain parts of *Mahabharat* into Arabic by Abu Salih Ibn and later by Abul Hassan Ali

Firoz Tughlaq had ordered the translation of certain books on medicine in Sanskrit into Persian. Abul Fazal and his brother Faizi translated the Sanskrit works into Persian usually with the help of Sanskrit pundits and scholars. Translation of Arabic, Turkish and Kashmiri works were also undertaken.

During the reign of Sultan Zainul Abidin of Kashmir, *Mahabharata* and *Rajtarangini* were translated into Kashmiri language. The famous adventures of Sindbad the sailor were translated and included in the *Arabian Nights* which was partly of Indian origin.

The translation of Sanskrit works into Persian continued with similar momentum throughout the entire Muslim period. The Mughal rulers even patronised the famous Hindi poets like Sunderdas, Chintamani, Kavindra Acharya, Jagannath Tripathy, Indrajit Tripathy and Samant. Amir Khushru, Amir Hasan, Dihalvi and Malik Muhammad Jaisi were Persian poets of repute who penned their immortal works during this period.

The tradition of writing history got impetus during the Mughal period. The famous chroniclers of the, period were Abul Fazl, Nizamuddin ^imad, Badauni, Abdul Hamid Lahori, Khafi Khan and Saqi Mustaid Khan. Moreover, rulers like Jahangir and ladies from the royal family like Gulbadan Begum too recorded socio-political accounts of their age for posterity.

BIRTH OF URDU

The most remarkable impact of foreign languages on the indigenous literary tradition was the birth of Urdu language. It was popularly called the camp language during the Mughal period. It was born out of military necessity to understand each other when the Rajputs and Muslim soldiers camped at one place to fight a war or suppress a rebellion on behalf of the emperor.

The common language of the Indians was Hindi and under the Sultans Persian was the court language. By continuous interaction between, the two languages a mixed variety of language called Urdu was born having Persian script and many resemblances with Hindi language and style. Thus Urdu became the most volatile and lyrical language which was basically a product of linguistic synthesis. Urdu rose to prominence during the early phase of British rule in India. In subsequent years, the British authorities elevated Urdu to the status of court language. Since then it has retained its status as a powerful and flourishing language of India.

VERNACULAR LANGUAGE

Indian vernacular language had been benefitted by Islamic influence to a great extent. The Muslim rulers of Bengal and

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Lucknow were great patrons of Bengali and Hindi literatures. In the South the Sultans of Bijapur and Golconda also encouraged this trend. Muslim influence on Hindi language, grammar, rhetoric and style are now accepted facts. Similarly in Gujrati, Marathi and Punjabi languages, the imprints of Persian and Arabic languages are quite obvious. It has been rightly noted by Prof Sarkar and Dutta,

"Muslim writers wrote in vernaculars on subjects of Hindu life and tradition as Jaisi did on Padmini and Hindu writers too produced works after Muslim literary tradition in Persian languages as Rai Bhanamal did in the line of chronicles."

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

With the establishment of Muslim rule in India there was a marked growth in cultural excellence in the realm of art and architecture. The Muslim rulers of India were great patrons of art. They brought with them significant impressions of Islamic style of art. New designs, new modes of construction like spherical domes, arches, tall minarets, open courtyards, pillared caves, huge walls etc were introduced in architectural creations following the Islamic style. But these changes in designs were carried out by Hindu craftsmen. As a result a fusion of Hindu and Muslim styles of art took place. From this interaction a new style of art called Indo-Islamic art tradition gradually evolved. To quote Sir John Marshall,

"Indo-Islamic art was neither merely a local variety of Islamic art nor a modified form of Hindu architecture. It derives its character from both sources though not always in an equal degree."

Thus with a new majestic spirit Indo-Islamic art manifested itself through different channels that included two types of structure, namely,

(i) Religious structure

(ii) Secular structure

Religious structures mainly consisted of mosques and tombs. Secular structures included those meant for public and civic purposes like palaces, forts, town gates etc.

The first phase of Muslim rule in India, i.e., from 1206 A.D. to 1526 A.D., otherwise called the Sultanate period, is marked by three styles of architecture :

(i) Imperial or Delhi style of architecture

(ii) Provincial style, of architecture

(iii) Hindu style of architecture

IMPERIAL OR DELHI STYLE OF ARCHITECTURE

Imperial or Delhi style of architecture is to be found in Delhi and its neighbouring areas. The following important structures come under this style :

- Qutab Minar
- Quwwat-al-Islam Mosque
- Alwai Darwaja
- Kali Masjid
- Begumpuri Mosque
- Sikri fort and city
- Tombs of Mubarak Sayyid and Sikandar Lodhi
- Bada Gumbad Mosque

The Qutab Muiar was the most impressive among them all. In the words of Mercy Brown,

"Qutab Minar as a whole is the most impressive conception, the vivid colour of its red sandstone, the changing texture of its fluted storeyes with their overlay of plain masonry and rich carvings, the shimmer of the shadows under the balconies, all combine to produce an effect of marked vitality."

PROVINCIAL STYLES OF ARCHITECTURE

After the decline of the Sultanate of Delhi the rulers of provincial dynasties asserted independence and began to build tombs, mosques and palaces on their own. Hence these structures had their respective regional trends and manifestations that were quite different from the Delhi style of architecture. They formed a separate category called Provincial style of architecture. This style was enriched with local artistic traditions and technical differences. Within this distinct category the following structures deserve specific mention :

- Tomb of Sah-Rukn-i-Alam in Punjab,
- Adiana Masjid, Dakhil Darwaja, Chhota Sona Masjid and Bada Sona Masjid of Bengal,
- Jami Masjid, Teen Darwaja, Tomb of Ahmad Shah in Gujrat,
- Jahaj Mahal, Ashrafi Mahal, Hindola Mahal, Tomb of Hushang Shah in Malwa,
- Biwi-ki-Masjid in Khandesh,
- Chand Minar of Daulatabad, Gol Gumbaz, Mithar Mahal, Zenana Mahal and Deval Mosque in the Deccan.

HINDU STYLE OF ARCHITECTURE

When the Sultanate of Delhi lavishly patronised the architectural growth of the country, the Hindu rulers also did not lag behind. Different Hindu ruling dynasties extended their helping hands for the growth of structures of art. These Hindu structures had their own peculiarities marked by narrow pillars, cornice or *chhaja,* corbel brackets,

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tapering arches, decorative designs and figures with liberal doses of religious sanctity. This style of architecture flourished mainly in Rajasthan and at Vijaynagar in the South. Some examples of this style are :

- Tower of Victory at Chittor
- Fort of Kumbhalgarh
- Jai Stambha in Rajasthan
- Vithala Temple

MUGHAL PERIOD

From 1526 A.D. to 1707 A.D. the Mughal rulers ruled over India. It was during this period that Indo-Islamic architecture reached the pinnacle of glory and magnificence. The artistic temperament of the rulers and economic prosperity along with liberal royal support brought in its wake an outburst of architectural activities. Prominent structures of the Mughal period include the following :

- Purana Qilla in Delhi
- Tomb of Sher Shah at Sasaram
- Tomb of Humayun at Delhi
- Buland Darwaja, Diwan-i-khas akFatehpur Sikri
- Tomb of Akbar at Sikandara.
- Jama Masjid
- Red Fort at Delhi and Agra
- Taj Mahal
- Tomb of Itimad-ud-Daula at Agra

The architectures of the Mughal period are marked by splendour and form, graceful domes, magnificent palace halls, decorated gateways of slender pillars. These pieces of architecture reveal a splendid synthesis of Persian and Indian style - Muslim structure with Hindu decoration. To quote Tara Chand,

"The craftsmanship, ornamental richness and general design remained largely Hindu while the arches, plain domes, smooth' faced walls and spacious interiors were Muslim superimposition."

The other side of the picture is equally interesting. From the second half of the 16th century Hindu buildings showed traces of Mughal architecture. The romantic city of Amber, the palaces of Bikaner, the fortresses of Jodhpur and Orchna are the most notable instances of this style.

PAINTING

The art of Indian painting got a new lease of life during this period. Of course long back during the ancient period of Indian history painting had formed a part and parcel of Indian tradition. It had always been a speciality of the Indians to maintain the tradition of Bacterial art. Hindus, Buddhists and Jains had carried on their paintings with carved statues and murals. The Ajanta paintings of the Gupta period are the most glorious examples.

The Hindu art of mural painting underwent a remarkable change with the arrival of the Mughals who brought with them the tradition of Chinese-cum-Persian painting. It began with the Mughal ruler Humayun who was quite familiar with this tradition. Famous painters of Mughal India were Mir Sayyid Ali, Dost Mohammad, Basawan, Mansur, Abul Hasan.

The themes of the paintings were quite varied. They consisted of *Razmnama* (Persian translation of the *Mahabharat), Hamzanama* (story of Prophet Muhammad's uncle Amir Hamza), *Tarik-i-Alfi* (story of the first thousand years of Islam) and *Padshanama* (description of court ceremonies and other important events).

Towards the later part of the Mughal rule, the Rajput School and Pahari School of painting began to develop under local patronage. Though Rajput school was indigenous by nature, after coming in contact with Muslim painting, it was completely transformed and gave birth to Kanga School of painting in the 18th century. Among Pahari School of painting Basoli, Chamba and Jammu groups were noteworthy. All these schools centred around representation of mythological themes.

Thus in the field of art, architecture and painting Muslim influence maintained its uniqueness and excellence and constituted a significant phase in the annals of Indian art.

MUSIC

The Islamic impact was also felt keenly in the realm of music. The Muslim rulers were great lovers of music. So they openly patronised the growth of music and musicians in the country.

During this period Islamic music came in close contact with Indian classical music. From this synthesis a number of new musical regulations and instruments came into existence. Even the Indian musical treatise *Raag Darpan* was translated into Persian during the reign of Firuz Tughlaq. The Indian musical instrument veena combined with Iranian tambura led to the birth of a new string instrument called

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sitar. Besides, various other new instruments were born out of this cultural synthesis like rabab and tabla.

Among the regional patrons of music mention may be made of Sultan Hussain Sharqi of Jaunpur and Raja Mansingh of Gwallior. With such a mixed patronage from Hindu and Muslim rulers a lot of changes were introduced in the Indian traditional 'ragas' and 'raginis' (melodies) to suit the demand of the audiences. The introduction of Thumri, Khayal, Qawali and Raga Dhrupad made Indian classical compositions more melodious.

Ain-i-Akbari provides a list of thirty six musicians in the court of Akbar who were very talented and were known all over the country. Several preachers of Bhakti cult and Sufism also adopted music as a way of their teachings. Saint Sarangadeva wrote the Encyclopaedia of Indian music known as *Sangeeta Ratnakar.*

GARDENS

The impact of Islamic culture found another outlet in the setting up of public and royal gardens. The art of gardening reached perfection during the time of Mughals who had great taste for the same.

Prior to the arrival of the Mughals the concept of gardening as a form of fine arts had not emerged. The Mughals were not only lovers of nature but also possessed the aesthetic sense to find relief from the toils of daily life through gardening. With due patronage from the rulers a systematic science *-of* gardening with certain forms and designs began to develop.

Geometrically the Mughal Gardens was in the form a square, divided into four fold plots called *char-bagh.* It had an artificial irrigation system in the form of channels, tanks or dwarf waterfalls. The main pavillion was built either on the topmost terrace or on the lowest one to allow the visitor to have a complete look of the garden. Kabul Bagh and Shalimar Bagh were some of the most famous specimens of such gardens.

OTHER ARTS

Under the Islamic influence various other branches of arts also developed in India. Many new arts and crafts with Islamic origin began to emerge in the Indian cultural scene. The art of making jewellery with setting of pearl and other precious stones on gold and silver ornaments reached its perfection. The Peacock Throne of diamonds, emeralds, rubies and pearls is a legendary masterpiece of the Mughal period.

For embroidery works on dresses and curtains, *karkhanas* (factories) witM labourers, craftsmen and master artists sprang up in different parts of the country. Works on stones, marbles, metals, ivory, enamel paintings, making of paper, floral and other colourful designs on walls and glasspanes were the result of Islamic influences. Art of calligraphy, weaving and dyeing also developed during the Mughal rule. With such innovative techniques, silk brocades, magnificent carpets, muslin clothes and shawls began to be very popular.

Thus, Islamic impact left a lasting influence on various aspects of Indian culture. The indigenous cultural tradition underwent a great transformation after coming in contact with Islamic heritage over several centuries in the realms of literature, art, social customs etc. The effects of this cultural synthesis are no longer alien and have become an integral part of Indian culture.

IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY ON INDIAN SOCIETY

Major factor of influence Christianity are the missionaries. Initially the missionaries worked in the tribal areas and among the untouchable populations but later on spread their activities in urban areas too.

"In India Christianity has been one of the important factors of modernization and economic development through the social values it has legitimised " (Victor D'Souza, 1994). The essence of Christianity is universal brotherhood, egalitarian outlook, and service of the underprivileged. Consistent with its' social philosophy. Christianity attacked the evils of the caste system in India and contributed immensely to loosening up the system through its preaching oriented towards the formation of an egalitarian society based on self respect and social justice. Undoubtedly, Christianityhas contributed to the 'opening up' of Indian society and has provided a healing touch to the underpriveleged especially the victims of the oppressive caste system. Christianity has been one of the earliest agencies of social welfare for the weaker sections and through the vast network of social services has been able to provide educational and medical facilities to the relatively isolated regions of India untouched by government support in these areas. The best evidence in favour of this statement is the high rates of literacy in areas where Christianity and it's social services network has been relatively strong. ■

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EMERGING TRENDS AND CONTRIBUTIONS OF INDIAN ANTHROPOLOGISTS AGAINST THE BACKDROP OF WORLD ANTHROPOLOGY

ABSTRACT

The history of anthropology is replete with several theoretical and methodological turning points that characterize the healthy trend of an ever-growing discipline. In anthropology, since its inception, we have witnessed the opening up of a number of new horizons. This way many a sub-field came into being. Recently the emphasis has been shifted gradually to more and more problem oriented issues that stalk human existence at present. It does not mean that this phenomenon has altogether obliterated the relevance of sub-disciplinary boundaries of anthropology, but it has freed anthropology from its stereotypic fixation. This trend is well reflected in the works of Indian anthropologists. How they have responded to the emerging currents of anthropology can be understood from the nature of work they presented in the national and international forum. Here an attempt has been made to isolate the major areas of interest of the Indian anthropologists, the issues addressed or raised by them and how it comes in the context of world anthropology.

Right from the very inception of anthropology in India, it has been trying to find a cause with the surrounding milieu. This pragmatics of the discipline should not be undermined on the grounds of any pure hermeneutical or epistemological reasons, because as a matter of fact, the subject has remained a quite well responding entity till this date and so to remain in the days to come. It should not be denied that anthropology in India has been influenced by the currents of world anthropology since its beginning in our country. The study of society and culture is social- cultural anthropology in our country and here we are influenced by the social anthropological tradition of Britain and cultural anthropological tradition of United States. This needs no elaboration because we are all familiar with this generic past. But beyond a simple familiarity there have been attempts to know this past and to critically understand it to ferret out the roots of current trends. Majumdar (1950, c.f. Vidyarthi and Rai, 1984,pp. 10) made a pioneering attempt in this regard.Vidyarthi (1984, 1991) has shown the rise of anthropology in India, that took place up to 1980s. Mahapatra (1974) has made a very brief but pithy analysis of development of cultural anthropology in India. He has shown the major areas of research done by the Indian anthropologists until that period. After that much lead has been effected in the field of anthropology. Some scholars have attempted to identify the thrust areas of the research during this period (Bera 1995; Das 1998; Sarkar 2003).We shall discuss this later in some detail. Now it is important again to identify the emerging areas of anthropology in this rapidly changing world.

The present paper endeavours to identify the major areas of contributions of Indian anthropologists as reflected from their presentations in the international forum. Here the papers presented in the ICAESs in 1988, 1998, 2003 have been taken into consideration to see the trend. These are again set against the publications in a major journal of anthropology in India - *Journal of the Indian Anthropological Society.*

Mahapatra (1974) divided the major areas of research into six main types. These were - 1.Development and patterning of Indian Civilization 2.Cultural change. 3.Contribution to theoretical anthropology. 4.Culture and personality study. 5.Study of kinship. 6.Study of religion. Now this classification needs revision in the light of current development in the discipline. This will be quite evident if we look at the contributions made by Indian anthropologists in the global arena. Sarkar (2003) identified the major approaches of study as reflected in the works undertaken in the Anthropological Survey of India. These approaches are: Ethnographic approach, Short term survey of social/ cultural/ political movements, Area study approach, Quick survey approach, Micro-level approach. These approaches have resulted into works in diversified fields. Some of these fields include management of environment and natural resources, study of traditional knowledge, folkart, folkmusic, urban anthropology, development, regionalism, psychological and ecological perspectives of culture etc.

INDIAN IN THE GLOBAL

Social-Cultural anthropology has certain conventionalized sub-divisional categories such as Political anthropology, Economic anthropology, Ecological anthropology, Medical anthropology etc. along with the study of social structure, family, marriage, kinship, religion and the like. In the late 1980s and in the 1990s we noticed how these conventionalized areas had been fussed with each other and rather more thematic areas of study were emerging. However

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these thrust or thematic areas have changed over the years, still we may say that the emphasis remained more upon problem oriented issues rather than on theoretical issues. This is neither entirely an applied kind of undertaking nor it is absolutely theoretical one; it is a stage of between and betwixt. This is probably the best description for this neo-theoretical position. Now, if we chart out the common areas of research into which Indian anthropologists have been contributing for a period of 15 years the areas will be as given below.

From the table one cannot find any consistent trend of growth or decline of any particular area of study. It is characterized by the differential emphases at different points of time. For example, we see a spurt of work on ecology in the late 1980s this trend waned in the later years. There was very little work on human rights in 1998, but it grew into enormous proportion in 2003. Only certain areas like study on health, magic, rituals and applied anthropology have maintained a more or less consistent trend.

Table: *Comparison of issues common and discussed in three ICAESs, figures against each topic are in percentage*

Sl. No.	Topic	1988	1998	2003
1.	Ecology	38.9	5.8	8.1
2.	Health	4.5	11.1	8.6
3.	Development	16.9	5.	
4.	Gender	3	5.3	
5.	Ethnicity	2	9.7	
6.	Forest		6	15.3
7.	Theory			
8.	Aging	4.1	2.5	
9.	Children		5.7	
10.	Human rights		1.2	8.6
11.	Magic & rituals	8.1	5	
12.	Applied	8.1	11	

The areas of emphasis have been shifted from time to time. In the 2003 ICAES session, the Indian anthropologists contributed most in the field of indigenous knowledge (32 percent of the total papers contributed by Indian anthropologist to the congress). Next comes the area of forest management and climatic change (15.2 percent) followed by collective violence and human rights (8.6 percent) and medical anthropology (8.6 percent). In the preceding congress (14th ICAES; 1998), the major thrust areas of Indian anthropologist were social-cultural dimension of health (medical anthropology), applied anthropology and ethnicity. But in this congress we do not find any lopsidedness of the Indian anthropologists to study any particular fields of research, which was very much evident in the congress ten years back. There over half of the total contributions were shared by only two fields – ecology (38.99 percent) and development (16.97 percent).

Now the question which seems most pertaining to this situation is whether the issues of ecology and development have lost their relevance. The answer is, I think, not a straitjacketed one because the issues of ecology and development became diversified and the anthropologists began to address them separately. For example the theme of ecology got subdivided into the sub-themes like ecology of aging, global environmental change and human dimensions, international perspective of ecology, environmental crisis, and resource management through indigenous knowledge etc. This sub-thematic classification took place in 1998 Congress. By the next Congress the issue of indigenous knowledge grew into a full-fledged area of study into which Indian anthropologists contributed in quite astonishingly high proportion (32 percent). But this field is not again a homogenous field of inquiry under a single thematic boundary. In fact, it got classified into the following areas: indigenous knowledge and sustainable development, science in society: relevance of indigenous knowledge and wisdom in 21st century, revised anthropological studies on the adivasis of Andaman, anthropology of sociopolitical empowerment of indigenous people, involuntary displacement and sustainable livelihood restoration, strategy for tribal development in India, maintain oriented and water-oriented groups, interaction between human groups and lacustrine environment in Mesoamerica, the sacred circle nation population. Here, we see that the issue of tribal development has been included in the domain of indigenous knowledge.

The theme of development, for example, too, has been shifted from more assessment-oriented study to participatory kind. Now it prescribes the area to be addressed in more detail. A perusal of the sub thematic divisions under the broader area of development supports the above proposition. In 1998, these sub-areas were: participatory development, sustainable development, role of ethnic culture in development, issues of gender in development and role of anthropology in design and implementation of developmental projects.

It can be said that now the earlier notions of sub disciplinary boundaries are being gradually replaced by the thematic issues which are being addressed across the perimeters of traditional sectarian categories. This trend will grow as anthropology would try to make it more relevant to the changing sociopolitical scenario.

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It is a fact that all the emerging trends in the world anthropology have been reflected in the publications in the different journals of anthropology in India. It is undenying that each country has its own priorities. So is the case in India. The societies and culture differ from one country to other. Thus, it is quite natural that Indian anthropology has charted out its own priorities. But at the same time, it is a part of global knowledge society. Therefore it is to respond to some extent to the developments taking place globally. In fact, we can isolate some of these repercussions. The majority of the papers in social-cultural anthropology published in last 20 years in the *Journal of the Indian Anthropological Society* deal with the following two issues - ecology and ethnicity, followed by the studies in health, development, social structure and theoretical issues. The studies in ethnicity increased in the 1990s. Highest number of contribution took place in 1998. At the same time it can be said that though the anthropologists in India publishing in good number on theoretical issues here; but in international forum contributions in this field is miniscule. Here they have made a good number of studies on social structure, family, marriage and kinship. It is no longer a field of direct enquiry in world anthropology.

The field of indigenous knowledge and technology that figured as the predominant area of contribution by the Indian anthropologists in 15th ICAES, 2003 still remains major area of research. The categories of ecology and development are much on the wane compared to the fields like indigenous knowledge or people. Same was the case with medical anthropology and applied anthropology. Applied anthropology is probably transforming itself to more management, business and knowledge based studies. And as the recent focus of study is being more on problem oriented or thematic issues, then the applied anthropology has to transform.

THE GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT ISSUE

The attempts made by Majumdar (1950, ibid.) and Vidyarthi (1984, 1991) were directed to locate the trends of anthropology in India. Taking cue from Penniman, Majumdar (1950,ibid.) divided Indian anthropology into Formulatory (1974-1919), Constructive (1920-1937) and Critical (1938-) periods. Vidyarthi (1972, 1976, 1991) brought little changes in the temporal span of the above mentioned periods. Moreover he replaced the 'Critical period' by 'Analytical period'. In Vidyarthi's classification, now the historical divisions of the Social- Cultural anthropology in India appear to be the following: Formative Period (1774-1919), Constructive period (1920-1949) and Analytical Period (1950-). The above classification, I think, is self-explanatory so as to indicate the characters of change as well as trends in Indian anthropology. Later, Bera (1995) suggested four-fold divisions of the stages of development of anthropology in India. To him these stages are-Formative period (1974-1919), Constructive period (1920-1945), Empirical Period (1946-1978) and Developmental period (1979-onwards). Of these, the above mentioned developmental stage coincided with the period under present study. In this period author has noticed an Indianization in the anthropological researches". Danda (1981) has earlier reached at a similar conclusion with regard to the state of affairs in Indian anthropology. He noticed, a 'definite degree of indigenization' in Social- culture anthropology in India (Danda 1981). Again we notice that the need of 'Indianness' in the anthropology is emphasized in a symposium on anthropology in contemporary India held in 1996 in Punjab University, Patiala (Sarkar 1996). But how much these introspective illuminations have guided anthropology in India, is still a matter of further and more detailed enquiry. Now, on the basis of the data at hand, it can be said that the Social-cultural anthropology in India is still to build up a very characteristic type of its own. Much of its emerging trends are influenced by the global developments. But at the same time it has not altogether swept away by these global trends. From the emerging areas, it has chosen the right fields that have relevance and applications in contemporary India. This way the anthropology in India has taken the Indian path that may be called the global connection in Indian Anthropology.

To suggest an 'intellectual equivalent' to a panacea capable of eradicating all sorts of physical ills, Hobart (1987) named the discipline of anthropology. Though it may appear to be an exaggeration, but in real sense anthropology is assuming that shape in its pervasiveness. It has to be so. Otherwise there would be an identity crisis. This sense is well captured in the words of Joao De Pina-Cabral of Lisbon University. He writes:

"Today, Socio-cultural anthropology is emerging out of the crisis of self-doubt that attacked it during the post-colonial era. In the Portuguese-speaking, Spanish speaking and German-speaking worlds, the discipline is once again demonstrating a heightened capacity for renovation and for dealing with highly topical, fully contemporary issues." (Pina-Cabral: : 2006 : 663)

What is most important about Cabral's passage is the use of the words Tiighly topical, fully contemporary issues'. It is evident from the earlier discussions that anthropology has been gradually taking up more and more contemporary issues in India. The issues are not coming under a very stereotyped brand of applied anthropology. The knowledge in its more applied sense is being studied

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as indigenous knowledge. The topics like forest management, human rights, violence, human ecology, medical anthropology have a preponderating presence.

This turning or trend is premeditated and I think, very much linked with the global activities. As early as 1981, there was a study to show the regional and theoretical interest of the British-based social anthropologists (Kuper, 1983). The study divided the domain of anthropology into the following fields - 1. Social structure. 2. Cognitive anthropology. 3. Applied anthropology and change. 4. Ecology and modern production. 5. Epistemology (concerning methodology, philosophy)

It was revealed that those who were born earlier were more interested in traditional fields of social structure etc. But the anthropologists born in the 1940s, were showing greater interest in the applied fields of study. By now these later anthropologists are mellowed with ages and ruling the roost in the period under present study. They also set-off the trends globally to which the Indian anthropologists remain no exception. Again looking at the regional interests of the anthropologists under above study (Kuper, 1983), another very significant point is noticed. It was found that, of the five above mentioned fields highest number of study has been undertaken in applied anthropology in India. This linkage is subtle, but suggestive. And here again the global connection is manifest. Mehta (2003) opined that some of the areas for urgent research are constituted by the studies of ethnicity, pluralism and conflict. We find some justification of her observation.

Indian anthropologists though sharing much of the theoretical interests in world anthropology show little interest in certain fields which have been a very flourishing or have remained major areas of concern of the world anthropology. In this connection we may cite the examples of visual anthropology, anthropology and folklore, media studies etc. Visual anthropology is a very large area of anthropological studies outside India. It has enormous scope at present in India. Similarly, the field of folklore studies is mostly crowded by the scholars from literature in India; where as globally social and cultural anthropologists have great contribution into this field. Therefore, it deserves greater attention at present from Indian anthropologists. In spite of these shortcomings, Indian anthropologists are no way altogether 'directionless' as often criticized (Debnath 1999). In the fields of women studies, child labour, human rights they have made significant contributions. These are rays of hopes waiting to be transformed soon into glaring lights in the days to come.

IRAVATI KARVE AND THE PRODUCTION OF AN INDIAN ANTHROPOLOGY

SUBHADRA MITRA CHANNA

Iravati .Karve's works cover a holistic conceptualization of Indian society, but in her methodology she moves beyond the static, homogenous version of society popular in her times to understand the multifaceted dimensions of social reality foreshadowing later theories in anthropology th; it take a critical stand on the earlier versions of culture and society as stable, timeless concepts. In her worts, she definitely shows a greater influence of the cultural historical approach of Boas and the Culture-Area hypothesis of his student, Alfred Kroeber. The influence of the American cultural tradition is strong in her works as she dwe Us on evidences of cultural diffusion and a methodology that takes strong support from folklore and oral traditions. Her treatment of literary traditions as a major source to understand society and its evolution goes beyond the American cultural tradition and is better understood in a postmodern framework that gives authenticity to the written word and presents a contested version of truth where the subjectivity of the scholar is foregrounded. The feminist critique that follows upon this theoretical stance is very much reflected in Karve's works where in her interpretation of the written texts she dwells at length on the inner psychological states of women and she also does not fail to mention the patriarchal bias in the writings of the ancient texts. In fact, her literary and semi-anthropological work *Yuganta,* attempts to rectify this bias by presenting a feminist interpretation of some of the mythological characters of popular Kindu texts.

Even in her works on *Kinship Organization in India* and *Hindu Society-An Interpretation,* she emphasizes the complexity of Indian society and the possibility of alternate interpretations as well as the fact that gender plays a key role in interpretation-and understanding. Coming at a time when both feminism and gender played insignificant role in anthropological theory, Karve was a true visionary possessing a keen sociological imagination that allowed her to understand society as a complex as well as an interpretative phenomenon rather than taking a static positivistic view.

A major understanding she brought to anthropological theory in India was an aversion to a blind faith in concepts and typologies generated by western scholars. She had insisted on definitions and understandings of concepts as

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they exist in Indian society, that included such kinship and sociological terms *asgotra, vansh andjati,* for which she claimed no meaningful western term existed. In this way she was able to reveal the true nature of culture as part of a local meaning system and the methodology of adhering to native terras for institutions rather that distorting them to fit in with a terminology generated by western anthropologists. In this she anticipated the colonial critique and the works of such cultural historians who gave a gendered historiography a:- Susan Bayley, Rosalind Hamilton, Bernard Cohn, and others. Hers was an effort to build up a true Indian anthropology, using native terminology and a meaning system not derived from the west but from the history of the South Asian society. In this she was a true believer in historical-particularism and a cultural historical interpretation of contemporary institutions.' She firmly believed that the character of Indian society was that of absorption and not of division, a point of view reflected in her theory of caste.

In this paper, I will do ,a re-reading of her three major anthropological works in light of the critical approach developed in post-modern, post-colonial anthropology. My efforts would be to show how Karve anticipated both feminism and a post-colonial critique in her work while adhering to a methodology whose limits were defined by the existing American cultural tradition. But most of all her efforts to situate her work in the context of the Indian sub-continent and its special ethnographic content is what marks her out as a contributor to the production of a truly Indian anthropology. If she fails in that attempt, it is only because of her own reflexivity, her subject positioning as a Brahmin woman who in spite of all efforts failed to transcend to a level of encompassing the true diversity of India, confining herself to a largely Hindu and Brahmanical view of Indian society.

Iravati Karve was a leader from the front in more ways than one. In a Preface to the second edition of her work on kinship (1965) Hutton does not fail to mention her 'sex'.

> It is probably symptomatic of a new India, unknown to my generation, that this contribution has been made by one of her sex: at any rate it is one which anyone of either sex might feel proud to have accomplished (Hutton -1965: viii).

This quote makes it clear that even in world anthropology, at the middle of the twentieth century, there were not too many women scholars. To be a woman invited such comments as to the 'sex' of the writer especially if she belonged to a group that had earlier formed ths "other" for colonial anthropologists such as Hutton. As understood in later theoretical developments, the identity of the anthropologist till the last part of the twentieth century was 'male, white' and not 'woman and non-white'. As Moore (1996 : 1) has put it :

A whole series of new questions has been posed by the sustained challenge third world, black and feminist scholars have provided to the established agenda of the social sciences and humanities in the recent years.

It would thus be theoretically rewarding to investigate whether Karve who fits the bill of being non-white and 'black' (implying non-western) also fits the description of being a feminist and whether and to what extent her work is a deconstruction of dominant concepts of her time, of paradigms developed within a specific cultural and social set-up situated historically in the colonial era; also to the extent to which she follows the theories popular in her age and the orientation of her contemporaries. The influence of the American cultural tradition on her work is evident in the manner in which she has divided the Indian sub-continent into linguistic areas that she rightly refers to as cultural areas too. In the beginning of her book, *Kinship Organization in India,* Karve makes a rather profound statement,

> Three things are absolutely necessary for the understanding of any cultural phenomenon in India. These are the configuration of the linguistic regions, the institution of caste and the family organization.

She further develops the idea that to understand any of these elements one must conceptualize the regional diversity of India and traaslate it i:ito methodology; in other words, situate one's analysis within a regional and linguistic framework. Thereby she states a fact made clear by later works on India that culturally and anthropologically, India is not a unified entity. This in fact would lead us to another rather Karve herself has already given the answer in the preliminary lines of her book as quoted above, anything in India CL.n only be understood in the context of caste, family and linguistic regionalism. But as a criticism to her approach I would like to point to the distinct bias of her construction of a general picture of Indian society, especially kinship, one that upholds Brahmanical Hinduism and a distinct upper caste culture as 'typical' Indian culture. If we agree with Karve that caste should be a key factor to understanding Ii dian society, then what are we to do with the entire North- eastern part of the country and with all such groups that do not have a caste organization? In h(r classification of Indian languages, she mentions only three groups, namely Indo-European, Dravidian and Austro-Asiatic; then where is Tibeto-Burman? She herself admits to not analyzing data from Kashmir probably because it was not available at her times. But she should have made an honorable mention of all the areas and regions that she did not cover, instead of ignoring them totally as if they did not exist. Her book is also conspicuous by the absence of any data on the Muslims. In fact, she should have named her book, 'Hindu Kinship' rather than 'Indian Kinship', unless to her Hindu and Iniia were the same!

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Not only does her work reflect a definite cultural and po.itical bias but it also reflects on the teaching of anthropology in India that till today sustains a largely Hindu and upper caste interpretation of society as 'The Indian Society'. Karve's book on kinship served as a text for at least two generations of scholars who kept learning by rote statements such as

> The behaviour pattern of the kin-group in the northern families is like that of the patri-family in ancient India. The man lives with his patri-kin among whom he is born and reared. He comes in contact with his wife's relations but rarely. The woman on the other hand spends her life, except for the few childhood years, with her affinal kin with whom she is not acquainted up to the moment of her marriage.

FURTHER SHE WRITES:

> The northern joint family is a status group where husband, wife, parents-in-law, daughters-in-law, sons, daughters, sisters-in-law and brothers-in-law have each a definite place assigned to him or her vis-a-vis all others.

Though Karve has mentioned the existence of tribes and various other groups in her enumeration of the central and southern parts of India, her description of the northern joint family has captured the imagination of many. The fact that many lower castes and tribes and landless populations never had any concept of a joint family, and in India we also have matrilineal societies are realities that are not incorporated within the main descriptive framework of her book. Following the lead, many anthropologists in India try to explain away the fact that actual joint families are difficult to come by when they go to the field by attributing it to "change", so that an oft-repeated question in many question papers is, "Identify the factors that led to the dissolution of the joint family in India" or something similar. The assumption being that the normal state of the Indian family should be joint, and secondly, if it no longer exists, one assumes that it *changed* rather than it *never* existed.

Such assumptions also were rooted in the structural-functional methodology that concentrated on the present and ignored history. Thus when an anthropologist found that the majority of families in the field area was nuclear it was attributed to 'external' factors. But fieldworkers have subsequently critically questioned this ideal model especially when they began to use the historical method. A.M. Shah, a well known sociologist, highly regarded for his work on family, found in his social and historical study of a village in Gujarat that the kind of family assigned to tradition was not present even in the pre-colonial era. Let us see what he has to write about Radhvanaj, a village consisting primarily of upper caste Rajputs and Brahmins (Shah 1998).

> According to the Census of 1825 Radhvanaj had a population of 716 persons divided into 159 households and there were 25 castes, 73% of the total number of households were very small or small in 1825. The ideal of the so-called joint family household was not very strong in the village and this was even before the beginning of industrialization and urbanization.

But even though there were no joint families, the Rajputs, namely the Rathods of this region, formed exogamous lineage groups. But in the very same village such lineage groups were not found among the other caste groups. By and large, strong and elaborate lineage groups were associated with control over land. As Shah has further elaborated, land ownership provided stability of residence and facilitated growth of lineages. Land ownership also provided power and therefore, lineages with the help of the unity provided by the kinship bond, tended to be repositories of power.

In my own work on the Dhobi (washermen) in northern India, in Delhi (Channa 1985), I found no trace of any joint living. As rightly pointed out by Shah, landownership often provides the economic basis for joint living. For households which have to live off their daily earnings it is a difficult proposition to pool in the earnings at the end of the day and go for joint living. What the earlier authors had relied upon was an ideal basis for the family based on values and scriptural norms. But in reality the economic and political considerations determine at the actual level what shape is going to be taken by the household.

Thus, stereotypical definitions as given by Karve, do not reflect the truth, but only the author's vision of the truth, filtered through the lens of an upper caste Brahmin woman of an aristocratic class. Moreover, as was the climate of her times, her typology is static, it assumes a timeless classification rather than recognizing the dynamism of actual societies. At the same time, she was well aware of both history and archaeology and her theory on caste formation is both historical and takes into account the process of evolution of caste. Thus there is a tension in her work, where at some points she appears as a conservative scholar, depending upon the normative structures of society and ready to represent it in terms of her own subjective situatedness and at other points she bi eaks free of conservatism and goes into an analysis that is both reflexive and dynamic. She comes into her true mettle when she is discussing women.

Thus Karve's contribution becomes much more creative when she breaks out of the methodological bondage of a 'scientific' approach and gives expression to her inner voice about women and their role in Hindu society. Though she is better known as a social anthropologist who interpreted the

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basic institutions of Indian society, I think her contribution as; a feminist is much more laudable. But, at all points, her analysis must be viewed strictly as an interpretation of only a section of Indian society, largely Hindu sanskritic and upper class.

While describing the scriptural texts in her book on kinship (1965: 61), she gives us a sympathetic account of the lives of Sita, Draupadi, Kunti and Madri, contextualizing these lives to the cultural practices prevalent and the patriarchal social structure. She makes a sensitive description of the carefree and happy childhood of an Indian woman in her father's house and the privy and tribulations in her husband's house where her identity is submerged into that of her husband. Making a critical analysis of the concept *ofpativrata* as it was interpreted in ancient times and as it is understood in contemporary Indian society, she works against the patriarchal interpretations of her own times and of her own culture. In ancient times, as the example of Kunti and Draupadi shows, virtue in a woman had quite a different meaning. These women would fail the test of being virtuous wives by contemporary definitions by not being virgins and exclusive sexual property of their husbands. But they were exemplary women of virtue in their own times; not because of their sexual purity or the fact that they belonged to only one man but by the fact that they bowed down to every wish of their husbands and the needs of his patriline. Thus, these women had to suppress their own desires and feelings to do what was required of them by the dictates of patriarchy. This norm is illustrated by the practice of a woman being passed on to her *dcvr* (or classificatory brothers of her husband) in order to procreate heirs for his patriline, a practice well illustrated in the Mahabharata.

Karve is able to understand the pain and suffering of these women, who are queens and princesses, but who have no control of their own bodies. She writes:

> To the honour of the poets mav it be said that the husband of each of these women was blamed, *but we fail to get a glimpse of the woman's thought in all these circumstances* (1965: 73; italics mine).

Thus, Karve in her inter-subjectivity and reflexivity as a woman is able to understand and describe the suffering of women whose emotions had bypassed even the poets who created them. Her own reading of the ancient texts clearly ind-cates that she is guided by her feminine understanding as she picks up and emphasizes precisely those areas that throw a clear light on the plight of women and she makes it a point to comment that ner interpretation has a feminine bias not present in the texts. In this case, her consciousness of her subjectivity is subsumed under her projed ion of an objective scientific methodology. Her disdain for 'conjectural' deductive reasoning led her to carefully document and substantiate her arguments, even if her perspective can be understood as interpretative from an analytic distance. That she set rigid standards of objectivity for herself it demonstrated throughout her works.

To clarify on the position of women, she looks into some of the laws and dictates of those times. The importance of a son in p itriarchal Hindu society is demonstrated in two ways, one by tne concept of *asramas* where as a householder a man is expected to discharge his dharma by paying off two debts : (1) debt to ancestors; and *(2)* debt to gods. Both the debt to ancestors aad the debt to gods requires a man to marry and beget sons frr not only must the ancestral sacrifices and offerings be made by the man himself but he must ensure their continuity by h.iving a son; the third debt that to the sages is made by living the life of a pupil in the *brhamacharya asrama.*

In contemporary times, most scholars writing on this Sibject are happy to dismiss the preference for sons to practices of dowry or to economic considerations only. But, as Iravati Karve has rightly analyzed, such preferences may be far more deeply ingrained into the value systems that originated thousands of years back. More interesting is the definition of who is to be called a son? Here, Karve quotes from the Mahabharata where

> Pandu is supposed to be giving the authority of the law books *(dharmashastras)* for the following type of sons. The first six are kin *(bandhu)* and inheritors, while the next six are neither kin, nor have they the right to inherit (Karve 1965: 74).

What Karve notes is that the first six are all kinds of sons bora to the wife, whether or not they were born of the father, whos name they are supposed to carry. The last six categories are cf adopted and foster sons who are not born of the wife's womb. The only biological sons of wife debarred from inheritance is ;* son who was fully grown when a woman marries a man who was not his progenitor and the case of a son born to a woman of low caste. Both these types of sons are present in th ; Mahabharata as Vyasa, the son of Satyavati, before her marriage to the king Shantanu and Vidur who was born of *i dasi.* It is interesting to note that when there is a search for a suitable *devr* for the widows of queen Satyavati's two sons, *in lieu* of a prince of the Kuru lineage it is this

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son of Satyavati who has to stand in as a brother. This indicates that the woman was completely integrated into the husband's patrilineage ii the *bija ksetra* analogy where her body is likened to a field on which the seed of the patriline is to be sowed. While on on *2* hand this analogy raises the position of the mother in giving identity to her sons, it degrades the position of the wife who must provide her womb willingly or unwillingly so that it CE n be used to sow the seeds of her husband's patriline.

The present day cultural practices in most of India no longer conform to such values. In the absence of a son, it is considered appropriate to adopt one rather than use the wife's womb as a field to sow the seeds of the patriline. Modern day Indian families conform much more to the western ideals of virginity and monogam}' considering the husband as the sole sexual claimant to his wife's body. More than sons, the purity of women is linked to the honour of a patrilineage. How aver it is also true that such values are more prevalent among th e elite and middle classes and upper castes of Indian society, and marginal groups may be still or were till quite recent times having values nearer to those depicted in the ancient texts. Post-colonial scholais have often attributed colonial rule and the western values imposed by the foreign rulers to have brought about substantive transformations in Indian society, especially beginning from the top and permeating downwards. Thus, sexual purity of women, a rigid caste structure and enhanced patriarchy are now deemed to be more an influence of westernization than as part of ancient Indian traditions. Thus, the works of scholars such as O'Hanlon (1997), Dirks (1997, 2001), Cohen (1996) and Chatterjee (1993), to name only a few, have shown how the brahmanical model followed in a colonial production of knowledge about Indian society as well as the specific interventions based upon the western systems of morality and the artificial projection of Indian society as homogenous and static fulfilled the requirements not only of the colonial rulers but of a large section of Indian elites as well. One observation made by almost all these scholars was that the interpretations of Indian society were made largely by upper caste men, the only ones the British considered as trustworthy or respectable, as a reflection of their values derived from their own society. The glorification of the ancient 'Hindu' culture hy those termed Indophiles by Trautmann also went into the emerging Hindu nationalism of the post-colonial era.

Karve's work upturns many of such myths that came to dominate upper strata of Indian society and was being passed off as 'Indian tradition' by the elite. In this way, she gives a true post-colonial critique and her work predates most of those who are now recognized as providing such a critique. Her commentaries would also make the advocates of glorious Hindu traditions of the past uncomfortable in the honest appraisal unclouded by any sentiments that she makes of the epics. Her brilliant commentary on the Mahabahrata, *Yuganta,* takes away from the commonly held norms of a Hindu family and an ideal woman or man. At this point, it becomes imperative to highlight the importance of her deep involvement with history and the ancient textual material. As Rosalind O'Hanlon has pointed out, one of the greatest fallacies of historical practice with reference to the South Asian data has been the assumptions of a static society.

> The strongest of these assumptions, enshrined in an intellectual tradition of considerable age and authority, hr.s been of the essentially static character of Indian society (O'Hanlou 1997: 148)

Karve, by her methodology, had been attempting to refute exactly this kind of assumption. She shows quite clearly that Indian society has evolved and transformed over the ages and also in the character of a true feminist she is able to identify the cause of the assumption, the self-interest of the guardians of patriarchal authority.

To be objective, Karve by herself has not fore grounded the aspect of colonial influence in her work. But she is very clear about the prioritizing of male voice, a fact that she mentions several times. She was also deeply committed to the understanding of society as changing and dynamic. Refuting the assumption of *ihs* rigidity of caste structures that had been emphasized by colonial and patriarchal scholars, she is quick to point to both the elastic and loose structure of the caste system.

> By its very nature the caste society presented a loose structure which could take on new units and is so doing re-arrange old units (1961:109).

In this way, she fulfills aptly the requirements of a feminist methodology that has been expressed by Valle (1993: 7) as:

> More than any other field within the discipline, feminist anthropology is deeply connected to changes in society and the demand for change emanating from diverse interest groups. Concurrently, the degree of this connection gives a special element to the study of gender, namely questions about the many situations in which women live, and the many variations in what it takes to be a woman or a man.

Thus Karve by showing the transformative nature of Indian society and its dynamic nature refutes the assumptions of stagnation. She delineates the difference

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between *Shrutis* and *Smritis* and the fact that most of the laws governing family and marriage as contained in the *Smritis* are to be viewed as both dynamic and contextual, suitable for certain ages and interpreted situationally. The implication for the lives of women is tremendous as morality and family values are shown to be changing and changeable and not rigid and inviolable. Thus, Hinduism contains within itself the germs of development and is not by any means an immobile tradition. While she nowhere refutes the greatness of Indian civilization her approach is truly academic and non-political.

Many scholars as well as political interest groups use many of the stories and practices depicted in classical texts to project an image of women in ancient India as having a higher position-than contemporary Indian women by saying that she had greater authority and freedom and could have more than one sexual partner. While it may be partly true tha t she had a better position vis-a-vis her progeny it was also a matter of interpretation. Karve has rightly indicated that such practices were causes of greater suffering for women as they subjugated her sense of self and personhood. She was always an instrument for the goals that were to be achieved by her husband. Thus while he paid his debt, she was only a partner whom he had to use to achieve h s ends. The woman neither had personhood nor had she agency to act positively for her own good. Whatever she did was for her husband and his salvation. While she exposes the sufferings of women she also exposes the veaknesses and cowardice of men. In her analysis, women, though suffering, still emerge stronger.

Now l come to the question as to whether we can consider Karve to be a feminist. Here again one has to examine how one dafines a feminist? As Valle (1998: 15) puts it:

> Acceptance of gender as a new analytical category implies the acceptance of knowledge that has already been considered marginal and on the periphery; it has been constructed, developed and expanded by those who are not placed at the center where recognized knowledge develops and expands.

Karve was definitely as a woman and as a South Asian placed at the periphery of anthropological knowledge of her times do ninated by white, western males. Her analysis is sensitive tr the facts of her womanhood, even though the concept of feminism had not found an expression in the theoretical discourses of her times. Thus while analyzing the more conventional institutions of caste and kinship, she remains confined to more conventional approaches of her times. in her inierpretation of women and their position, she breaks free and is able to transcend the limitations of methodology imposed on he \ Moore (1994: 4) has raised a quertion:

> Can people actively recognize and choose the subject positions they take up, and to what degree are they able to resist the term of dominant discourses?

When we analyze the works of Karve, it is clear that she was unaware of the concept of reflexivity at a conscious level, yet her observations and her theoretical orientations clearly indicate that she was deeply influenced by her own subjectivity and was inspired by her own individuality to take up ar independent stand even when she was not required to do so by the norms of the times. It is her inner strength as a person and a deep conviction about her identity that makes her stand out, as a scholar who would not be cowed down by the 'dominant discourses'. Thus, it is irrelevant to raise the issue of Karvc being a feminist unknown to her self. She was both aware of her idertity and her responsibility to express the voices that were suppressed in the textual narratives she refers to. Such a point has been made explicitly by her in *Kinship* and she has in .addition written a book *Yugarita* (originally in Marathi) in which she courageously reinterprets most of the characters well known in Hindu mythology and who have been stereotyped in common everyday life in Indian homes. For example, the act of Gandhari, bandaging her eyes, interpreted commonly as an act of sacrifice for the sake of a blind husband is revealed for what it was, an act of anger and hurt, to punish her husband and her own family for betraying her. The poignant conversation between Gandhari and Dhritarashtra, in the forest at the fag end of their lives reveals the bitter relationship of an angry woman and a husband who felt the resentment of his wife and the punishment inflicted on him by her, all his life. The interpretation is a truly feminist one in which Iravati is able to say out loud, what had been suppressed all along, the voice of a wronged woman. Thus, the male interpretations commonly given out by male scholars and priests had by their very misinterpretation, suppressed a voice of protest, converting it into one of passive suffering. Karve is able to show Gandhari for what she was, a strong woman, keen to inflict revenge on her kin and husband and not a passive suffering wife, *apativrata.*

Moreover, Karve was fairly contemptuous of the 'greatness' of the Puranic characters such as the Pandavas or even of Krishna of whose identity as a historical character

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she has many questions. For example Karve brings to dust a much revered figure in Hindu mythology, Bhisma, the grandfather, the man usually upheld as one of the noblest figures of heroes of the Mahabharata. Karve has nothing but contempt for a man she thinks spent all his life wronging women and bringing them to misery for his own glorification and ego. Throwing all conventions to the wind, she is able to write:

How all these women must have suffered! How they must have cursed Bhishma! He alone was responsible for their humiliation. Bhishma was the active leader of the Kuru clan, the one who had wielded authority. In his zeal to perpetuate the house, he had humiliated and disgraced these royal women (1991 :14).

Thus Karve's voice has been a true feminist voice in deconstructing male voices and situating herself in the position of a marginalized section of Indian society, namely it;3 women. Not only women, but Karve is quick to catch on to all the injustices perpetrated by those in power and that has been conveniently overlooked in order to glorify some. For example, she has a sympathetic voice for the poor tribal woman and her five sons who are burnt in *thejatugriha* incidence. In *Yuganta,* Karve spares no one, not even Arjun, and Krishna whom she castigates for burning down the Kha.ndava forest only to gain the land of the Nagas. Thus instead of glorification as divinity of the characters that emerges on the pages of the great epic, she is able to write of the high born prince and princesses like Dhritarashtra, Pandu, Gandhari, Kunti and the rest:

....all these Kshatriyas lived restless. intense lives. Their lives had heights and depths. loves and hates. Whatever real peace they had. came only after death. In old age. beaten by life, they finally achieved with great effort a resignation which was not so much peace as a desperate attempt to impose calm. ...What was true of the Kshatriyas was true of the Sutas. ...Even the Brahmins, Drona. and Ashvatthama. were not spared from the tormenting activity of the mind and body (1991: 70).

Thus, at the same time, as she takes a subjective stand with regard to women and men and their emotions and sufferings she also has a clear cut scientific and objective view of the texts that are in no way clouded by her sentiments as a Hindu upper caste woman. She nowhere treats the characters as divinity but regards them as flesh and blood historical people or as in the case of the *Ramayana* she is more inclined to treat it as a pure *kavya,* a run of the poet's imagination. While *Mahabharata* is for her a document of social conditions and cultural practices of a specific historical era and most of the characters appear to have a substantive reality, the *Ramayana,* appears as romantic poetry describing the ideal types rather than flesh and blood persons who may have lived on this earth. Therefore, her analysis concentrates more on the people who live in the verses of the *Mahabharata* than *the Ramayana.* The former she treats like a historical document that can be subjected to an anthropological analysis provided one dispels the clouds of religious sentiments. Thus she is able to make bold hypothesis as to the father and son relationship between Vidura and Yudhishtira, although in the text Yudhishitira is mentioned as the son of the god Yama or Dharma. To the social anthropologist that she was, the role of the *deur,* in impregnating his elder brother's wife was an appropriate cultural practice. Also the suppression of this fact could be related to the caste of Vidura who unlike his brothers was born of a *dasi* and hence of the *snta* and not the *kshatriya* caste. Although she makes many observations, some of them like the above, being quite startling yet her conclusions are drawn within the strict dictates of positivist methodology as she supports each of her statements with substantive data. Thus, we find that although her construction of Indian society is the construction of a Hindu society, yet she is a true critic of that society. While she cannot tranacehd ,her Hindu identity, her self-appraisal is highly critical.

Methodologically, she seems inspired by the Golden Age of American anthropology than by the static analysis of British structure-functionalism that seemed to have deeply influenced most Indian anthropologists almost up to the recent times. The reason could have been her deep-rooted interest in archaeology and history and the conviction that Indian society and culture could not be understood without referring to their roots. In this, she is guided by the theoretical commitment to understanding culture as a dynamic and historical process and not an entity in timeless equilibrium.

Her approach also leads her to studying Indian society as a holistic concept rather than fragmenting it into smaller 'community studies' that became popular as ethnographies at around the time she was writing. So that much before her we have ethnographies of tribes from scholars such as S.C. Roy.

Yet Karve chose an approach that was civilizational, confining herself to studying largely what may be termed as the Great Tradition. Yet it does not mean that she ignored the existence of a substratum of Indian society that was composed of rural and tribal people. But she

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was convinced that there was no significant difff rence in India between the higher and the lower groups as far a culture and traditions were concerned. She *is* critical of the term 'primitive' as used by Western anthropologists of her times as suitable for use in the Indian subcontinent. To her, what could be termed as Indian civilization had an over all identity that justified the use of titles such as *Kinship Organization in India* and *Hindu Society.* To her, what can be termed as Indian society was largely Hindu but again what she means by Hindu is not to be interpreted in the narrow sense that it is defined today but as 'inhabitants of this sub-continent' and an amalgamation of the various traditions and of people who live here, have migrated here and mingled with each other right here on this land. The association of culture with area comes again quite likely from the influence of the culture-area hypothesis popular in American cultural 'radition. The rich diversity of Indian society is well recognized by her even though she uses terms such as Hindu society, in l.er analysis she breaks up this analytical category into its ground level manifestations of local and regional communities. She is keenly aware of the internal diversity of groups that I rofess the *samejati* name such as *kumbhar* (or potter), to give an example. She explains the internal diversity through the hypothesis of amalgamation rather than fission. She successfully explains the diversity as well as dynamism of Indian society by a single theory of addition rather than solitting.

She had done her anthropology, partly from Germany. The influence of German scholars, the d'ffusionists who had later influenced Boas, the founder of American cultural tradition, is clear in her orientation. But her individuality and her keenness to develop an Indian anthropology is exhibited in her rejection of terms coined by western anthropologists. She cl ;arl3' finds it impossible to describe the Hindu social organization by making use of terms such as clans and lineages and instead builds up a vocabulary of kinship terms such as *sapinda, gotra, kul* and *vamsa* that are derived from Indian data.

A dimension of her scholarship was to take anthropology as a unified discipline of physical, social and prehistory, an amalgamation now long rejected that we find in her book *Hindu Society* and in her seminal paper on caste published in *Current Anthropology.* While discussing the material on Indian society in terms of geographical and cultural divisions, something that to her is concurrent, she also makes use of scattered references to physical anthropological variables. A typical example is the sentence in which she is describing the Saraswat Brahmins:

epigraphic record shows that they have been oecupying the coastal strip and the neighbouring places on the mountains at least since the Kadamba dynasty, i.e. since the 12th century. Anthropomorphic measurements show them to be one among the three broad-headed communities of Maharashtra (1961: 23).

Similarly with reference to the Chitpavnas, she writes:

The Chitpavans distinguish themselves in having a larger percentage of hazel or cat's eyes than the other coastal communities *(ibid:* 24).

This mixture of physical and social anthropology was found only among the early colonial administrators like Hutton and Risely, but not followed by any reputed social anthropologists of the British or American school. Her opting for such a combined approach may be reflecting upon the trend existing at that time among her contemporaries like Ghurye who too had taken help of anthropometry to prove his theory of caste. To her credit, she has tried to use physical anthropology not to prove a racial theory of caste as done by Risely that was supported to some extent by Ghurye but to dispel the myth of a concurrence of caste and race. She is clear in her condeinnation of the colonial hypothesis linking caste and race and the British telling of the Aryan myth. She writes:

It is wrong to suppose that the varna system arose out of a consciousness of racial distinctions as indicated by skin colour (1961: 53).

And she clearly dismisses the theory of the Aryan theory of' caste propagated by British scholars as conjectural.

Be this as it may looking at the Sanskrit record itself we have no evidence that caste was 'created' by race conscious Brahmins. It appears that the Aryans came upon the phenomenon of caste and fitted it into a scheme known to them *(ibid:* 58).

In her paper in *Current Anthropology,* co-authored by K.C Malhotra (1968), she provides enough statistical and biological evidence to support her hypothesis that the various castes are a result of amalgamation and the system as such shows no racial difference between one caste and another, least of all between the Brahmins and others.

Thus there is no justification for assuming that the distance between the Brahmin 'castes' under investigation is less than the distance between a Brahmin 'caste' and a non-brahmin 'caste', for some Brahmins are closer to members of other 'castes' than to each other (1968: 115).

Thus, summing up on the contribution of Karve, one is overwhelmed by her single-minded pursuit of truth. True

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to her times, she considered that such a truth did exist and could be deciphered by objective, rigorous and painstaking academic endeavours. Her own academic methodology was based upon certain premises that she had derived from a theoretical orientation based upon the conviction of history and society being intrinsically connected. To her, no sociological analysis could be static and based upon observation only of the current situation as advocated by the British school of structural-functionalists but had to be understood by investigating as far as possible the development and transformations through the historical time. Her major theoretical premise is the futility of attempting to understand culture without its history; to understand society without its traditions. Her attempt to establish a true Indian anthropology and her conviction that such was possible led her to establish some extremely valid truths about caste, kinship and social organization in India; many of her observations are supported by later scholars. Take, for example, her observation on the changing and non-racial nature of caste. In her chapter on a historical survey of caste (1961: 50-77), she not only indicates how the castes were formed by historical processes spread over time but also makes the observation: "The process of caste-making has not stopped. New castes are coming into being even in the present age" *(ibid:* 65). I Thus the complexity of the nature of caste, its fragmented I nature, its situational nature, its historicity and the fact that it was not an institution devolving upon the existence of the brahman, were all ideas, glimpses of which we get in her works although she did not put it in the political framework as it was dons by scholars in the latter half of the twentieth century.

She has certain convictions that are hers and not derived from any other scholars and most significant among them is her methodology in which she has treated the ancient Indian texts as a significant data base but first reinterpreting them in anthropological manner. She herself comes across as a person rooted in her traditions but innovative enough to project herself into the future as a post-modernist and feminist scholar. For a woman who was educated in India and abroad, who had reached the heights of professional achievements to write addressing her husband, "I place my head on your feet and ask for your blessing" is an achievement that can be equaled by few scholars, feminist or not. That Iravati Karve could not be cast in any stereotypical image is truly demonstrated by this one sentence.

C. VON FURER-HAIMENDORF : HALF A CENTURY OF HIS IMPRINT ON TRIBAL WELFARE IN ANDHRA PRADESH

URMILA PINGLE

What was to be a brief reconnaissance in the Hyderabad otate Lied out for Furer-Hannendorf and Betty, his newly wedded wife, a life long commitment to the welfare of the tribes They arrived in Hyderabad in August 1939, at invitation of Sir Theodore Tasker, the Revenue Member of the H.E.H. the Nizam's government. Tasker informed the young couple that the War had just been declared and that Furer-Haunendorf was to be interned as an enemy alien (his Austrian nationality was converted into a German one) and had to cancel his plans to go to the Naga Hills as earlier planned. The bright side to this disaster was that instead of Furer-Haimendorf languishing in the internment camp till the end of the War, the Nizam of Hyderabad was wise enough to offer him the opportunity to work among the tribai people of his dominions Thus for he next nine vears from 1940-49 Furer-Haunendorf devoted himself to the meticulous study and policies for the different tribal cultures he studied Internment gave him a unique opportunity not only to do concentrated research on the tribes but to gam the confidence of the Nizam's government and become an official adviser on riba ma ters and policies in 1945. After four years of directing tribal welfare work, Furer-Haimendorf left Hyderabad to take up an academic position at the School of Oriental and African studies (SOAS), University of Londun. Thereafter, he returned to Hyderabad for short intervals to direct the handing over of t he work he had initiated. Retirement from SOAS in *1916* would i elease him again to revisit the tribes of Andhra Pradesh and undertake a series of restudies on the changes occurring among those tribal communities (Furer-Haimendorf 1982). From 1978 to 1988, he participated in active field work. The result of this Vv-ork was published as a series of monographs.

ETHNOGRAPHIC STUDIES OF THE TRIBES (1940-49)

Furer-Haimendorf consulted with various officials familiar with the geography of the state and this helped him to choose in an evolutionary way to first study the Chenchus, food-gatherers (1943), then the Hill Reddi who were shifting cultivators (1945) and finally completing his ethnographic work among the more complex Raj Gonds who were settled agriculturists (1948). In all these three monographs he used *a* multidisciplinary approach to the

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holistic understanding of the tribes. The detailed observations of the geography and ecology of the areas the tribes inhabited coupled with their agricultural and forest activities enriched the studies and made them useful for administrators to make important decisions for the welfare of these communities. The meticulous study of the traditional customs of land ownership and usage in these tribes as varied as food-gatherers to shifting cultivators to settled cultivators helped administrators in prioritizing the important economic issues to be tackled in each one of these tribes. Most important, his sensitive perception of the early signs of the troubles to come in the tribal areas and the appropriate steps taken to stabilize the economy of the tribal societies helped strengthen tribal cohesion for more than a decade.

THE CHENCHUS - JUNGLE FOLK OF THE DECCAN (1943)

The Chenchus lived along both banks of the Krishna, the river forming the border between Hyderabad State and the British administered Madras Presidency. The Chenchu that Furer-Haimendorf studied lived on the higli plateau atop the Nallamallai Hills. Furer-Haimendorf and Betty settled down in an abandoned forest bungalow in the village of Farahabad as their main camp for the next nine months of their anthropological stay. As Furer-Haimendorf noted in his autobiography (1990):

> Compared with the splendid Nagas with their colourful ornaments these Chenchus were a poor lot, and I felt sorry for Betty who had expected to live among Nagas in the magnificent scenery of the Assam hills.

So their honeymoon was spent in the most difficult of terrain, under war time conditions of rationing of food and medicines and the summer heat with very little shade that the deciduous forest had to offer. Their resilience helped them adapt to seasonal vagaries and they began to forge a close relationship with the local Chenchu. They started bartering with the Chenchu, obtaining forest fruits, honey and tubers and giving in exchange rats which they caught with their mouse-traps. The Chenchu were delighted with this valuable food as they themselves had noted the skill to trap small animals. In retrospect, Furer-Haimendori notes in his autobiography that they realized they made a mistake by not having eaten the rats themselves and depriving themselves of the only available source of protein. For, by the beginning of the monsoon in the Chenchu area, th ere was acute food shortage and they were reduced to a Chenchu diet, living on edible roots and tubers and wild berries. By the end of the nine months spent among these people, Furer-Haimendorf had a deep understanding of this unknown tribe and the problems they were facing. He had made many friends among them and with whom he remained in touch in his subsequent visits. Both Furer-Haimendorf and Betty walked the extensive forest areas and followed the Chenchu groups in their annual summer miration down to the river banks. They traveled as lightly as the Chenchu themselves carrying a blanket, mosquito net, tea and a few handfuls of rice and their notebooks and cameras. The constant mobility of this bandgroup in searching for forest food would often hamper Furer-Haimendorf in seeking lengthy discussions with the Chenchu who would get very restive. So the Haimendorfs hit upon the idea of doling millets to their informants who would then be no longer under pressure of time to leave for their collecting grounds. They would then talk at length about their gods and their myths. In between interviewing the Chenchu he carried out a detailed census on all the families (426) on the upper plateau. The outcome of this work was published in 1943, with an appendix on the Notification of the Nizam's Government in establishing the greater part of the upper Amrabad Plateau as a "Chenchu reserve" covering one lakh acres. This important step to protect the welfare of this vulnerable group was the outcome of Furer-Haimendorfs work among the Chenchu. The rules governing the Chenchu reserve ensured the Chenchu living within this reserve to follow their way of life without restrictions and to extract all minor forest produce without payment for their domestic use. The forest department was made responsible to organize a purchasing and sale center to purchase all minor forest produce brought by Chenchu and supply them with their requirements. No tradesmen were allowed to deal with the Chenchu from the reserve. The forest department was to help the Chenchu within the reserve to take up forest industries such as bamboo weaving, etc. A specially selected Chenchu forest guard and forest watchmen sympathetic to the ideas underlying the creation of the Chenchu reserve were to be employed.

THE REDDI OF THE BISON HILLS (1945)

The next stage of Furer-Haimendorfs journey took him to the relatively isolated Papi Konda or Bison Hills in the South-Eastern part of the State. Access to the Hill Reddi was only by boat, for there were no roads or cart tracks along the banks of the Godavari. The Konda Reddi lived on the river bank settlements and the hills on both sides of the river and were traditionally shifting cultivators growing small millets, maize and pulses. They were independent farmers, but at the time Furer-Haimendorf started his research it had come to an end with the forest department of the Samasthan of Paloncha auctioning bamboo growing on the hill slopes. Timber merchants of the nearby town had acquired the right of bamboo extraction and they employed the Hill Reddi in this operation. However, the relationship between the merchants and the tribals turned into one of exploitation, the tribals being led into debt by the merchants who

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advanced them grain and other provisions. The illiterate Reddi had no means of calculating the sums of money the merchants owed them as wages and the value of foodgrains they received. The Reddi were warned by the merchants not to divulge any information to the Haimendorfs, so the naturally friendly tribals became sullen and uncommunicative. In spite of these initial problems, the Haimendoris continued on their tour of the Reddi villages observing and gathering information on the varied activities of these hill people. They spent a year in these areas, both suffering from bouts of malaria and greatly weakened. They shifted camp to the hill top village of Gogulapudi where the Reddi were more traditional and remote from the influence of merchants. It was in those months that many of the tribals in that region came to the Haimendorfs to seek help and advice in their struggle against the oppressiveness of forest contractors, merchants and minor officials. Furer-Haimendorf used this information in drafting his powerful reports to the Nizam's government entitled, "Tribal Hyderabad – Four reports" (1945) which enabled the administration to take the appropriate steps to improve the condition of these tribal communities.

THE RAJ GOND OF ADILABAD (1948)

The Haimendorfs after their return from Bison Hills and a brief stay in Hyderabad left for their tour of Adilabad in December, 1941, which was the Northern most district of the Nizam's State. Through the use of Survey of India maps they made their way up these highlands with extensive stretches of forest scattered vith tribal villages and cultivated areas. There were no motorable roads, so they hired two bullock carts from Asifabad, the headquarters of the subdivisional officer. After having paid their respects to the Gond Raja living at Pangri village, they accepted the invitation of Lachu Patel of Marlavai to establish their permanent camp at his village. Furer-Haimendorf was greatly impressed by this articulate Gond who had an excellent understanding of the rituals connected with their clan-god worship. Besides, the highland area was scarce in drinking water and Lachu Patcl assured them that Marlavai had a good well. So it was that the Haimendorfs settled down in Marlavai in a house built for them by Gonds. They lived in a community which was occupied throughout the year with agricultural activities, seasonal festival, participating in rituals connected with birth, marriage and death and visiting neighbouring villages. A valuable task that Flirer-Haimendorf set for himself was the detailed recording of Gond myths from the Pardhan bards who had an outstanding knowledge of these myths, a cultural heritage which was being lost in areas where Gond were living with other populations. This had never been put down in writing but was orally recited over generations by the Pardhans. Furer-Haimendorf also studied in great detail the organization and functioning of the tribal panchayats presided over by the Utnur Gond Raja, the most influential among the Gond local chiefs. The Raja settled disputes and was the custodian of Gond customs. After some length of time in Gond eountry, Furer-Haimendorf realized that though at first the Gond seemed prosperous farmers without harassment of moneylenders and outsiders, they were, in reality, facing many difficulties. Marlavai soon became the gathering point, for Gonds from other villages to come to the Haimendorfs with tales of woe. At that time, though Furer-Haimendorf had no official position as Adviser he was prepared to listen and note down their grievances but he made it clear to the Gond that he had no authority to solve their problems. However, he assured them that he would convey their petitions to the concerned officials and explain personally the circumstances of each case. i The Gond too were happy to get a sympatl etic hearing and thus Furer-Haimendorf carne to build up a picture of the socio-oconomic and political situation that these people were facing. The picture that emerged was that already in the 1940s the Gond were ousted from the lands cultivated by their forefathers in the lower regions of the riverine tracts drained by the Penganga and Godavari. They had lost much land to Hindu and Muslim settlers. The highlands around Marlavai were still protected from encroachment with compact areas of forest and jxclusively tribal villages. The alienation of land had already spread to the highlands of Utnur and Furer-Haimendorf noted he beginning of the influx of Maratas, Kunbis and Banjaras from neighbouring district of Maharastra. Most of the village accountants (Patwaris) were Maratha Brahmans and had little empathy for the Gonds and were easily bribed to abet the non-tribals in occupying Gond clan land. Later with the help of W. V. Grigson, a former administrator of the state of Bastar who joined the Nizam's government in the position of Revenue Member, Furer-Haimendorf was able to place proposals for tribal rehabilitation which were promptly sanctioned by the Nizam's government.

ANTHROPOLOGIST-ACTIVIST

During his stay at Marlavai, Furer-Haimendorf had no official position to tackle the land problems of the Gonds, so he thought of other means to strengthen the Gonds in their struggle against exploitation by non-tribals. Since much of their inability was due to illiteracy and ignorance of government laws and rules, he wanted them to be prepared for this eventuality. With this objective in mind, Furer-

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Haimendorf began to formulate the Gond education scheme and in May 1943 the training school was formally established in Marlavai under the guidance of Furer-Haimendorf and with the support of the Revenue Member. It had a modest budget and this enabled the young Gond students to receive stipends for the period of their training. In this school a new set of tribal leaders-teachers and Patwaris were taught to maintain village records. It worked well as the new leaders worked harmoniously with old leaders as they were sons of the soil.

In order to open up primary schools in Gond villages, the medium of instruction had to be Gondi as that was the only language spoken by the Gond. Hence, the second function of this education scheme was to identify and train young and intelligent Gondi-speakers to become primary school teachers. Furer-Haimendorf spent most of his time recruiting the first teacher candidates and working out the basic principles of their teaching. He appointed a teacher to head this centre and with his help began composing primers and readers in Gondi written in Devanagiri script, which is the script used for Hindi, Marathi and other Indian languages. It lent itselt to the transcription of Gondi phonetics and familiarized the Gond students with an all-India script. Urdu, the language of Hyderabad state, was to be introduced only in the higher classes (Furer-Haimendorf 1990). By 1946, thirty primary Gond schools were functioning. By 1949, at the time of Furer-Haimendorfs departure, the number of schools had trebled. By 1951, this centre which in 1943 had begun with the training of five semi-literate Gonds had produced ninety-five teachers, five village officers, one revenue inspector, five clerks and seven forest guards. One of the trainees of this school went on to become the president of the Panchayat Samithi of Utnur Tribal Development Block. The success of this centre helped establish a second centre at Ginnedari village in Asifabad taluk. Teacher training centres were also established among the Koya of the Godavari valley.

ANTHROPOLOGIST-ADMINISTRATOR

Between 1945-49 Furer-Haimendorf functioned as the Adviser to the Nizam's government for tribes and backward classes. Besides giving advice, he had the heavy responsibility of dealing directly with the problems of the tribal population of the State. This was an enviable position for him as few anthropologists ever get the authority to bring about change and improvements among tribes. Furer-Haimendorf had immediate access to the Revenue Secretary and the Director-General of Revenue, being allotted an office in the Revenue Secretariat. He could thus obtain information on the current developments of tribal policy. During this period Furer-Haimendorf undertook tours to different tribal areas of the state, co-ordinating the various schemes concerned with tribal problems throughout the State. Several of his reports were published by the Revenue Department entitled *Tribal Hyderabad.*

Furer-Haimendorf was also appointed a Warden to the Civil Service House which was an institution to instruct freshly recruited young men in subjects that they would be required subsequently to know as district officers. His close proximity to these officers and interaction with them helped sensitise these people on tribal matter.

Besides these two positions he was appointed as a part-time Professor in Anthropology in the Department of Sociology at the Osmania University. This was the first time that anthropology was to be introduced in this university. This gave Furer-Haimendorf an opportunity to turn out a cadre of officers trained in anthropology who would later join the Social Service, a department specifically concerned with tribal welfare.

SYSTEMS OF LAND TENURE IN TRIBAL AREAS

In homogeneous tribal populations, there are hardly any problems of enchroachment. Their ancestral or clan lands are owned by the village community, and therefore, the concept of having permanent rights to individual plots was foreign to the tribes. The cultivation based on clan ownership was not recognized by the Nizam's government. The majority of the Gonds in Adilabad highlands then cultivated according to a system of land tenure known as *siwa-i-jamabandi.* The land they tilled remained government land, although they had permission to cultivate and annually pay the land revenue. They were not registered as owners *(pattedars)* in the village register. The allotment of land on this tenure system was within the powers of the *tahsildar* who endorsed the actions of *thepatwari* and revenue inspector without inspecting the rights and wrongs of individual cases. This meant that the *patwari* had the final say in the matter. This allowed the lower revenue staff with opportunities to enrich themselves by shuffling land from one cultivator to another, and every year many tribals were evicted from lands which they were cultivating on *siwa-i-jamabandi* tenure. The Gond practice of frequently shifting their fields ar d being the inhabitants of large expanses of cultivable land and forests became an attraction for new settlers who then obtained title deeds for he occupied land. At the turn of the century it was the government's policy to open up the district and encourage the influx of new settlers and to grant them title deeds free of charge for as much land as they could make arable. Moreover, the reservation of forests had begun to encroach on the traditional habitat of these tribes.

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TRIBAL REBELLION

Until the British rule, the tribal people were left relatively undisturbed. The extention of a centralized administration under the British over areas which had previously been outside the effective control of princely rulers reduced the autonomy of the tribal rights and customs, and the establishment of "law and order" in these areas exposed the tribes to the pressure of more advanced populations. Traders and moneylenders were able to establish themselves under the protection of the British administration. Often they were followed by settlers who succeeded in acquiring large tracts of tribal land. By imposing an alien system of land tenure and revenue collection developed in advanced areas on the tribals, the government unintentionally facilitated the transfer of tribal land to members of other ethnic groups. This set about a deterioration of tribals' position in Peninsular India as early as the middle of the nineteenth century and continued into the twentieth century. This gave rise to a series of rebellions of tribals against the authority of the government, and resulted in defeat and loss of lives among the ruled who had to struggle against the organized power and sophisticated system established by the ruler. One such rebellion was the Rampa Rebellion in 1879, which involved the Hill Reddi of the East Godavari Agency of Madras Presidency, now part of Andhra Pradesh. This Rampa country was in possession of a feudal lord who was not Reddi. He had managed to control the lives of these tribals. He had leased out his villages to subordinate chiefs for an annual income of Rs. 8,750. The last straw of this oppressive rule was leasing the toddy revenue to contractors entitled to collect taxes at their own discretion. Simultaneously, the feudal chief brought an excise regulation forbidding the Hill Reddi from drawing toddy for their own use. Compounded with this the civil law operating there was an additional grievance of the tribals whose trustfulness and ignorance of court proceedings enabled the traders to play mischief by making unfair contracts with them. When the tribal people could not fulfill their contracts, the traders would file suits against them, obtain ex-parte decrees and acquire as much land as they could lay hands on. The hill people blamed the government for all these injustices and therefore, carried out attacks on police stations and this movement spread to neighbouring hill areas covering an area of 5000 square miles. Government forces countered this guerilla war and did not quite succeed in entirely suppressing this reuellion until 1880.

The aftermath of this movement instituted special methods of administering tribal areas in Madras Presidency to protect the tribals from exploitation and enchroachmerit by outsiders. The various orders that were passed from time to time were consolidated in a legislation known as The Agency Tracts Interest and Land Transfer Act, 1917. This served as a blueprint for future legislations in other ti ibal areas. The four important regulations of this Act were:

(1) The interest on any debt or liability shall not as against a member of a hill tribe be allowed or decreed at a higher rate than 24% per annum nor shall any compound interest or any collateral advantage be allowed against him.

(2) The total interest allowed or decreed on any debt or liability against a member of a hill tribe shall not exceed the principal amount.

(3) Notwithstanding any rule of law or enactment to the contrary any transfer of immovable property situated within the Agency tract by a member of a hill-tribe shall be absolutely null and void unless made in favour of another member of a hill tribe or with previous consent in writing of the Agent or any other prescribed officer. (Agent was the revenue officer comparable to the Collector of a district).

(4) Where a transfer of property is made in contravention of sub-section (1) the Agent may on application by anyone interested decree ejectment against any person in possession of the property claiming under the transfer and may restore it to the transferor or his heirs.

This act remained in force till the promulgation of the Andhra Pradesh Scheduled Areas Land Transfer Regulation, 1959.

PROTECTIVE TRIBAL LAND LEGISLATION IN HYDERABAD STATE

Large scale evacuations occurred in the 1920s in Adilabad district as a policy of forest conservancy and continued until 1940. This policy of clearing large tracts of forest of human habitation, including old, established villages, led to the only case of armed resistance by Gonds in this district. It was a small rebellion called Babijheri named after the locality in which it occurred and has found a place in Gond folklore The leader of the Gonds was one Kumra Bhimu who tried repeatedly to get some land as most of the land in his village had fallen into the hands of non-tribals. He finally settled in the village of Babijheri which was subsequently established as an enclave in the state forest. Since Bhimu and the other Gonds had *nopatta* rights they were ask sd to vacate the place. As they had not vacated the place by the specified date, all their houses were burnt by the forest guards. They then moved to Jhoreghat, east of Babijheri and with the permission of *thepatwari* .and revenue inspector cleared some land. The forest guard then came and told them that they could clear as much forest as they liked provided they

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paid him Rs. 500. They borrowed the money and paid the forest guard but he continued to harass them to pay more.

Bhimu and four other Gonds went to Hyderabad and obtained printed permission to cultivate 57 acres. In spite of showing this permission, the forest guard threatened to burn their houses if they did not pay the money he demanded. However, the forest ranger without the knowledge of his superior officer sent a party of his forest staff with a gun to enforce the evacuation of these Gonds. They resisted this party and overpowered them and finally the forest staff ran away after they got a good beating. The negotiations between the district forest officers and Bhimu and his supporters were mismanaged and Bhimu refused to give himself up. The police party then advanced into the hills where Bhimu and his supporters had gathered and Bhimu fired the first shot without wounding anyone. Thereupon, the police opened fire, killing Bhimu and ten other Gonds and wounding many others. This left the Gonds deeply resentful of the government and it was not until four years later that the measures for their rehabilitation were implemented.

Furer-Haimendorf knew that a fundamental change in tribal economy would be achieved only by securing the rights of the tribals to the land which their forefathers were cultivating. This could be done only by new legislation modeled on the 1917 Act and creating an agency concerned with the protection of tribal rights. Hence Furer-Haimendorf identified a zone covering tribal villages in Adilabad district and notified it to bring protective legislation to the tribes living within this area. With the support of the Revenue Member, W.V. Grigson, he helped formulate and execute the farrighted and radical Tribal Areas Regulation 1356 Fasli (1946 A.D.). This swung into action in 1949 during the interim period when Hyderabad State came under military government. *Thiu* law assured the tribes of permanent rights in the land they cultivated and empowered their traditional panchayats to run their affairs and decide any cases without outside interference. This regulation empowered the government to make the rules which vested the administration of the Notified Tribal Area in the first *talukdar* (Collector) as agent, in the special social service officer as assistant agent and in a panchayat to be established by the agent. Instead of having to deal with numerous officials and distant courts whose proceedings were unfamiliar, the tribals were now under the care of officers of the Social Service department who were sympathetic to their cause and vested with sufficient powers to prevent land alienation among the tribals as well as exploitation of tribals by non-tribals. Furer-Haimendorf helped correct the injustice done to the tribals of Adilabad when large areas of tribal clan land was taken away from the tribals by the Nizam's government and held as reserved forest. He persuaded the government to dereserve 160,000 acres of fertile land for allocation to 12,000 tribal families (15 acres/family) along with title deeds, popularly known as "Haimendorf *patta*". This had a positive impact on improving the economy of the tribals, 85% of whom now had adequate land for cultivation.

IMPLEMENTATION OF LAND LEGISLATION

To implement these protective measures, Furer-Haimendorf created a special agency attached to the revenue department and known as Social Service. This agency which he directed until he left in 1949 provided the field staff for carrying out the tribal welfare work. These officers were trained in anthropology in the Osmania University and even learnt several of the tribal languages (such as Gondi). They were posted in tribal areas and their activities helped forge friendly relations between tribals and government officers. The tribals had easy access to the officials sympathetic to their problems and able to provide quick remedial measures. Also, the presence of officers of the Social Service department acted as a check even on the highhandedness of forest-guards *andpatwaris*. The organization of co-operative societies to inculcate the habit of thrift and self-reliance provided social security to the tribals. There was also provision for the supply of plough bullocks to needy tribals on long-term credit. The establishment of village grainbanks helped provide food security to the tribals in any eventuality of crop failures.

When Furer-Haimendorf returned in 1977 to do intensive research on the Gond of Utnur he found that the whole demographic scene had changed with numerous settlers from Maharashtra. This non-tribal movement into the tribal area of Utnur had reached a climax between 1965-1975. They occupied cultivable land al: the expense of the Gond in the span of a few years. The laws prohibiting the acquisition of tribal land by non-tribals were obviously ignored. The methods used to achieve this were similar to those used fifty years ago to dispossess the tribal of the lowlands. Apart from outright trickery and bribing of *patwari* and revenue staff to change entries in the land register, the immigrants deliberately led Gonds into debt, then induced them to lease their lands and finally refused to return thus land to the owners.

The occupant's name was entered in the vi'lage records as owner in place of the original owner with the connivance of the patwari and revenue officials. The demographic figures for Marlavai Circle in 1941 show that it was purely tribal in composition, the percentage of tribals in 1961 was 90%, but by 1971 it had dropped to 65%. To compound this invasion into the tribal areas, in 1970s the Banjara (an immigrant community from the district of Berar) succeeded in dislodging many Gonds from their holdings. At that time, Banjaras were

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not notified as tribes, but in 1977, with their inclusion in the list of scheduled tribes, there remained no legal bar to the transfer of land from Gonds to Banjara. Such transactions between tribals were permitted by law. Hence, with these two important events, the position of the Gond which had stabilized, turned a full circle to return to the precarious position Furer-Haimendorf found the m during the 1930s. There was one important difference though, there was no more vacant land available in the forested highlands for the Gond to take refuge and they were thus red iced to becoming landless laborers.

BREAKDOWN OF TRIBAL COHESION

The author's own independent studies among the Gonds of Adilabad district from 1970s and the unique opportunity she had in accompanying the Haimendorfs on their annual revisits froi i 1977-88 resulted in two publications co-authored with Furer-Haimendorf entitled, *Gonds and their Neighbours (1982)* and *Tribal Cohesion in the Godavari Valley (1998)*. The picture that emerged was that in spite of protective legislation, the wholesale immigration of non-tribal settlers and the introduction of commercial cash crops, mainly cotton among subsistant tribal groups, was too great an onslaught on the Gonds' way of life. The entire cropping pattern of Utnur tamk underwent a transformation that was detrimental to Gond economy. The high prices for the cotton transformed a food producing area into a re-^on concentrating on growing cotton. The increasing number of commercial centres in the area and exploitation of the tribals by traders led them into debts and ultimate loss of ownersl ip of their lands to non-tribals.

Added to this, Gonds had to face the change in governme its twice in the span of a decade: the partition of Hyderabad state in 1956 and the merging of the Telengana districts with And'ira districts into Andhra Pradesh. This change of administration also brought about the repeal of the Hyderabad Tribal Areas Regulation in 1963, replacing it by the Andhra Pradesh Scheduled Areas Land Transfer Regulation, 1959. While the latter regulation also protected the land of the tribals, prohibiting any transfer to non-tribals, it did not contain any provision for the maintenance of the tribal panchayat. Most importantly, it stripped the social service officers of the authority and judicial powers with which the Hyderabad Tribal Areas Regulation had provided in all cases involving tribal land. Moreover, any non-tribal whose occupation of tribal land was challenged by a revenue official could now, and still can, lodge an appeal in a civil court. The termination of the functioning of tribal panchayats ended an institution which had regularly brought together the headmen of groups of villages in settlement of disputes according to the rules of tribal customary law. The commercialization of the local economy further resulted in the breakup of tribal solidarity, as it inevitably tended to encourage individualistic tendencies as opposed to the welfare of the community.

The imposition of a grassroot democratic system, the panchayati raj in tribal areas was designed more for the needs of more advanced regions of rural India and undermined the traditional authority of tribal panchayats. Previously, the village was the basic unit and now the smallest unit was a cluster of villages or the gram "panchayat. Hence, the splitting up of villages and the reconstitution of blocks from parts of different vill .iges was done more for beauracratic convenience, but it definitely undermined tribal village cohesion and created division within tribal society. Since tribal areas are no more homogenous due to the demographic transformation, the constitution of villages dispersed over large distances and consisting of other ethnic groups, the elected members could seldom meet and had little sense of solidarity and purpose to accomplish anything.

In 1977, Utnur Taluk had 40 gram panchayats, and in 29 of these the sarpanch was a Gond or Pardhan, while in seven gram panchayats an immigrant Banjara held that position. Even in gram panchayats with a tribal sarpanch, non-tribal members exerted a far greater influence, especially if they were economically more powerful.

In view of all these problems highlighted by Furer-Haimendorf, the Bhuria Commission was appointed to re-examine the provisions of the 73rd Constitution Amendment Act, 1992, and recommended a system of *panchayat raj* in harmony with existing traditional tribal institutions. The Panchayat Raj (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 was passed by the parliament and in 1997 the Andhra Pradesh state too enacted a law in pursuance thereof. However, the Act is still to be implemented since the panchayat raj elections have not been held in the state. The gram sabha is empowered to safeguard its customary law and settle disputes. They have the control over the management of community resources and have power to decide on land alienation cases and restoration of the land back to the original owner. They have the powers to grant mining leases and licenses. This is the ghost of Hyderabad Tribal Areas Regulation, 1949 rising from the grave after half a century.

FUTURE ROLE

The younger generation of anthropologists cannot afford to sit in ivory towers any more but move into the difficult yet challenging role of focusing their attention on the future welfare of tribal societies whose very survival is being threatened by the process of modernization. The trend today, even among the educated class as well as administrators is a growing unwillingless to accept that more than eighty million tribal people continue to need special protection. The ecologists are fighting to save the forests, but very little attention is being paid to the displacement of tribals living for millennia in these forests which have now

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been reserved or established as wild life sanctuaries. For example, the Rajiv Gandhi Tiger Sanctuary in Andhra Pradesh, which was earlier a "Chenchu Reserve", protecting the rights of this small group totally dependent on the collection of minor forest produce, is now a reserve to protect timers. The forest department has been trying to resettle some of the Chenchu outside this reserve. This programme has failed, with Chenchu returning to their forest homes. It is ironic that so much hue and cry is made for the protection of tigers by the environmentalists but so little attention is given to the plight of this threatened tribal group. It is for such issues that both anthropologists and ecologists need to come together to help put this matter in a proper perspective. They should approach the government to work out the modalities of implementing programmes in a scientific and humanistic manner.

The author has been taking part in these programmes and debates with the government which involve tribals and other rural poor in participatory management of forests in Andhra Pradesh. She has evaluated the JFM programme as an independent consultant teaming up with senior foresters in suggesting strategies to make this programme sustainable, by tying up the economic improvement of the poor with the scientific management of the forests. She has been involved in analyzing the process of empowerment of grassroot institutions in decision making and implementation of forest management and protection (1993, 1998). She has also stressed the importance of strengthening women's thrift groups to take a more active role in their own development process. The JFM programme in A.P. has clearly shown that when tribal communities are handed over the responsibilities of protecting and sharing the usufructs from forests, the impact on forest regeneration is good. Besides, the attitude of the tribals to the foresters has undergone a sea change in a short span. The tribals who used to disappear on seeing a forest jeep, on the contrary, now see them more in the light of development agents who come to their doorstep to help attend to their basic problems. The Andhra Pradesh government is now designing rural programmes based on the participation of the community, such as water users committees, watershed committees, forest protection committees, thrift groups, education committees, etc. The earlier top down developmental approach which the government had been following has failed to trickle down to tlie grassroot level. However, for the participatory approach to work, the mindset of the beauracracy has to be re-oriented to take up these new challenges where the answei s are not known. They have to be determined through a scientific approach and involvement of the village communities which have a repository cf empirical knowledge on the soil profiles, the flora and fauna, which they are so closely in touch with. It is here that anthropologists and ecologists should work together to help gather the infornation for effective implementation of these programmes.

The political empowerment of tribals at the grassroot level through active participation in panchayat raj elections will give them a capacity to influence decision-making process, planning and implementation of their welfare programmes. The one-third reservation for tribals and their women guarantees their ropresentation. In the states of Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka, poor rural and tribal women have already won representation in Panchayat Samathis, often more than the minimum of one third seats reserved for them. The women who ware previously shy to appear in public are now confidently bringing basic amenities to the villages they represent. They ai e active in improving education, health and sanitation in their villages giving more priority to these programmes than their men. In this sphere of activity too, the anthropologists have an in portant role in creating awareness and capacity building of t) ibal women and men to participate in both the political and development process. These efforts cannot be done by the government alone and NGOs, anthropologists and sociologists should pitch in to give a helping hand.

The educational backwardness of tribals in Peninsular India co-relates with continuing high levels of poverty among them. The government in Andhra Pradesh has made very little impact or imparting quality education to tribal people. The latest overall tribal literacy in A.P. is 17% as compared to 44% in the general population. The dropout rate of tribals in the primary an d middle school level is 82% in boy? and 89% in girls. All this indicates an apathy of the government to impart good education to the tribals and make it their top priority.

The work that Furer-Haimendorf did for the welfare of tribal people half a century ago is still so relevant and radical for providing deep insights in tackling the complex problems facing the tribals in India. Those of us (anthropologists, administrators and NGOs) who have had the opportunity to interact with him have come away a little bit wiser than before. Marlavai *wat* the home of the Haimendorfs and they returned so often to watch anxiously over their beloved Gonds, often somewhat helplessely in their struggle for survival. Not having the authority anymore to bring about change, Furer-Haimendorf resorted to persuading and gently prodding many a young civii service officers working for the welfare of the tribals to take appropriate steps in the right direction. Hence, the annual visits, of the Haimendorfs helped rally and inspire a group of people seeking ways and means to help the; tribal cause.

The Haimendorfs had endeared themselves to the Gona who have immortalized them in their myths. The Gond of Marlavai have built mausoleums for their beloved ancestors Christoph and Betty Haimendorf. ■

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RELIGIOUS AND LINGUISTIC MINORITIES

India is widely known as 'a nation of pluralism/ multiculturalism'. People speaking hundreds of languages and dialects and followers of all the major religions of the world inhabit this land of amazing cultural pluralism. However, there appears to be substantial differentials in the socio-economic and demographic profiles of major religious communities in India, mainly emerging from socio-cultural and historical reasons. The status of linguistic communities is also largely related with these factors.

The constitution of India uses the term minority but does not define it. In order to have some understanding of the term 'minority', one refers to the works and interpretations of social scientists and judicial decisions. The term 'minority' is a compound of the Latin word 'minor' and the suffix 'ity', meaning inter alia "the smaller in number of the two aggregates that together constitute a whole". The Webster dictionary defines it as "a group characterised by a sense of separate identity and awareness of status apart from a usually larger group of which it forms or is held to form a part". The Oxford English Dictonary defines minority as "the condition or fact of being smaller, inferior, or subordinate" or as "a number which is less than half the whole number". The meanings and definitions just referred to contain a common criterion, namely, the statistical criterion. "Apart from the statistical criterion mentioned above the term 'minority' may also be denned on the basis of certain characteristics whijEh are commonly possessed by the members constituting it. In this sense the term signifies such groups of people as are united by certain common features and feel they belong to one common unit. Such groups may be held together by ties of common descent, physical characteristics, traditions, customs, language or religious faith or a combination of these" (G S Sharma, 1973). In any case, therefore, there is a sense of akiness, a sense of community or unity prevalent in the group or groups that distinguishes them from the majority of the inhabitants of the area where such minorities function. It is this sense of akinness within the group coupled with the consciousness of a difference with the majority, which may serve as the basis of various political or other claims. There may also be cases when differential treatment alone is the pointer that may determine the minority status. Such differential treatment may be shown by another group or other groups of people towards this group or it may be self-imposed by the 'minority' group itself.

Sumanta Banerjee (1999) adding a very important dimension to the meaning and interpretation of minority says that, "in the context of human rights today, the term 'minority' is no longer a numerical concept, but bets-come to signify a non-dominant and disadvantaged group in a state or society, be it ethnic, teligious or linguistic. The Muslims, for instance, are a disadvantaged minority group in India." Thus, the place of a group of people in the power structure of the society and the state becomes very crucial in identifying it as a 'minority'

Though the constitution of India does not define 'minority' yet -it recognises two types of minorities based on religion and language. That is how and why we talk about religious and linguistic minorities. The constitution uses the term 'minorities' only in four articles, namely, Articles 29 (1), 30, 350-A and 350B

ARTICLE 29

(1) Any section of citizens residing in the territory of India or any part thereof having a distinct language, script or culture of its own have right to conserve the same.
(2) No citizen shall be denied admission into any educational institution maintained by the state or receiving aid out of state funds on grounds of religion, race, caste, language or any of them.

ARTICLE 30

(1) All minorities, whether based on religion or language, shall have the right to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice.
(2) The state shall not, in granting aid to educational institutions, discriminate against any educational institution on the ground that it is under the management of minority, whether based on religion or language.

ARTICLE 350 (A)

It shall be the endeavour of every state and of every local authority within the state to provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education to children belonging to linguistic minority groups; and the President may issue such directions to any state as he considers necessary or proper for securing the provision of such facilities.

ARTICLE 350 (B)

(1) There shall be a Special Officer for linguistic minorities to be appointed by the President.
(2) It shall be the duty of the Special Officer to investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for linguistic minorities under this constitution and report to the President upon those matters at such intervals as the President may direct, and the President shall cause all such reports to be laid before each house of Parliament, and send to the governments of the states concerned. Thus, in the absence of any formal or definite definition we largely go by the judicial pronouncement given from time to time. But one thing is absolutely clear and that is the fact that all the internationally

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recognized normative principles are enshrined in the Constitution of India. On practical plane, the word *minority* in India is most often used in the context of religious communities—Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Parsees (Zo-roastrians) and Jews. This category also includes Budhists and Jains which means that all the non-Hindu communities come under the category of minorities. Following are the profiles and important facts and figures about the social, economic and political status of the religious minorities.

Religious Communities	% to Total Population	Sex Ratio (Females per 1000 males)
Hindus	82.00	925
Muslims	12.12	930
Christians	2.23	994
Sikhs	1.94	888
Buddhists	0.76	952
Jains	0.40	946

Source: Census of India 1991, Religion (series 1 India, Paper I of 1995)

MUSLIMS

Muslims in India are the largest and the most important religious minority of the country. Though a minority in its numerical strength, it it so big as to make it the second biggest Muslim population in the world, after Indonesia. They constitute about 12% of the total population of India and form an important segment in the social fabric of the country. They are distributed all over the country and live in every region, state and union territory in varying numbers.

Muslims are in majority in Jammu and Kashmir and Lakshdweep and constitute a significant minority in several other states. They are

- more than 20% of the total population of Assam Kerala and West Bengal.
- 10-20% in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Karnataka.
- 5-10% in Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, Rajasthan and Gujarat.
- in terms of absolute numbers they are the most numerous in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.
- in the remaining states they constitute 1-5% of the total population.
- in states like Sikkim, Mizoram, Meghalya, and Nagaland they are less than one percent.
- significantly, states with higher percentage of Muslims do not account for larger Muslim population
- A significant fact about Muslim demography is their higher urban population. About 35% or more of Muslims live in urban areas and it has significant bearing on their economic profile and access to health care and educational facilities.

ECONOMIC SCENE

All the available studies, surveys and reports reveal that Muslims are an educationally and economically backward community. A sizeable majority of Muslims live in abject poverty. The percentage of Muslims population below the poverty line stands at 43, higher than the national average. In rural areas, they are mostly landless and lack access to employment opportunities and other wage employment avenues. The majorities (53%) of Muslims are self-employed and earn their livelihood through petty business, small-scale enterprises and low paid jobs. In the rural areas, their overwhelming majority is agricultural labourers and artisans while in the urban areas they earn income from artisan and industrial work. As compared to other communities, the participation of women in their workforce is much lower. They contribute to the family economy largely through jobs performed within the four walls of the house especially in the urban areas where they are involved in such works as bidi making, chikan work in and around Lucknow and similar other occupations.

It is unanimously accepted that, through the ages, Muslims have been excellent artisans involved in different types of handicrafts and this has proved to be their undoing. In the face of the challenges of mechanization and industrialization, emergence of new market forces and lack of access to institutional finance they have been reduced to mere wage labour and cease to be the owners of these units in most of the cases. The following table may give the readers some idea of this problem.

Substantial presence of Muslims in the following industries

Bangles, glassware etc.	Ferozabad (U.P.)
Woolen, woodwork	Saharanpur (U.P.)
Carpets Bhadohi,	Mirzapur (U.P.)
Brasspots	Moradabad (U.P.)
Lungi	Madras (TN)
Woolen shawls, carpets	Kashmir
Handloom	Madras, Bhiwandi (Maharashtra), Mau (U.P.)
Chikan embroidery	Lucknow (U.P.)
Locks	Aligarh (U.P.)
Shoes	Kanpur (U.P.)
Leather	Calcutta, Madras
Scissors	Meerut (U.P.)
Silk	Ramnagram (Karnataka)

Survey reports reveal that only in some of these industries they dominate while in others most of them are wage earners.

Using National Sample Survey Report of 1988, Reserve Bank of India report of 1992, Gopal Singh Committee report on Minorities (1984) and a number of other studies have

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painted a dismal picture of the socio-economic plight of Indian Muslims. Some of these findings are:

- 52.3 percent Muslims live below poverty line with a monthly income of Rs 160.7- or less
- 50.5 percent Muslims are illiterate
- Only 4 percent of Indians who received education upto high school are Muslims
- Only 1.6 percent of Indian college graduates are Muslims.
- Only 4.4 percent of Indians in government jobs are Muslims.
- Only 3.7 percent of Indians who received financial assistance from the government for starting business are Muslims.
- Only 5 percent of all Indians who received industrial loans from the government owned banks are Muslims
- Only 2 percent of Indians who received loans from the government are Muslims.

It should be noted that most of the above figures relate to the public sector wherein communal discrimination is more difficult to practise and data on employment practices are rela tively more accessable, more difficult to hide. The large and powerful private sector takes recourseto it on a far larger scale, in a far more effective manner and with greater impunity.

It is shocking to see that even after more than a decade when the above facts and figures were compiled the gap between Indian Muslims and others remain as glaring as it was. The latest, 55th round countrywide survey, conducted by the National Sample Survey Organization (NSSO), presents a depressing scenario.

It is the same 'official' NSSO surveys, which yield usually reliable estimates of consumption, expenditure, employment and other characteristics that are routinely used as inputs for policy making by the Government. Some of the main findings of the survey are:

- The NSSO estimates show that a larger proportion of Muslims than others suffer from lowlevels of consumption. The best summary economic measure is how much a person spends on food, clothing, entertainment and other items of consumption. Average consumption expenditure by each member of a family was less than Rs 300 a month in 29% of rural Muslims while the corresponding proportion for rural Hindus was 26 percent. The difference is much wider in towns and cities.
- If cultivation of land still decides economic status in rural India, then Muslims remain at a disadvantage. Of the Muslim households with access to land 51 percent cultivate very little or no land while for others it was 40 percent.
- Unemployment among Muslim was higher in the rural areas but only marginally more in towns.
- Illiteracy rates are also higher among the Muslims. In rural areas 48 percent Muslims above the age of 7 could not read or write while in the urban area 30 percent of them are put in this category.
- If the Indian Muslims in 1999-2000 (as per the latest findings) did more poorly in consumption, education, employment and land holding, the changes over the time do not indicate that the gap between the two main religious groups is closing.
- The NSSO surveys indicate that during the 1990s, the divide was either constant or growing under.
- The same NSSO estimates suggest that 90 percent of India's poor are members of the scheduled castes and tribes, other backward classes arid Muslims.

The Muslims are also" poorly represented in civil services. They are only 2.86 percent in IAS cadre, 2 percent in IPS cadre, 3.04 percent in Group 'A' services and 2 percent in Banks and other public sector undertakings. Similarly, they are as poorly represented in medical and engineering colleges.

The relative underdevelopment of Indian Muslims is both a Muslim and an Indian problem. The Report of the Subgroup on Minorities ((1996) constituted by the Planning Commission illustrates that there are no signs of any significant improvement. Yet, it is heartening to note that in spite of their relative marginalisation in the national economy, Indian Muslims are continuing to make their presence felt in important spheres of economy. The success story of Azim Premji and his WIPRO, CIPLA and others may be the most obvious examples. Of course, there is a tiny Muslim elite too.

EDUCATION

As stated eaYlier the Muslims are below the national average in literacy and education. Some attribute it to their economic backwardness while some are of the view that it is on account of their religion. There is a popular perception that Islam discourages secular education and encourages only religious education and that is why there are so many *madarsa* and very few schools and colleges maintained by them. If religion is any hindrance to secular education then why even a theocratic country like Iran ruled by religious priests put so much emphasis on the teaching of science and technology or Indonesia with the largest Muslim population of the world invests so much on secular education?

The partition of the country in 1947 had an important bearing on the educational status of Muslims. The modern, educated urban middle and upper class Muslims left for Pakistan, especially from the north and western India and those left behind were the poor and illiterate masses. Apart from a small middle class community of Muslims, those left behind were artisans, small traders, coolies, rickshaw pullers,

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and tongawallas and lumpen elements in urban areas and small peasants, landle r, labour and others in rural areas. With such backward economic status there was hardly any incentive for a modern secular education. There are some other factors contributing to the educational backwardness. Firstly, most of the Muslims in urban areas are artisans and others like dyers, weavers and bangle makers. They not only consider it beyond their means to send their children to schools but also a sheer waste of time as their children supplement the parental or family work. However, they can be sent to a *madarsa* either in the early morning or late evening. Moreover, Muslim's low economic status and the parental perception that their children will not get job anyway on account of prejudices (though this may not always be correct) also discourage them to send their children to schools or colleges. The lack of higher aspirations and opportunities for upward mobility are also discouraging factors. On account of low economic status of their parents, the rate of drop out is also high among them. Beyond the primary level, it exceeds 60 parcent and therefore the percentage of graduates among them is hardly four percent though their population is more than 12 percent.

The much maligned and condemned *madarsas* have played an important role in Muslim education especially promoting literacy among the Muslims. Though Islamic theology, logic, philosophy and history have been the traditional areas of knowledge in *madarsa* education, modern and secular areas of knowledge are now being added to them. The existing *maktabs* and *madarsa* need to be revamped so as to provide scope for the introduction of modern education along with religious education. States like Karnataka, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh and some *madarsas* from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have already introduced the teaching of science, mathematics, geography and computer education in *madrasa* curriculum. The Union government as well as a number of state governments are helping in the modernization of madarsa education by constituting the State Madarsa Education Board. Part of the reason why *maktabs* and *madarsa* flourish is because the state has not done enough to promote "secular" education in mofussil towns and the rural hinterlands. Hence, children of poor Muslim families flock to *religious schools – madarsa* among the Muslims and Hindu *Pathshalas* among the Hindus. Of late, some political vested interests have launched vicious campaign of misinformation against the *madarsa* by dubbing them as 'centers of anti- national activities'. One may condemn the *madarsas* for their orthodox, conservative', dogmatic and outdated syllabi but generalized accusation that they harbour ISI agents and terronsts, is highly irresponsible Education is both a challenge and a solution to mostoi.the problems being faced by the Indian Muslims.

SOCIAL CONDITION

Indian Muslims are not a 'cultural community' in the sense that they do not have a common language or adhere to the same life style. They do not occupy a common geographical space. They are not regional communities either. "They are born, live and die in 'different parts of India and speak a multiplicity of languages. What is, however, common to them is their religion, which they share with fellow Muslims all over the world. Therefore, to identify religion as the sole basis of their identity is incorrect and illogical" (T.K. Oomen, 1998). But the irony is that the religion based socio-cultural specialities are magnified and utilized to mark out the religious minorities.

To many people, they are held responsible for the partition of India. But three important facts should not be ignored here. First, the allegation that the Muslims were responsible for partition is applicable to Muslims of North India, particularly of Uttar Pradesh. Second, a substantial section of the Muslims were vigorous participants in the anti-colonial, freedom movement. Third, at the time of partition, only a small number of Muslims from the territory allocated to India migrated to Pakistan; the vast majority stayed back.

Indian Muslims like Hindus and others, are steeped in the caste based social stratification contrary to the ideology of Islam. They, too, have higher and lower caste groups - Ashraf referred to the higher castes such as Saiyyad and Shaikh and *Ajlaf* referring to the lower castes mostly the occupationally specialized castes and artisan groups such as *julaha* (weaver) *qasai* (butcher), *raeen* (vegetable vendors), *manihar* (bangle seller), *badhai* (carpenter), etc. At the same time there is a strong backward class movement among them marginalising the *ashraf* castes.

Doctrinal variety, social hierarchy and economic stratification are quite pronounced characteristics of Muslims as well-though they are perhaps, not as marked, open, obvious and proclaimed as in the case of Hindus. The Shias the Sunnis and the Wahabis, or the Khojas, the Bohras and the Aghakhanis are just a few examples of a large ilumber of differentiations based on religious as well as quasi-religious beliefs and ritual practices.

The status of women, polygamy, family planning (birth control) and uniform civil code vs personal law have been issues steeped in subjective prejudices, preconceived notions and wild speculations. For having a correct understanding of their social status one must have an objective understanding of these issues in their proper perspectives. When we have a look at the status of women among the Muslims we must honestly acknowledge the fact that the status of women in India as a whole is lower than

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the western societies. If the status of Muslim women is sought to be determined only on the basis of one determinant i.e. easy divorcee or triple *talaq* (divorce) then what about the rampant dowry problem, maltreatment, female foeticide and infanticide and bride burning among the Hindus? The case of several Muslim countries where women are more empowered and enjoy a higher 'ocial status point to the fact that religion has never been a barrier to social mobility among the Muslim women. The case of theocratic Iran, Egypt, Indonesia, Turkey, etc. may be cited in support of this argument. Look at the educational backwardness of Indian Muslim women. The traditional society always tried to keep her uneducated or gave her only elementry religiol s education so that she can perform certain religious duties, nothing more. However, this is more a social than religious or ideological problem.

Our attitudes are determined as much by social factors as by religious or ideological one. At times social aspects prevail overriding religious or ideological aspects. If educational level among them is comparatively lower the reason is socio-economic rather than religious. It is true that education and socio-economic status are closely related. But it is also conditioned by the value system prevalent in a given society. The fact remains that what Islam had given her, the male dominated society has taken away. But the situation is infact changing. The winds of modernization are sweeping the Muslims too. The Muslim girls are going for modern education, participating in all the spheres of life, have a better share than ever in the decision making process at the family level and quite a few of them have started refusing to be cowed down by the religious threats.

Powerful myths are promoted to achieve sectarian-political ends in India. One glaring example is the prevailing communal propaganda about polygamy and population growth. A rational and objective examination of empirical data is essential to know the truth. Though the religion and the law allows a Muslim to have more than one wife but is it empirically true? As per the 1991 census data there are 930 females per 1000 males among the Indian Muslims. Is polygamy possible on a substantial scale? Any demographer worth his salt would immediately rubbish it. When the report *ofitheNational Committee on the Status of Women in India* (1971-74) came out with the startling revelation presented below, it shocked many a people.

Incidence of Polygamy in India

1.	Tribal communities	15.2%
2.	Buddhists	7.8%
3.	Jains	6.7%
4.	Hindus	5.8%
5.	Muslims	5.7%

The figures are corroborated by the figures from the office of the *Registrar General* and *Census Commissioner of India,* found in *Polygynous marriages in India* – a Survey and *People of India Project* (Anthropological Survey of India). As per the findings of this report the cultural motivation for plural marriage beside barrenness of wife, absence of son, the custom of marrying brother's widow etc. the economic gain is also an important motivation for polygyny among communities where women contribute substantially to the family economy. Some artisan groups, both Muslim and Hindu, find it cheaper and convenient to have a number of wives as extra hands than hiring labour from outside the group.

Thus, the incidence of polygyny is directly related with the status and role of women in their respective societies.

As far as population growth is concerned it is true that the birth rate is marginally higher among the Muslims. The acceptance of family planning methods and birth rates is dependent upon a large number of factors. The major ones are occupation, income, access to new technology, child survival, education and skills, and the economic value of children and security in old age *(Report of the Working Group on Population Policy,* Planning Commission), The significance of these and other factors lend credence to the possibility that the Muslims have a marginally higher birth rate because they are relatively more disadvantaged in all these areas. If the facts are examined without prejudice, the inescapable conclusion is that religion is not the primary determining factor in population growth. In this background one must also note that birth rates in the Malabar region of Kerala, an area with a Muslim population of 40 percent, are significantly lower than those in Uttar Pradesh with only about 17% Muslim population. For that matter Goa, with its large population of Catholics, has one of the lowest birth rates in the country. Then, if religion does not matter much what accounts for the persistently higher rate of population growth of Indian Muslims besides the factors enumerated above? Swaminathans. Anklesaria Aiyer (2001) comes out with more factors as given below:

- Traditional Hindus do not allow the remarriage of widows, while Muslims encourage it,
- A disproportionate number of migrant labourers are Hindus, and their long absence from home tend to reduce births per woman.
- Literacy is lower among Muslims, especially Muslim women. Low female literacy is associated globally with higher birth rates.
- Failure of the State : The world over, government efforts have been important in persuading people to adopt contraception. The State has been able to persuade

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'Muslims to use contraception in Iran, Libya, Bangladesh and many other countries. But the State has not been able to carry conviction with Muslims in India. Do not blame this on the culture and religion of Muslims.

The debate on Uniform Civil Code versus Muslim Personal Law has also been a contentious issue steeped in misconceptions, sociological distortions and preconceived notions. Historically speaking, Islam in India functioned as a political entity rather than as a legal system. The *shariat* was never really enforced during centuries of 'Muslim rule'. Social, political and economic rather than religious factors were more important.

As rightly pointed out by Rafiq Zakaria (1994) the Muslim Personal Law is merely a compilation of some *moulvis* (religious priests/scholars) at the instance of Lord Macaulay; it is based in many respects on the *Futuhaat i-Alamgiri*, the judicial pronouncements" i'n the reign of the moghul emperor Aurangzeb. It bristles with innovations and is known as Mohammedan Law which it self is a misnomer. It has been considerably modified by the decisions of the Privy Council during the British rule and by some of the legislative measures introduced by the Muslim members of pre-partition Central Assembly. Moreover, some sections continued to be governed by customary laws. Similarly, usury, which is prohibited by the *Shariat* was widely practised by such orthodox, practising Muslims as the Pathans, and the Arab immigrant. The theologians kept silent and connived at these lapses because of worldly compulsions.

If we take a look at the demand often made by the secular sections of the Indian society for reforms in Muslim personal law there is hardly any evidence of an attempt to change the whole of it unlike the demand made by the *Hindutva* forces inimical to any Muslim identity. The demand for some required changes in Muslim personal law from the progressive and secular forces does not seem to be contrary to the spirit of Islam. Essentially, whatever controversy there has been arose around the issues of polygamy and divorce. Islam can be shown to allow polygyny within certain restrictions, but it certainly does not enjoin it on everyone. This right has been severely restricted in most of the Muslim countries and there is no reason why polygamy cannot be completely banned, for Muslims and non Muslims alike, if the Indian Parliament so desires. It will be entirely in the spirit of Islam, As to the matter of divorce in actual practice Muslim males are at some advantage compared with the females, though the concept of allowing women to get a divorce is in the books from the beginning. There is no reason why uniformity should not be established in this respect by simply requiring a uniform marriage contract, and by providing relevant safeguards to protect both the parties from economic hardships.

It is tragic and dangerous, as rightly pointed out by M. Nairn (1999), on the part of the present (largely self acclaimed) leaders of the Muslim community to assert that the national parliament is not competent to make these changes. They fear that if changes are allowed in one area, then more changes will follow in other areas too, and the Muslim Personal Law will be replaced by the present Hindu code. This fear is baseless. Even for highly religious Muslims any and every change should not be opposed as long as it does not violate the spirit of their religion. Do not let the male dominated society take away what Islam gave to women and weaker sections of the society. Can the minority rights be different from human rights.

POLITICAL STATUS

Indian Muslims enjoy all the civil and political rights enshrined in the constitution for all the citizens of India. They are an integral part of the socio-political fabric of the Indian society. Their electoral behaviour has been a matter of great interest for the political scientists. It is heartening to see that, by and large, Muslims have preferred non-communal political parties and except Kerala (where Muslim League has a different structure and character) they have never supported, after independence, any communal Muslim political party even in Muslim dominated constituencies. The Muslims, along with other religious communities have been participating actively in the democratic political process. However, serious communal riots specially after 1960s have instilled a sense of insecurity among the Muslims and tend to push them into their narrow communal shell. The state sponsored anti-Muslim violence in Gujarat during February-May 2002 supposedly in retaliation to the Godhra incident has shaken not only the Indian Muslims but all the concerned Indian citizens. This must be a thing of the past and Indian polity should never allow a similar episode otherwise the authority of the state shall lose its legitimacy.

In his outstanding work of formidable scholarship, *Ethnic Violence and Civil Life: Hindus and Muslims in India* (2002) Ashutosh Varshney writes that" in Hindu-Muslim relations in India the State tends to act in a politically strategic, not in a legally correct manner. The state in Gujarat acted in a primarily strategic, not a legally correct manner.....Citizen's action in India has to take two forms: (a) While continuing to pressure the state for it's dereliction of constitutional duty it should (b) focus on building integrated civil structures. The first has been the primary strategy for citizen action in India thus far. Such action is necessary but not sufficient. Citizen's initiative should follow a two track strategy, combining (a) and (b) The state, otherwise, will continue to get away with utter misconduct and gross disrespect for huinan lives during communal riots."

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Political integration does not mean political subordination. It means closer unity for political purposes in a heterogenous country and plural society like India. Healthy regionalism, autonomy of cultures, free development of languages, liberties of social organization are the very lifeblood of federal democratic polity. This, the majority– communal and political- more than the minorities ought to remember. Rasheeduddin Khan (1987) in his significant observation says that taking advantage of the constitutional possibilities and the establishment of the process of democracy and change, the Muslim leadership at all levels should encourage their co-religionists to discard their separatist tendencies and enter the arena of competitive polity and its composite problems so as to accelerate the pace of modernization. Hitting where it hurts most, an eminent human geographer Moonis Raza (1994), comments that the *"Indianness"* and *"Muslimness"* of the Indian Muslims are both defining characteristics and neither can be ignored nor underplayed in any rationally sound and scientific assessment of the situation. Thus, Indian Muslims are Muslim Indians as well.

In the past the Muslims had been either rulers or the ruled. Today, in India, they are co-rulers as joint sharers of national sovereignty. As Rashiduddin Khan (ibid) rightly points out, the majority community is bound to be the first beneficiary of nationalism in a democratic society, therefore the minorities in order to retain their identity, depend not merely on the promotion of nationalism but also on the simultaneous development of the sub-nationalism. And Kancha Iliah (2003), in his characteristically blunt and ruthlessly honest narration, comments that "Indian nationalism is not only the property of Hindus. It is the property of Muslims, Christians, Buddhists and Sikhs as well". Thus, religious minorities are the natural guardians of a secular state.

CHRISTIANS

The Christians constitute the second largest religious minority in India and they are 2.34 percent of the total population of the country. The emergence of Christianity and

Christians in India, as per popular belief, has been linked up with the advent of the British colonial rule. However, well established traditions and historical evidences tell us that Christians have been existing in the state of Kerala right from the first century A.D. Therefore, the Christians can be considered not only the oldest religious minority, but Christianity also as one of the oldest religions in India. Thus, the 2 crore plus Christian population has been an integral part of India.

Like the Muslims, they are widely distributed in the country forming a sizeable proportion of population in several states and union territories. Following are some of the important facts and figures about the Christian population in the country.

- The Christian population reveals a strong tendency of concentration in the southern states of Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka.
- About 56 percent of the total Christian population of the country lives in the four southern states mentioned above.
- Kerala alone has almost one third of the country's Christian population, while Tamil Nadu takes care of about one sixth of the national total.
- A second major concentration of the Christians is seen in the north-eastern states which together share 22 percent of the total Christian population of the country.
- Though at national level, they form around 2.5 percent, at state level they are in majority in three states viz. Nagaland (88%), Mizoram (86%) and Meghalaya (65%). There are a few other states with a significant percentage of Christians. These are Manipur (34%), Goa (30%), Kerala (19%) Arunachal Pradesh (10%) and Tamil Nadu (6%). In Assam and Sikkim they form 3 percent of the state population while in the remaining states' their population varies between 0.4 percent to 2 percent. Among the Union Territories, Andaman and Nicobar Islands has the highest Christian population (24%) and Pondicherry has a substantial Christian population (7%). In the rest of the Union territories, it ranges between 1 percent to 3 percent.
- Among all the religious communities of India the ratio of female population among the Christians is the highest which is 994 females per 1000 males. Perhaps that is why they are not only more 'visible' but also constitute significant segment of their workforce.
- Contrary to the popular belief Indian Christians too are largely rural. Seventy one percent of all Christians in India are of rural background. Interestingly, while in the south and the northeast the Christians are predominantly rural, in north India, they are predominantly urban.
- Among all the major religious minorities the Christians have the highest rate of literacy mainly because of the untiring efforts of the missionaries.

The Indian Christians, like Indian Muslims, do not constitute a 'Cultural Community'. They speak different languages, they maintain different life styles and do not occupy a common geographical space. Even in the matter of religion, like the Muslims, they are divided into several denominations. Of the multiple Christian denominations in India today, only

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five could be distinguished as the main groups from which the various sub-branches have emerged. These are the Syrian Christians or the St. Thomas Christians, the Latin or the Roman Catholics, the Protestants, the Tribal and the Dalits. The last two are often fused together since many of their concerns are similar. However, for better reasons, the two should be seen as separate groups. The fact that the Roman Catholics constitute a major chunk of the Indian Christian population is also evident from the number of catholic institutions such as churches schools and colleges, and hospitals. The distribution of Catholic Church in India, related as it is with the concentration of catholic population, appears to be an outcome of the long history of diffusion of Christianity. The spread of Christianity owes much to the dedicated social work of missionaries in the area of education and health care.

Two very indigenous offsprings of the Christian movement are the tribal *anddalit* Christians. As Bonita Aleaz (2002) points out, "the tribal Christians are geographically dispersed throughout the territory of India. However, it is possible to be vocationally specific about two of the largest segments which constitute more than 80 percent of the tribal Christians in the country. These are the tribals of north-eastern India and the Santhals who in turn are scattered over Bihar, West Bengal, Orissa and Assam". In the remaining tribal areas, Christianity has touched the tribes only marginally. Christianity has been an important agency of welfare and modernization among the tribal societies. It has brought some positive changes in a number of their customs and practices. Among all the Christians in India, the Dalit Christians are the most vocal today. Most of them come from the Hindu untouchable castes who found Christianity as a welcome relief from the tyranny of the caste system. C.B. Webster (1994) has meticulously traced the origin and gradual proliferation of the Dalit Christian movement. He mentions that, on the basis of 1881 census report, four maingroups of Dalits could be identified, viz, the Chuhras of Punjab, the Chamars of North India, the Mahars of central and western India and the Paraiyars of south India. Even though these groups were not homogenous, certain common characteristics could still be distinguished among them. These were their main occupation as agricultural labours, poverty, similar rituals concerning birth, marriage and death, and finally lack of sympathy or support to their cause from other social and caste groups. Of course, all of them were also untouchables and suffered from a number of socio-economic disabilities like lack of landownership, lack of getting services from other castes such as barbers, washermen, priests, etc., bondage, lack of access to education and so on. In the 1920s and 30s there was a tremendous spontaneous movement of Dalits towards Christianity. The Dalits escaped into the Christian fold to take advantage of upward mobility through economic independence and education. But discrimination continued to persist, though on a much lower scale, as the descendants of higher caste Christians continued to look at them from the higher pedestal of caste hierarchy. Sometimes even the church resorted to discrimination. As Bonita Aliaz (ibid) pointsout that even today the church is not free from caste prejudices. In the north, however, class within the church community has largely replaced caste. But the relationship of Dalit Christians, with other communities is still defined by caste. In the south, the associational view of caste predominates within the Christian community.

Large numbers of Christians in rural areas, mainly converts from lower Hindu castes, follow their pre-conversion occupational pattners. Rowena Robinson (2001) making incisive comment on this aspect says that "the negotiation of caste differences within Christian groups constitutes an area of considerable historical and sociological interest. Wherever group conversions took place, the c'onverts carried their caste identities with them even as they shed their religious affiliations. In contradiction to the -popular understanding which is unable to come to terms with how an egalitarian religion condones inequality, it may be pointed out that the Christian missionaries have *not* always and everywhere unequivocally opposed caste, or all of its implicated distinctions. Converts themselves often resisted any missionary efforts to establish egalitarian relations. In Kerala, the converts from untouchable groups such as Pulayas and Parayas are largely landless labour and work for Syrian Christians and other landed upper castes. There is no question of interdining or inter marriage between the Syrian Christians and the untouchable converts. In many cases, the latter worship in their own churches. In rural Tamil Nadu, untouchable converts often remain residentially segregated from the higher castes. Ideas of purity and impurity persist."

There is a small section of urban middle class Christians which has experienced upward mobility through the educational facilities made available by the missionaries. TK. Oomen (2000) talking about their political status says that Christians in India are not organised into a political party and this is due to two factors : first, their socio-cultural fragmentation based on denominations and language to which we have already referred; and, second, their conscious rejection of separate electorates initially and the subsequent non-communal approach they seem to have adopted in political affairs. Following the recent tradition of the modern west, Christians in India accept the separation between church and state. This, too, stands in the way of their being organized on a political-religious platform on an all India basis. Further, their small size and physical dispersion does not equip them to acquire any political clout except in certain regional contexts such as in Kerala or the north east." There is one area in which Christians dominate in India, not withstanding their small size and economic disabilites, and that is in the area of service institutions, particularly in education and health.

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The last decade witnessed large scale attack on the churches and Christians in Gujarat, Orissa and several other states. The alleged 'large scale' conversions through 'coercion and fraudulent means' are said to be rootcause of these atrocites. There are more than a million Christians in Bihar, Karnataka and Maharashtra but, significantly, the states targeted for the fundamentalist attack were Gujarat and Orissa having 0.44 percent and 2.1 percent Christian population respectively. Though there have always been some cases of conversion of dalits and tribals the issue has been blown out of proportion and the hate capaign against minorities especially Christians and Muslims is being used as a political tool by a major political party and its various affiliates. BK. Roy. Burman (1999) analyzing the facts of conversion tell us "that the followers of Christianity among the tribal peoples of Gujarat were 0.09 percent of the total tribal population of the state in 1961, 0.24 percent in 1971 and 0.40 percent in 1981." The percentage of Christians in fact has decreased according to the census of 1991. If Christian missionaries were all the time busy with conversions, why is this decrease in numbers? If a person changes his religion on his own, that is his own choice and such a personal choice, is respected all over the world. Yet, in a multi-religious society like India surrounded by fundamentalist regimes even microscopic number of conversion to any non Hindu faiths generates fears, apprehensions, insecurities and illwill. Under such circumstances it is in the interest of the minorities to keep away from any such activities.

SIKHS

The Sikhs are the third major religious minority in India. Originated in Punjab, they are found in all parts of the country carrying with them the vital elements of the Punjabi culture.

The Sikhs constitute about 2 percent of the total population of India that comes to 16.26 million people. Significantly, the overwhelming majority of the Sikhs are still concentrated in Punjab. Of their total population 78.5 percent reside in Punjab, 6 percent in Haryana and the remaining in Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan, Delhi, Chandigarh and Jammu & Kashmir. Significantly most of the areas in these adjoining states were once part of the greater Punjab.

The partition of the country in 1947 was a major event in the history of the Sikhs. There was almost a complete exodus of the Sikhs from west Punjab and their resettlement on this side of the border. Analyzing the social geography of the country Aijazuddin Ahmed (1999) says that the "redistribution of Sikh population in the wake of partition introduced Sikh elements in the neighbouring Haryana and Raj as than where the irrigate colonies, such as' in. Ganganagar and Kurukshetra districts, emerged as the new foci of Sikh resettlement. Sikhs also settled down in the Terai region of Uttar Pradesh transforming this once malaria infested wetland into a granary of northern India. This transformation came due to the sturdy Sikh farmer, an alien to the region and yet tied to the soil." The Sikh jats became a symbol of irrigation agriculture and perhaps the most active agent of agrarian revolution that followed the construction of canals in Punjab.

The Sikhs are not a monolithic community. They consist of several sects such as Namdharis, Nihangs, Udasis, Nirankaris, Niranjanis, Nanak Panthis etc. A Sikh Guruduwara is not merely a sacred religious place of worship. It is the religious-cultural hub of the community where so many rituals and ceremonies related with birth, nomenclature, marriage and death are performed. It is the most important place of congregation, which has been used even for such secular activities as electoral politics. Though the devout Sikhs visit a village gurudwara or a city gurudwara as a matter of routine, but the most important congregations may be seen on Baisakhi, which marks the birth of the *Khalsa panth,* and the two *Guru Parva* (birthdays of Guru Nanak and Guru Govind Singh)

The economic status of Sikhs has always been a matter of envy to others. In the rural areas, wherever they live, they are excellent cultivators and a substantial section of them are rich farmers. As stated earlier these Sikh jats have played a very important role in the 'Green Revolution' of the country. In urban areas most of them earn their livelihood in the trade and commerce sector. They have substantial presence in transport, automobile, spare parts and transport service sector such as garage etc. They have always maintained a larger share in defence forces, larger in ratio than their population.

Like the Muslims and the Christians, the Sikhs are also internally segmented. They are divided into caste, class and urban-rural divides. The urban Sikh trading community, popularly known as *bhapas* (Khatris, Aroras, etc) are on the one hand and the daily wage earning Sikhs, generally of lower castes, are on the other. Moreover, there are caste-class divisions among artisans, such as carpenters *(Ramgarhias),* black smiths *(lohars)* etc. right from the cities to the towns and the villages. Then there are *Mazhabi Sikhs*- the scheduled castes.

After the partition turmoil, the post-Indira Gandhi assasination anti-Sikh violence was the second event that shook the entire Sikh community. Thousands of Sikhs were massacred in Delhi, Kanpur, Bokaro and elsewhere. But being a robust and vibrant community, they have recovered from this trauma too. The Sikhs, in spite of their cultural pride, still closely identify themselves with India and except a microscopic minority they are not tempted by secessionism. ■

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LINGUISTIC MINORITIES

Language is one of the greatest glories and achievements of human kind. It is indeed one of the greatest treasures of human civilization. It is the most important part of human culture and cultural expression. Language also gives any human group its cultural identity and the preservation of all the components of culture is ensured through language.

India is the home of a very large number of languages. Grierson in his monumental work *Linguistic Survey of India* enumerated 179 languages and as many as 544 dialects in the country. Even if we take out several languages from this category of languages and put them in the category of dialects, the fact remains that India will be described as a land of great language diversity and linguistic pluralism. Writing on the social geography of India, Aijazuddin Ahmed (1999) writes that "the prevailing situation in the country is not pluralistic but that of a continuum. One dialect merges into the other almost imperceptibly; one language replaces the other gradually. Moreover, along the line of contact between two languages, there is a zone of transition in which people are bilingual. Thus, languages do not exist in watertight compartments. Linguistic pluralism is a state of mutual existence of several languages in a contiguous space and continues to be a distinctive feature of the modern Indian state."

When India became independent and different types of groups and communities in pluralistic India were craving for the fulfillment of their aspirations India's national leaders had to confront several language problems in the first two decades of independence. These problems included the official language issue, demands for the linguistic reorganization of the provinces of India whose boundaries during British rule did not conform to linguistic divisions, and the status of 'minority languages' within the reorganized states. Thus, the issues and problems of 'linguistic minorities' are largely the by product of the reorganization of states.

What a 'Linguistic Minority' means is clear from Articles 29 and 30 of the constitution. Thus, 'Linguistic Minorities' are minorities residing in the territory of India or any part thereof having a distinct language or script of their own. The language of the minority group need not be one of the languages mentioned in the Eight Schedule of the constitution. In other words a Linguistic Minority at the state level means any group of people whose mother tongue is different from the principal language of the state, and at the district and *taluk* levels, different from the principal language of the district or the *taluk*. It would thus be observed that the speakers of all the languages become eligible for being included among the linguistic minorities in one or more states, districts or taluks, except for those where the principal language is the same as their own language" *(Commissioner for Linguistic Minorities in India,* 1988). Apart from the constitutional provisions as enshrined in Articles 29, 30, 347 and 350 of the Constitution, the bulk of the safeguards for linguistic minorities were formulated during the period 1956 to 1961, i.e., immediately following the re organization of states on the linguistic basis.

Talking about the prejudices and discriminatory tendencies among the dominant ruling class, Paul R.Brass (1995) rightly points out that in contrast to the pluralist policies pursued by the Government of India, many of the states have pursued discriminatory policies towards their linguistic (and other) minorities within their boundaries. Moreover, the Centre has been unable to protect such minorities effectively against the opposition of the state governments concerned. The examples of Bengali speaking people in Assam, Kanada, Malayalam and Tamil speaking people of Andhra Pradesh and vice versa may be cited. Among the worst casualties have been Urdu in the north Indian states and the various so called "mother tongues" or dialects of Hindi and other larger languages which have not been granted official recognition by either the central or state governments. Moreover, even when official recognition has been granted grudgingly in some states, for instance to Urdu in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Andhra Pradesh, the discriminatory policies and practices continued unabated. The case of some of these dialects for example, the Maithli language of north Bihar may also be cited. These are separate languages in all but official recognition. To avoid the controversial issue of distinguishing between "languages" and "dialects", however, it is best to follow the practise of the Indian census authorities and use the term *mother tongue* to encompass both the terms. Paul Brass (ibid) stretching

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the argument further says that the languages and mother tongues are, in effect, arranged in a hierarchy of official status. At the top are the two languages, Hindi and English, recognized as official languages of the Union. At the next level are the regional languages recognized as official languages in the linguistically reorganized states (such as Kanada, Marathi, Oriya, Tamil, Bengali etc) all of which are also listed in the Eighth Schedule. At the third level are those languages listed in the Eight schedule which have no official status in any province, namely Sanskrit and Sindhi, the language of the province of Sindh now in Pakistan.

Since language is the most important marker of identity the linguistic minorities in different states have to face discriminatory and sometimes hostile attitude of the dominant class in different states especially in the sphere of job competition and other economic grievances. The speakers of minority languages are alway conscious of their cultural identity and when face a hostile state tend to come together and become a political force for the redressal of their grievances.

While the linguistic minorities are entitled to reasonable safeguards to protect their educational, cultural and other interests, it has to be borne in mind that such safeguards should not so operate as to perpetuate separatism. The best interest of both linguistic minorities as also the dominant linguistic majority can be secured only by promoting mutual understanding, goodwill and cooperation between them rather than by mere insistence on rights and safeguards. After all, in the ultimate analysis, the welfare of the individual or groups of individuals, whatever be their mother tongue, depends on the progress made by the country as a whole and by defending the national independence.

The case of tribal languages and linguistic groups is also an important issue in any discussion on linguistic minorities. Paul Brass (ibid) taking a holistic view of the situation rightly says that recognition of a mother tongue by a state government is no guarantee that facilities will actually be provided for students in government schools to receive instruction through the medium of their mother tongue. State government rules and regulations generally require that the parents of the children who wish such instruction formally request it and that a certain number of children in each school and classroom must do so in order to receive such instruction. Even then, competent teachers and text books in the language may not be available. Spokesmen for several other tribal languages both in the predominantly Hindi speaking states and in other states with large tribal minorites have demanded instruction for their children in their mother tongue, but the Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes Commission appointed by the Government of India in 1960 reported that, "in actual fact some of the states have taken this matter very casually". Moreover the state governments in general have tended to ignore the requests of the Commissioner for Linguistic Minorities and for Scheduled Castes and Tribes even the information on the extent to which speakers of tribal minority mother tongues have actually been provided with facilities for instruction in their mother tongues is not easily available. For example, the government of Bihar claims to have provided facilities for instructions through the medium of Oraon, Ho, Santhali, and Mundari but has not provided any figures to support it's claim since 1975-76."

A lot remains to be done for our tribal linguistic groups. The problem of lack of script and the constraints of inadequacy of text books need to be tackled at the national level. Early action needs to be taken for evolving a common script for tribal languages/dialects with a view to promoting education among the tribal people, particularly at the primary stage of education. Devanagari may appear to be an appropriate script for adoption for the tribal languages and dialects in the country, as has been adopted by Bodos of Assam, Bhils, Munda and Gonds of Madhya Pradesh.

National integration is not possible without emotional integration. Small minorities may be bulldozed into submission for the time being but in the long run it will lead to separatist tendencies among them when any minority group feels that its language, religion, customs and traditions are safe in the country and the state is doing all for its conservation. It strengthens the sense of belonging and acceptance of the language and culture of larger society. Cultural pluralism has been the essence of Indian civilization. India's destiny lies in pluralism and unity in diversity. Moreover, among the determining criteria of any 'civil society' are the ways minorities and women are treated in it.

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MODERNIZATION

Sociologists of the present age use the concept of modernization in the analysis of social change. It means the development of modern approach and outlook and adoption of modernity in everyday life. Modernization refers to the deeper change in man's way of thinking and feeling, a change in his whole attitude to life's problems, the society and the universe. As such, modernization appears to be a complex phenomenon involving the development of rational outlook and acceptance of realities and facts in the context of scientific value. It implies an inherent change in the mode of life in a particular direction for attaining modernity. Hence, man's attitude, idea, outlook and approach are oriented towards change in that direction. The term modernization is used not only to describe the changes in the material culture of a nation but also in its belief system, values and way of life on the whole. It is a process which brings desired types of changes in the social structure, value orientation, motivations and norms. It is a process of transformation of a society from its backward framework to a forward looking, progressing and prospering structural build up. Modernisation is not a process which has emerged out just recently. The Western people have been undergoing this process for some five centuries and people in the least developed regions of the world for less than a century.It began with the colonial history of many nations. In fact, the process of modernization has been slow in the initial stage but was accelerated after 1945. After World War Two it has been sped up and broad-based.

The factors which facilitated and accelerated the process of modernization are : the achievements in the field of science and technology, rapid growth of industrialisation and urbanisation, the rationalisation of social life, the emergence of a rational outlook in every walk of life, rapid development of mass phenomena like mass production, mass communication, mass, education and participation, democratization of political structure and growth of large heterogenous complex societies Weiner points out that each social science discipline is primarily concerned with modernization in terms of man's application of technologies to control the resources of nature so as to achieve a marked increase in the growth of per capita output. Basically the process of modernization is concerned with the natural, behavioural and social processes and the application of the new knowledge to human affairs. This process also involves an achievement, orientation and self-reliance in each individual. It does not mean mere imitation of the developed nations. It is a process which helps a nation to establish its own identity. Of course a nation has to learn much from the developed countries. But being a replica of the developed nations will not necessarily result in modernization. Society in the process of modernization recognizes its values of cultural heritage, but is not bound by the out-moded patterns of beliefs. It is a society which has cultural patterns favouring the adaptation of new methods and techniques in enriching its, physical, moral and socio- economic life. Daniel Lerner holds the view that the process of modernization involves the replacement of sacred revelation by the secular enlightenment in the guidance of human affairs. Secular enlightenment is personal to be achieved by each person. One wrong notion about modernization is initiation of one society by the other but modernization is essentially based on "a rationalist and positivist spirit." It is essentially a mass affair involving not only changes at the institutional level but also fundamental changes at the personal level, a change in modes of thinking, beliefs, opinions, attitudes and actions. It involves a fundamental change in social structure. In the Indian context it may be viewed as a structural change from the immutable Caste society which is a closed society to a casteless, classless, open society in which the ascriptive pattern changes to achievement pattern, *i.e.* an individual's status depends not on his birth but on his personal achievement and attainment. As such, the main feature of modernization is the building up of an 'open society' in which individuals of talent, enterprise and training, can find places in the society appropriate to their achievement.

Modernization is experienced in different spheres:

(i) in the political sphere, as simple tribal or village authority systems give way to systems of suffrage, political parties, representation and civil service bureaucracies ;

(ii) in the educational spheres, the social system strives to bring down the rate of illiteracy and enhance economically productive skills ;

(iii) in the religious sphere traditionalistic religions are gradually replaced by secularized belief systems,

(iv) in the familial sphere, the extended kinship units gradually break down

(v) in the stratificatioaal sphere, geographical and social mobility make a shift from fixed and ascriptive hierarchical system. These multiplicity of changes do not begin simultaneously or do not proceed at a uniform speed. Rather. these changes occur at different times and progress at different rates in a developing nation.

In the economic sphere Neil J. Smelser evinces at least four distinct processess which are also interrelated.

(i) In the realm of technology, a developing society changes from simple and traditional techniques towards the application of scientific knowledge.

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(ii) In agriculture, the developing society evolves from subsistence farming towards the commercial production of agricultural goods.

(iii) In Industry, the developing society undergoes a transformation from the use of human and animal power towards industrialization, or men working for wages at power-driven machines, which produce commodities marketed outside the community production.

(iv) As regards the ecological conditions, the developing society moves from the farm and village towards urban concentrations.

Political modernization comprises of the following features:

(i) the existence of a legal structure

(ii) the broadening of popular participation in the polity.

(iii) the capability of maintaining national integration through orderly accommodation of various divisive forces.

(iv) the capacity to blend administrative expertness, responsibility and rationality alongwith the popular will into an effective amalgam.

Factors of Modernization : A number of factors are involved in modernization *i.e.*, education, mass communication, ideology, values and attitude, growth of knowledge and science.

Education is the prime instrument in the creation of modern man, Shils and Anderson indicate that education plays a vital role in the inculcation of a sence of national loyalty and in creating attitudes and skills essentials for technological innovation. Development of mass communication is an important means of spreading modern attitudes.

The media helps create knowledge of desirable things fasler (ban these things themselves produced. Ideology also plays a significant role in changing mass behaviour and attitudes. Attitudinal and value changes are pre-requisites of the creation of modern society, economy and political system. The growth of knowledge and its application will enhance man's control over nature. Science has provided the information needed by people to increase the strength of their own impulse to modernize.

Thus modernization is a multi-dimenuonal process and the complex and interrelated series of changes in man's way of life. The occidental people have been undergoing this process for last live centuries and peoples in the least developed regions of the world for less than a century. It is a part of the universal experience. Although modernization holds great hopes for the welfare of maiikincl. it lias also been regarded as a destructive process in many respects. By destroying the traditional pattern of life, it has shattered the humane values evolved through centuries together. Implying considerable value changes, modernization involves the emergence of a new behavioural system having certain distinctive characteristics of its own. Value change is considered essential for institutional rearrangement which is absolutely necessary for modernization. A multiplicity of analyses of modernization provide its historical, economic and political perspectives. However, from the sociological angle these perspectives lack tolerence and miss certain important aspects of human context. The works of Lerner, Almond and Coleman, Mcclelland. Pool, Moore provide the following list of characteristic attributes of modernity :

(i) Mobility

(ii) High participation

(iii) Interest articulation

(iv) Interest aggregation

(v) Institutionalised political competition

(vi) Achievement orientation

(vii) Rational ends means calculations

(viii) New attributes to wealth, work, savings and enterprise

(ix) Faith in the desirabity and possibility of change

(x) Social, economic and political planning.

Thus a telescopic view of the works of social scientists make us believe that modernization is but just superficial acquisition of some isolated elements and characteristics of the more advanced countries.

PRE-REQUISITES OF MODERNIZATION

Eisenstadt holds that modernization requires three structural characteristics of a society :

(i) a high level of structural differentiation.

(ii) a high level of social mobilization, and

(iii) a relatively centralized and autonomous institutional framework.

Prasad holds that the pre-requisites— needed for a shift from traditionalism to modernization are :

(i) an awareness of purpose keeping in view the future

(ii) an awareness of existence beyond one's own world.

(iii) a sense of urgency

(iv) availability of variety of opportunities and roles ;

(v) an emotional preparedness for self-imposed tasks

(vi) emergence of devoted, dynamic and limited leadership.

Eisemtadt is of the view that in any social system modernization, the requires three structural characteristics:

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(i) a high level of structural differentiation
(ii) a high level of social mobilization and
(iii) a relatively centralized and autonomous institutional framework.

Ways of response to modernization : As the process of modernization is not responded in an uniform manner, in all social systems, Blumer evinces five different ways of response to the process of modernization, such as;

(i) Rejective response
(ii) Conjunctive response
(iii) Assimilative response
(iv) Supportive response and
(v) Disruptive response.

Rejective response presupposes that a traditional society may reject modernization and maintain traditional order due to powerful groups, landed aristocracy, oligarchy, religious fanaticism, vested interests, social prejudices, special interest and firm attachment to given forms of traditional life.

In the conjunctive response pattern, there occurs the co-existence of traditionalism and modernity without threatening the old order.

The assimilative response comprises of an absorption of the process of modernization by the traditional order. But simultaneously the traditional organizational pattern and life pattern are retained.

In supportive response the new and modern things are accepted on the ground that they strengthen the traditional order. The traditional groups and institutions utilize the scope provided by modernization to pursue the traditional interests in a more effective manner.

The disruptive response to modernization undermines the traditional order at many points while making adaptation to the changing situation.

These five responses are controlled by values, interest or preferences and occur at different stages of the traditional order and in different combinations.

CONCEPTUAL FORMULATIONS OF MODERNIZATION

In social sciences, modernization is conceived through four conceptual formulations at the minimum. These are :

(i) Psychological formulation
(ii) Normative formulation
(iii) Structural formulation
(iv) Technological formulation.

Motivation and orientations of the individual, his mode of thinking, beliefs, opinions, attitudes and actions are all conceived in the psychological formulation.

The normative approach to modernization emphasises norms and values like universalism, humanism, rationalism, individualism, pragmatism, liberalism and secularism.

Structural conceptualisation of modernization stresses structural components of society such as bureaucracy , democratic associations and complex economy. Simultaneously it recognises the importance of psychological as well as normative formulations

Technological approach to modernization emphasizes the economic resources and the utilisation of inaninate power in production system.

Daniel Lerner believes that modernization implies changes not only at the institutional level, but also at the personal level. As a rationalist and positivist spirit, it involves changes in the modes of belief, thinking, attitudes, opinions and action of the individual. Prof. Y. Singh also holds that modernization "symbolises a rational attitude towards issues and their evaluation from universalistic and not particularistic view point." As a form of cultural response, modernization involves "attributes which are basically, universalitic and evolutionary ; they are pan-humanistic, trans-ethnic and non-ideological." The very root of modernization lies in the scientific world views. "It has deeper and positive association with levels of diffusion of knowledge, technological skill and technological resources in a particular society." However, Prof. Singh believes that the commitment to scientific world-view, the internalization of humanistic and philosophical view point of science on contemporary problems are the essential conditions for modernization.

PROCESS OF MODERNIZATION IN INDIA

Contact with the west, particularly the British initiated the process of modernization of Indian tradition. This contact resulted in a multiplicity of changes in Indian culture and social structure. Although the main focus of this contact was directed towards modernization, it, nevertheless, straightened a variety of traditional institutions. "This demonstrates the weakness of assuming a neat contratriety between tradition and modernity. This polarity may be more heuristic than real." But modern cultural institutions and forms of social structure could only be introduced after the establishment of British rule in India. The attitude of the British rulers in India were formed in a social background of transformed sratification, systematic, social reformation, emergence of protestatism, cumulative chain of innovations in science and technology and a rational *individualism* in the economy and society in Europe. Such an attitude of the rulers and administrators determined the course and nature of modernization in India to a large extent. To them, Indian

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society appeared a composition of "discrete plural traditions of castes, sub-castes and tribes devoid of systematic binding force of a universal nature" Therefore the contribution of the colonial administrator in the process of modernization lied in the creation of such networks of social structure and culture which were "Modern and pan-Indian"

At the initial stage, mainly during the seventeenth century, modernization of the sub-culture began with the socialisation of a small nucleus of trader-cum-middlemen in the western manner. Later on it led to the institution of a modernization of Great tradition. Spread of new means of communication and transport, urbanization and industrialization, social reforms, expansion of western education, and a universalitistic legal system were construed as the normative components of modernization in India. As regards structural modernization, rational bureacratic systems of administration and judiciary, industrial bureaucracy and army emerged. Alongwith them a class of political elite and a nationalist leadership also came into existence. That apart, a class of industrial workers and the organization of trade unions in the western pattern came into being. In spite of the uniform character articulation of nationalist aspiration throughout the country, the growth of this modernizing process was selective and segmental. It failed to pierce the micro Indian social structure, such as family caste or village community due to the policy of least interference of the Britishers. In the twentieth century, due to the momentum gathered by the nationalist movement and introduction of communal electorate system the contingency traditional institutions was increased.

The Indian process of modernization during the Freedom Movment ushered in a novel political culture due to the personality of Mahatma Gandhi and his love for tradition. In the post-colonial period, the process of modernization, in India has undergone a fundamental transformation from its earlier colonial pattern. "Discontinuity between modernization of macro-structures and micro-structures and Little and Great Tradition has now been consciously abolished". Modernization has been envisaged for all levels of cultural and structural systems through politicization of every sector of social organization by the introduction of adult suffrage and a federal form of political structure, legal reforms affecting the foundations of traditional Hindu marriage and family structure, community development projects coupled with land reforms, and local level management and administration of justice.

Thus the Indian society, since the days of independence, is engaged in the tremendous task of transformation from a traditional hierarchical, poverty stricken society to a modern equalitarian and affluent society. Modern India, in real terms, is made up of three major influences. Hinduism the British 'rational-legal authority' and the reconstructive rationalism of the colonial era.

If we analyse social change in India by segments of social development, we will have to go by the suggestions of Peter Markel." They are : (i) the economic system (ii) the social structure *(iii)* the family *(iv)* the role of the individual (v) the cultural system *(vi)* the political system.

These developments are studied in three stages, *i.e* pre-British phase, British phase and post-independence stage.

THE ECONOMIC SYSTEM

In the Pre-British phase, India was an agrarian society. The vast majority of her population lived in isolated villages and tribal communities. They produced very simple food. Their production hardly exceeded the demands of subsistence. The plough and the bullock carts were the important assets of the Indian farmer who lacked in innovative spirit and incentives for improvement. Of course a small chunk of the population mostly comprising of a class of traders, craftsmen and courtesans lived in cities. Their life style was relatively more modern, but it did not affect the population at large. The bulk of population, characterised by ignorance and isolation, in general, has hardly played any role in politics.

During the British rule, the introduction of industry and technology in India caused awareness among the Indians. India experienced the impact of modern science in the process of production. Due to the establishment of large industries, people began to move towards the cities in search of employment. Scientific technology replaced the traditional mode of production. The British exploited the country. For this purpose they had to establish a sophisticated network of communication which helped the people integrate. India suffered at the hands of British capitalism which left a permanent scar on the economic as well as on other forms social structure. In this regard Paul Barun writes : 'They existed under capitalism. Yet there was no accumulation of capital. They lost their time, honoured means of livelihood, their arts and crafts, yet there was no modern industry to provide new ones in their place. They are thrust into extensive contact with the advance science of the West, yet remained in the state of the largest backwardness. A lot of blood and sweat, oppression and injustice, cultural

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frustrations and even human life in India, made Britain industrially prosperous. Simultaneously, it resulted in an inverse degradation of India's social, economic and cutural resources A proper account of the happenings in India, under the colonial rule gave the idea that British rule was helping India modernise. But whatever modernization occured, it helped quench their thirst for gold and power.

When the alien rulers left India, dividing it, in two parts, they did more injustice to the economy than ever before. Of course, the introduction of scientific technology and industry in India set the "pre-conditions for the take off of modern economic growth. But this was jeopardized due to financial problems to start afresh the industries which were left behind in the hands of leaders of the post independence era.

Left in a confused state of economy, the leaders had no option of phasing the processes of growth into a sequential development. Rather they had to pursue diverse goals simultaneously. At least four goals are to be identified in this regard : the goal of "self-sustained growth, the goal of high rate of growth", the goal of "equality" and the goal of equity and justice." The first goal was concerned with independence of the economy from its reliance on strategic imports and foreign aid, the second goal related to resource mobilization and capital accumulation leading to increase in rates of saving and investment. The goal envisaged reduction of sectoral and social disparities. The last one was concerned with providing minimum conditions of subsistence and survival. The leader of Independent India took steps to implement land reforms and set up planning machinery to start a coordinated effort at resource mobilisation and planned development and the initiation of community development movement and cooperative movement, to provide basic facilities for rural development. The implementation of these new schemes and reforms evinced the beginnings of economic take off. Since then modernization has been going on incessantly but at a slower rate.

SOCIAL STRUCTURE

The traditional Indian society comprised of self-sufficient and sparsely settled villages and tribes. The feudal lords ruled over many ethnically distinct communities. The *spatial* ability was quite low and means of communication limited. The Indian farmer was engaged in a subsistence economy. He depended neither on imports nor on exports from the rural community due to lack of communications between the village and outside world. The farmer remained illiterate and had no knowledge of the outside world. Wide variations were marked in matters of customs, languages and religions. All these resulted in a variety of cultures. The division of traditional Indian society into different rigid occupational social communities, such as the castes and sub-castes, provided a localised social structure. The rigid caste system was characterised by functional interdependence, individual identification, and social cohesion. By restricting a person's choice of occupation, way of life and marriage partner and marriage pattern, the caste system rigidly defined his social and cultural identity . People expressed a multiplicity of loyalties towards their group family, caste, class and village. The hierarchical authority structure and the traditional normative pattern laid down by the higher caste or village eldrs were imposed on the individual.

The British rule in India disrupted the traditional social order and culture so drastically that Humpty Dumpty could never be put together again. Inspite of the spread of urbanisation, rapid expansion of railways and other means of communication, development of news media, no revolutionary changes occured in the caste system and social issues during the British regime. It continued to be the force of conservatism. The members belonging to the higher caste groups also dominated the profession and captured the higher post and all white collar jobs in the government. On the other hand the lower castes were contended with certain essential services and goods. In oder to manage the higher services the Britishers created English speaking middle classes. The members of these classes were mostly drawn from the higher caste groups. The Britishers also created cleavages among the Indians on the basis of caste system and religious orders. Through such tactics they could be able to rule over the Indians for a longer period. However the colonial rule broke down the traditional form of authoritarianism and the percolation from democratic culture.

In the post-independence era the process of transition towards modernisation kept up its speed. Nevertheless after five decades of achievement of independence, we have not been able to abolish the caste system. No doubt the caste system is gradually breaking down but casteism is solidifying its base due to the democratic political process by drawing the caste stern in its nexus of organisation, the democratic polity finds substance for its articulation and wounds it to it's own design. However the rigidity of caste system, the barriers which the caste system had in the past, are in the process of disintegration. Restrictions relating to commensality and connubium are losing ground and inter-caste marriages and secularization is going on. Simultaneously caste is playing an important role in the elections.

THE INDIVIDUAL AND THE FAMILY

The traditional Indian family was based on a strict hierarchical principle of age and sex and superiority of males and older persons, whereas males were considered superior

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to females, older persons were regarded superior to younger ones. The prevalence of joint family system was the order of the day and individual status was determined on the basis of his family and caste. His position in the larger social system was based on the occupation to which he was entitled, his affinity to the traditional authority and his obligation as a member of the family. Individual was complying with responsibilities assigned to him by the social system and performing his well defined duties in a perfect manner. In return for his compliance with social expectation, he was given protection by the family, the village or the class.

With the introduction of industries and factories during the colonial era, the joint family system began to disintegrate and failed to provide any individual security. Although the joint family was considered a hindrance to individual mobility, still there were many industrial workers who continued to maintain their relations with their joint families. However an individual status was no more solely associated with his family, village and class. Rather his status began to grow with the level of education and the type of job he was employed in, under the colonial administration. This resulted in the creation of a new class – English educated, tutored in liberal ideas and imbued with western style. This section of the society, the new middle class, was prepared to serve under the British.

In the post-independence era, the process of transition, began by the foreigners, has been accelerated. India has been politically free. It has obtained sovereignty. She declares herself to be a secular, sovereign, socialistic, democratic republic and grants the citizens social and economic justice, equality and freedom, it also provides every individual equal rights and duties as well as equal importance due to its democratic polity. The welfare responsibilities of the individuals which lied with the joint family has been taken up by the stale. The caste system due to its incompatibility with the principle of rationality, egalitarianism and democracy and mobility has come in conflict with the assumptions of the political regimes and it is in the process of gradual erosion. In order to maximise their freedom, people have started realising the significance of associations in social, economic and political spheres of life.

THE CULTURAL SYSTEM

The history of India reveals that it owed it's unity not to the authority of the given political system but to the wide diffusion of the cultural symbols, the spiritual values and the structure of roles and functions characteristic of a continuous civilization. The Vedantic type of religion provided humanitarian sentiments of love, friendship and universal brotherhood and social service. The Vedic sanction also accorded the institutions of Varna and Jati and the joint family which dominated the Indian social life for centuries together. Traditional people also believe in purity of heart. Due to the prevalence of such belief pattern and institutions in traditional Indian, social development was very slow. Obstacles to development were very many. In this kind of situation as prevailed in India then, social modernization would have taken a very long time to set in India.

The arrival of the Britishers and their colonial rule for over two centuries in an incessant manner dispelled many barriers. Despite the prevalence of the rigidity of the caste system, the family system began to change. The social reformers like Raja Ram Mohan Roy and Mahatma Gandhi through their untiring efforts, could be able to remove the orthodox customs like the practice of Sati and untouchabilily. The country began to pass through a period of modernization.

The capitalistic economy brought into existence the cultural lag and the force of westernization strengthened it. People began to forget their own culture and tradition and made themselves available for those cultural pattern prevalent in Britain and America. Although some of the traditional values of Indian culture have been rejected in the way towards modernisation and reform, nevertheless the social institutions and cultural values in the present India are not adapted to the way of life of an industrial society. The cultural lag still haunts the country. The steps taken to bridge the gap created by the cultural lag only appear like bridging the gulf between the rural and urban India.

THE POLITICAL SYSTEM

Throughout the eighteenth century and the early part of the nineteenth century the Indian political scenario was very much confused. India lagged in a central authority due to the down fall of the Moghal empire and constant wars of territorial acquisition were waged by the foreigners. The end of the Moghal empire made Indian situation militarily and politically chaotic. It was a land divided. The arrival of the British changed the entire political scenario. After the military revolt of 1857, the British power emerged stronger. It established an unchallenged political foothold in the Indian subcontinent. The entire country was brought under one empirial rule. The English power dominated for a long time "without fear of either dissruption from within and aggression from without". Such a unity was a major achievement in the sense that later on it provided the territorial basis on which prevailed the feeling of nationalism and the feeling of India as a nation. The enforcement of the rule of law and political order may be construed as another positive aspect of British dominance and the political development of India. The British Raj had

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the manifest function of providing a unified administration but its latent function lied in the integration of the nation. The modern type of bureaucracy based on. merit and open competition thrust India towards political modernisation. The English educated baboos comprising the middle class mostly participated in the competition. The colonial administrator ensured the operation of West Minister model in this country before they left India. The British also initiated the democratic form of government which remained the pivot of the Indian government in the post-independence era.

After achieving independence, India chose to adopt an open system of development that involved a simultanety of goals and a mix between tradition and modernity. The Indian National Congress came to inherit power from the British Raj. It was an outgrowth of considerable intellectual awakening, social "renaissance", and reformist activity throughout the nineteenth century. The Indian National Congress had pragmatic leadership, accommodating various stands of thought and commitment with anti-colonialism as its ideology. It also believed in solidarity with other colonial nations.The Indian National Congress prophesized a participart democracy, equality and social justice, respect for diversity, inguistic states, planned economic development, tolerance of minorities and communal harmony, rejection of voilence as means of resolution of conflict and planned economic development. It was a highly amorphous organization with such a consensus on the basis of clearly defined ideology. Gandhiji's interpretation of tradition resulted in the mobility of the past for the transformation of the direction of the present. He always strove to legitimize his programme and to build bridges over both time and space. That apart, a sense of over riding unity prevailed which cut across ethnic, linguistic and religious diversity, political divisions and ideological differences. A fine blend of the nationalist movement and of the Hindu civilization contributed to the unity of the new India and largely determined its modernist design, depth, flexibility and manoeuvrability. " Together with the long duration and Conformity to India's ancient civilization, many things have facilitated the process of transformation along a modernist path. Unprecedented impact brought about by the colonial thrusts, one of the longest nationalist movement, the emergence of charistmatic leaders and centralizing elites imbued with modernist ideology all determined India's path of modernization in the form of reconciliation between tradition and change. Attempts were made to modernize our society at various levels. At the social level equality and human dignity, social values ensuring social mobility, removal of caste disabilities and raising the status of women were emphasized. At the economic level we desired to bring about technological growth and distributive justice. We desired to imbibe ideal of secularism, rationalism and liberalism at the cultural level. At the political level the Indians wanted a democratic polity through representative government, people's partipation and greater voice in the governance of the country, decentralisation of power at the grass root level and achievement oriented power structure.

Rational and scientific means were selected for modernizing the Indian society. Legislation was considered an important agent of social change. Spread of education was stressed to dispel the ignorance of people. Assistance from foreign countries was sought for economic development and the policy of liberalization was adopted. However, the unique feature of modernization in India was that it did not suffer from structural breakdown. Rather, it carried forward modernization through adaptative changes in the traditional structures. The good features of traditional institutions are retained through adaptation, in the developmental process. Attraction towards the modern values and love for the traditional ones cause inherent clash between tradition and modernity. As a developing society, India faced the tensions of the legacies of the past, accentuated by economic development, dichotomy between the forces of stability and conservation and the forces of transformation and modernization. We evince many a challenge to modernization in India. Illiteracy, regionalism, parochial outlook, migration, inflation, lack of capital, expenses on defence, political corruption and inefficient bureaucratic organization have hindered the process of modernization in India.

As regards the *problems of modernization,* process of disorganization and dislocation, stagnation of some parts and dynamism of others causing inconsistent growth alongwith its own miseries and problems, large scale unemployment, population growth, need for housing and social security, cleavages and conflicts between various groups and movements of protest cause resistance to change.

Unrest among the educated unemployed, uneven structural change, conflict between changing socio-economic institutions and traditional ways of life, disjunction between modern roles adopted by people and inculcation of traditional values, lack of co-operation among the agencies of modernization and the institutions and systems to modernise leading to cultural lag, lack of facilities to fulfil the aspirations of people raised by modernization results in frustration and social unrest. But these are necessarily the birth tanks of modernising society. A close look at the models of the developed nations reveals that they have to pass through various ordeals during their period of modernization ranging from revolutionary strifes to violent wars. As viewed by F.W. Riggs, these crises were not only "unavoidable consequences of development, but perhaps in a more significant way they were the causes of development" Hence these stimulus of crises may be viewed as the necessary dynamism of development. ■

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LEGISLATION AND DEMOCRATIC DECENTRALISATION

UNDERSTANDING LAW AND LEGISLATION

There is a reciprocal relationship between law and social change. law is both an effect and cause of social change. In this chapter we shall consider law as a strategy for social change.

In its broadest sense, law includes all patterns of socially expected rule enforcement. In this sense, it covers all customs or rules whose observance is required and enforced by a recognised authority. However, for sociological purposes it is better to limit the term law to formally enacted and recorded norms. Though there is no exact demarcation between law and norms that are found in a society, a distinction has to be made between laws on the one hand and norms on the other. In the present discussion we shall use law in the sense of rules of action established by a legitimate authority.

Lawa are enacted by legislatures. They are always written and recorded in some manner. They are interpreted by courts and enforced by administrative agencies like police. For example, the nature of punishment and the procedures for giving such punishments for theft or robbery are all mentioned in law books.

Broadly speaking, there are two categories of law – criminal law and Civil law. Criminal laws prohibit actions disruptive to society such as theft, murder or fraud. Civil laws, on the other hand, regulate the rights of individuals such as resolving property disputes. Civil law takes many forms depending upon the nature of social life involved. They may be commercial, constitutional and family laws.

The law-making system in every society produces legislations concerning various aspects of life. legislation may be of different types. Some of them are framed to maintain law and order in society. such legislations act as a mechanism social stability. In contrast, some legislation are applied to remove social evils and change the conservative faiths and beliefs. The term social legislations. Social legislations play a dynamic role in society. They are effective instruments of social change.

LAW AND SOCIAL CHANGE

History is full of examples where laws have been used to bring about changes in society. Laws have been created to achieve desired goals. It is not only articulates but also sets the course for major social changes. In fact, attempted social change through law is an important feature of the modern world. This is visible in almost all developed and developing societies. The changes that have occurred with the transformation of Western capitalist societies and the emergence of Soviet-type societies have essentially been through laws. The Soviet Union and several east European countries for example, have successfully made largescale social changes through laws. Income redistribution, nationalisation of industries, land reforms and provision of free education are examples of the effectiveness of law to initiate change.

Nonetheless, a distinction is made between direct and indirect aspects of law in social change. In many cases law interacts directly with social institutions and brings about abvious changes. For instance, a law prohibiting polygamy has a direct influence on society. It alters the behaviour of individuals. On the other hand, laws play an indirect role also by shaping various social institutions which in turn have a direct impact on society. The most appropriate example is the system of compulsory education which enables the functioning of educational institutions, which in turn leads to social change. However, such a distinction is not absolute but a relative one. Sometimes, emphasis is on the direct aspect and less on the indirect impact of social change, while in other cases the opposite may be true.

There is another way of examining the role of law in social change. Law redefines the normative order and creates the possibility of new forms of social institutions. It provides formal facilities and extends righs to individuals. In India, for example, law against untouchability has not only prohibited the inhuman practice but has also given formal rights to those who suffered from such disabilities to protest against it. In this sense, law not only prohibited the inhuman practice but has also given formal rights to those who suffered from such disabilities to protest against it. In this sense, law not only codifies certain customs and morals, but also modifies the behaviour and values existing in a particular society. Thus, law entails two interrelated processses: the institutionalisation and the internalisation of patterns of behaviour. Institutionalisation of a pattern of behaviour means the creation of norms with provisions for its enforcement. Internationalisation of pattern of behaviour, on the other hand, means the incorporation and acceptance of values implicit in a law. When the institutionalisation process is successful, it in turn facilitates the internalisation of attitudes and beliefs.

LEGAL SYSTEM IN INDIA

Historically, no universalistic legal system based on the principle of equality existed in ancient India. In ancient India

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there was a close connection between law and religion. a rule of law was not different from a rule of religion. It was maintained that all laws were contained in the *Dharmshastras*. The legal system was primarily based on the social position of castes and classes. No uniform standards were applied in providing justice to people. There was no uniform legal norm at an all-India level. Local customs and regional practices defined and determined these norms. another important feature of the ancient legal system was its orientation towards the group. Legal norms applied more to the group as a unit rather than to the individual. This characteristic of legal system continued even during the medieval period.

It was only during the British rule that radical transformation took place in the legal and judicial systems of the country. the British introduced numerous changes in the traditional legal system. the new legal system was based on the principle of universalism. The notion of equality before law was recognised and received legal sanction. Law courts were established at different levels. The enactment of the Indian Penal code and the Codes of Civil and Criminal Procedure produced a strong system of judicial administration. This legal system was, however, not confined to criminal justice alone. it even brought domestic and personal life of the people under its purview. Several social legislations came into operation which covered areas like collective bargaining, social security and employment contract. A continuous rationalisation of law was introduced by condification of customary law. It increased the separation of law from religion.

Moreover, some legislation in relation to prevailing conservative and orthodox social practices were also passed during the colonial period which acted towards social reform. Indian society in the nineteenth century was under the grip of inhuman customs and practices. Untouchability was practised throughout the country. The position of women was most degrading. Child marriage, widowhood and the cruel practice of sati put women to life-long misery and humiliation. These inhuman practices were, however, challenged by social reformers and the British Indian Government responded by enacting several social legislations.

The practice of *sati* (widow burning) was declared illegal in 1829. The Hindu widow Remarriage act of 1856 legalised the remarriage of the Hindu widows. When the members of the Brahmo Samaj in Bengal started facing problem in marriage, a Native Marriage Act was passed in 1872. the Brahmos claimed that they did not belong to any religious groups in India. This act worked like a civil marriage law under which people outside any religious fold could marry. Another important legislation linked with marriage was the Age of Consent act of 1891. The Act prohibited the performance of marriage was the age of Consent Act of 1891. The Act prohibited the performance of marriage for girls below the age of twelve. During the closing years of the nineteenth century, besides personal laws, several other laws relating to land and industry were also enacted.

The Factory Act of 1881 addressed the issue of the welfare of factory workers. The Bengal Tenancy Act of 1885 introduced reforms in land tenure system. Similarly, the Press Act of 1885 introduced reforms in land tenure system. Similarly, the Press Act of 1878 was a landmark in the field of mass communication. These legislations not only advanced the cause of cultural change but also contributed towards transformation of the agrarian structure.

SOCIAL LEGISLATION IN POST - INDEPENDENT INDIA

The nature and extent of social change in India has been influenced largely by radical social legislation introduced after the independence. They pertain to subjects ranging from economy, polity, trade and commerce to marriage, family and inheritance. Legislations impact upon every aspect of people's lives. the number of legislation enacted after the independence is, however, so large that all of them cannot be discussed here. Therefore, we have selected only some important legislation to highlight their role in social change.

Laws have been passed to eradicate social evils. Under Article 17 of the Indian Constitution, untouchability is prohibited and its practice in any form is made punishable. A comprehensive legislation called the Untouchability (Offences) Act, 1955 was passed later. This Act was further amended as the Protection of Civil Rights Act in 1976. according to this Act, an untouchable (Schedule Caste) has access to all public places including places of worship. Though this legislation has not been fully able to eradicate the practice of untouchability, it has definitely attacked caste prejudice.

Similarly, a number of laws have been enacted for the upliftment of women and children. These Acts have brought about a perceptible improvement in their position in society. The special Marriage act of 1954, the Hindu Marriage act of 1955, the Hindu Succession Act of 1956 and the Dowry Prohibition Act of 1961 have initiated changes in the very structure of Hindu society. Most of these legislations have further been amended to accomodate more radical and relevant issues. For example, the Hindu Marriage Act of 1955 was amended in 1976 to provide the right to a girl to deny marriage before attaining puberty. In fact the original

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Act itself was radical because it enforced monogamy and permitted divorce among the Hindus. The Dowry Prohibition Act of 1961 was also amended in 1984 that made cruelty towards women a cognisable offence. the socio-economic changes that have been brought about through legislations have created a favourable situation regarding the status of women.

A number of legislations have also been passed to safeguard and protect the rights of children. some of them are the Hindu Adoption and Maintenance Act, 1956, the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986, the Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1996 the Juvenile Justice Act, 2000 and so on.

The role of legislation in transforming the socio-economic condition of tribals is even more explicit. We may throw light on this issue by citing the example of north-eastern India, which is home to a large number of tribals. The tribal communities of this region have experienced remrkable changes in their traditional economy, cultural life and political systems. The safeguards provided to tribals in the states of Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram under the sixth Schedule of the Constitution of India have facilitated numerous programmes for administration and development. Special provisions under Article 371A of the Constitution have been made for the State of nagaland to safeguard the cultural identity of the Nagas. The State Governments have passed several legislations which have ushered changes along with preserving their identity. The Autonomous district Councils established under the provisions of the Sixth Schedule have been given wide power to maintain control over the tribal land. The Land Transfer Act of 1971 passed by the Meghalaya State Legislature has almost stopped the process of land alienation. Likewise, the Lushai Hills District (Acquisition of Chief's Rights) Act, 1954 abolished the age-old system of chieftainship among the Mizos as the people themselves demanded it. What we have attempted to illustrate here is that, in a democratic state like ours legislation can be effectively used as an instrument of social change.

DEMOCRATIC DECENTRALISATION

The question of division of power among institutions and individuals has been a matter of considerable debate among the people involved in governance. This need has been specially emphasised as democracy as a form of government has gained acceptance in the modern world. Decentralisation means sharing of decision making authority with the lower levels in institutions and organisations. It is called democratic as this sharing is based on the basic principle of democracy and democratisation. There are different forms of decentralisation – political, administrative and financial.

It is argued that decentralisation is essential for the functioning of a democratic system at different levels. it helps to empower social groups which traditionally have been weak and deprived. Decentralisation is particularly necessary for a country like ours which is large in size and complex in socio-cultural settings. Diversity exists in India in terms of religion, language, culture and economy. Thus, the geographical and social complexities require decentralisation for the purposes of planning and administration.

The need for decentralisation in India has long been realised and attempts have been made to achieve it. Decentralisation became, particularly, important after Independence to achieve goals of democracy and development.

In the section that follows we will discuss the Panchayati Raj institutions as forms and institutional schemes for achieving democratic decentralisation.

PANCHAYATI RAJ INSTITUTIONS

BACKGROUND

The history of panchayat in India goes back to hundreds of years. The term panch is ordinarily used for a group of persons (panch = five) who take decisions on collective affairs of the village. The people repose so much confidence in panch that they are called panch parmeshwar (God speaks through the five). The system of taking collective decision through panch is known as panchayat. It is, largely, a self-governing institution.

The growth of panchayat in India as a self-governing institution has not been steady in the course of its long history. However, the ideals of panchayat were revived when Mahatma Gandhi arrived on the national political scene. Gandhiji asserted that the village panchayats would now be a living force in a special way, and India would almost be enjoying self-government suited to its requirements. Accordingly, the idea of panchayat as a system of local government remained an important issue in India's freedom struggle. But when the country became independent the panchayat of Gandhi's vision did not acquire a central place in the Indian Constitution. It was merely included in Article 40 under the Directive Principles of the state Policy. article 40 says, "the State shall take steps to organise village panchayats and endow them with such powers and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as units of local self-government".

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Nonetheless, it is interesting to point out that, although the Directive Principles of the Constitution are only suggestive in nature, the significance of Panchayati Raj institutions was recognised by all States. Immediately after the Independence an ambitious development programme for rural areas was launched. The programme, known as the Community Development Programme (CDP), covered almost all activities of rural development. But it could not fully achieve its goals. in order to review the causes of its limited success, the Government of India appointed a Study Team. It was headed by Balwantrai Mehta, the then Member of Parliament. The Study Team came to the conclusion that the CDP had failed to achieve its targets because of the absence of the people's participation in the programme. In view of this, it recommended the creation of certain institutions based on the principle of democratic decentralisation for facilitating people's participation in development programmes. the formation of three-tier Panchayati Raj institutions in the country was the result of the above recommendations. All the States in India passed Panchayat Acts by 1959. Accordingly, panchayats were established at village (Village Panchayat), block Panchayat Samiti) and District (Zila Parishad) levels. Another committee, popularly called the Ashok Mehta Committee, also reviewed the functioning of the Panchayati Raj structure. This Committee proposed a two tier system for grass-root governance. But the Government did not accept this recommendation and we continued to follow the three-tier system proposed by the Balwantrai Mehta Committee report.

This setup of panchayats continued for almost more than two decades. Though the basic objectives of these institutions were uniform in various states but their powers, functions and modes of elections differed considerably. under these circumstances, the performance of these institutions widely varied from State to State. In some States, they effectively contributed to development activities, but in other States panchayats they merely generated conflicts and rivalries among various caste groups for controlling power in these institutions. Panchayati Raj institutions failed in benefiting the weaker sections of rural society.

Moreover, the organisational structure of these institutions remained very weak. In the absence of any legal binding, no regular elections to panchayats were held. No financial power was given to these panchayati bodies. Government officials continued to maintain wide-ranging command over *panchayat* represenatatives Such bureaucratic control killed initiative and interests of the people in the Panchayati Raj structures. The stagnation and decline of Panchayati Raj institutions continued till the early nineties when steps were undertaken to revitalise them.

RECENT EFFORTS

As stated before, except a marginal reference in the Directive Principles of the State Policy, Panchayat had no constitutional status. But the position radically changed in 1993, when the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution was passed in the Parliament and received the assent of the President of India. The Amendment is based on the principle of 'power to the people' and provides constitutional guarantee to panchayats. The salient features of the Act are given below :

a. It recognises panchayats as 'institutions of self-government'.

b. It entrusts panchayats the powers and responsibilities to prepare a plan for economic development and social justice.

c. It provides for the establishment of uniform three-tier system of strong panchayats at village, intermediate (block/taluka) and district levels for all states having a population of over twenty lakh.

d. it gives guidelines for the structure, powers and functions, finance and elections, and reservations of seats for the weaker sections at various levels of panchayats.

The Constitution (73rd Amendment) Act has been hailed as a revolutionary step towards establishing grass-root democracy. The blueprint provided by the Amendment has now become a reality. All the states have passed legislation in conformity with with the provisions of the Amendment. Thus, for the first time in the history of Panchayat Raj system, a high degree of uniformity has been achieved on panchayats.

Another Act has been passed for the tribal areas of some States. The provisions of the Panchayats (Extension to the Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 extends panchayats to the tribal areas of Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Himachal pradesh, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Orissa and Rajasthan. This has come into effect on 24 December 1996. All states have passed laws to give effect to the provisions contained in the Act 40 of 1996.

Against the above background we now move on to discuss various aspects of Panchayat Raj Institutions in terms of structure, composition, power and function.

STRUCTURE AND COMPOSITION

Panchayats are constituted at the village, intermediate and district levels. The term intermediate has been used for Community Development Block or taluka because it exists between a village and a district. However, panchayats at the intermediate level may not be constituted if the population of a state does not exceed twenty lakh.

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Gram Sabha is a body consisting of all persons registered in the electoral rolls to a-village comprised within the area of Gram panchayat. Gram Sabha is regarded as the soul of Panchayati Raj. since all the registered voters of a village Panchayat are included in a Gram Sabha, it acts as a general body of the village panchayat. it provides a forum for the people to ensure transparency and accountability in the system. All-State Panchayat Acts have provision for the constitution of Gram Sabha. The Sabha has to meet at least once in six months.

All the seats in a panchayat are filled by persons chosen by direct election from territorial constituencies in the panchayat area. each panchayat area is divided into territorial constituencies for this purpose.

The Chairperson of a panchayat at the village levels is elected ordinarily by the voters of the concerned panchayat. But the Chairperson of panchayat at the intermediate level or a district level is elected by and from amongst the elected members.

RESERVATION OF SEATS

In every panchayat seats are reserved for the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes in proportion to their population in the panchayat area. Depending upon the decision of a State, provision for reservation of seats may be provided in favour of the Other Backward Classes of citizens.

Not less than one-third of the total number of seats to be filled by direct election is reserved for women. this includes seats reserved for women belonging to the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes.

The posts of the Chairperson in Panchayats at the different levels are also reserved for the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and women. the number of such reserved posts for the first two categories depends on their population. But in the case of women the number of reserved posts of Chairpersons has to be not less than one-thid of the total number of posts at each level.

Finally, the State has also been given power to make any provision for reservation of seats and posts at any level for the Other Backward Classes.

DURATION OF PANCHAYATS

Every Panchayat shall have the duration of five years from the date of its first meeting. An election to constitute a Panchayat has to be held before the expiry of its duration of five years. But in such a case an election to constitute a Panchayat has to be ocmpleted before a period of six months from the date of its dissolution.

POWERS AND RESPONSIBILITIES OF PANCHAYATS

Panchayats have been given power and authority to enable them to function as institutions of self-government. There are two major areas which have been identified for this purpose. They are :

a. The preparation of plans for economic development and social justice; and

b. The implementation of schemes for economic development and social justice.

The Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution has listed some subjects concerning the above schemes that may be undertaken by panchayats at different levels. some major subjects are

1. Agriculture
2. Land improvement, implementation of land reforms, land consolidation
3. Minor irrigation, watershed development
4. Animal husbandry
5. Fisheries
6. Social forestry
7. Small scale industries
8. Khadi, village and cottage industries
9. Drinking water
10. rural housing
11. Roads, culverts, bridges etc
12. Rural electrification
13. Poverty alleviation programmes
14. Education including primary and secondary schools
15. Cultural activities
16. Health and sanitation

OTHER MAJOR CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS

In addition to the above provisions, the Constitution has made some other provisions to strengthen Panchayati Raj institutions.

a. Panchayats have been authorised to levy, collect and appropriate taxes and and fees.

b. A Finance Commission has to be constituted by every state to review the financial position of the panchayats.

c. A State Election Commission consisting of a State Election Commissioner has to be appointed in every state. it will conduct all elections to the panchayats.

PANCHAYATS IN URBAN AREAS

A provision has also been made to constitute panchayat in some urban areas. In order to provide a common

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framework for urban local bodies as effective democratic unit of self-government. Parliament enacted the Constitution (74th Amendment) Act, in 1992 relating to municipalities. The Act received the assent of the President on 20 April 1993. The act provides constitution of three types of Municipalities.

a. Nagar Panchayats for areas in transition from a rural area to urban area.
b. Municipal Councils for smaller urban areas, and
c. Municipal Corporation for large urban areas.

Like rural panchayats, the Act has made provisions for making these bodies effective and strong. these provisions include fixed duration of municipalities, appointment of State Election commission, appointment of State Finance Commission and constitution of metropolitan and district planning committees. All the States have implemented these provisions.

Our discussion so far clearly suggests that the Panchayat Raj Institutions (PRIs) have assumed an important place in our democratic political structure. They are playing a significant role in achieving democratic decentralisation. The pace of socio-economic development in the rural areas and the level of people participation in these affairs has increased. all this has made us realise the process of self-governance at the grass-root level through this system.

The access of weaker sections to rural decision making has been legally ensured. it has enalrged the social base of the Panchayat Raj. The reservation has sought to empower women to highlight their grievances. In fact, reservation has made panchayats more representative of the village community. Reservation, of course, does not automatically create equality but it gives these sections a share of participation.

Social change occurs only when all sections of society actively particiapate in the decision making process of it. ■

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT AND SOCIAL CHANGE

We know that the social world is made up of many aspects– economic, political, religious, educational and so on. all these aspects can be analysed independently of each other but they also influence one another. In this sense, economic aspects of social life cannot be ignored while discussing social change.

All human beings have economic problems. as individuals how we earn our living is the most important fact of life. Similarly, the most significant fact of any society is how its members produce and distribute their food. Accordingly, economic production is the basic activity of a society, and it plays a determining role in shaping its social structure.

India is a land of villages. there are more than six lakh village in our country. Agriculture continues to be the primary economic activity of the people. Land is, therefore, the basic means of production in the countryside. In this way, we can say that economic development in India depends essentially on its agricultural development. Against this background, we shall now examine some crucial aspects of agrarian structure and social change.

LAND REFORMS

Agrarian structure forms a critical aspect of any discussion on socio-economic development in India. The issues of economic backwardness and rural tension are all involved in the basic nature of an agrarian society. Land continues to be the mainstay of the people. it constitutes not only the structural feature of rural areas but changes in land relations act as significant indicator of social and economic change.

CONCEPT OF LAND REFORM

The term land reform has been used both in a narrow and in a broad sense. In the narrow and generally accepted sense, land reform means redistribution of rights in land for the benefit of small farmers and landless people. this concept of land reform refers to its simplest element commonly found in all land reform policies. On the other hand, in a broad sense land reform is understood to mean any improvement in the institutions of land system and agricultural organisation. This understanding of land reform suggests that land reform measures should go not only for redistribution of land but also undertake other measure to improve conditions of agriculture. The United Nations has accepted this notion of land reform. The UN definition says that the ideal land reform programme is an integrated programme of measures designed to eliminate obstacles to economic and social development arising out of defects in the agrarian structure.

In the present context also, by land reforms we mean all those measures which have been undertaken in India by the government in India by the government to remove structural obstacles in the agrarian system.

OBJECTIVES OF LAND REFORMS

There are no universal motives behind land reforms but some common objectives may be found everywhere.

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Social justice and economic equality are the major objectives behind land reforms. The ideal of equality has become part of people's consciousness in the modern world. Particularly in a traditional hierarchical society, the idea of equality has emerged as a revolutionary force. It also subsumes the elimination of the worst forms of discrimination and poverty. The ideology of equality and social justice has been expressed in terms of programmes like land reforms and poverty alleviation.

Secondly, nationalism has been another motivation behind land reforms. Most of the developing countries in the world gained independence mainly after the Second World War. Thus, the achievement of national independence has been associated with the removal of institutional structures created during the colonial rule. Such structures may include the ownership of large estates by persons of alien nationality or various forms of land tenures imposed under the colonial rule. The abolition of Zamindari in India is an outstanding example. Zamindari, a form of land settlement established during the British rule was a symbol of colonial exploitation. Naturally, it was always a target for the leaders of India's freedom struggle. Accordingly, its abolition became the goal of the first phase of land reform measures after independence. We shall talk abou it in detail a little later.

Thirdly, the urge for democracy in contemporary world is another factor behind land reforms programmes. The idea of democracy has become a moving force in political power. The goal of liberty and justice can be achieved only in a democratic society. in this manner, even the poor and the deprived express their grievances and articulate their demands in a democratic way. thus an environment for reforms is created.

Finally, land reform is taken as a means to increase productivity of land: it is thus considered one of the key issues in economic development in agricultural societies. it has been adopted as a central programme for agricultural developmetn. The basic issues of agrarian reorganisation are resolved through effective implementation of land reform measures.

LAND REFORMS IN INDIA

Land reforms in India got underway both in political factors as well as in organisational mobilisation of peasantry. The political factors were associated first with British rule and later with the growth of nationalism. it created a situation in which undertaking land reform measures became a compulsion for the government. Thus, some agrarian legislations which attempt to protect the rights of tenants date back to the middle of the nineteenth century.

The poverty of the people and extreme exploitation of the peasantry by zamindars and moneylenders attracted the attention of political leaders during the freedom struggle. it became an important plank of the programme of the Indian National Congress. A major programme of agrarian reforms was presented in 1936 at Jawaharlal Nehru's initiative and Mahatma Gandhi's approval. In his presidential address at Faizpur Session of the Congress, Nehru asked for "the removal of intermediaries between the cultivator and State" after which "cooperative or collective farming must follow".

Almost around the same time, pressure was being created by the increasing number of peasant struggles in different parts of the country. The All India Kisan Sabha in its meeting at Lucknow in 1936 demanded the abolition of Zamindari, occupancy rights for tenants, redistribution of cultivable waste land to landless labourers and others. In fact, between 1920 and 1946 several peasant organisations emerged which expressed the grievances of the middle and poor peasants. the Kisan Sabha Movement led by Swami Sahajanand Saraswati, the Kheda Agitation of 1918, the Bardoli Satyagrah of 1928, and the Tebhaga Movement of 194-47 in Bengal were some of the major pesant struggles of the pre-Independence days. Agrarian discontent and injustice had spread throughout the country. these grievances were expressed in widespread conflicts between peasants and landlords. But if seen in the context of their goals, these peasant struggles produced positive results. The pressure created by the long drawn struggle compelled the Government to work out plans for the redressal of the complaints of peasants. in this sense, independence assumed historical importance for the and reform programmes that began just after the independence.

LAND REFORMS AFTER THE INDEPENDENCE

Shortly after the independence ample emphasis was put on land reforms as part of the national policy to transform iniquitous agrarian structure. The strategy adopted was to introduce land reforms through land legislation. It was broadly indicated by the Government of India and enacted by the state legislatures :

The primary objective of land reforms were :

a. to remove motivational and other impediments which arise from the agrarian structure inherited from the past, and

b. to eliminate all elements of exploitation and social injustice within the agrarian system so as to ensure equality of status and opportunity to all sections of the population.

It is obvious from these objectives that land reforms were introduced with a view to modernise agriculture and reduce inequalities in the agrarian economy. these objectives were converted into the following programmes of action :

a. the abolition of all forms of intermediaries between the state and the tiller of the soil.

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b. conferment of ownership rights on the cultivating tenants in the land held under their possession.

c. imposition of ceiling on agricultural land holdings,

d. consolidation of holdings with a view to making easier the application of modern techniques of agriculture, and,

e. rationalisation of the record of rights in land.

A. ABOLITION OF INTERMEDIARIES

The British rulers introduced three major forms of land settlements – Zamindari, Raiyatwari and Mahalwari – to gain maximum revenue from land. Under the Zamindari system the rights of property in land were given to the local rentgatherers. These persons were called Zamindars and belonged generally to the upper castes of the community. This new settlement turned the actual cultivators into tenants. This structural change in the land system created a class of intermediary between the State and the actual tillers of the soil. Under the Raiyatwari system, no intermediary owners were recognised. The actual tillers of the soil were given transferable rights in their lands. But under this system also influential Raiyats emerged as powerful landholders. In the mahalwari settlement, too, a class of intermediaries had emerged.

These intermediaries had no interest in land management and improvement. Moreover, while the Zamindars were required to pay a fixed amount of revenue to the Government, there was no limit on collections from the actual cultivators. Numerous illegal cesses were imposed from time to time. The Zamindari system allowed a high level of absenteeism. Thus, the system was not only unjust but it was also characterised by acute economic exploitation and social oppression.

It was against this background that abolition of intermediary interests became the first target of land reforms during the early years of the Independence. This measure, undertaken all over the country, essentially sought removal of all intermediaries Like Zamindari, jagirdari, mirasdari and others. It brought cultivators into direct relationship with the State. it conferred permanent rights in land to these actual cultivators. Accordingly, by 1954-55 almost all States abolished of intermediary tenures represents a remarkable transition to a modern agrarian structure.

B. TENANCY REFORMS

Use and occupancy of land of another person on a rental basis is known as tenancy. Tenancy in land has been a widespread practice in different parts of the country. Different forms of tenancy such as the share cropping system, the fixed-kind produce system, the fixed-cash practice have existed both in the Zamindari and Raiyatwari settled areas. under the system, the small farmers and landless people lease-in land for cultivation from rich landowners. These landless cultivators pay rent in kind (produce) or cash to the landowners in return for land. They are known as tenants (local names are : Adhiars in Assam, Bargadars in West Bengal, Bataidars in Bihar, Warmadars in Tamil Nadu, kamins in Punjab etc.). These tenants have weak socio-economic position and lack security and protection. They may be evicted any time by the landowners. Thus, they have been tenants-at-will for all practical purposes.

In view of large scale prevalence of tenancy, reforms were introduced to rationalise the rights and obligations of various classes of tenants. Tenancy reforms laid emphasis on three major aspects of the problem:

1. Regulation of rent.
2. Security of tenure; and
3. Right of purchase for the tenants

These steps have been taken to improve the condition of cultivating tenants. They have been protected against rack-renting through the regulation of rent. Security of tenure for tenants has regulated eviction from land by the landowners. The tenants have also been conferred ownership rights over the land cultivated by them as tenants. Over 124.22 lakh tenants have got their rights protected over an area of 156.30 lakh acres till September 2000.

C. CEILING ON LANDHOLDINGS

The basic objective of fixation of ceiling on landholdings is to acquire land above a certain level from the present landholders for its distribution among the landless. it is primarily a redistributive measure based on the principle of socio-economic justice. The disparity in landownership in India is a well-known fact. while nearly one fourth of rural households have no land all, there were a large number of landholders owning thousands of acres each on the eve of independence. Thus, fixation of ceiling on agricultural holdings has been used as a means to correct this imbalance.

Legislations imposing ceiling on landholdings formed the second phase of land reform package in the independent India. this process began during the Second Five Year Plan in most states. almost all the states have legislations restricting the size of holding which a person or family can own. However, the permissible size varies according to the quality of land. Acquisition of land in excess of the ceiling is prohibited. Land rendered surplus to the ceiling is taken over by the state and distributed among the weaker sections of the community.

Though land ceiling laws have been passed within the broader framework suggested by the Central Government,

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there are differences among various state law. In all the Act there are a variety of exemptions from the ceiling. The ceilings fixed are also different. while in most states, the ceilings fixed are very high, in others ample scope is left for manipulation by the landowners. The process of taking possession of surplus land and its distribution among the landless is rather slow.

The total quantum of land declared surplus in the entire country since inception till September 2000 is 73.49 lakh acres. out of this, only about 64.84 lakh acres have been taken possession of and 52.99 lakh are have been distributed. The total number of beneficiaries of this scheme in the country is 55.10 lakh, of whom 36 per cent belong to the Scheduled Castes and 15 per cent to the Scheduled Tribes.

D. CONSOLIDATION OF HOLDINGS

The fragmentation of landholdings has been an important impediment in agricultural development. Most holdings are not only small but also widely scattered. Thus, legislative measures for consolidation of holdings have been undertaken in most of the states. major focus has been on the consolidation of the land of a holder at one or two places for enabling them to make better use of resources. Attempts have also been made to take measures for consolidation in the command areas of major irrigation projects.

E. LAND RECORDS

The record of rights in land has been faulty and unsatisfactory. the availability of correct and up-to-date records has always been a problem. It is in view of this that updating of land records has now been made a part of land reform measures.

However, progress in this respect has been poor. The Five Year Plan documents say that "in several States, record of right do not provide information regarding tenants, subtenants and crop-shares...." It has further been highlighted that large areas of the country still do not have up-to-date land records. The main reason behind this has been the strong opposition of big landowners.

Nonetheless several states have initiated the process of updating the land records through revisional surveys and settlements. Steps have also been taken to computerise these records. a centrally sponsored Scheme on Computerisation of Land Records has been launched with a view to remove the problems inherent in the manual system of maintenance and updating of land records.

GREEN REVOLUTION

The fundamental change and phenomenal increase in foodgrains production in late sixties in India has earned the name of 'Green Revolution'. The word 'green' here refers to green fields of the countryside and 'revolution' indicates a substantial change.

The availability of adequate food-grains has been a serious problem in the country till recently. Foodgrains had to be imported from the developed countries to feed the vast population. Shortage of food was mainly caused by low productivity of land, over-dependence on monsoon and the outmoded agrarian structure. Under these conditions, achieving self-sufficiency in foodgrains became the top priority of our national efforts. We have already seen how various schemes under the five year plans, land reforms and community development programmes have all been directed towards achieving this goal. However, these efforts could not initially succeed in increasing agricultural production. Consequently, a new agricultural strategy was adopted in the early sixties to accelerate the process of agricultural development.

The new agricultural strategy was based on the thinking that intensive application of science and technology in agriculture would bear fruits in the form of massive increase in foodgrain production. Under this strategy, adopted in early sixties, agricultural development programmes were revised to meet the needs of the farmers. Major programmes undertaken in this regard are discussed briefly in the paragraphs that follow.

The Intensive Agricultural district Programme (IADP), popularly known as the Package Programme, was started in 1961 on a pilot basis in seven districts of the country. The programme was subsequently extended to cover some other districts. It aimed at combining improved technology, credit, high yielding seeds and assured irrigation for stepping up agricultural production. This experiment of intensive agriculture yielded significant results. Production of foodgrains remarkably increased and the programme was extended to cover larger areas. It resulted in giving rise to a new programme called the Intensive Agricultural Areas Programme (IAAP).

Encouraged by the unprecedented success of this programme some other schemes were introduced in late sixties. They included the High-Yielding Varieties Programme (HYVP), small Farmer's Development Agency (SFDA), and the Marginal Farmers and Agricultural Labourers Development Scheme (MFALDS). All these schemes were supplemented by the assured supply of inputs like fertilisers, pesticides, institutional credit and increased irrigational

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facility. Among all these programmes, the HYVP made spectacular impact. The progressive increase in areas under high yielding varieties resulted in substantial increase in foodgrain production. Wheat production more than doubled by 1977-78 and rice production also started increasing. The progress under maize, jowar and bajra was, however, rather slow, but did not remain too far.

Green Revolution, which saw the light of the day in the late sixties, has sustained till date. It began with Wheat Revolution but subsequently rice surpassed it. Other crops like pulses, Jowar, maize and bajra also did not remain too far. it was widespread as it continued its journey from Punjab to other regions of the country. Now we are not only self-sufficient in foodgrains but also have started exporting it. Our view in this regard is amply supported by the latest foodgrains statistics available to us.

The overall production of food grains for 1999-2000 at 208.87 million tonnes is 5.26 million tonnes more than the last year. The production of rice during this period was 89.48 million tonnes as against the production of 86.00 million tonnes during 1998-99. The production of wheat was 75.57 million tonnes during 1999-2000 as against the production level of 70.78 million tonnes during 1998-99. However, during this period the production of coarse cereals (jowar, bajra, maize etc.) is estimated at 30.47 million tonnes as against the production of 31.35 million tonnes during 1998-1999. Being dependent entirely on rainfall, the output of coarse cereals shows considerable variation over the years.

SOCIO-ECONOMIC CONSEQUENCES OF GREEN REVOLUTION

Green Revolution has certainly improved the food situation in the country. it has solved the problem of hunger and has given a strong base to the indian economy for further growth. it has transformed the mindset of farmers. in this respect Andre Beteille has aptly remarked, "The Green Revolution has indeed created a new faith in the dynamism of the Indian farmer who has shown himself to be capable not only of quickly absorbing technology innovations but also of handling social arrangements with considerable dexterity."

However, the impact of this programme has not been equally favourable for all sections of agrarian population. What we wish to point out here is that the Green Revolution has brought destabilising impact on the socio-economic condition of small and poor peasants, share-croppers and landless agricultural labourers.

The new technology and the other inputs such as improved seeds, fertilisers, pesticides, water etc. are beyond the reach of small and marginal farmers. Naturally some regions with large landholdings like Punjab have performed better than others like Bihar and orissa where marginal and poor farmers are in plenty and institutional credit is not easily available. This has widened the gap between the small and the rich farmers.

Secondly, the affluent farmers are enjoying the fruits of increased profits from land but the real wage rate for agricultural labourers has been declining in most places. Most of the share-croppers are now joining the rank of landless labourers because small holdings out to these share-croppers.

Thirdly, economic inequality in agrarian sector has widened resulting in increased agrarian unrest in rural areas. During the late sixties and the early seventies numerous cases of conflicts were reported particularly from the Green Revolution belts. The situation became serious and the Ministry of Home Affairs of the Government of India studied the causes and nature of agrarian tensions and admitted the socio-political implications of the new agricultural strategy. The The Report concluded that new agricultural strategy has created 'widening gap between the relatively affluent farmers and the large body of small holders and landless agricultural workers." analysing this problem, P.C. Joshi argues that conflict and discontent are inherent in the outmoded agrarian structure'. While such an agrarian structure provides the basic cause of tension, the 'promimate' causes which have led to the eruption of 'latent' discontent into 'manifest' tension are located in the new agricultural strategy and the Green Revolution.

The poor peasants, share-croppers and landless agricultural labourers have not been able to share profitably in the general prosperity, which came in the wake of the green revolution. In this context, T.K. Oommen shows that 'the green revolution as such does not lead to the welfare of the agrarian poor unless substantial alterations in the prevalent socio-economic and political structures are effected at the grass roots.

Finally, increased agricultural production has been visible mainly in areas like Punjab, Haryana, Western Uttar pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra. In this fashion, substantial areas in the country have not been benefited by this agricultural change. Likewise a new class of capitalist farmers has emerged in the green revolution belts. Another important trend suggests that the agricultural production has increased but the social index has not changed in the same proportion. For example, the gender-ratio in those areas where agricultural prosperity has been achieved is still unfavourable. However, despite these limitations the Green Revolution has undoubtedly paved the way for faster economic growth and corresponding social change. ■

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NEW GROUPS, CLASSES AND GLOBALISATION

While studying social structure and stratification, you must have noticed that caste and class are two major forms of social stratification. These two systems are also 'open' class systems. Structures of stratification vary in their rigidity from one society to another, and from one period to another in the same society. Thus, patterns of stratification are not always static. Changes do occur in their nature and structure. Thus, it, is not only the class position of an individual which may change one but the caste position may also change in a generation or two. We have also point out this aspect of mobility in caste while discussing the process of Sanskritisation in an earlier section. What we intend to highlight here is that new groups and classes emerge in every society in the wake of social change. In most of what follows, we shall confine our illustrations to the Indian society and discuss the nature of new groups and classes which are emerging due to social change.

Trends of change in Indian society show the emergence and consolidation of new groups and classes. This is visible not only in the rural areas but also in the urban and industrial settings. However, in the absence of systematic sociological studies on the nature and size of these groups and classes, it is a difficult task to give conclusive statements about them. We have, therefore, selected only a few groups of illustrate this trend.

GENTLEMAN FARMER

The composition of the traditional landowning class is changing in the country. Earlier most of the landowners inherited land from their ancestors. Land could not be purchased in the market because the land market was not fully developed. But this situation has changed now. The restructuring of agrarian system has set in as a result of the land the reforms and the Green Revolution. The introduction of new technology in agriculture has transformed the mode of agricultural production. resources other than land have assumed importance. resources such as tractors, mechanised ploughs, pumpsets, power threshers and others are acquired through the market. Today even if one has not inherited land through the traditional channel, it is possible for one to join the class of landowners.

In this fashion, a new class of farmers is emerging consisting of persons with different skills and experiences. They no longer belong to the traditional landowning upper castes. There are the people who have retired from the civil and military services and have invested their savings in agricultural farms. This is the story behind the emergence of gentleman Farmers.

This group now attracts the people who are educated and wish to make agriculture their vocation. The increased profitability of agriculture is the primary reason behind it. These agricultural farms are run like business firms with all features of modern organisations. In this respect, there is a substantial difference between the traditional agricultural system and the emerging system.

CAPITALIST FARMERS

The emergence of capitalist farmers is another important development in independent India. The question whether and to what extent capitalism has penetrated Indian agriculture is still being debated, but the trend in agriculture as in industry is clearly towards infusion of capital. A capitalist form of wage-labour agrarian system has replaced the traditional customary land relation. There is a clear transition from the peasant family farms to the commercial-capitalist farms.

A powerful class of rich peasants, undoubtedly, existed even earlier but they could not be characterised as capitalist farmers because there was not capitalist penetration in agriculture as such. However, in the recent past, apart from the land reforms, other forces are at work in agricultural sector. Introduction of new technology along with several other schemes of agricultural development have facilitated a small section of rich peasantry to emerge as powerful commercial and capitalist farmers. Extensive facilities and resources such as supply of high yielding variety of seeds, fertilisers, improved implements, irrigation as well as facilities of credit and improved transport and communication – all have been fully utilised by these farmers. The capitalist farmer hires labourers for accomplishing her/ his requirements. the actual tillers of the soil are the wage-labourers employed by the capitalist farmers. The latter is involved in agriculture only to appropriate profits from it. A surplus is, thus, generated in agricultural production that is reaching to the market.

The size of the class of capitalist farmers is still small in the country today. But its emergence and growth reveal a significant aspect of change in the agrarian social structure. The emergence of this class has not only increased the efficiency and productivity of agriculture but also has helped industrial growth and development. However, this trend has widened the gap between the rich and the poor farmers. Inequalities between the top and the bottom layers of the agrarian classes have accentuated leading to unrest in rural areas.

DOMINANT MIDDLE-CASTE PEASANTRY

The impact of the land reforms and the Green Revolution has not been uniform throughout the country. In certain regions, some sections have benefited more than the others.

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While the owners of large landholdings have pocketed the maximum profits in every region, the share of benefits to the small peasants has been limited almost everywhere. However, it is the middle peasant who have been the real beneficiary all over the country. A natural question is why has this been so.

The answer to this question lies in the very nature and composition of the middle peasantry in the Indian countryside. Middle peasants ordinarily belong to the middle caste groups. Though there is no all- India hierarchy of castes, it is yet possible to locate certain layers that may be characterised as middle. All those castes, which are below the upper castes but above the lower and Scheduled Castes, constitute the category of middle castes. it is not a homogenous category but as these castes possess some common features, they may be included under a single category. Some of the major features of the middle castes anre mentioned below.

In the first place, they occupy a higher position in local caste hierarchy. No social diasabilities such as untouchability and discrimination are imposed on them. Secondly, most of the castes included in this category are traditionally peasant castes. They have been self-cultivating owners of medium size landholdings. Thirdly, unlike the upper castes, they have been directly involved in agricultural operations. Finally, populationwise they are predominant at the local level. In fact, the middle castes are like the dominant castes according to the formulation of M.N. Srinivas. Most of the features of these two categories are similar but they are different in terms of their location in the caste hierarchy. While a dominant caste may belong either to the upper or the middle caste group, it is not so in the case of a middle caste.

It is the middle castes, which have emerged as the dominant middle peasantry. They have derived maximum advantages from the land reforms and the Green Revolution. At the time of abolition of intermediaries like Zamindari, the jagirdari etc. large scale and transfer took place. The members of these castes purchased most of these lands. Secondly, when the upper caste village dwellers started migrating to the urban areas in large numbers, the members of the middle castes bought their land. Finally; new programmes of agricultural development further helped the middle castes to improve their economic condition. Their peasant background provided them with a added advantage. Middle castes have, thus, achieved economic affluence within a short time.

The growing economic prosperity of middle castes was also instrumental in extending their influence to the political domain. Here, again, their numerical strength contributed towards gaining political dominance. The phenomenal rise of castes such as the yadav (Ahir) and the kurmi in Bihar and uttar Pradesh, Vokkaliga in Karnataka, Kamma and Reddy in Andhra Pradesh is a pointer to this trend. Thus, the emergence of the dominant middle caste peasant reflects the changing reality of the Indian countryside.

Our discussion of some of the new groupings has, thus, been concerned primarily with those which have emerged in rural areas. now, let us turn to the urban industrial setting where also several groups and classes have become visible. An important fact should be noted before we proceed to discuss the urban groupings. Groups and classes in rural areas, which we have considered above, are apparently new in the sense that they have appeared on the scene quite recently. But the situation in urban areas is quite different because groups and classes here are not new in the strict sense of the term. They emerged in industrial-urban setting fairly earlier but their position has now been consolidated both from the points of view of size and role. We shall examine some of these groups to throw light on the nature of change taking place in this domain.

BUSINESS ELITE

An entrepreneurial class or business elite started emerging in India by the middle of the nineteenth century. Although prior to the British rule a group of enterprising business persons and traders existed in the country, but the new business elite came into prominence only during this period. Traiditionally, most of the business persons belonged to the trading castes and communities. But when a new link was established between the Indian economy and that of Britain members of some other castes also joined-mercantile enterprises. As most of the business firms were under the control of the English persons, the Indian business persons mainly worked as middle persons and brokers to British firms. Thus, the emergence of the new business elite was initially linked with these activities. These groups of business persons were primarily commercial agents and not industrial entrepreneurs. Moreover, they were located mainly in Kolkata, Mumbai and Chennai regions because commercial and industrial activities were concentrated in these regions. The members of this group mainly belonged to the upper castes. For example, jains, Baniyas and kayasthas had the upper hand over others in Kolkata region, Parsis and Jains in Mumbai, and in Chennai region Chettiars controlled such businesses.

During the early part of the twentieth century the Indian industrial entrepreneurs started competing with the British. Gujaratis, Parsis and Marwaris emerged as the dominant groups among the business elite. Sociological studies have shown two major characteristics of business elite in India. In the first place, most of them are the members of the traditional trading castes and in this sense there is continuity with the past tradition. Secondly, there has been a close link of this group with the nationalist movement in India. These

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features, as yogendra Singh suggests, "influence the role that the business elite play in the modernisation of Indian society".

The size and role of business elite has phenomenally increased after Independence. It has been primarily because of the expansion of industrial activities during the last few decades. The industrial business groups now organise their activities on modern scientific lines and are comparable to their counterparts outside the country. Trained managers manage their organisation. Thus, a kind of bureaucratic structure has emerged giving rise to a new class of industrial bureaucrats.

The accelerated growth of business elite suggests a significant change in the entrepreneurial motivation of the people. The grop is gradually becoming broad-based as members of the diverse social groups and castes are entering into this fold. The industrial development of the backward regions in the country is a pointer to this trend.

THE NEW MIDDLE CLASS

The emergence of the new middle class is an interesting development in the era of economic liberalisation in India. Academic studies had, no doubt, focussed earlier on the character of the Indian middle class in general, but it is only recently that the rise of the new middle class has attracted the attention of social scientists.

In a celebrated study of the Indian middle classes, B.B. Misra has suggested that the members of the educated professions, such as government servants, lawyers, college teachers and doctors, primarily constituted the bulk of the Indian middle classes. he also included the body of merchants, agents of modern trading firms, salaried executives in banking and trading, and the middle grades of peasant proprietors and rentiers under this category. This notion of the middle elass has continued for years for the purpose of examining the role of the middle class in contemporary India.

It has been argued that in the early years of the Independence, material pursuits of the middle class were subsumed in a broader ethical and moral responsibility to the nation as a whole. A restraint on materialistic exhibitionism in a poor country was the ideal reflector in the character of the middle class. Changes have, however, occurred in the basic character of this class. Pavan Varma, for example, in his book The Great Indian Middle Class has initiated a significant debate on the declining social responsibility of the Indian middle class. It is in this context that the idea of new middle class has been made popular in India.

The current culture of consumerism has given rise to the new middle class. The economic liberalisation initiated in India in the 1990s portrays the middle class as a sizeable market which has attracted the Multinational Corporations (MNCs). Images of the urban middle class in the print media and television contribute to the prevalence of images of an affluent consumer. The spread of the consumer items such as cellphones, cars, washing machines and colour televisions has also consolidated the image of a new middle class culture. Advertising images has further contributed to perception.

The new middle class has left behind its dependence on austerity and state protection. The newness of the middle class rests on its embrace of social practices of taste and consumption and a new cultural standard. Thus the "newness" of middle class involves adoption of a new ideology rather than a shift in the social basis of India's middle class.

Critics of this new middle class have pointed out the negative effects that middle class consumerism holds in the terms of environmental degradation and a growing indifference towards socio-economic problems of the country. However, proponents of liberalisation have projected this new middle class as an idealised standard for a globalising India.

GLOBALISATION AND LIBERALISATION

The phenomenon of globalisation has aroused much interest since the eighties. We will discuss it in the context of social change.

Globalisation is one of the distinctive features of the contemporary world. The term is used mostly in an economic sense. Globalisation is the process of integration of world economies in conditions of free markets. Free market envisages free flow of trade and capital and movement of persons across national borders. Globalisation is, thus, identified with the new world trade order and opening up of commercial markets. Science and technology have greatly helped in the growth of globalisation. The whole process is facilitated by newly developed technology for immediate transmission of information.

Historically, the world had experienced periods of economic integration even in the later half of the nineteenth century and early part of the twentieth century. But the process was interrupted by the world wars, economic depression and restrictions on the movement of people till almost the 1970's. However, the process of globalisation received new impetus during the last two decades.

Internationalisation of production has been taking place in a big way through the MNCs. Large companies based in one country but operating in several countries are called Multinational or Transnational Corporations. The MNCs have thousands of affiliated companies all over the world. According to one estimate, their sales in 1998 were of the

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order of almost one-third of the world trade. These corporations treat the globe as a single market rather than a set of national markets.

Moreover, trade beyond the national boundaries is substantially expanding as duties and tariffs are getting shapely lowered and other barriers are removed to increase the volume of foreign trade. Transport and communication costs have gone down considerably. Consequently, technologically advanced companies and enterprises move to different locations in different countries. Globalisation has opened up new avenues for the MNCs. The era of globalisation has unfolded new opportunities for both developed and developing countries. Globalisation is turning the whole world into a 'global village'.

POTENTIAL OF GLOBALISATION

Globalisation is supported on many grounds by its protagonists, some of which are discussed below.

The process of globalisation is based on the basic premise of free market. It is presumed that free markets beget competition and increase efficiency which is lacking in controlled markets. Increased efficiency improves quality of goods and services. Free market is particularly helpful to the backward economies.

Under the condition of globalisation, foreign investment flows into the domestic economy which makes it strong and boisterous. These investments specially assist the countries that face the shortage of internal resources. In this manner, free trade facilitates inflow of foreign capital and good swich is expected to provide buoyancy to the stagnating economies of the Third World.

Globalisation guarantees increased employment opportunities. More employment and more economic growth would create better quality of life for the people. As unemployment continues to be a serious problem for most of the developing countries, globalisation is projected as a panacea to the problem.

It is assumed that economic development would be achieved through the integration of economies, which would also take care of the issues of social justice. the innovative and rationalising mechanisms of the global economic order will make provision for safety nets for the disadvantaged groups. It is, thus, believed that liberalisation of economy, instead of causing havoc, provides new hope to the disadvantaged groups.

Furthermore, globalisation increases co-operation and solidarity among business partners at the international level. it also enhaces co-operation at the governmental level. it gives rise to a new world order based on consensus and partnership. Values of reciprocity and solidarity among nations are supposed to usher in an era of world peace and amity.

CONSEQUENCES OF GLOBALISATION

According to the United Nations' study in 1999. 'the era of globalisation is opening many opportunities for millions of people around the world'. The study suggests that it offers enoromous potential to eradicate poverty in the twenty-first century.

But the experiences of globalisation so far, particularly in the developing countries, do not follow this trend. It has given rise to serious risks for countries that are unable to become internationally competitive. The negative consequences of globalisation are more dominant compared to its positive potential. Increased trade, new technologies, foreign investment and expanding Internet connections have, no doubt, led so substantial economic growth in the world today but the gains of economic growth are not evently distributed among different countries. There are several problems that emanate from this basic weakness.

The economic process under globalisation is connected with market expansion. The development of national market economies is integrated globally on market principles. The market system is always driven by the search for profits. Open competitive markets may guarantee efficiency, but not necessarily ensure equity. Therefore, great reliance on the 'invisible hand' of the market is pushing the world towards unsustainable levels of inequality. It has rightly been said that markets are neither the first nor the last word in human development'. There are several activities and goods, which are important for human development, but today they are overlooked in the rush to integrate with the global market. It is evident in areas where the market frontier has moved in recent decades, such as in African and Asia. It has increased migration to cities, the anomie in urban life, the collapse of the extended family and the replacement of sentiments by money as the basis of human motivation.

Global capitalism is relatively free from regulations. But it enjoys the support of powerful capitalist states. A number of international economic institutions such as the International Monetary Funds (IMF), the World Bank and the World Trade Organisation (WTO) reinforce the ideology of global capitalism. These countries and institutions create the political and legal conditions for the global market. These conditions have been created by steps like (a) removal of barriers to international trade and services, (b) movement of capital, (c) global protection of property rights (d) privatisation of state companies, (e) deregulation of business activities, and (f) phasing out of welfare services. All these steps have reduced the capacity of the nation states to provide essential social services to the people. The effects of structural ajustment policies in Africa, Asia and the south Pacific imposed by the IMF and the World Bank have been no less than disastrous. They have decreased the access to

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education, health and nutrition to the underprivileged sections of the population. Of course, it has extended these facilities mainly to the most privileged groups. Even in Europe, where the welfare state was born, there has been severe reduction in these facilities.

At present, for developing countries, the risks are more than the advantages and opportunities. The most direct impact has been on jobs. For example, unemployment rates doubled in Asian countries where the depression of 1997-98 was worst. Wages in the current labour market are generally low. Intense competition for employment means that workers have low capacity to bargain in most countries. The real wages throughout Latin America and Africa have yet to return to levels considered normal twenty years ago.

Failure to create sufficient employment has undermined the prospects for poverty reduction. The number of people living in poverty fell in mid-1990s but then started to rise again in almost all countries. This is not because the world as a whole has been getting poorer but because the benefits of growth are unevently spread. In fact, there has been a remarkable in inequality over the past decades. In the developing countries, the rich can easily adjust to the new environment, but the poor are becoming poorer.

Moreover, the economic globalisation is problematic not only because it complicates economic relationships between nations but also, because it concentrates economic power in the hands of the MNCs. Such a concentration of economic power leads to convergence of political and social power. In this fashion, social and economic rights of common citizens are restricted under globalisation. It effects social policy and reduces the role of State activities.

It is against this background that some resistance against the imposition of external conditionalities on the country's economy has emerged at the people's level. The people in the developing countries are concerned about numerous international negotiations which are taking place on agriculture, services and patent protection. The concern is whether the developing countries would get fair deal in these agreements. These negotiations and agreements are held under the aegis of WTO which is the legal and institutional body of the global trading system. Member countries are supposed to follow rules and disciplines of WTO.

LIBERALISATION

The process of liberalisation is closely related to globalisation. Liberalisation is the economic content of globalisation. It is a process under which a highly regulated economy is transformed into an outward-looking economy. Domestic economy is liberalised through deregulation and decontrolling. The dominance of the state in most spheres of activity declines and gives way to proviate enterprises and companies. The privatisation of commerce and industry takes place by dismantling public sector units. The idea of liberalisation is essentially based on the thinking that the economy and society will be much better by reducing the state intervention. It is popularised by the slogan, less state, better state. The process of globalisation, as we have seen, is integrating economies of the world. This process of integration is facilitated by liberalisation and privatisation of individual economies. In other words, various countries have to liberalise their economies by resorting to deregulation where there will be less and less control of the State. Liberalisation policy emphasises the efficiency aspect of economy. Private enterprises are considered more efficient than the public sector undertakings.

CHALLENGES OF GLOBALISATION AND LIBERALISATION IN INDIA

The processes of globalisation and liberalisation are more predominant in the modern world. under such a condition, India too is facing challenges of these processes. A significant transformation has taken place in the country since 1991 as we moved from a highly regulated and inward-looking to an outward-looking economy. The dominance of the State in most spheres of activity is giving way to private enterprises.

You will understand this situation clearly if an example is provided to you. Indian economy has adopted the mixed-economy model. It is called mixed because it consists of two sectors – the private sector and the public sector. While the public sector is fully controlled by the state, the private sector includes enterprises owned by individuals. The public sector has played a dominant role in the Indian economy. The State, thus, has been present in most spheres of activity. its control and regulation have been wide ranging and even covered the private sector industries. The latter were controlled through numerous licenses and permits. In fact, this practice has been so widespread that th epeople often called it the quota permit raj.

It was this system of regulation and control that received a blow in the era of liberalisation. The process of liberalisation started in India around 1991 with numerous structural changes in the economy. The first phase of reforms (1991-1994) focussed on the dismantling of controls and regulations in trade and industry. Taxes and tariffs were lowered. All these steps created a conducive climate for private investments – both domestic and foreign. Thus, the era of liberalisation witnessed a clear transition from an insular to an outward-looking and export – oriented economy.

The process of liberalisation and privatisation has further been accelerated in the second phase of reforms. Two major developments in this phase are encouraging more foreign

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direct investment and downsizing the public sector. India is a large market. From 1 April 2001, all quantitative restrictions have been removed and the market is now open for imported products. Disinvestment in public sector undertakings has not only been initiated, but several corporations have already been sold to private enterprises.

India has now completed the first post-liberalisation decade with satisfactory growth rates. Inflation has been contained. Industry is no longer protected from external forces. More recently, the breakthroughs in Information Technology (IT) sector has proved skills of Indian professionals who are in great demand in developed countries of the world. It is expected that IT-related services would give a boost to the economy in the years to come.

Norwithstanding these achievements during the era of liberalisation, there are still critical challenges ahead. Poverty continues to be one of the most important challenges. Around 26.10 percent of the population is still below the poverty line. The situation with regard to employment continues to be grim. During the last decade, more retrenchment from jobs has taken place because companies have reduced their size or merged to face the rigour of competition. This is happening when the Indian economy is not able to generate sufficient jobs. Full employment, universal literacy, primary education, health care and raising the quality of life for all citizens are equally challenging tasks to accomplish.

Privatisation is affecting women in many ways. it has already started reducing employment opportunities due to the introduction of sophisticated technology both in agriculture and industry in India, women are more gainfully employed in handicrafts and household industries. They are mainly in unorganised sector. Economic liberalisation has affected this sector, which is threatened because of the entry of mechanised products and mass producers of these items in the local markets.

Under such circumstances, the challenge of globalisation today is to adjust rules and institutions for stronger governance to preserve the advantages of global market. While modifying these institutions the country has to provide enough space for human and community resources. It is imperative to ensure that globalisation works for the people because despite the attendant risks and challenges not a single country would be able to stop the approach of globalisation. ■

MASS MEDIA AND CULTURAL CHANGE

We are living in an era of information. The amount of information generated today is simply incredible and beyond one's dreams. It is primarily the result of the revolution in information technology. A convergence of tele-communication, television and computer has taken place. The sum of all these technologies constitutes information and communication technology. The latter has tremendous potential to transform various aspects of people's life. Unde rthe condition, the transmission of information becomes a necessity, if information has to be put to use by people for their welfare. This function is performed by the mass media.

In common parlance, mass media means the media such as radio, television, print and films which are used to communicate to a large number of people. The term 'mass' is defined here in the sense of a large number of people of a community or a group or a country as against a particular class or category of the people. This notion of mass implies that mass media is different from other kinds of communication because they address a cross-section of a large population rather than a few individuals or a particular section of the population. It is also called mass media because information is disseminated through these channels simultaneously to the masses.

Of late, two terms – mass media and mass communication – are the subject. Some scholars also generally make a distinction between the two. While mass communication is the process in which information is disseminated to a large number of people, the mass media are the media are the means of carrying this material to the people. Mass communication, thus, includes the transfer or messages and information from a sender to a mass audience. This transfer is done through the technologies of the mass media such as newspapers, magazines, television programmes, films, computer networks and so on. The sender in this case may be a person attached to some large media organisations or government agencies, the messages are public and the audience is large. Nonetheless we do not make such a subtle distinction between these terms in the discussion which follows. We, instead, use the term mass media, which is more popular and serves our present purpose.

Mass media involve organised form of public messages production and dissemination which include television, radio, films, newspapers and magazines. These means of communication are broadly categorised as print media, electronic media and audio-visual media.

SOCIETY AND THE MEDIA

The discussion in this section mainly concentrates on social functions and general criticisms of the media.

Mass media provide information to people regarding day-to-day events and occurrences. this involves everything ranging from the weather condition to the local, national and international events such as politics, wars, and natural disasters. In large cities and towns where people are more

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separated from each other, the media keep them informed about what are going around them.

Secondly, entertainment is another important function of media. People get entertainment not only through obvious matters of entertainment like films but also through information provided by the media. Local news programmes, for example, furnish information as well as entertainment by devoting time in reporting violent crimes and sports. The local television channels in most of the cases survive primarily because they make profits by proving ample entertainment to the people.

Thirdly, the media now play an increasing role in socialisation of the young. As you know, family, peer group and school normally act as primarily agents of socialisation. However, with the development of mass media, children come under the active influence of the media usage. Musicians, dancers, sport heroes, actors and actress give young people new ideas about how to behave and how to dress. Certain values, attitudes and beliefs projected through media are also imbibed by them. Martin Esslin in his book The Age of Television points out that television brings an endless stream of collective daydream and fantasies in our homes, and this leads to a blurring of the difference between fact and reality, the real world and the fantasy world. Television feeds our desire to be rich and caters to our erotic desires. This aspect of media effects diverts our attention from the reality of life and brings loss of the ability to think logically.

Finally, the media lend a hand in maintained cultural continuity. they play an important role in keeping cultures alive. In the fast changing world, several elements of culture are disappearing from the scene. By showing these elements in media programmes, the people are reminded of the existence of such elements and cultural practices. In india for example, it is radio which broadcasts programmes of classical music and attempts to continue this tradition.

Let us now consider the negative effects of the media. There are scholars, educators and other who have been very critical of the consequences of the media. Some of the criticisms directed at the mass media are :

a. It encourages escapism.
b. It leads to passivity and distracts people from serious matters of life.
c. It kills individual tastes and leads to cultural homogenisation.
d. it uses female gender to sell products through advertisements.
e. It presents a false picture of reality.

Most of these criticisms are not essentially directed against the instruments of the mass media, but they refer primarily to the nature and themes of the programmes covered by them. These arguments also reflect the limitations of the media policy of the State and society where these channels are operating. These negative aspects of the mass media, however, are not going to stop the advancing pace of it in the modern society. We have to live with them.

THE MEDIA SCENARIO IN INDIA

India has been a land of great mass communicators. Being a country of diversities, communicating with a large number of people simultaneously has always been a problem. In the past, when modern channels of communications such as television and Internet were not available, people used to receive information through interpersonal communications. These sources included religious preachers, human messengers, traders, travellers and other forms of traditional channels. Thus, all kinds of communication strategies, models and experiments have been tried since long. However, the traditional sources of information are no longer popular as new communication avenues are available.

The mass media play a vital role in creating in people awareness by providing information and education., besides healthy entertainment. All major communication media – print, electronic and audio-visuals – have developed in the country. Let us now briefly describe the media scenario in India today.

PRINT MEDIA

As the term itself suggests, the print media include newspapers, periodicals and magazines of different types.

According to the Annual Report of the Registrar of Newspapers in India (RNI) for the year 2000, the total number of newspapers and periodicals being published in India was 49,145 as compared to 46,655 during 1999, registering and increase of 5.34 per cent. There were 5,364 dailies, 339 tri/bi weeklies, 17,749 weeklies, 6,553 fornightlies, 13,616 monthlies and 3,425 quarterlies etc. Newspapers were published in as many as 101 languages and dialects during 2000. The largest number of newspapers (19,685) was published in Hindi followed by English (7,175) and urdu (2,848). Daily newspapers were published in all principal languages except in kashmiri. Newspapers are published from all states and union territories. Bombay Samachar, a Gujarati daily published from Mumbai since 1822 is the oldest existing newspaper. As per the RNI's report, the total claimed circulation of the Indian newspapers during 2000 was 12,69,63,763 copies.

The modern print media has been strengthened through the establishment of various agencies. The Registrar of Newspapers in India (RNI) was set up in 1956 to allot newsprint for newspapers. Every newspaper/ periodical has to be registered with the RNI. There are news agencies like Press Trust of India (PTI) and United News of India (UNI) to collect and supply news to newspapers. The Press Council of India has been established to safeguard freedom of the Press and maintain and improve the standard of newspapers

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ELECTRONIC MEDIA

Radio and television are the two major players in electronic media in India.

Akashvani : The privately owned transmitters started broadcasting in India in 1927. In 1930, these transmitters were taken over by the government and the broadcasting started in the name of Indian Broadcasting Service. It was changed to All India Radio (AIR) in 1936 and it came to be known as Akashwani since 1957. Now, more than 100 FM (Frequency Modulation) radio stations have been operating in the country.

The All India Radio presently has 208 radio stations and 327 transmitters. These include 149 medium wave, 55 short wave and 123 FM transmitters. From 28 May 1995 on FM channel and from 25 February 1998, AIR news on Phone Service is also available in the country. AIR is now connected to Internet for on-line information service. The present national coverage of broadcasting in India is 90.6 per cent by area and 98.8 per cent by population.

Doordarshan : Doordarshan (DD), the national television of India, is one of the largest terrestrial networks in the world. Television made a modest beginning in India on 15 September 1959 on an experimental basis with a station at Delhi. it was used as the medium for imparting social education. The regular service with a news bulletin in Hindi was started from 15 August 1965. The country's second television centre was set up at Mumbai in 1972. it was followed by Srinagar and Amritsar in 1973, and Kolkata, Chennai and Lucknow in 1975. In april 1976, Doordarshan was separated from All India Radio and was made a separate department. In 1984, a second channel was added to Delhi to provide an additional view option.

Now, DD reaches 87 per cent of the population and 70 per cent of the area of the country through a network of 1042 terrestrial transmitters. It has production studios in 49 cities across the country.

The educational television programmes are relayed from different Doordarshan kendras in different languages. On 26 January 2000, Doordarshan started an exclusive education channel, DD-Gyandarshan in collaboration with the Ministry of Human Resource Development through the Indira Gandhi national Open University (IGNOU). In addition, the broadcasting sector has about hundred private television channels and cable networks all over the country which are telecasting programmes in different regional languages besides Hindi and English.

AUDIO - VISUAL MEDIA

Film has been by far the most popular means of mass media in India. Feature films are being produced here since 1912-13. While R.G. torney, along with Chitre, made Pundalik in 1912, dhunjiraj Govind Phalke produced Raja harischandra in 1913. The talkies replaced the era of silent films in 1931 when Adeshir Irani produced Alam Ara (movie with dialogue). India is today the leader in the world in the annual output of feature films.

Films in India can be publicity exhibited only after the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) has certified them. In the year 2000, the Board certified 855 Indian and 252 foreign feature films, 1,058 Indian and 194 foreign short films, 111 Indian video feature films and 38 foreign video feature films, and 503 Indian video sort films and 167 foreign video short films.

The Films Division was established by the Government of India in 1948 to record, propogate and preserve the achievements of resurgent independent India. it has been a vital link between the people and the government. it is the largest national agency devoted to production and distribution of news magazines and documentaries.

COMMUNICATION, MASS MEDIA AND CULTURAL CHANGE

It is now recognised that communication is an important factor in development and change. It is assumed that transmission of new ideas through the mass media can create a favourable environment for change. Besides bringing about change. Besides bringing about change in attitude and values, communication is also expected to impart knowledge of new skills and techniques. Communication helps to enlarge the mental horizons of people. It can be used to raise the levels of aspirations.

Despite a high rate of illiteracy, the importance of print media cannot be ignored. Now, newspapers are popular not only in urban areas. They have become popular even among the literate section of the village population. One copy of a newspaper is read by dozens of people in a tea or coffee shop. In reality, the newspaper has become a true mass medium. Similarly, television is also becoming a common source of entertainment and transmission of current information. As a matter of fact the increasing importance of mass media has brought about some kind of revolution in the life of the people.

However, effects of mass communication have been diverse. The media-exposure has accelerated the process of change. People now know more about new things and places. Several new elements are added to their own culture.

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Eve day-to-day life and practices come under the influence of practices other than their own. To put it little differently, various forms of the media have led to a cultural change. The expansion of modern means of communication has also given rise to new cultural challenges. People have realised the significance of their own cultural identity. They have revived interests in their cultural symbols and objects. The traditional group activities are reinforced with the help of modern means of communication. This process has integrated folk cultural institutions with the emerging cultural tradition. Sociologists call it 'cultural resilience' of the Indian people. This strength has led to a kind of cultural integration between the value systems of tradition and modernity.

GLOBALISATION AND LOCAL CULTURE

We have defined globalisation, earlier, as an economic process. We now wish to add that globalisation is a multifaceted one rather than only an economic process. it is a set of processes that interconnect individuals, groups and communities. Such connects lead to far reaching consequences for human beings. The social relation established under this condition is deeply transformed because life is more intensively interconnected. In this manner, under globalisation, the lives of individuals and the fates of communities increasingly depend on what takes place in distant places. Both national and local borders are weakened. Transcontinental and transnational networks of activities are generated. New linkages are established in cultural terms. These changes refer to the cultural dimension of globalisation. In the light of this, we aim to discuss now the impact of globalisation on the local culture.

You know that culture is an integral part of human society. it is one of the major elements of a social system. Every society has its own culture with its own feature. The regional differences, however, do occur in culture within a single society. For example, we notice several streams within Indian culture itself located in different regions. There are different traditions in these cultural regions. We may call them sub-cultures. Some sociologists name such regional cultures as 'local culture'. The term local culture is used in a relative sense. When we talk about culture of a country, for the people of other countries it becomes a national culture. But if the reference point is cultural regions within a country, its context changes. For instance, Indian culture is a national culture of India for the Americans and the Britishers. But for Indians, local cultures include different cultural patterns found in, say, Bihar, Orissa, Tamil Nadu or Kerala. We may even speak of local cultures of tribal communities.

What we intend to show here is the changes taking place in cultures of different groups and communities in the wake of globalisation. We notice significant cultural changes across the nationa in the modes of consumption, style of dress, use of synthetic materials and so on. Changes are taking place in music, cultural performances, art forms and regional cultural traits. How far these changes are caused by the growing globalisation is difficult to say with certainty. But we cannot at the same time ignore the role of exposure to the trans-national cultural institutions and practices. Market and commodity-oriented cultural forces are causing dislocation of cultural values and practices.

Globalisation has increased the real as well as perceived threats to local and smaller cultural identities. The growing importance of market has converted cultural symbols into commodities. Culture is being offered for sale in bazaar. What we notice is marketisation of culture'. The emergence of tourism as an industry, increasing number of tourist resorts, and marketing of cultural objects are issues affecting the local communities. Such turn of events has led to the loss of meanings in cultural objects. The erosion of structure of folk culture is its natural consequence. Globalisation may thus cause cultural fragmentation because it threatens the core values of the cultural tradition.

Furthermore, globalisation presupposes homogenisation. It is based on the idea of uniformity and homogeneity. On the other hand, the essence of culture lies in its uniqueness. Diversity, not uniformity, sustains a cultural system. It is particularly so in a multi-cultural society. India provides the most suitable example of such a multi-cultural setting. Globalisation attempts assimilation of cultural traits and thereby denies plurality. The universalistic mission of global culture seeks to deny all cultural differences and specificities. As globalisation considers the entire world as a single system, its attempt is to create a global culture. Accordingly, the loss of local culture and subculture is legitimised to give rise to a global culture.

Thus, cultural autonomy of nations is in jeopardy under globalisation. At the social level, the structures and institutions of traditional culture get disrupted. The media texts produced in the Western countries have come to dominate media channels all over the world. In our own country, television networks have started broadcasting programmes that are made in foreign countries. These programmes destroy local cultures. They carry ideological messages that subtly brainwash people into accepting alien values and beliefs.

In the name of cosmopolitan culture, a shallow consumerist package is being distributed in the Third World countries. Under the influence of such a culture every relationship tends to become a short-lived activity for monetary satisfaction. Values of sharing, collaboration and harmony decline and tension in society increases. This degradation in the realm of culture is indeed a serious negative aspect of the phenomenon of globalisation. ■

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AGRARIAN SOCIAL STRUCTURE AND SOCIAL ORGANIZATION OF AGRICULTURE

The study of agrarian social structure has been a matter of serious study in rural sociology and social anthropology. If we go by the dictionary meaning, agrarian pertains to land or its tenure or to a general distribution of lands and organising or furthering agricultural interests. Agrarianism refers to a set of values, which holds that agriculture is the most natural and desirable vocation and the farm, the ideal place to live. Thus an agrarian society may be accepted as "any form of society, especially traditional societies, primarily based on agricultural production and associated crafts rather than industrial production," *(Collin's Dictionary of Sociology, 1991).* If we wish to elaborate further we may say that an agrarian society "focuses its mode of production primarily on agriculture and the cultivation of large fields. This distinguishes it from the hunter-gatherer society which produces none of it's own food, and the 'horticultural Society' which produces food in small gardens rather than fields" *(The Blackwell Dictionary of Sociology, 1995).*

Besides others, AR Desai and Andre Beitelle have contributed significantly to the understanding of agrarian social structure in India Beitelle while defining the agrarian social structure is clearly of the view that only peasantry does not constitute it ; it means something more than the study of peasant societies and cultures. Thus all those playing a role in agrarian society form various parts of it. He further says that the study of agrarian social structure revolves round mainly two aspects: (i) Technological arrangements, and (ii) Social arrangements. While the former refers to the ecological conditions and agricultural technology, the later refers to land ownership and control, power structure, land tenure and related social dimensions. Talking about the Social Framework of Agriculture Andre Beitelle (ibid) says that the economic activities and economic change cannot be adequately understood in isolation from the social framework within which it takes place. This is particularly true of the underdeveloped (and developing) countries of Asia where economic organisation has a lower degree of autonomy than in the industrial societies of the West. Thus, in such Asian societies the economic organization is found to be more closely intermeshed with a variety of social institutions whose functions are partly economic and partly non-economic. He further emphasises the relevance of the social framework to economic activities by elaborating that the economic activities involve the mutual interaction of individuals whose rights and obligations are socially defined. The same broad set of activities, as in agriculture, can be socially organized. The understanding of agrarian social structure and the Social Organization of Agriculture, described as 'Social Framework of Agriculture' by Andre Beitelle (1974), is not possible without having a sound understanding of peasantry or peasant society and its various implications and dimensions in the Indian setting.

PEASANT SOCIETY

A peasant society is a small-scale social organization in which peasants predominate. Anthropologists have defined and explained peasant societies in different ways. A.L. Kroeber was the first anthropologist who tried to provide a formal definition of peasant societies. He described peasant societies as the 'part society' indicating its dependence in technological, economic, political, administrative, religious and moral spheres on the larger society. George Foster taking clue from Kroeber described peasant society as a 'half society'. He implied that the larger society, such as a nation may consist of two parts – the first part consisting of cultivating class living in villages and the second part consists of upper classes living in urban centres. That part of a larger society which is composed of cultivating classes is peasant society or 'half-society'. Robert Redfield followed Kroeber and he also defined peasant society as a 'part society'.

Until 1960s, the peasantry was largely ignored in sociology as having no significant role to play in history. This was despite the fact that peasants have existed for most part of recorded history and in many parts of the world. From the 1960s, the publication of key works, such as Eric Wolf (1966) and Barrington Moore (1967) began to change this perception, introducing to sociology perspectives developed in anthropology and political economy. The role of peasantry in the Vietnam War, and the growth of peasant political activity in Latin America and Asia raised questions about the assumed passivity of the peasantry. Within Marxist work, partly under the influence of Maoism and events in China around the 1949 Revolution and subsequently, there emerged the question of whether the peasantry in the Third World represented the revolutionary force of socialism. There is now a major area of interdisciplinary peasant studies. Till date the debate continues over whether a distinctive category of peasantry can be identified both conceptually and empirically. Shanin presents one of the strongest and most influential defences of the concept. Drawing his inferences from various peasant studies in 20th century, he argues that there are four inter-related characteristics of the peasantry.

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(a) The family farm is the major economic unit around which production, labour and consumption are organized.

(b) Land husbandry is the main activity combined with minimal specialization and family training for tasks.

(c) There is a particular 'peasant way of life' based on the local village community which covers most areas of social life and culture and which distinguished it from urban life and from those of other social groups.

(d) Peasants are politically, economically and socially subordinated to non-peasant groups against whom they have devised various methods of resistance, rebellion or revolt.

(e) A specific social dynamics involving a cyclical change over generations, which irons out inequalities over times via land division;' and the rise and fall of the availability of family labour through the domestic cycle.

(f) Especially in the contemporary world, a common pattern of structural change, drawing peasants into market relationships, often through the influence of outside bodies such as agri-business, and incorporation into national politics. There precise outcome of these common changes is not predetermined."

Robert Redfield in his landmark work *'Peasant Society and Culture'* (1956) placing peasant society between *folk* and *urban* communities, has described the following three as the most important features of a peasant culture:

(a) Highly reverent attitude towards land.

(b) Acceptance of agricultures as the noblest, best and the ideal job, and

(c) A pronounced, industrious attitude of the people demonstrating a firm belief in the dignity of labour.

Among the important features of peasant society are:

(i) Family is the primary unit of multilateral social organization,

(ii) The main source of livelihood is land and agriculture which fulfil almost all the requirements of life,

(iii) They maintain a distinctive, traditional culture in terms of day to day life and its schedule, and

(iv) Usually they are dominated by outsiders.

For the peasant societies, agriculture is not an enterprise but a way of life, which cannot be given up in favour of any other activity promising more money or profit. If agriculture becomes an enterprise instead of a way of life, a peasant becomes a/armerlike the rich farmers of Punjab, Haryana. Maharashtra or Karnataka. Thus, peasants are subsistence cultivators of agricultural land. They may be owner-occupiers or tenants, participants or non-participants in the market. Some writers (such as Chayamov and Eric Wolf) have attempted to isolate a distinctive peasant economy; others (such as, Redfield) stress the notion of a peasant culture.

As the above description indicates, all definitions of the peasantry agree on emphasising the importance of the opposition or contrast between the peasant stratum and the urban elite. The peasantry and the urban centre are two opposing poles of a single socio-economic system, and this is reflected not only in their economic inter-dependence but also in the complex relationship, which exists between peasant and urban culture. This may be seen in the concepts of Great / Little Tradition and Folk-Urban Continuum. Among the anthropologists, Eric Wolf emphasises the economic aspect when denning peasantry. Wolf (1969) in his *'Peasants'* defines the peasants as those whose surplus production is transferred to a dominant ruling group, which employs this surplus both to maintain itself and to redistribute it to other non-agricultural sectors of the population.

Peasants can be most clearly distinguished in agrarian societies,. Significantly, cultivators are not the only segment of population constituting a peasant community. People, who are not analytically defined as peasants but still a part of the peasant community, may be traders, labourers without land and artisans who may have close social and economic links with the peasants. Further, people who are analytically defined as 'peasants' will often engage in some of these activities for part of their time. Thus, while, definitions of the peasantry sometimes rest on the functioning of the household, it is essential to see how this is firmly integrated into a wider social, political and economic network. David Lehmann (1985) stated that it seems best to discard the term 'peasant' as *a* comprehensive descriptor of rural populations of any sort and to use it instead as an adjective describing feature of rural production systems without pretensions to exhaustive definition.

CHARACTERISTICS

Anthropologists and Sociologists like Kroeber, Foster, Redfield, Wolf, Norback, Thorner, Shanin, Andre Beitelle and many more who have written about peasant societies have agreed on the following features as characteristics of peasant societies.

i) A peasant society has long history commensurate with that of city and state.

ii) A peasant society has a social system based on face to face relationships. It includes village communities. The inhabitants of each village are known to one another through shared experience in work, ritual and leisure activities. This close association entails a social system based on face-to-face relationships. The inhabitants of each village may also have personal ties with individuals outside then-village community.

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iii) A peasant society views agriculture as a means of livelihood, not as a business for profit. It is not so much that peasants lack an interest in selling a portion of their crops but rather that such sales are not an end in themselves. These sales can best be understood as transactions that help maintain a given style of life and permit the acquisition of basic necessities. Consequently peasants are primarily concerned with subsistence production and generally consume a major portion of the food and other articles they produce.

iv) A peasant society is based on antiquated technology and low agricultural productivity. It's technology in many parts of the world has changed little since Neolithic times. The productivity of peasant agriculture is low. The peasant economy reveals reliance on agriculture, simple technology, an emphasis on subsistence production, a limited range of items produced, and a direct dependence on the environment.

v) A peasant society directs its economic behaviour at a pattern of immediate consumption and at meeting the material demands of ceremonialism. First, a peasant society is characterized by lack of deferred gratification i.e. the tendency to spend rather than to save, to spend now rather than tomorrow. Second, every peasant society directs its efforts at meeting the material demands of religious observances and social position in terms of festive foods, fireworks, incense, traditional payments and obligations, taxes, shares and other dues and rents.

vi) A peasant society always maintains communication with the urban centres. It produces some exchangeable surplus food, which goes to support towns, and cities, which in turn provide certain types of manufactured or processed goods and services. These exchanges are frequently organized and carried on through a system of market places usually in the towns or cities. Many of it's institutions are local manifestations of national institutions such as the use of a national currency in economic exchange and national educational system. Further, the religious, intellectual and moral life of the urban centres influence the life at the village level and link the peasant community to the wider society.

vii) A peasant society is resistant or very slow to change. Peasants have survived for thousands of years through a series of techniques designed to make them less tempting targets. It is difficult to convince peasants that they can now discard these defences with impunity. Peasants make the economists sigh, the politicians sweat, and the strategists swear all over the world Moscow and Washington, Peking and Delhi.

POWER STRUCTURE AND CLASS STRATIFICATION

The usual and universalistic way of describing social structure has been through institutions based on birth such as family, kinship and caste. Another way of describing it is through class. Thus, the agrarian class structure may be used to understand the power structure and class stratification in Indian rural social structure. However, both caste and class are necessary to describe the agrarian social structure in India. It also explains the power structure in rural India. In this way when we talk of agrarian class stratification we get a better view of rural India which was, traditionally, viewed through caste stratification only. K.L. Sharma (1980) putting the whole issue in proper perspective makes the incisive comment by saying that caste incorporates the element of class and class has a cultural (caste) style, hence the two systems cannot be easily separated even analytically".

Broadly speaking, the modern agrarian class structure in India evolved during the British colonial rule. It was the outcome of the land revenue system evolved and enforced by the British rule. There were three classes:

(i) land owners
(ii) tenants
(iii) agricultural labourers

Daniel Thorner (1973) in his classical work describes these three classes as

(i) proprietors
(ii) working peasants
(iii) labourers

In vernacular language he uses the terms *maalik, kissan* and *mazdur* for these three classes respectively. The landowners or proprietors traditionally belonged to the upper caste groups. They were tax gatherers and non-cultivating owners of land. Thorner understands that the category of proprietors or *maalik* refers to families whose agricultural income is derived primarily (although not necessarily solely) from property rights in the soil. That is to say that whatever other sources of family income may exist, such as from a profession or business, the main agricultural income is derived from a share of the produce of lands belonging to the family.

Typically, this share will be realized in the form of rent. Usually, the rent will be taken in money, but it may be in kind also on crop sharing basis. Instead of renting out his lands, however, a proprietor may hire labourers to cultivate them for him. He may manage these hired labourers himself or he may hire some one else as manager. He may actually go into the fields and perform some of the work along side of his hired labourers. The main determinant should be his mode of income – if his agricultural income from that part of his holdings which he cultivates with his own hands is less than the amount he receives from renting out the rest of his lands, or having thom tilled by hired labourers. Within this group or class of proprietors, it is possible to separate out two subgroups. One consists of large absentee landlords, who typically have

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holdings in more than one village. The second consists of smaller proprietors who reside personally in the village in which they own land, and usually exercise some degree of management and control over its cultivation. Most of the members of this class come from the higher castes.

The second class (referred to as *kisan)* or working peasants has also a recognised property interest in the land. They may be small owners, or tenants with varying degrees of security. By and large (but not in every state) their legal and customary rights will be somewhat inferior to these of the *malik* (proprietors) in the same village. The chief distinguishing feature, however, is the amount of land held. In the case of the working peasant the size of the holding is such that it supports only a single family and then only if one or more members of the family actually perform the field labour. In fact, the produce from the land owned by the *kisan* may not even provide the entire income required by his family, but at least it provides a larger share than whatever funds he may receive from other agricultural sources, such as doing labour on other people's lands. *Kisan* as defined here are those villagers who live primarily by their own toil on their own lands. They do not employ labour, except briefly in the ploughing or harvest season, nor do they commonly receive rent. They come from the middle level cultivating or artisan castes, most of these being OBCs or backward castes.

The third agrarian class referred to as labourer or *mazdur* comprise those villagers who gain their livelihood primarily from working on other people's land. Families in this class may indeed have tenancy rights in the soil, or even property rights, but the holdings are so small that the income from cultivating them or from renting them out comes to less than the earnings from fieldwork. Wages may be received in money or in kind. If the latter they may be fixed or may be in the form of a crop share. In practice the lower ranks of croppers and tenants at will are almost indistinguishable from *mazdur,* they will tentatively be included in this category. Most of the members of this class come from the traditionally landless, deprived, lowly untouchable castes or scheduled castes and backward castes.

As Thorner rightly points out, the maintenance of this hierarchial structure of interests in the land has required that quite a substantial proportion of the produce be reserved for persons who perform no agricultural labour. What was left to the actual cultivator, after the claims of the various superior might holders were satisfied, might still be subject to collection as unpaid debt by the moneylender. Thus, the power structure in the agrarian classes is largely based on exploitation and deprivation.

In his landmark work D.N. Dhanagre (1983) says that although Thorner's categories and sub-categories are nearer the realities of the Indian agrarian social structure there is still a need to readjust or regroup these categories into a broader and more comprehensive model and redesignate them by commonly used concepts and criteria in the study of peasant societies. Such a model can be drawn from the works of Lenin and Marx, especially those relating to analyses of agrarian classes in the Russian and Chinese societies respectively:

I. Landlords
II. Rich Peasants
III. Middle Peasants
IV. Poor Peasants
V. Landless labourers

Dhanagre further opines that the social composition of these agrarian classes in terms of specific status groups like castes, religious or ethnic groups, etc is far too complex in different regions of India to reduce into any simplistic formulae. However, for a loose and broad classification this may hold ground. For example, landlords and rich landowners (including non-cultivating urban moneylenders/ owners) belonged to the upper castes such as Brahmin, Thakur, or Bania in northern India. In Andhra Pradesh the Kammas, Reddis and Raos, in Mysore the Okkaligas and Lingayats, the Patidars in the Gujarat region while the Kunbi, Marathas and Deshmukhs in Maharashtra could be cited as more examples of the locally dominant landowning castes. The middle and poor peasantry, mostly debt ridden, came primarily from the traditional castes of cultivators, artisans and so on. The landless labourers belonged mostly to untouchable castes, the scheduled castes.

The post-independence period witnessed significant changes in the agrarian class structure in India. The impact of land, reforms and rural development programmes facilitated the emergence of new forces of change. In fact the challenge to the feudal class structure emerged' with the rise of the nationalist movement. Analysing these changes Yogendra Singh says that the agrarian class structure everywhere in India had a feudal character. The challenge to the feudal class structure came with" the nationalist movement not only was a radical agrarian ideology accepted but also the national leadership also actively undertook the cause of the exploited peasantry and led Kisan (peasant) movements in various parts of the country. Following independence, therefore, land reforms were introduced in most states and a beginning was made for transformation in the agrarian class structure. Most sociological studies of the agrarian structure refer to these processes of social change. Moreover, the significant trends mentioned in such studies are:

i) That there is a wide gap between land reform ideology projected during the freedom struggle or even thereafter

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and the actual measures introduced for land reforms. Consequently, socialist transformation in the class structure of the villages has not taken place.

ii) This lag could partly be explained by the class character of the Indian political and administrative elite who are resistant to the needed radical reforms.

iii) The existing land reforms have initiated a process by which the security of tenure and economic prosperity of the rich peasantry has increased, but the condition of the small peasants both in respect of economic level and tenurial stability has deteriorated.

iv) The feudalistic and customary type of tenancy has declined and it has been replaced by a capitalistic form of lease labour or wage labour agrarian system.

v) A new class of rich middle stratum of peasantry system has come into being, and not all of these are from among the ex-zamindars.

vi) The class inequalities, between the top and the bottom levels of the classes, have increased rather than decreased.

vii) The benefits of land reforms have so far not gone so much to the agricultural workers or even to ex-zamindars as to the emergent middle peasantry.

viii) As a result of these contradictions in the agrarian class structure the tensions in the rural social system have increased and are bound to increase further, and finally,

ix) That the sociological process that is dominant in the current class transformations in the villages is the 'embourgeoisiment' of some and 'proletarianization' of many social strata.

PC Joshi (1971) in his celebrated work has made very incisive comments on the trends in the agrarian class structure. Some of these are summarized as under:

(a) It led to the decline of feudal and customary types of tenancies. It was replaced by a more exploitative and insecure lease arrangement.

(b) It gave rise to a new commercial based rich peasant class who were part owners and part tenants. They had resource and enterprise to carry out commercial agriculture.

(c) It led to the decline of feudal landlord class and another class of commercial farmers emerged for whom agriculture was a business. They used the non-customary type of tenancy.

Thus, the rural India witnessed and still witnessing the process of social mobility and transformation. Depeasantization of small and marginal peasant is also a by-product of the transformation of village India.

CHANGING AGRARIAN STRUCTURE

When the famous British historian Eric Hobsbawm declared in his Age Extremes: 'The most dramatic Change of the second half of this century and the one which cuts as forever, from the world of the past is the death of the peasantry', he did not, of course, mean it literally. He was only referring to a spectacular decline world over in the proportion of workforce engaged in agriculture.

Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia proved to be exceptions to the rule. In India, from 1950 to 1970 the distribution of workforce in agriculture, industry and services more or less remained unchanged and Byres has termed it as 'structural stasis'. Even after that the shift of workforce away from agriculture was slow and jerky.

Table 1

Percentage Share of Total Workforce in Agriculture

Country	1960	1990
France	22	5
Japan	33	7
Brazil	52	23
Mexico	55	28
Republic of Korea	66	17

Table 2

Distribution of Workforce (in terms of Usual Status): India

Industry	1972-73	1977-78	1983	1987-88	1993-94	1999-2000
1. Agriculture	73.9	71.0	68.6	65.0	63.9	59.8
2. Mining & Quarrying	0.4	0.4	0.6	0.7	0.7	0.6
3. Manufacturing	8.8	10.2	10.7	11.1	10.7	11.1
4. Elec., Gas & Power	0.2	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.4	0.3
5. Construction	1.9	1.7	2.2	3.8	3.2	4.4
6. Trade	5.1	6.1	6.2	7.2	7.6	10.4
7. Transport & Storage	1.8	2.1	2.5	2.6	2.9	3.7
8. Services	7.9	8.1	8.9	9.3	10.7	9.7
All	100	100	100	100	100	100

As can be seen from the Table 2, from 1972-73 onwards the share of workforce in agriculture started declining slowly and shares in manufacturing and services increased marginally. The workforce diversification process suffered a setback between 1987-88 and 1993-94. The share of manufacturing in the workforce contracted and the decline in the share of agriculture was halted. For rural female

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workforce, the share of agriculture registered an increase during this period. From 1993-94 to 1999-2000 the share of agriculture has declined by 4 per cent. Mainly trade and transport have absorbed this displaced workforce. The increment in the share of manufacturing is marginal.

AGRARIAN TRANSITION - A POLITICAL ECONOMIC PROCESS

The structural shift of labour from agriculture to industry (and services) with the development of capitalism is not just a mechanical process.'It has a political economic content to it. It relates to the changing production bases (technology, production structure and property relations) both in agriculture and industry. These chances engender release of labour at one end and its absorption at the other. The interaction between the two sectors is complex and obviously involves flows other than the one way flow of labour.

Initially, the great bulk of working population is in agriculture and the great bulk of national product is generated there. When productivity in agriculture increases and surplus is accumulated, the countryside contributes to the development of manufacturing. The countryside provides labour, wage goods and raw materials and also creates home market for manufacturing. The industry in turn provides market and new inputs to agriculture, which further increase its productivity. The process is accompanied by critical changes in production relations at both ends leading to formation of dominant and subordinate classes. This transfer of surplus from agriculture to industry is described as the 'primitive accumulation' i.e. transfer of surplus from pre-capitalist mode of production to capitalist mode of production and ultimately the transition of peasant economy itself into capitalist agriculture.

Different paths of agrarian transition can be traced in history. T.J. Byres has presented a comprehensive historical account of these paths in his book and various articles. The paths essentially differ in terms of rise of class agents in the countryside who unleash the process of accumulation and consequent industrialisation. Lenin described the transition in Prussia as 'capitalism from above'. The feudal landlords - Junkers became the class of capitalist farmers. In north and west of United States it was 'capitalism from below'. Capitalism emerged from the class of petty commodity producers – the peasants. In France, capitalist impulse was frustrated for a long time by a stubborn peasantry that refused to make an exit.

From which strata, the class of capitalist farmers emerges and whether it emerges at all, depends on the pre-capitalist structures and property relations, and the pivotal role that state plays in mediating the agrarian transition. ■

STRUCTURAL STASIS IN INDIAN AGRICULTURE

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW

The possibility of capitalist industrialisation arising out of increased productivity in the pre-capitalist agriculture was thwarted in India by the colonial rule. The rigid land revenue system and commercialisation of agriculture in imperialist interests destroyed the production base of the extant peasant economy. Vast sections of peasantry were pauperised and reduced to landless or near landless status. In the year 1931, 32 per cent of rural workforce was classified as landless. At the other end, land and consequently surplus got concentrated in few hands. This surplus was neither used for increasing productivity of agriculture, nor did it induce growth of manufacturing. Both the processes were constrained by limited size of home-market. India as a colony not only provided raw material to British industry but also markets for British manufactures.

The limited development of manufacturing replaced the artisans but did not create sufficiently many jobs to absorb the pauperised peasantry. The uprooted peasantry was forced to find livelihood opportunities in agriculture itself. This created a land lease market with very high rents and a labour market with wage rate below subsistence level. The landless and poor farmers leased in land to attain a cultivator status and took consumption loans to supplement their income. Landowners could then get high returns by leasing out land and usury. They had little incentive to invest in productive enterprises. They did cultivate land employing farm labour. These farms were characterised by small outlays and low level of technology. Farm labour was tied to these farms through debt bondages, oppressive caste relations and lack of opportunities elsewhere. As Utsa Patnaik clearly states this was not capitalist farming.

Capitalist farming with re-investment of surplus was confined to plantations. These were tiny enclaves-foreign owned and export oriented.

In short, the agrarian structure bequeathed to us by the colonial rulers was characterised by an extremely skewed distribution of land and other resources. Agriculture was stagnant with falling per capita production and availability of food grain. Further, possibility of accumulation through

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rent and usury prevented investment of surplus in productive enterprises.

This historical overview helps in understanding the evolution of production conditions and production relations in the post-independence period. It also points out the similarity between the neo-liberal regime today and the colonial rule then.

UNSUCCESSFUL LAND REFORMS

'Land reform' was an important constituent of the economic programme of 'national freedom movement'. Elaborate legislation was drafted after independence with a view to end the oppressive and exploitative feudal relations, provide land to the tiller and thus attain an equitable distribution of land and other resources in rural India. In general, there is a consensus that the land reform programme completely failed to attain its objectives. Notwithstanding abolition of absentee landlordship and intermediaries, the rich upper caste landlords retained feudal dominance through political-administrative and judicial machanisation. Wherever any progress was made towards reducing the domination of feudal interests, rich peasantry quickly appropriated the ensuing political and economic space. Tenancy legislations in the states only succeeded in driving tenancy underground. Concealed and informal tenancy exacerbated the misery of impoverished and marginalised tenant farmers. The record of imposing land, ceilings and redistributing land has been dismal. Only a minuscule bit of land was redistributed and invariably it was barren and poor quality land.

Vast divergences exist with respect to formulation of legislation and its implementation at the state level. Thus, semi-feudalism remained intact in Bihar but the Marxist governments in West Bengal and Kerala did succeed in altering the rural production base. In Punjab consolidation of land was carried out efficiently, which was crucial for introduction of modern technology and mechanisation. It is, therefore, necessary to qualify any all India level inference in this regard. In fact the divergence is so large that some scholars consider all India generalisations to be futile.

A decade later 'land reform' agenda was pushed into background and 'green revolution' arrived on the forefront.

GREEN REVOLUTION AND SPREAD OF CAPITALIST FARMING

The new technology (High Yielding Variety seeds) was introduced when the agrarian structure was still characterised by feudal dominance. The existence of numerous small, marginal and landless units enabled the landowners to accumulate through leasing and usury. High ground rent and high interest rate constituted an insurmountable barrier to the development of capitalist agriculture. Only in the event of a technological breakthrough, which promised a quantum jump in expected profits, could the surplus be diverted into productive activities. HYV seeds along with the accompanying input package of irrigation, fertilisers and pesticides offered this break through.

The official view was that the required growth in agriculture could be attained by on rich peasantry and landlords. Accordingly, physical and financial infrastructure was extended to them. HYV seeds, subsidised fertilisers and pesticides were made available through government network. At the same time favourable market conditions were created through minimum support price.

Initially the spread of new technology was confined to the irrigated wheat belt of Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh. By mid 1970s a breakthrough was achieved in paddy cultivation and new technology reached southern and western states. During 1980s, there was a further spread to the eastern states of West Bengal, Orissa and Bihar etc. 1980s also witnessed introduction of hybrid seeds in cotton, oil seeds and coarse grains, which extended new technology to the central region.

Spread of new technology has been accompanied by spread of capitalist production. State-wise data on proportion of hired labour, market orientation and capital accumulation pattern indicate that by the beginning of 1990s capitalist farming had penetrated almost all the states.

Three ramifications of rising capitalist tendency in Indian agriculture need to be noted:

1. ***Differentiation in Peasantry is Sharpened***

   The state opened up new vistas of profit making opportunities to big farmers. The big farmers and landowners withdrew their land from the lease market for self-cultivation. There was also increased tendency towards reverse tenancy, especially in regions where capitalism did establish itself.

   For small semi-medium farmers shifting to new technology was not possible because of resource constraints. A great deal of literature exists on how green revolution increased concentration of resources and adversely affected the small and marginal farmers.

2. ***Employment Opportunities in Agriculture were Squeezed***

   Capitalist farming and investment for increasing productivity is accompanied by the mechanisation of farm operations. This drastically reduces the labour requirements. Further, labour intensity is greater in small and medium farms because using family labour enables them to reduce labour costs below subsistence level.

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Finally, structured employment on capitalist farms does not provide space to absorb surplus labour. The sponge capacity of agricultural sector to absorb labour indefinitely (albeit at low productivity and low income level) gets eroded with capitalist farming. In Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh wage rates have been higher than the rest of India, but the employment elasticities (increase in employment per unit increase in output) have been near zero or even negative.

3. ***Social Property Relations Blocked the Transfer of Surplus***

Surplus that accumulated with the rich farmers did not get transferred to manufacturing. Rich farmers' movements emerged in Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka and, of course, in Punjab and Haryana. They blocked agricultural taxation and demanded favourable terms of trade for agriculture. Further, the surplus accumulated in agriculture vas concentrated in few hands. This limited the size of market and thus constrained expansion of labour intensive manufacturing.

The state led industrialisation was geared to the requirements of big bourgeoise in industry. The state invested in heavy industry, which was capital intensive and generated limited employment opportunities.

The marginalised and landless households, therefore, remained trapped in agriculture.

Two questions distinct from the existence or spread of capitalist development refer to the extent of which capitalist relations have taken roots in the agrarian structure. Whether capitalist production relations have entrenched themselves deep enough to qualify as the dominant mode of production? Alternatively, have they entrenched themselves deep enough so as not to allow any obstruction to capitalist transition process? Will capitalism become the dominant mode of production in foreseeable future? Most scholars in the 1980s and till the beginning of 1990s gave an unequivocal 'no' as answer to these questions.

Tables 3,4 and 5 give distribution of ownership holdings and operational holding and Gini coefficient or concentration ratio for the two distributions. A tendency towards differentiation of peasantry and increasing concentration can be discerned from these tables. At the same time, it is clear that notwithstanding penetration of capitalist farming, the agrarian structure in the year 1991-92 was dominated by small and marginaliandholdings. Not only did they constitute 80.6 per cent of total operational holdings, they also accounted for 34.3 per cent of the total area cultivated.

Table 3

Percentage Distribution of Ownership Holdings in Rural Households

	Marginal (0-1 hect.)		Small (1-2 hect.)		Semi-medium (2-4 hect.)		Medium (4-10 hect.)		Large (>10 hect.)	
Year	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area
1960-61	60.06	7.59	15.16	12.40	12.86	20.54	9.07	31.23	2.85	28.24
1970-71	62.62	9.76	15.49	14.68	11.40	21.92	7.88	30.75	2.12	22.91
1980-81	66.64	12.22	14.70	16.49	10.78	23.38	6.45	29.83	1.42	18.07
1991-92	69.38	16.93	21.75	33.97	5.06	17.63	2.84	17.64	0.95	13.83

Source: Agricultural Statistics at a Glance, Govt. of India, 1993.

Table 4

Percentage Distribution of Ownership Holdings in Rural Households

	Marginal (0-1 hect.)		Small (1-2 hect.)		Semi-medium (2-4 hect.)		Medium (4-10 hect.)		Large (>10 hect.)	
Year	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area	Holding	Area
1960-61	39.1 (17.13)	6.9	22.6	12.3	19.4	20.7	14.0	31.2	4.5	29.0
1970-71	45.8 (21.25)	9.2	22.4	14.8	17.7	22.6	11.1	30.5	3.1	23.0
1980-81	56.0 (33.05)	11.5	19.3	16.6	14.2	23.6	8.6	30.1	1.9	18.2
1991-92	62.8 (37.70)	15.6	17.8	18.7	12.0	24.1	6.1	26.4	1.3	15.2

Source: NSS survey on land and live stock holdings 17th, 26th, 37th and 48th round.

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Table 5

Trend in Gini Coefficient (Rural India)

Gini Coefficient

Year	Operational holdings	Ownership holdings
1960-61	0.583	0.731
1970-71	0.586	0.709
1981-82 -	0.629	0.712
1991-92	0.641	0.710

Source: NSS survey on land and livestock holdings.

These numerous small and marginal holdings have contributed to keeping the land lease and the informal money lending markets vibrant as can be seen from Table 5 the concentration ratio for operational holdings is significantly less than that for ownership holdings. In fact, as land leasing became difficult for the marginal farmers and the landless, they responded by offering higher rents. The higher rent, need not always be in money terms or in terms of larger share of the produce. It could be in terms of offering free labour to the landowner or payment in some other form. Rising rent in the land lease market can reassert the barrier to capitalist accumulation process. This tendency has been witnessed in some states.

On the other hand, the existence of these numerous small and marginal units also contributed towards retaining the sponge capacity of agriculture toehold much more than the required workforce. State policies in 1970s and 1980s also helped in containing the workforce in this sector. Various poverty alleviation programmes and small farmer-marginal farmer schemes enabled the landless and marginalised to get supplementary earning opportunities.

Thus, the process of agrarian transition reached an impasse in the absence of employment opportunities outside of agriculture. As can be seen from Table 2, the decline in the share of agricultural workforce was halted between 1987-88 and 1993-94.

GLOBALISATION AND CRISIS IN INDIAN AGRICULTURE

The structural adjustment programme and WTO trade regime in the decade of 1990s, have brought about a new crisis of rural livelihoods. The new economic regime, in a way, has taken us back to the colonial era, where the process of surplus accumulation and utilisation is once again to be mediated by metropolitan capital.

WITHDRAWAL OF STATE

State withdrew from its earlier declared role of intervening in the market processes to protect economic space of domestic producers and among them that of small producers and weaker sections. The elaborate structure of controls on domestic and international trade and on investment has been dismantled rapidly. The Essential Commodity Act, Agricultural Produce Marketing Act and Small Scale Industry Reservation Act, restricting movement, storage, marketing and processing of agricultural produce have been modified. The multinationals and big domestic units are now allowed to enter into these activities.

Exim policy in the post-liberalisation period has removed import controls on agricultural commodities rapidly - sometimes much ahead of WTO stipulated phase out period. Trade liberalisation has taken place in the background of extremely unfavourable global market conditions for primary commodities. The prices of all primary commodities (including wheat and rice) have fallen dramatically since mid 1990s.

The infrastructure facilities provided by the government are on the decline. A number of minor and medium size irrigation network projects are left incomplete, not because they are controversial but;because of paucity of funds. The last decade saw the privatisation of power sector and the agenda for the coming decade is to privatise water. The ramifications for Indian agriculture will be wide spread. It may shatter the viability of even medium level farmers.

Table 6

Falling Prices of Primary Products in US Dollars

(USD per ton.)

Commodity	1988	1995	1997	1999	2001
Wheat (US HW)	167.0	216.0	142.0	–	133.0
Rice (US)	265.7	–	439.0	–	291.0
Cotton (US cents per lb)	63.5	98.2	77.5	–	49.1
Groundnut Oil	590.0	991.0	1010.0	788.0	–
Palm Oil	437.0	626.0	93.5	74.7	–
Soya Bean Oil	464.0	479.0	625.0	71.4	–
Soya Bean Seeds	297.0	273.0	262.0	–	178.0

Source : Utsa Patnaik (2002), 'Agrarian Crisis and Global Deflationism', *Social Scientist*, Jan-Feb. 2002.

The changed priority of banking sector has slashed down the direct advances to agriculture made by commercial as well as cooperative banks. Schemes to facilitate the credit needs of small and marginal farmers are completely eroded. This has led to an aggressive growth of informal credit markets. Apart from traditional moneylenders, traders of new technology, inputs and equipments have entered these markets.

Fertiliser subsidies have been cut down in annual budget exercises and the government has handed over the task of providing seeds to the multinationals and private companies.

Finally, in the current parlance the term 'land reform' is being used for advocating removal of land ceiling and tenancy regulations. This would allow corporate sector to enter into direct farm operations. The big farmers would be able to negotiate profitable deals with the corporate sector and MNCs. Some states like Maharashtra and Karnataka have made significant moves in this direction. ■

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ENTRENCHMENT OF CORPORATE SECTOR (MNCs) INTO INDIAN AGRICULTURE

The most fundamental shift in the structure of international political economy of food has been the mergence of transnational agro-food corporations, attempting to organise the production and consumption in national economics geared to their investment and marketing goals.

In India, the corporate sector has been prevented from entering direct farm production because of the land ceiling laws. The low ceiling limits do not allow scale intensive farming in which companies are interested. Only plantation sector has been exempted from the land ceiling regulations. Capitalist farms controlled by foreign companies have existed in this sector since before independence. The average size of large farm in Assam is 88.80 hectares and in Kerala 59.33 hectares. Under the new definition of 'land reform' there is an increasing pressure to allow companies to undertake direct farm production especially in the areas of horticulture, floriculture and agro-forestry. The demand is to substantially extend the land ceiling limit or to remove it altogether. As already mentioned many state governments are prepared to concede this demand. Maharashtra government has already taken the initiative to grant exemption in landholding act to trusts, companies and cooperatives for horticulture purposes. Fallow, waste or khar lands can be purchased by such entities and land under cultivation can be taken on lease. The farm size can be as as large as 1000 acres.

In the meanwhile companies have been acquiring vast tract of land in Orissa and southern states for aquaculture. A large number of small and marginal farmers have been uprooted in this process. Several companies are entering agro forestry (teak-planting) circumventing the land ceiling regulations. They buy the land and allot it to individuals on payment of substantial sums and in turn promise them attractive returns.

However, the design of agri-business to control the surplus of far more ambitious than what can be achieved through direct farm cultivation. Agri-business is fast acquiring control on the input and output flows of the farm sector with the acquiescence of Indian state. The design is to alter the land use pattern geared to their profit interests.

CONTRACT FARMING

Under contract farming, farmers are commissioned to produce and supply specific product, in specific quantities and of specific quality at a specified time and at a specified price. The company provides seeds, fertilisers, technology, credit and also farm equipments to the farmers. Tomato crop in Punjab (HLL, Pepsi and Nijjar), Mustard crop in Punjab (Markfed, a para-statal cooperative body), Potatoes (McDonalds), Wheat crop in Madhya Pradesh (Rallis and HLL), horticulture and floriculture (Ace) are examples known to everyone. Contract farming is, however, confined to few areas and a few products.

SEED COMPANIES

The control of MNCs over seed industry is far more pervasive. With the introduction of HYV wheat, National Seed Corporation was set up in 1963. Subsequently state seed corporations were setup to meet the requirement of quality seeds. Under the World Bank supported seed projects, private sector entered seed industry during the period 1973 to 1985. In 1987, MRTP and FERA companies were invited to manufacture seeds. In the same year import of seeds was put in Open General Licence category. Under the TRIPs regulations of WTO, the multinational seed companies have emerged as very powerful agents proceeding to take complete control over seed industry and thus control the land use pattern in Indian agriculture. Hybrid seeds with seed specific nutrients and pest management and tissue culture based plant varieties are being supplied by MNCs at prices beyond the reach of poor farmers.

At the other end, agro-processing industries, which were earlier reserved for the small-scale industry sector, have been opened up for big corporations and MNCs.

The land use and land ownership pattern in Indian agriculture can be expected to change very rapidly in the coming years.

The changeover from a state controlled regime to a market regime dominated by mega-size international players has affected different sections of farming community differently.

Ambiguous Stance of Big Fanners' Lobby Towards the Neo-liberal Regime

As already mentioned, along with the spread of green revolution and increased productivity of agriculture, rich farmers' lobby emerged as a powerful political movement in the 1970s. Sharad Joshi in Maharashtra, M.S. Tikait in Uttar Pradesh and Ajmer Singh Lakhowal, Balbir Singh Rajwal and Bhupinder Singh Mann in Punjab led it. These movements have demanded remunerative prices of their produce and increased subsidies on farm inputs.

The reaction of the rich farmers' lobby to globalisation process has been ambiguous. On one hand, they perceived trade liberalisation, diversification of farm produce and entry of agribusiness as advantageous to them. On the other hand, they were apprehensive that they would not be able to compete with the imports dumped by heavily subsidised farm sector of the developed countries. Thus, while Sharad Joshi welcomed the proposals of Dunkel draft of Uruguay round, the farmers' movements in Uttat Pradesh and Karnataka opposed it.

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In 1988, *a* para-statal in Punjab (Punjab Agro-Industries Corporation), Bhartiya Kisan Union and the farmer based political party Akali Dal invited Pepsi as a joint venture partner with Voltas to procure and process fruits and vegetables. The MNCs contract farming arrangements are essentially with medium and big farmers. Engaged in tie-ups with companies, the big farmers identify their interests with the corporate sector. Along with the corporate sector the farmers' lobby is also pressurising the state governments to modify land ceiling legislations and carry out consolidation of land holdings. Micro-level studies indicate that the reverse tenancy phenomenon, which showed a marked presence in Punjab and Haryana during 1970s and 1980s, has rapidly spread to other states in the 1990s.

It must, however, be noted that in view of the deflationary trend in world market prices of primary commodities and unequal bargaining power *vis-a-vis* the corporate lobby, the big farmers' lobby is at the moment uncomfortable in the new milieu. It wants the government to protect its economic space in WTO negotiations. Tomorrow, if the big farmers perceive greener pastures in international markets and expect attractive deals from corporate partners, they may switch over to the other side. Whether the big farmers can become an integral constituent of an anti-imperialist struggle is a moot question.

NON-VIABILITY OF SMALL AND SEMI-MEDIUM FARMS, AND INCREASING LANDLESSNESS

Small and medium farmers usually follow the lead taken by big farmers in switching over to new technology, new cropping pattern and new production arrangements. Sometimes they do it willingly in the hope that the returns will be high. However, more often it is done under the compulsion because the earlier infrastructure has been dismantled. Many of the small and medium farmers have shifted away from coarse grains to Soyabean, new variety of cotton, and oil seeds production. This shift requires substantially increased expenditure.

In the wake of a squeeze on the availability of organised credit in rural areas, farmers are forced to take credit in informal credit market either from traditional moneylenders or from new input traders. If the crop fails or the price of the produce collapses because of international market, the small or medium farmer is completely ruined.

Indebtedness and consequent farmers' suicides in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka have attracted a lot of media attention. Whether or not they committed suicide, the small and marginal farmers are increasingly getting dispossessed of their land resource base. Detailed NSS survey data on land holding is not available beyond 1991-92. However, the above inference can be substantiated by the information on landholding given in the Employment and Unemployment surveys for the year 1993-94 and 1999-2000.

As can be seen from Table 7, in a very short span of time *ihs* share of households possessing 0.01 and 0.4 hectares of land has swollen by 10.6 per cent. Up to 0.4 hectare the holding is sub-marginal and does not ensure subsistence livelihood. As can be seen in Table 8, majority of households possessing this small piece of land do not cultivate it. They either lease in more land and increase their holding size or lease out their plot and look for some other occupation. It is apparent that the first option has not been chosen. Either it is not available or if available it is not viable. Tables (7 and 8) indicate that these sub-marginal households have given up their land and migrated out to the landless labour category. The households, who cultivate up to 0.4 hectares of land, often leave if for women. The male members move out in search of better income earning opportunities. Feminisation of agriculture emerges from proliferation of these sub-marginal farms.

Landlessness has increased rapidly at all India level and in every state.

The non-viability of small, semi-medium and medium farm households can be expected to gather momentum as electricity charges increase and user charges are levied on water.

LIVELIHOOD CRISIS OF THE POOR AND MARGINALISED

Along with increasing landlessness, the NSS Employment and Unemployment Survey for year 1999-2000, shows a startling decline in the employment growth in agriculture.

Table 7

Distribution of Rural Households by Size Class of Land Possessed

size Class of Land Cultivated (0.00 hectares)

Years	0.00	0.01-0.40	0.41-1.00	1.01-2.00	2.01-4.00	4.01 & above
1993-94	12.9	40.4	18.7	14.0	8.8	5.2
1999-2000	7.2	51.0	19.1	11.5	7.3	3.9

Source: Employment and Unemployment Situation in India, NSSO, GOI.

Table 8

Distribution of Rural Households by Size Class of Land Possessed

Size Class of Land Cultivated (0.00 hectares)

Years	0.00	0.01-0.40	0.41-1.00	1.01-2.00	2.01-4.00	4.01 & above
1987-88	35.4	19.1	17.3	13.9	8.5	5.8
1993-94	38.7	18.8	17.1	13.4	7.6	4.3
1999-2000	40.9	22.3	16.8	11.2	5.9	3.0

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Source: Employment and Unemployment Situation in India, NSSO, GOI.

The fall is steeper in the case of weekly and daily status indicating that the usually employed now get work for less number of days. The employment elasticity in agriculture has declined from 0.7 (during 1987-88 to 1993-94) to .1 in the period 1993-94 to 1999-2000. In as many as 11 states the employment elasticity is negative or hear zero.

Whereas increased mechanisation (especially increasing use of harvasters in the 1990s) and changes in cropping pattern explain part of this decline in employment growth, a major contribution is that of changing land holding pattern and the changing land-lease market.

As already mentioned, the small and semi-medium farm operations are much more labour-intensive than the big farms. Further, work can be divided and sub-divided in these farms to accommodate many more people than is actually required. As small and semi-medium farmers get dispossessed and as it becomes difficult for the landless to lease and land and acquire cultivator status, the capacity of agriculture to accommodate, labour gets compromised.

As can be seen from Table 10, the share of self-employed in agriculture remained unchanged at 37.7 per cent during 1987-88 to1993-94. It declined to 32.7 per cent in the year 1999-2000. There is a decline in absolute number of self-employed in agriculture. The share of agricultural labour households has increased during this time.

In the 1970s and 1980s, the state came forward to partially support the subsistence livelihood of the marginalised peasantry. In the 21st century state has absolved itself of all responsibilities. This time the poor and marginalised in agriculture are being forced to migrate out. Migration from one region to another, from rural to urban and from farm sector to non-farm sector is on the increase.

Table 9

Rates of Growth of Agricultural Employment

Period	Usual Status	Usual + Subsidiary Status	Weekly Status	Daily Status
1987-88 to 1993-94	2.08	2.17	3.91	2.47
1993-94 to 1999-2000	0.80	0.18	0.68	0.14

Source: Employment and Unemployment Situation in India, NSSO, GOI.

Unfortunately there is no space available outside. The already limited employment possibilities in the industrial sector have been further reduced by the neo-liberal regime. The small and labour intensive manufacturing units have rapidly closed down and the traditional big industrial units have resorted to retrenchment and out-sourcing. The modern units are capital and import intensive with space only for the highly skilled. This leaves the service sector, which, like agriculture, has the sponge capacity to absorb excess labour at low-productivity low-income level. Between 1993-94 and 1999-2000, labour thrown out of agriculture went into service sector. However, service sector can accommodate labour only up to a limit.

Table 10

Distribution of Households by Household Type in Rural India

Household Type	1987-88	1993-94	1999-2000
Self-Employed in Agriculture	37.7	37.8	32.7
Self-Employed in Non-Agriculture	12.3	12.7	13.4
Agriculture Labour	30.7	30.0	32.2
Other Labour	9.0	8.0	8.0

Source: NSS Employment and Unemployment Survey 1999-2000.

Finally, those who remain in agriculture and dare to stake a claim on their miniscule share in the resource base, face the violence of big peasantry and state administration - sometimes to the extent of getting physically eliminated. It must be noted that penetration of capitalism in agriculture has throughout accommodated and utilised feudal superstructure. Modern capitalist exploitation of labour has not just left space for caste hierarchy and oppresion, it has made use of it to serve its own interests.

TO CONCLUDE

The agrarian transition under the state led industrialisation of Indian economy reached an impasse. Concentration of resources both in agriculture and industry led to an industrial growth where space for labour was scarce. Agriculture obliged by containing the unskilled and marginalized mass of workforce within itself.

In the 21st century the neo-liberal global regime has brought about inexorable changes world over. The global circuits of production, exchange and finance have qualitatively changed the functioning of national economies. The agrarian equestion in India is now being resolved in its own ruthless manner by the globalisation process.

The increasing control of agri-business over input and output flows of agriculture will necessarily result in a massive debouching workforce from this sector. Such a trend is already discernable. The workforce, debouched from agriculture, just does not have space outside. Manufacturing and service sector together are quite incapable of accommodating it. The situation admits no other solution but a radical restructuring of the entire production base.

For those of us, who owe allegiance to an equitable society ensuring dignified human existence, the 'agrarian question' can then be looked at only in its first layer of meaning namely to seek the support of uprooted peasantry for overthrowing the existing regime. *(Courtesy: Alternative Economic Survey, 2002-03 by Alternative Survey Group, Rainbow Publishers).*

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IMPACT OF MARKET ECONOMY ON INDIA'S VILLAGES

When we look at India's villages we find that, traditionally, rural economy has been primarily a subsistence economy oriented to satisfy the consumption needs of the local population. The *jajmani* system served as the basis of the economic organization under which the local people belonging to different castes were involved in exchange of goods and services as per the local traditions. But it is also true that within this subsistence economy there was some role of the market. There used to be local, informal markets with varying periodicity but they served socio-cultural functions more than a place of formal economic transactions. These periodically held markets provided avenues for inter-relationship among the clusters of villages. Significantly, the economic exchange in such markets was predominantly either redistributive or reciprocal type. Thus, we can say that limited degree of cash economy and market exchange did exist in the pre-industrial urban centres in India from the medieval period onwards.

With the advent of the British rule and the consequent process of modernization the pace of change increased rapidly. The colonial vested interests of the British rule pushed a new kind of capitalistic economy in agriculture. Land became a commodity and property. A new kind of land revenue system was introduced promoting monetization. Simultaneously the process of peasantization and de-peasantization was also witnessed especially in the case of tribal communities. The system of land tevenue settlement introduced by the British rulers required the payment of revenue in cash. This became instrumental for a rapidly increasing tendency of raising more cash or commercial crops. In this way the village economy got linked to the urban and later to the national economy. This was the beginning of monetisation and extension of market economy to Indian villages.

After independence modern means of transport and communication were introduced by the government as part of massive economic development programmes resulting into full-fledged extension of market economy to village India. Now the commodities of daily use in urban markets such as soaps, toothpaste, hosiery etc. are also available in village and towns markets. On the other hand, poultry items from a village in northern India has reached the markets of metropolitan cities of far off regions. The emergence of a rich class of peasantry created enormous demand of luxury goods in villages. A.R. Desai, in his pioneering contribution has identified four major trends of change in village India:

(a) Rapid transformation of agrarian society from subsistence economy to market economy,

(b) Rapid transformation followed by the introduction of modern technology,

(c) Abolition of intermediaries such as *zamindars* and *biswedars*,

(d) Emergence of associations and institutions having linkages with urban and national organizations.

With the introduction of market economy there was a change in the nature of production and consumption. Now the prime motive behind agricultural production was to generate surplus for the market thus facilitating the entry of more and more market forces. It also promoted consumption oriented life style among the rural folks. The demand for urban, machine produced items increased rapidly. Consumption and possession of these items became status symbols. Thus, the rural transformation promoted by the market economy may be summarised as under:

(a) The new market economy cheated a new class of rich peasants, big traders, petty officials and political workers.

(b) It promoted a large number of new facilities especially related with credit. Now, even credit cards have entered into the rural society.

(c) It facilitated the entry of improved implements such as tractors, water pumps, thireshers etc.

(d) Polarisation of peasants into rich landowning class and extensively poor landless labourers increased manifold.

(e) Monetisation has expanded the avenues of social mobility. It had a deep impact on such traditional social institutions as joint family. The differential capacities of various members of the joint family to generate income led to a tendency towards nuclear families.

(f) It led to occupational mobility and diversification

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(g) An occupation free caste structure emerged proving to be a big blow to the traditional jajmani system.

(h) Caste barriers to economic mobility are crumbling.

(i) New avenues of healthcare and education have entered into rural life.

(j) It indirectly promoted empowerment of women.

Among all these features the most glaring phenomenon of recent origin is the agrarian distress and the resultant suicides of the peasants even in regions of green revolution such as Punjab, Haryana, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, etc. AR Vasavi (1999), analysing the phenomenon of suicides among the peasants, has identified certain general trends and factors. She rightly points out that the promotion of commercial agriculture based on the utilization of hybrid seeds, chemical manures and pesticides, in a predominantly semi-arid region, has had several repercussions. As a whole, there is a lack of compatibility between the ecological specificity of the region and commercial agricultural practices. Climatic changes, especially changes in the rainfall pattern compound the conditions of uncertainty and risk in agriculture subjecting agriculture to an ecological crisis.

Along with the ecological crisis the economic crisis worsen the situation further. Though commercial agriculture is promoted on the basis of utilization of external inputs, institutional credit facilities to purchase these inputs are available to a limited number of agriculturists (mostly large landowners). Most agriculturists incur heavy debts in order to engage in commercial agriculture. Small and marginal cultivators for whom institutional credit is not readily or easily available resort to non-institutional debts at higher rates of interest in order to take to modern cultivation or to remain in cultivation. The local moneylenders *andsahukars* are the mostly easily available sources of credit who thrive on usury. In times of ecological crisis such as an outbreak of pests or diseases, such peasants incur more debts.

The introduction of commercial agriculture in a predominantly dry agriculture belt has its impact on the social fabric. This type of agriculture no longer draws on the established principles of local or indigenous knowledge and caste and kin based ties. The agri-business agents and agencies along with the agriculture-extension workers enter the scene at the cost of the traditional institutions of dissemination of knowledge. They are not always congenial to the interests of the hapless peasantry.

Sharp fluctuations in prices as part of market economy, compounds the problem. Increased cost of production without assured procurement or support prices from the government agencies push the cultivators into a corner. Cultivators also complain of the large-scale dilution of pesticides and lack of guarantee of many commercial seed varieties. The loss of crops for two successive seasons has been devastating. Under such conditions of changing agricultural practices, minimal state and administrative support, increasing subordination to market forces, high risks in agriculture and declining community support, it is not hard to imagine the personal distress that cultivators experience. The subordination of cultivators to market and capital forces without any safety net to support them in times of crop loss or radically fluctuating prices beyond their control accounts for the devastation and pauperisation of small farmers. Just as the suicides are symptoms of pervasive distress in the region, the loss of staple food grains in the region must also be considered to be a serious issue. As Susan George (1985) says, the loss of staple grains in any specific region without a substantial alternative economic base indicates a threat to the food security and hence the fragility of the local communities. Thus the phenomenon of suicides is directly related with the economic factors as part of market economy. ■

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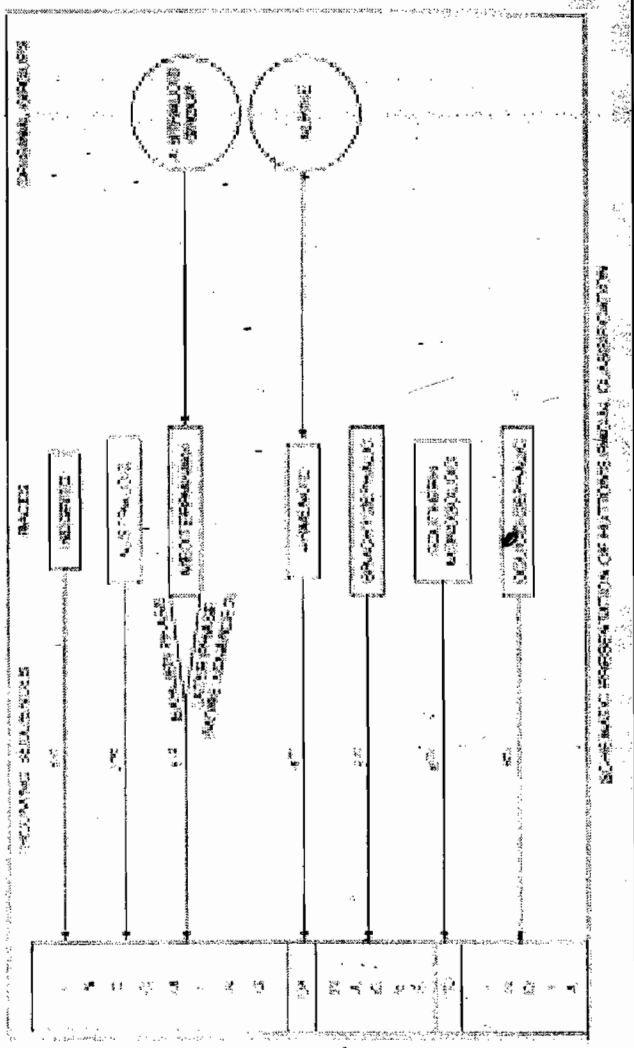
BIOGENETIC ELEMENTS OF INDIAN POPULATION

According to D.N. Majumdar "If a group of people who by their possession of a number of common physical traits can be distinguished from others, even if the members of this biological group are widely scattered, they form a race".

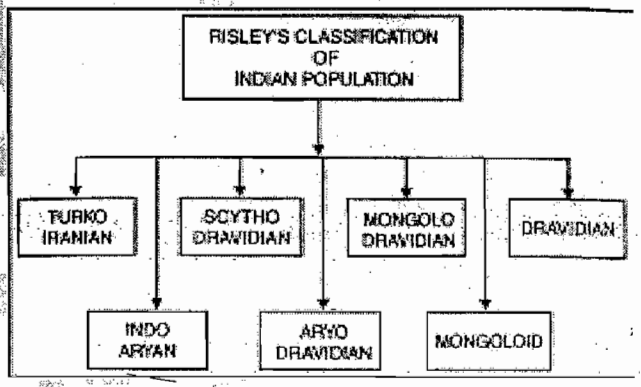
A.L. Krober defined race as, "A race is a valid biological concept. It is a group united by heredity, a breed or genetic strain or sub-species."

CLASSIFICATION OF J.H. HUTTON

Hutton describes that probably the earliest occupants of Indian were Negritos. Then next entered the Australoid race. Proto-Australoid or the pre-Dravidian race he believes that, is the outcome of Australoid race. The Mediterranian race came after Australoids. First entered the earlier batch of Mediterranian and then another batch from the same race entered India. The later batch was more advanced than the earlier. Hutton believes that the later batch of Mediterranian was related with Indus valley civilisation.



The Mediterranian race was followed by the Armenoids. Armenoids are from Alpine race. They also developed a high degree of civilisation. Then from the Western side and from the Eastern side two different races entered into India. The Brachycephalic race from the West and Southern Mongoloids from the East. Then entered the dolico-cephalic branch of Indo-Aryan race who were followed by a number of other races.



RISLEY'S CLASSIFICATION

Sir Harbert Risley has classified Indian population into seven categories.

(a) Turko Iranian
(b) Indo Aryan
(c) Scytho Dravidian
(d) Aryo Dravidian
(e) Mongolo-Dravidian
(f) Mongoloid
(g) Dravidian

(a) **Turko Iranian**: These people are mainly found in Afghanistan and Beluchistan. These two places are now in Pakistan.

(b) **Indo-Aryan** : This type of race is mainly concentrated in Punjab, Rajsthan and Kashmir. Rajput, Khatri and Jat are coming under this category.

(c) **Scytho-Dravidian** : This race is the combination of scythians and Dravidians. They are found in Saurastra, Coorg and in Madhya Pradesh. The upper strata people are coming under scythian and lower strata people are included under Dravidian.

(d) **Arya-Dravidian** : It is the mixture of two races : Indo-Aryan and the Dravidian. They are mainly concentrated in U.P. and Bihar. Brahmins and other high caste people are included under Aryan whereas Harijans and other lower caste people are included under Dravidian category.

(e) **Mongolo-Dravidian**: This race is the mixture of Dravidian and Mongolian races. They mainly live in West Bengal

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and Orissa. Brahmins and Kshatriyas of these are included under this category.

(f) **Mongoloid :** The tribal people of Assam and North-East frontier, are included under this race.

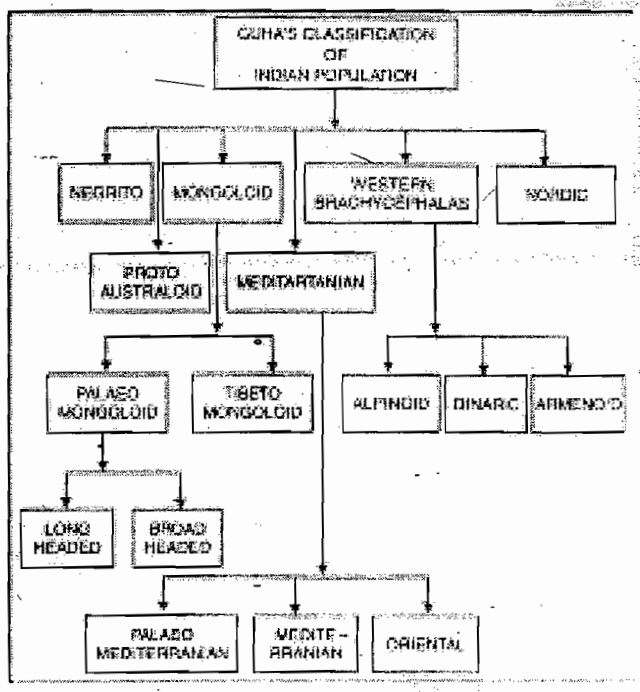
(g) **Dravidian** : People of this race is mainly concentrated in South India and Madhya Pradesh.

However, there are two main criticisms of Risley's classification of race.

1. He remained silent about the presence of Negrito race in India.
2. D.N. Madumdar says that this classification speaks more about linguistic division rather than racial division.

CLASSIFICATION OF B.S. GUHA

B.S. Guha analysed different types of classifications and has classified Indian population into six categories.



(i) The Negrito
(ii) The Proto-Australoid
(iii) The Mongoloid
(iv) The Mediterranean
(v) The Western Brachycephals
(vi) The Nordic

(i) **The Negritos :** They are found in the Andaman Island and in the North Eastern frontier. The people are Nagas, Radars, people of Rajmahal hills in Bihar. They are dark in complexion and have frizzly hair and thick lips.

(ii) **The Proto-Australoid** : The tribal people of India belong to this race. They are Mundas, the Santals, the Savras, the Paraja, the Khonda etc. They are mainly found in Bihar, Singhbhum and hilly track of Vindhya region.

(iii) **The Mongoloids :** They are found in North-Eastern region. They are of two types

(a) Palaeo-Mongoloid

(b) Tibeto-Mongoloid

(a) The Mongoloid : is divided into two sub-groups Long headed type and Broad headed type. The long headed type of the Palaeo-mongoloid people are found among the Angami Nagas. The broad headed type of Paleo-mongoloid people are found among the Assamese, Kashmiris and people who are living around Himalayan region.

(b) Tibeto-Mongoloid : People of Sikkim and Bhutan are included under this category.

(iv) **The Mediterranian :** It is one of the important race in India. There are three sub-divisions in mediterranian race

1. Palaeo Mediterranian
2. Mediterranian
3. Oriental

1. **Palaeo-mediterranian :** This race is mainly concentrated in Andhra Pradesh and TamilNadu. The Brahmins of both the places belong to this category.
2. **Mediterranian** : The people of this category are scattered almost all over India. It is belived that they planned Indus valley civilisation.
3. **Oriental** : It is just like mediterranian race. Though Mediterranian race is found all over India, but main concentration is in South India.

(v) **The Western Brachycephals** : From the Western side the people of this race entered India. There are three divisions of this race :

1. **Alpinoid:** The people of Saurastra, Gujarat and West Bengal are/injcfuded under this category.
2. **Dinaric :** People of Orissa, West Bengal and Coorg are included in this type.
3. **Armenoid :** Parsees of Mumbai are included in this category.

(vi) **Nordic**: This race entered India from northern side. So, this race is mainly found in Northern India, mainly in Punjab. It is believed that they contributed new ideas on art and culture of India.

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LINGUISTIC ELEMENTS OF INDIAN POPULATION

George Grierson in his writing "Linguistic Survey of India" found that India has more than 175 languages and more than 500 dialects. Majority of languages are spoken in Northern part of India. All the Indian languages have been classified into different linguistic families. They are not equally distributed all over India.

All these Indian languages can be grouped under four different families : 1. The Indo-Aryan 2. The Dravidian 3. The Austric 4. The Sino-Tibetan

1. **The Indo - Aryan :** A number of languages and dialects are coming under Indo-Aryan spech family. Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, Assamese, Bengali, Oriya, Gujarati, Marathi and Kashmiri languages are included under this group. Hindi is the most important language of all the languages. Majority of Indians use Hindi as their language. It is also recognised as the national language by our Constitution. The written form of Hindi is Devnagari. Urdu language is used by the people who are living in and around Delhi. They use Persian script for writing. Urdu has similarity with Hindi in spoken form but differs in script. Assam people use Assarhes language. Bengali is used by the people of West Bengal. Oriya is the mother tongues of Orissa. Gujrati is spoken by the people of Gujarat and Marathi by the people-Maharastra. Kashmiri is spoken by the people of Kashmir.
2. **Dravidian language :** It includes four languages, i.e., Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam. Telugu is the language of Andra Pradesh. Tamil is used by the people of Tamil Nadu. Kannad and Mulayalam are used by Karnatak and Kerala.
3. **Austric languages :** Most of the languages and dialects used by the different tribal groups of Central India like Santal, Munda, Oraon, Ho, Birhor, Kharia etc. come under this group.
4. **Sino-Tibetan languages :** The languages and dialects which are used by the North-Eastern tribal people like Aka, Dafla, Padam, Rangma Naga, Angami Naga etc., coming under Sino-Tibetan language group. ■

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STATUS OF TRIBAL WOMEN

The status of any social group is determined importantly by its levels of health-nutrition, literacy-education and employment-income. The tribal women, constitute as in any other social group, about half of the total population. However, the importance of women in the tribal society is more important than in other social groups in India, because of the fact that the tribal women, more than woman in any other social group, works harder and the family economy and management depends on her.

The well-being of the tribal community, as that of any other community, depends importantly on the status of their women. The popular image and perception of the tribal women is that of being better off than their non-tribal counterparts. There is no child marriage, no stigma on widowhood. She enjoys the right to decide about her marriage, etc. Instead of dowry there is bride price indicating high social status of the tribal woman. A tribal woman can divorce and remarry easily. She earns and is, therefore, to a great extent economically independent.

A higher social status of women was reported by many studies. However, there are many facts which indicates a low status for the tribal woman. For example, she does not have property rights except in a matrilineal society which is a small proportion of the tribal population. She is paid less as wages than her male counterpart for the same work. Several taboos discriminating against tribal women exist in certain tribal groups implying impurity and low status. The tribal women cannot hold the office of a priest. There are taboos related to menstruation as in non-tribal communities. The Kharia women, cannot touch a plough nor can she participate in roofing of *a* house. The Oraon women is also prevented from touching a plough. The Todas of Nilgiri Hills do not touch a menstruating women for fear of destruction of harvest. In certain tribes only the males can participate in ancestor worship. The Toda and Kota women in southern India cannot cross the threshold of a temple. The Santal women cannot attend communal worship.

The development projects have adversely affected the tribal women. With deforestation they have to travel a longer distance to gather forest products. Incidentally this has been one of the reasons for the participation of tribal women in Chipko movement to save the tribal the trees. There are evidences of sexual exploitation of tribal women by forest and mining contractors. The incidence of sexual assualts on tribal women have increased.

There are a large number of studies on tribal communities but only a few are focussed on tribal women. Reviewing the studies of tribal women, K.S. Singh has concluded that there is "need for generating studies which can fill the information gap about variations that exist and about the role and status of tribal women from one region to another and one community to another". Singh has also reiterated that there are material on tribals in general but the existing literature specifically on tribal women is limited. Health statistics also give an overall picture and data on gender differentiation of longevity, level of health, extent of mortality, infant mortality, nutrition, etc. are not available. Emphasising the need, for base-line data on at least certain basic parameters relating to tribal women, he status that data on various tribes are needed as they differ from one another.

The United Nations has declared 1993 as the International Year of the Indigenour Poeples, the Government of India has not signed the ILO Convention 169 of 1989 and has not accepted that the tribals in Indian are the Indigenous Peoples to the tribals of India have been discussed by K.S. Singh and B.K. Roy Burman in Status of the Tribals in India. Notwithstanding the political difficulties in the definition of the Indigenous Peoples, there is not doubt that the tribals are among the earliest settlers in India if not the original settlers. The Hindi word Adivasi, literally means the first habitants. The UN International Year of the Indigenous Peoples is an appropriate occasion to review the Status of the Tribals of India and also the Status of the Tribal Women.

HEALTH STATUS

Efforts have been made to collect available literature on the health studies among different tribal women in the light of several parameters i.e. Sex ratio, female literacy, marriage practices, age at marriage, fertility, mortality, life expectancy at birth, nutritional status and health, child bearing and maternal mortality, maternal and child health care practices, family welfare programme, sexually transmitted diseases and genetic disorders. It may, however, be mentioned that health related found to be limited, most of the available population found to be limited, most of the available studies fragmentary in nature without an adequate sample size and standard methodology. The present author has carried out comprehensive health related has carried out comprehensive health related studies among different , tribal groups namely Muria, Maria, Bhattra, Halba of Bastar district, Madhya Pradesh, Jaunsaris of Jaunsar Bawar, Dehradun district, Uttar Pradesh, Kutia-kondhs of Phulbani district, Orissa, Santals of Mayurbhanj district, Orissa and Dudh Kharies of Sundergarh district, Orissa and Dudh Kharis of Sundergarh district, Orissa. The research findings of all the available studies are discussed in the context of the following parameters:

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SEX RATIO

Sex ratio (females per thousand males) measure the balance between males and females in human population. Large imbalances in this aspect affect the social, economic and community life in many ways. In a population closed to migration, the sex ratio is an indicator of the sex differential in mortality. A higher or lower sex ratio reflect the status of the socio-cultural, maternal and child health care prog -amines existing in the population.

The sex composition of the population in India is found to be favorable to males. Female disadvantage in mortality attributed as the cause for the low sex ratio (F/ M over the last 30 year i.e. 941 (1961), 930 (1971), 935 (1981), 927 (1991). As compared to the general population, there appears to be a more even distribution of males and females among the Scheduled Tribes i.e. 987 (1961), 982 (1971), 983 (1981), 972 (1991). This suggest that the females in the tribal society are not neglected; the social and cultural values protected their interest. However, it may he pointed out that their sex ratio (972) in 1991 census shows a definite decline when compared to the 1981 census figure of 983.

The sex ratio of the Scheduled Tribes varied within the country i.e. among the States it was highest in Orissa (1002) and lowest in Uttar Pradesh/Sikkim (914); among the Union Territories, it was highest in Dadra and nagar Haveli (1022) and lowest in Daman and Diu (931). The sex ratio of the Scheduled Tribes in India was found to be near even in Arunachal Pradesh (998), Meghalaya (997), and Kerala (996). While conducting health related studies among the individual tribal population groups, the sex-ratio- was found to exhibit a variable picture. Kutia Kondhs, a primitive tribal group of Phulbani district, Orissa, had a low sex ratio of 920 females per thousand males as compared to the Scheduled Tribes of India (972). This indicated a preponderance of female deaths among the Kutia Kondhs. One of the ascribed social reasons for this sex difference was the utter neglect and apathy towards proper rearing of the female and apathy towards proper rearing of the female children among them.

A still lower sex ratio, i.e. 103 females per thousand males, was observed among the Jaunsaries Bavvar, Chakrata tehsil, Dehradun district, Uttar Pradesh. It seemed quite logical as the Jaunsaries were known to be a polyandrous tribal group. Higher sex ratio indicating a comparatively better health status indicating a comparatively better health status among the tribal women of Dhudh Kharies of Sundergarh district, Orissa (1098 females/1000 males) and Santals of Mayurbhanj district, Orissa (1019 females per 1000 males) were found during investigations. These sex ratio were much higher compared to the India's general population (927/1000) and the Scheduled Tribes (972/1000) in 1991. Datta while conducting demographic investigations among the Kora tribal the sex ratio to be 882 females per 1000 males which was quite low compared to the all India Scheduled Tribal figure of 972.

FEMALE LITERACY

Literacy is universally recognised as a powerful instrument of social change. The level of literacy is undoubtedly one of the most important indicators of social, cultural and health development among the tribal communities. Literacy is important for the young girl; it had correlations with the survival of her children. Infant mortality is found to decrease significantly when the mother is educated upto the primary level and above. The Indian tribes have been exposed to literacy only recently.

By and large, their response to programmes of literacy and of formal education varied significantly between tribes and from region. These responses depended on their socio-cultural, economic and demographic characteristics and on the magnitude and direction of the forces of modernisation, such as urbanisation and industrialisation. The influence of Christianity in some tribal areas had also played a significant role.

The census recognised an individual as literate if one could both read and write with understanding in any of the languages. According to the 1991 census data, excluding Assam, Jammu and Kashmir, the literacy rate among the general population aged 7 years and above was found to be 52.19 (64.20 for males and 39.19 for females). Literacy among the tribals was found to be very low i.e. 25.9 percent and especially so among he tribal females (14.5 percent).

Most of the literates among the Scheduled Tribes were literate only upto the primary level. Within the country, the level of literacy among the tribals' varied widely. At one end were tribal communities like the Malapan daram, Suhang etc. in the South'with hardly any literates among them, whereas on the other end, there were communities like Lushai in North-East Himalaya with more than 40 percent literacy.

The lowest level of literacy among the tribals was recorded in Andhra pradesh [14.5 percent] and the highest in Mizoram[80.0 percent]. The lowest level of literacy among the females was found in Rajasthan [4.1 percent]. Among the territories. The highest literacy among tribals was observed in Lakshadweep [79.1percent]. Studies on some individual tribes revealed the following trends of literacy :

Low litracy rate [3.3 percent] was observed among the primitive Abhujmaria tribe of Bastar district, Madhya Pradesh. The educational status among the Santal tribe of Mayurbhanj district, Orissa showed marked sexual differentials.51.6 percent males were found to be literate against 19.4 percent females. A similar literacy trend was observed among the polyandrous Jaunsaris of JAUNSAR Bawar, Dehradunn, i.e. 45.79 percent literate among the males and 15.26 percent literate among females. Kora females of Midnapur district, West Bengal had a very low literacy level [2.66 percent].

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The female literacy rate among the Dudh Khana tribal group of Sundargarh district, Orissa was found to be much higher, i.e., 41 percent as compared to that of the Scheduled Tribe females (14.5 percent).

Literacy among the tribals of the North-Eastern region could be due to the influence of Christianity. Literacy among tribals in general had improved slightly over time. Marked improvement over 1981 was notices in some of the States of North-Eastern, Western and island regions. In other, specially in the Eastern and Central regions and in some of the States of other regions, improvement in literacy level was still lagging behind.

MARRIAGE PRACTICES

The cultural norms that particularly affect women's health are attitudes towards marriage, marriage practices, age at marriage, values attached to fertility and sex of the child, pattern of family organisation, her status in the society, decision making capability and ideal role demanded of women by social and cultural conventions. All these determine her place in the family, her access to medical care, education, nutrition and other health resources.

India is characterised by the presence of a large number of endogamous casts, tribes and religious communities with different types of marriage practices. The pattern of marriages in India is largely government by three important regulation, namely a) Endogamy (marrying within the group of birth b) Exogamy (marrying out) and c) consanguineous or sapinda marriage. The regulation of consanguineous marriages does not permit marriages between two individual related though a common male ancestor upto the seventh generation on the father's side and the fifth, there is a greater incidence of consanguineous marriages specially among the population of the southern States, Muslim groups, Parsees and various tribal communities.

In many tribal communities, cross-cousin marriages were preferred and practiced. The system of cross cousin marriage had proved to be beneficial to the females in terms of care and treatment at husband's place. It also avoided high bride price/ dowry and maintained the property of the household. Consanguineous marriages may, however, result in an increased probability of abortions, miscarriage, still births, neo-natal deaths, infant and juvenile deaths physical and mental defects susceptibility to infections diseases etc.

In Himalayan region, some of the tribes like Naga, Lusia etc. practiced polygamy which was for econcmic reasons to protect the property and get help in agricultural activities. On the other hand, some of the tribes in India practised polyandry because of less number of women available for marriage, e.g. Jaunsaris of Jaunsar-Bawar, Chakrata tehsil, Dehradun, Todas of Nilgiri hills. Formerly the Todas practised female infanticide which resulted in less number of girls available for marriage.

The age at which the girl was given in marriage depened on social values. Among the tribals, virginity was not very much valued. Many of the tribal societies were lax towards pre-marital sex relations which were considered as a training in the art of love and sex life and often ended in marriage.

Girls in tribal societies were given in marriage generally after puberty. According to 1971 census at the national level, the age at marriage for tribal women was higher (16.39) than that of the rural women in general (15.39). The mean age at marriage of the tribal females in Assam, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Kerala, Manipur, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Arunachal Pradesh was more than 18 years, the highest being in Nagaland (21.33). On the other hand, it was less than 15 years in Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, the lowest being in Uttar Pradesh (14.50).

There were a few micro-level studies which dealt with the age at marriage of individual tribes e.g. female age at marriage - Ao Naga (16-20 years), Bhil (16 yrs.), Chenchu after puberty, Khasi (13-18 yrs.), Koli 12-16 yrs.), Bodh (19 yrs.), Gond (18 yrs.), Munda (18 yrs.), Oraon (16 yrs.). Mean age at marriage of Jaunsads was 12.2 yrs., Dudh Kharias 21.41 yrs., and Santhals 17.87 yrs.

Jaunsaris of Jaunsar-Bawar, Debradun were a polyandrous tribe and they followed the custom of child marriage as a part of their cultural behaviour which was s*;ill prevalent among them. Investigation showed that 33.83 percent of the Jaunsari females got married, before or at 8 yrs, 29.70 percent in the age group 9-15 yrs, 30.33 percent in the age group 15-20 years and the remaining 5.6 percent got married above the age of 20 yrs.

In the North-Eastern region, the age at marriage was found to be relatively high whereas it was relatively low in the central region because of the influence of Hindu culture. It was further observed from research investigations that the frequency of abortions, miscarriages, and still-births were found to be much higher in younger mothers below the age of 19 years. The major life threatening complications for very young mothers were pregnancy induced high blood pressure, anaemia and difficulty in delivery due to disproportion between the pelvic-size and the head of the baby.

FERTILITY AND MORTALITY

Studies on fertility and mortality trends among the tribal population of India have been found to he fragmentary and isolated. Limited studies are available on infant mortality and hardly any study is available on maternal mortality among the tribal population. However, a brief review of the available studies are discussed zonewise.

I. *North-Enst Zone (Arunachal, Assam, Megbalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim and Tripura)*

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A few studies on fertility and mortality of individual tribes besides two studies on tribes in general were available from North-East zone. On the basis of the census data, Gogoi found that during 1961-71, the rate of growth of tribal population in North- East India was lower than that of the general population. This was mainly because of a very low natural growth rate of the tribal population in the region.

Pandey observed high fertility and mortality in Mishmi tribal groups and attributed itto the low level of education and income lack of knowledge of family planning method and importance of small family size poor medical facilities, lack of proper sanitation and drinking water.

Barua studied 196 everpregnat women belonging to the Hajong tribe of West Garo hills district of Meghalaya. High infant mortality [18.2%] and prenatal moratality [3.1 %] were reported among them.

Das studied two Lepcha village of northern Sikkim namely Lachen and Lachung and found th^ tooal fertility rate for Lachung and Lachen to be 4.66 and 3.79 respectively. The results on total fertility rate were more or lets similar to the Indian national population.

Differences between the two were possibly due to the socio-culrural factors. The number of surviving children per women in Lachung and Lachen were found to be 3.70 and 2.65 respectively. The net reproductive index was observed to be 3.6 in Lachung and 1.80 in Lachan.

II. *Northern Zone (Himalayan belt of Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Darjeeling district of West Bengal)*

This zone has been better investigated and about 10 studies on individual tribes were available. Prakask and Malik showed that high altitude Bods had higher fertility than the low altitude Bods. They also had higher mean number of children (4.11 per mother) as compared to the low altitude Bods (3.63 per mother). The altitudinal differences in fertility have been explained in terms of socio-cultural factors such as education, awareness, urban contact, advancement in medical facilities which were higher at low altitude. The differences have also been accorded to a stronger feeling in the altitude population that children were economic assets.

Kurnar and Mitra observed high infant mortality and fertility among 199 Tharu tribal women of Naintal. DC spite the availability of modern facilities of treatment, Tharus had their own beliefs and concepts of diseases.

Saxena in his study conducted among.the Tharu and Buksa tribes of Uttar Pradesh reported that the Tharu and Buksa couples displayed a high level of fertility which was well reflected in the tendency to achieve higher order births even at younger ages.

Basu, et al. while conducting research investigation on 481 households among the Jaunsaris of Jaunsar Bawar, Dehradum found a crude birth rate of 42.67 per thousand population and infant mortality rate of 79.64 per thousand live births. Polyandry and polygamy were found to co-exist in the study sample. A. Basu found that Lepchas ate fish and a type of tuber viz. Diascoria, while Sherpas did not eat them. It was observed that diasoria 'had a fecundity-inhibiting function resulting in lower fertility among Lepchas as against Sherpas though both shared a similar physical environment.

III. *Central zone (West-Bengal except Darjeeling district, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Eastern Maharashtrn, Orissa and some parts of Andhra pradesh)*

This zone has been investigated quite in depth and mortality were available. Datta reported from her study that Koras, a Scheduled Tribe of Midnapur, West Bengal had a mean of 3.30 surviving children in their completed age of fertility. She found the crude birth rate and total fertility rate to be 41.81 per 1000 population and 4.42 per 1000 Kora v/omen respectively. These values were relatively higher than the national figures for these measures. However, these values were in agreement with most of the tribal groups in India.

Study among the Toto tribes of West-Bengal conducted by the Demographic Research unit of the Indian Statistical Institute, Calcutta revealed the average number of children born to women married for 20 years and over to be 6.9.

Ray & Roth studied the fertility pattern of Jua ngs of Orissa. It was observed that the marital age specific fertility rate was highest (0.336%) among mothers in the 20-24 year age group whereas it was lowest (0.44%) among the 45-49 year age group. The total marital age-specific fertility rate was 1.157 among the Juang mothers. It was also observed that the Index of Overall Fertility and the Index of Marital Fertility among the Juangs were 0.49 and 0.50 respectively.

Basu and Jindal made an indepth study of a primitive tribal group i.e. Kuttiya Kondhs of Tumdibandha block of Phulbani district, Orissa. The average age at menarche among Kutriyas was found to be 14.5 years. It was observed that the average number of pregnancies per mother was 5.09 and 3.89 respectively among mothers of completed and incomplete reproductive life cycles.

Infant mortality was found to he very high i.e. 179.75/1000. The fertility record of Kuttiya Kondh mothers in various age groups indicated a total fertility of 5.0 estimated from the average fertility of the women in the group 45-49.

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Basu and Kshatriya studied the fertility and mortality trends among the Dudh. Kharia of Sunderagarh district Orissa. They reported that the estimated total fertility, crude birth rate, crude death rate and infant mortality rate were 5.39, 38.5, 11.80 and 102.4 respectively. All these demographic showed higher values than the Indian national population level according to the 1981 census these were similar to these of the other Indian tribal populations.

Ch. Satish Kumar reported that the average pregnancies per mother and infant mortality rate among the Desia Kondhs of Orissa were 3.89 and 151.28 respectively.

Khan while investigating the Dongria Kondhs of Orissa found average pregnancies per mother and the infant mortality rate as 4.07 and 153.11 respectively.

Choudhary and Kumar estimated the birth rate as 43.5/1000 among the Bhils of Jhabua district of Madhya Pradesh.

Sharma & Khan observed that the average fertility rate among Kharwars of Sarguja district (M.P.) was 4.85. The highest reproductive wastage (9.67%) was observed in the age group of 40-44 years and the pre-reproductive mortality was highest (6.84%) among mothers in age group 35-39 years.

Basu and Kshatriya reported the fertility and mortality estimates on the basis of demographic analysis of genealogical data collected from 792 households of the four tribal populations, namely Muria, Maria, Bhattras and Halba from Bastar district of Madhya Pradesh. The results of the study indicated that total fertility rates were 5.64, 6.00, 5.95 and 5.89 respectively for the four groups which were higher than the Madhya Pradesh rural non-tribal population and Indian national population and was in accodance with high fertility levels among the tribal. The study groups showed higher mortality among males than females. A very high rate of infant mortality was observed among Bhattras (148.56) followed by Murias (123.25) whereas Marias (85.44) and Halbas (92.78) from the same area displayed lower IMR.

IV. *Western zone (Western Maliarashtra, Gujarnt, Rajasthan, Dadra, Nagar & Haveli, Goa, Daman & Din)*

Very few tribal studies on fertility and mortality aspects were available in this zone. Most studies showed the general trend of fertility and mortality among the tribes.

Parsuraman and Rajan discussed the estimation of vital rates among the scheduled tribes in Western India. Avery high proportion of 0-14 population to the total population indicated a higher level of fertility and not so high mortality.

Parsuraman and Rajan reported that there were significant differences in death rates among the tribal population in different States. It was high in Maharashtra followed by Gujarat.

Sinha reviewed the fertility the fertility of tribal groups of Gujarat, M.P., Maharashtra and Rajasthan and found the General marital fertility rate to be 169.4 births/ 1000 females against 152.9 births/ 1000 females.

V. *Southern zone [Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu]*

The study of demographic and health determinants of infant deaths by Gurumurthy et al among the Sugali tribal group in the Kalyanadurgam and Beluguppa blocks of Ananthapur district of Andhra Pradesh pointed out that out of 348 infant deaths 45.4 percent were neonatal and 54.6 per cent were post neonatal. About 25 percent infant deaths occurred due to dysentry/diarrhoea and 20 percent due to maternal factors such as prematurity, birth injury/ multiple birth, low birth weight, birth asphyxia and so on.

The study of Sirajuddin among the Chenchu tribal group of Achampet taluk of Andhra Pradesh found that the average number of children for each women Average number of surviving offspring per married women and mortality in relation to live births were 3.67, 2.96 and 27.5 respectively.

Murty and Ramesh also found a high fertility and mortality among the Pardhans of Adilabad district.

M.P. Basu conducted a demographic research work among the Irular of Tamil Nadu and reported the net reproductive index which was also an indication of their fertility as 1.31. It was also reported that mortality according to the age of the child was highest in the first year.

Ghosh while studying the Kota tribe of Nilgiri hills, Madras found the average number of live births per women aged 40 years or more to be 3.73. Also the frequency or mortality before reproductive age i.e., 15 year was 30.8%. This also revealed a high mortality and fertility among the Kota tribe.

Murty investigated the Solige tribe in Karnataka in order to find out their fertility behaviour. The Crude Birth Rate (CBR), General Fertility Rate (GFR) and Total Fertility Rate (TFR) among the Soligas were found to be always higher in comparison to the general population of Karnataka. The unusual high fertility rate among the Soligas was influenced by their age at marriage which was ultimately influenced by the age at menarche. The mean age of menarche among the Soligas was 13.2 years and the age of marriage was 14.2 years which was very early. Eai ly age of marriage, and low levels of family

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planning acceptance seemed to be responsible for the high fertility among the Soligas. The completed family size among the Soligas was 5.64.

VI. *Island region (Andaman and Nicobar Islands)*

Aggarwal found that among 45 ever married Onge \vomen of the Andaman Islands, the mean number of children was 1.64 and the mean number of children per women was 1.13. Infant mortality was very high as revealed from the reproductive index which was 0.51.

LIFE EXPECTANCY

A general indicator of the health of girl and women is their life expectancy. The expectation of life is the average number of years remaining to be lived by those surviving to that age. The expectation of life at birth is the life table function most frequently used as an index of the level. It also represents a summarisation of the whole series of mortality rates for all ages combined as weighted by the life table stationary population. In those countries where mortality was higher, and where infant and child mortality in particular were high, the maximum expectation of life was at a more advanced age (4 or sometimes 5 years) and a child of 10 years of age had an expectation of life often close to that of the new born infant. Expectation of life was the index most often used when one wished to summarise the risk of mortality in a country.

Basu and Kshatriya while studying the Bastar tribal groups of Madhya Pradesh estimated the average life expectancy at birth based on q5 values for Muria (Males 37.56 yrs. Females 40.07) Maria (Males 40.26 years, females 45.30 yrs.) and Halba (Males 38.6 yrs and females 41.46 yrs.) tribes and 41.1 years for all the four tribal group combined. Although these figure were comparable to the rural non-tribal population of Madhya Pradesh, they were far below the average life expectancy at birth of 58.6 yrs. For the Indian population. Sex specific mortality differentials were observed with males experiencing highest moitality than females. The differences could only be attributed to the prevailing socio-economic, cultural and health care practices of the four tribal groups.

Chettlapalli et al. studied in depth a primitive tribal group i.e. Kuttiya Kondhs of Tumdibandha block of Phulbani district,. Orissa nd found the average life expertancy at bir.th'based on q5 values for Kuttiya males to be 46.49 years and for Kutia females to be 41.93 years.

Unlike the Bastar tribal group, Kuttia female life expectancy was found -to be -lower than males females. Datta while conducting demographic investigation among the Kora tribal the expectation of life at birth to be 33.87 years and 29.70 years for males and females respectively. The expectation of life when computed at age 10 for Kora males and females, however, was found to be 38.52 years and 35.13 years respectively. Social scientists ascribed physiological stress while others viewed biological factors as trie main cause of the difference in the mortality levels between the two sexes.

Basu and Kshatriya studied demographic features and health care practices in Dudh Kharia tribal population of Sundergarh district Orissa. Using q5 values to estimate the overage life expectancy, it was observed that the kharia females showed a higher life expectancy (52.95 yrs) as compared to the males (51.02 yrs). Sex retio of Dudh Kharias (1101/1000) lent further support to the-above observation. The general life style of Dudh Kharias was found to be relatively better than most of the surrounding tribal groups.

NUTRITIONAL STATUS

The health and nutrition problems of the vast tribal population of India were as varied as the tribal groups themselves who presented a bewildering diversity and variety in their socio-economic, socio-cultural and ecological settings. The nutritional problems of different tribal communities located at various stages of development weie full of obscurities and very little scientific information on dietary habits and nutrition status was available due to lack of systematic and comprehensive research investigations. Malnutrition was common and greatly affected the ability to resist infection, led to chronic illness and in the post weaning period led to perr tanent brain impairment.

Good nutrition was a requirement throughout life and was vital to women in terms of their health and work. Nutritional anaemia was a major problem for women in India and more so in the rural and tribal belt. In developing countries, it was estimated that at least half of the non-pregnant and two thirds of the pregnant women were anaemic.

The situation was particularly serious in view of the fact that both rural and tribal women had a heavy work load and anaemia had a profound effect on their psychological and physical health. Anaemia lowered resistance to fatigue, affected working capacity under conditions of stress and increased susceptibility to other diseases.

Maternal malnutrition which was quite common among the tribal women was also a serious ftealth problem, especially for those having many pregnancies too closely spaces, and reflected the complex socio-economic factors that affected their overall situation.

The nutritional status of pregnant women directly influenced their reproductive performance and the birth is crucial to an infant's chances of survival and to its subsequent growth and development. Nutrition also affected location and breast feeding which were key elements in the health of infants and young children and a contributory factor in birth spacing. Scanning through available data, it was observed that among most of the tribal groups the staple

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diet was rice or minor millets except the Mompas of Assam who consumed wheat also. Birds, fish and other meat products were also consumed by the tribals occasionally.

Diet of not a single tribal in the different Status of India can be said to be sully satisfactory. Tribal diets were generally grossly deficient in Calcium, Vit.A, Vit.C, riboflavin and animal protein. Diets of South Indian tribes in general, and of Kerala in particular, were grossly difficient even in respect of calories and total protein. Studies carried out at the National Institute of Nutrition and Planning Commission of India (Sixth Five Year Plan, Government of India) reported a high protein calorie malnutrition along the rice-eating belts.

Studies available on the dietary status and health of the Bihar and Maharashtra found deficiency calorie as well as protein and essential amino acids in their diets though major signs of nutritional deficiencies were not observed. Surveys on the nutritional deficiencies among the tribals reported a high incidence of goitre, angular stomatitis among the Mompas of Assam and Vit. A deficiency among the Onges. A high incidence of malnutrition was observed in some primitive tribal groups in Phulbani, Koraput and Sundergarh districts of Orissa and also among Bhils and Garasia of Rajasthan, Padars, Rabris and Charans of Gujarat and Bondas of Orissa. Studies of tribal communities in Orissa conducted by Ali found that an ecological imbalance caused by rapid deforestation had resulted not only in depleting food resources, but in prolonged droughts, adding to hunger and starvation.

Studies carried out by NIHFW among the Gonds (Muria and Madia), Bhatras and Halba tribal group; of Bastar district, Madhya Pradesh showed the following trends.

a) The average protein calorie intake was found to be much less in the Gond children as compared to the Bbattra and Halba children.
b) Higher frequencies of Bitot's spot, angular stomatitis and mottling of teeth were found among the Gond children as compared to the Bhatra and Halba children.
c) Muscular wasting was noticed to be higher among the Gond children as compared to the Bhattra children.

Consumption of milk or milk or milk products were taboo in pre-school tribal children due to the fact that milking of cow was a taboo among these tribal groups. The nutrition and health problems faced by Kannikar tribal women of Trivandrum district, Kerala in normal and physiological conditions like pregnancy and lactation were studied. Pulses, milk and milk products and other animal foods which were the sources of protein were lacking in their diets.

Average calorie consumption was found to be below the recommended level for the normal, pregnant as well as lactating women. Consumption of calcium (in the form of tapioca and fish) was noticed to be highest in normal women whereas it was poorest in the lactating women. Similar deficits of calcium in the diets of pregnant and lactating tribal women of western and central India was reported by Gopaldas. The intake of iron and vitamin A were found to be low.

Detailed clinical examination of the Kannikar tribal women showed that anaemia (99 percent), vitamin A deficiency (30 percent) and niacin deficiency {10 percent) were prevalent among them. The morbidity status of the tribal women revealed the prevalence of pyrexia, respiratory complaints, gastro-intestinal diseases and rheumatic diseases. Among the" adult women gynecological complaints arid deficiency diseases were common.

FOREST AND WOMEN'S HEALTH

The forest based tribal economy in most parts of the word as women-centred. Women made provisions for the basic necessities like *food, fuel,* medicine, housing material etc. from the forest produce: Food was obtained from shifting cultivation and from minor produce (MFP) like flowers and fruits collected from the forest. Extraction from herbs, roots and animals were used for msdicine. All these efforts incurred an excessive workload on women. In a study on the Garos of Meghalaya, Kar calculated the ratio of male or female investment in labour in shifting cultivation,to be 100:136 days per year. The contribution of women was more in almost all activities like clearing (169:120), showing (102:60), weeding (272:182) and cotton harvesting (56:6).

Because of the extensive feeling of trees by vested of the extensive felling of trees by vested interests, the distances between the villages and the forest areas had increased forcing the tribal women to walk longer distances in search of minor forest produce and firewood. In this rapidly changing milieu, tribal women load. A study on the Kondhs revealed that women put in an average of 14 working hours per day as compared to 9 hours put in by men. Given this additional workload, even women in advanced stages of pregnancy were required to work in the agricultural fields or walk great distances to collect fuel and minor forest produce. The over strain on tribal women however, was not adequately compensated due to the non-availability of minor forest produce and decrease in food grain production.

A study among the Pauri Bhuniyas of Orissa showed that 52 women as against 17 men in a sample of 268 persons suffered from diseases related to malnutrition. As a result of deforestation, additional distance and less fertile soil, the availability of food for the tribal family was reduced. This had implications particularly for the housewife who was responsible for the provision and distribution of food, in cases of shortage, she even deprived herself of food in order to feed the others. Studies in this connection have shown that tribals in general were undernourished.

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To add to the malnutrition and additional workload, there was the destruction of traditional herbs through deforestation and the lack of access of the tribals to modern medicine. This, combined with the increasing ecological imbalance, resulted in diseases such as TB, stomach disorders and malaria.

CHILD BEARING

Childbearing imposed additional health needs and problems on women, physically, psychologically and socially. The complications of pregnancy and of childbirth and of illegally induced abortions in areas where environmental and health conditions were adverse resulted in large numbers of female deaths. In India the maternal mortality was around 500 per 100,00 live births, which was about 50 times that in a developed country or in the better off segments of the India society.

Poor nutritional status with its concomitant problems of poor body weight, poor weight gain during pregnancy, low haemoglobin levels, was one of the primary underlying causes of maternal mortality in India, more maternal deaths occurred in India in one week then in all of Europe in one year Generally malnourishment, poor medical facilities and unfavourable social conctitions were the major underlying causes for high maternal mortality in India. Nutritional anaemia, a serious problem in pregnancy, affected 50 percent of the women of childbearing age in South East Asia. The situation was all the more aggravated among women in the tribal belt of India because of the prevailing magic-religious and socio-cultural practices.

Maternal mortality was reported to be high among various tribal groups but no exact data could be collected. The main causes of maternal mortality were found to be unhygenic and primitive practices for parturition. For example, it was observed that among the Kutia Kondhs, the delivery was conducted by the mother herself in a half squatting position holding a rope tied down from the roof of the hut. This helped her in applying pressure to deliver the child. In complicated labour, obviously it might lead to maternal as well as child mortality. Similar crude births practices were found to exist in other tribal groups like the Kharias, Gonds, Santals, etc.

MATERNAL AND CHILD HEALTH CARE

Maternal and child health care practices were found to be largely neglected in various tribal group (i.e. Baster tribal groups, Kutia Kondhs of Orissa, Santals, jaunsaris, Kharias etc.) Expectant mothers to a large extent were not inoculated against tetanus. From the inceptior of pregnancy to its termination, no specific nutritious diet was consumed by women. On the ether hand, some pregnant tribal women (i.e. Dudh Kharias, Santals) reduced their food intake because of the fear of recurrent vomitting and also to ensure that the baby may remain small and the delivery may bi easier. The consumption of iron, calcium and vitamins during pregnancy was poor.

The habit of taking alcohol during pregnancy was found to be common among the tribal women and almost all of them continued their regular activities including hard labour even during advanced pregnancy. More than 90 percent of the deliveries were conducted at home attended by elderly ladies of the household. No specific precautions were observed at the time of conducting deliveries which resulted in an increased susceptibility to various infections. Services of paramedical staff were secured only in difficult labour cases.

Maternal mortality directly related to pregnancy and childbirth was found to be appreciably high among the tribal population groups of Bastar district. In addition, a lot of females suffered from ill health due to pregnancy and child-birth in the absence of a well defined concept of health consciousness. As far as child-care was concerned, both rural and tribal illiterate mothers were observed to breastfeed their babies. But, most of them adopted harmful practices like discarding of colostrum. Giving prelacteal feeds, delayed introduction of breast feeding and delayed introduction of complementary feeds. Vaccination and immunisation of infants and children were inadequate among tribal groups. In addition, extremes of magico- religious beliefs and taboos aggravated the problems.

FAMILY WELFARE PROGRAMME

While evaluating the impact of the family welfare programme on tribal women through a study of 300 tribal women of Tamian development block of Chiridwara district of Madhya Pradesh, it was observed that tribal women gave more attention to child welfare and child development programmes rather than mother care or family planning programmes. This may be because of their inherent maternal instinct and protectiveness towards their, children. They contacted doctors more for antenatal- care than 'postnatal care because of their concern with the welfare of the foetus in the womb and preparing for a safe labour. More than 90 percent of the eligible couples of Jaunsaris -arid-San tals were found to be aware of family planning' methods whereas only 16 percent Dudh Kharia couples were aware of family planning methods.

SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED DISEASES

Infections of the female genital tract were numerous and widespread. They constituted a laige part of grade morbidity among women. Contributing to a continuous and physically draining fatigue. These infection were closely related to

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inappropriate care or poor hygiene in connection with child birth abortion or menstruation. They included the sexually transmitted diseases which were most prevalent diseases in the tribal areas. These infection were often untreated as they were difficult to diagnose and would even lead to infertility. VDIR, a very sensitive test to diagnose if a person was suffering from syphilis or not was found to be positive in 17.12 percent cases (relative in dilution of 1.8 or more) of polyandrous Jaunsaris of Chakrata, Dehradun. Out of 17 percent, 9.92 percent was found among the Santals of Mayurbhanj district, Orissa, 8.90 percent cases (relatively in dilution of 1.8 or more) of VDRL were observed, out of which 4.99 percent were females and 3.91 percent were males.

The prevalence of STD was also reported to be high in the polyandrous Toda tribal group of Nilgiri hills. While conducting a morbidity study among the Kondha tribe of Phulbani district, Orissa, Swain, et al. fond syphilis (10 percent) in Desia Kondhs whereas it was not diagnosed among the primitive Kutia Kondh tribal group. The presence of sexually transmitted diseases was also reported from Andamanese, tribal groups of Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Mysore, Laccadive and Minicoy islands.

GENETIC DISORDERS

There were two genetic disorders namely sickle cell anaemia which were found to occur in rather high frequencies in Schedule Tribes and Scheduled Caste populations, both male and female were equally, affected in the case populations. Both male and female were equally affected in the case of sickle cell anemia whereas males were more affected than females in G-6-PD deficiency cases, both these genetic disorders had profound health implications in terms of morbidity for the affected persons.

Sickle cell disease (HbSS): This disease invalued a shortened life span of the red cell leading to severe and often fatal anaemia. The disease was further characterised by enlarged spleen, painful crisis, organ damage, impaired mental functions, increased susceptibility to infection and ultimately. The patients tended to have shorter trunk with long legs, chronic leg ulcers and an overall asthenic (weak) built.

The sickle cell disease was found in 72 district of Central, Western and Southern India. There were more than 35 tribal population groups showing a frequency of more than 19 percent. It was estimated that approximately a staggering 50 lakh individuals were carriers (heterozygotes) among the tribals. Prevalence rate upto 40 percent of heterozyous form (sickle cell trait) was reported in some tribes i.e. Adiyan of Kerala, Irula, Paniyan, Mulukurumbha of Nilgiri hills and Gonds of Rajpur.

Glucose-6-Pliosphate enzyme deficiency (G-6-PD): This was in important enzyme of the red blood cell and Its deficiency was inherited as an X-linked recessive trait. Males were strongly affected but expression in females varied greatly. This enzyme deficiency caused frequent hemolytic episodes by intake of commonly used drugs such as anti-malarials, anti-biotics, analgesics etc, and also by the ingestion of broad bean, "Vicia Fava". About 13 lakhs G-6-PD deficients were present in tribal population. The prevalence was specially high among the tribes and Scheduled Castes of Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Orissa, Assam, specially in hyperendemic malarial zones.

EDUCATIONAL STATUS

The low educational status of tribal women is reflected in their lower literacy rate, lower enrolment rate and higher dropouts in the school. The literacy rate of the tribal population as well as Scheduled Castes and general population for three decades (1961-1991) are given in table 1 and 2.

Table-1 : Literacy rates among General, Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe population

	General		Scheduled Caste		Scheduled Tribe	
	1981	1991	1981	1991	1981	1991
Total	36.23	52.21	21.38	30.06	16.35	23.63
Male	46.89	64.13	31.12	40.24	24.52	32.50
Female	24.82	39.29	10.93	19.03	8.04	14.50

Table 2. Literacy rates among Scheduled Tribes and General population, 1961-1991

	1961	1971	1981	1991
Tribal Male	13.04	17.09	24.52	32.50
Tribal Female	2.89	4.58	8.04	14.50
General Male	34.44	39.45	46.89	64.13
General Female	12.90	18.70	24.82	39.29
Rural Tribal Female	2.62	4.06	6.81	12.74
Rural General Female	8.42	13.08	17.96	30.62
Total Tribal	7.99	10.89	16.35	23.63

The following major trends can be seen from Tables 1 and 2:

- the literacy rate of tribals is lower than that of general as well as SC population.
- the literaey rate of the rural tribal female is the lowest of all groups.
- there is gender bias in the literacy of tribal population as in other groups, the female literacy being lower than the male literacy. Through there has been five-fold increase in the literacy of tribal females it still is much lower than the national average for the females (39.29).

The relative ratio of girls-tribal and non-tribal-enrolled for every 100 boys is given in Table 3. The data relates to

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four years: 1965-66,1970-71,1975-76,1980-81). Though the enrolment ratio for girls has been increasing in both the tribal and non-tribal groups, the ratio for tribal girls is much lower than that for non-tribals at all given periods of time in classes I-V as well as classes VI-VIII.

Table 3: Relative Enrolment Ratios of girls per 100 boys for tribals and non-tribals

Year	Classes I-V		Classes VI- VIII	
	ST	Non-ST	ST	Non-ST
1965-66	38.6	57.9	27.3	37.3
1970-71	41.2	60.7	31.5	41.6
1975-76	45.9	62.5	37.2	46.2
1980-81	48.7	64.2	38.2	49.9

The drop-out rates for classes I-V,I-VIII and I-X for boys and girls are given for tribal and non-tribal population in Table 4. It can be seen from, the Table that the drop-out rates for tribals are higher than those for the non-tribals at all three levels of schooling. The drop-out rates for girls are higher than those for boys in.'tribal as well as general population. The drop-out rate of tribals at the secondary level is as high as 87 percent a'rd for the girls it is almost 90 percent. Consequently, there is a negligible percent (0.06%) of tribal women in institutions of higher education.

Table 4: Drop-out rates of girls an boys for tribals and non-tribals, 1988-89

	Total Population			ST Population		
	Boys	Girls	Total	Boys	Girls	Total
Class I-V	46.74	49.69	4793	61.94	68.73	64.53
Class I-VIII	59.38	68.31	65.40	76.21	81.45	78.08
Class I-X	72.68	79.46	75.36	84.87	89.91	86.72

There are wide variations in the literacy rates of various tribal groups. There are tribes with zero percent literacy and there are tribes with literacy rate as high as 40 percent (Nagas). The female literacy rates also vary from zero percent in some tribes to 33.4 percent in Khasis, Jaintias, etc.

Singh and Ohri in their paper entitled "Educational Status of Tribal Women in India" have suggested the following measures for the improvement of the educational status of tribal women:

- On the basis of data related to education available from various sources, identifying tribal groups for initiating innovative educational programmes at the micro-level.
- Conducting Statewise and district-wise surveys of causes of non-enrolment of girl child in tribal communities in order to achieve the goal of universalisation of elementary education.
- Studying the problems of drop-outs, wastage and stagnation among tribal girls in school.
- Examining occupational mobility among tribal women as a result of modernisation, education and social change.
- Evaluating ongoing integrated tribal development programme in tribal areas under the tribal sub-plans through performance appraisal with reference to:
- improvement in social and economic status of the people,
- health modernity,
- use of s:ience and technology in agricultural/ horticultural production, and
- environmental conservation.
- The role of mass media in educational development of tribals needs to be assessed.

Oraon has reported high rate of non-enrolment in the Oraon tribal female school students in Chotanagpur, due to the fact that the girls are required to work in the house.. Ambasht has argued that culturally appropriate learning materials be prepared for the tribal students to help them achieve Minimum Level of Learning.

EMPLOYMENT STATUS

A very large majority of the tribals are engaged in agriculture; their other economic activities being food gathering, pastoral, handicrafts, trade and commerce, and industrial labour. Rarely are they engaged in only one occupation. The employment status of tribal women may be considered in terms of their work participation, agriculture, forests, non-agricultural activities and impact of development programmes.

WORK PARTICIPATION

The work participation rates among tribals are higher than those among Scheduled Caste and general population (Table 5).

Table 5. Work participation Rates, 1981

	General	SC	ST
Male	51.62	52.60	56.66
Female	13.99	18.46	28.18

Through the work participation rate among tribal women has been increasing over a period of time (1997-1991), it is lesser than that for the tribal males, but higher than that for the general female (Table 6).

Table 6. Work Participation Rates, 1971-1991

	1971		1981		1991	
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
General	52.6	12.1	51.6	14.0	51.0	16.0
ST	55.0	20.8	56.7	28.2	53.7	30.0

Though the work participation among tribals is greater than among the general population, within the tribals it is

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again the males who have a higher work participation rate than the females, as in the general population.

AGRICULTURE

Through an overwhelming majority of tribal men (85%) and women (91%) were involved in agriculture, there were more cultivators among tribal males while more tribal women were agricultural labourers. The major role that women play in agricultural operations has been discussed by Roy Burman. In the slash and burn cultivation, women join in felling and burning trees, making holes with digging stick, sowing seeds, weeding and harvesting. In plough based cultivation, transportation , weeding, winnowing and dehusking is done entirely by women while harvesting and threshing are done by both men and women. Generally the ploughing is done by men but in some tribal societies, women do the ploughing too.

WOMEN AND FORESTS

Minor forest produce forms a major source of income in many tribal communities, specially those having less than five acres of land. Women and children are almost exclusively involved in collection of minor forest produce, its storage, processing and marketing.

Increased government control of forests has distributed tribal economy adversely affecting tribals lives, particularly that of women. Appointing of agents from outside for collecting forest produce has not only affected their livelihood, but has also made the work of women more difficult. Collection of fuelwood has become more difficult since it is less accessible and more time-consuming. The result has been less income combined with less fuelwood available for themselves and lesser nutrition. It also leaves them little time for earning wages. Government control over forests has also reduced hunting to a ritual.

NON-AGRICULTURAL ACTIVITIES

Only less than 10% of the tribal women are involved in activities other than .agriculture. This is less than half the percentage of females in the general population in similar occupations. This category includes livestock, forestry mining/ quarrying, manufacturing/ processing/ servicing and repairs in household as well as non-household industries, trade/commerce and services.

DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMMES

The impact of development programmes has been different on different sections of tribal women. A small number of tribal women have taken advantage of education, new opportunities for employment and self-fulfilment. In a seri-culture project for tribal women in Udaipur a remarkable change in the quality of life of the tribal women was reported. Besides economic benefits they had more leisure, self-reliance, innovativeness, adaptability and a more aware social outlook.

However, there have been negative effects of development Programmes also, such as:

i) the workload of women has increased,

ii) with modern agricultural implements, unemployment of women has increased and they have been migrating to other areas as labourers,

iii) restrictions regarding exploitation of *forests* has marginalised women,

iv) exploitation of women in various ways:

- with introduction of Rural Land Ceiling Act, Tribal Land Transfer Act, etc., the non-tribal men often marry tribal women to purchase land from tribal poor to avoid legal complications, or derive financial benefits received from Govt. but deny tribal women their position as wives;
- lands are taken away by mine owners in the name of development and no land is given in lieu of it nor is any rehabilitation programme sponsored; when vacancies occur, jobs are given to menfolk who are inheritors/ owners of land;
- women are prohibited from working in nationalised mines in evening and night shifts; they are permitted in private mines but these don't employ women to avoid maternity benefits, equal remuneration, rest shelters and creches;
- indirect retrenchment is done by introducing voluntary retirement programme for women : a woman may retire after 36 years and offer her job to any male member who continues with her Provident Fund number and gets all her PF benefits;
- tribal women are used for immoral trafficking in collieries and mines and by labour contractors;
- women labourers (rejas) are exploited socially and sexually. Almost half of them are unmarried and parents don't get them married fearing loss of substantial income. On the other hand, tribal men prefer to marry non-rejas and even wives are deserted for doing this job.

Tribal women are working women almost without any exception. Working women in all social groups work harder than men. This is more so for the tribal women. They are overworked : they rise in the morning and go to the forest to collect fuel, fetch water, help in agricultural activities, cook for the family, look after the children, do the washing etc. They are lower paid than men. They have been adversely affected to deforestation and development projects. New strategies have been devised to remove women from work. Non-tribal men are marrying tribal women to get land/jobs.

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Tribal women are sexually exploited by non-tribal men. Much has been written about the sexual permissiveness in the tribal society, without understanding and even with an attitude of 'holier than thou'. But the permissive sexual behaviour in the tribal society is controlled by strong social customs such as Bithla in the Santals, and it is very different than the permissiveness of the contemporary Indian elite imitating the Westerners.

Tribal women are denied property rights. Mawar et al. In their study of Gonds in Madhya Pradesh found that most tribal women were illiterate and tied to a primitive economy. Their income level can be increased by raising their literacy level, and giving them training fir income generating activities.

PLAN OF ACTION

Tribal women in India had specific problems, some of these were built-in problems of these tribal communities and some were imposed upon them which jeopardised their overall development and progress inclusive of their health. Therefore, in order to improve the status of the tribal women, special devlopmental programmes should be designed for each specific tribal group in such a way cater to their specific needs and problems by ensuring their personal involvement. The following strategies may be pursued:

- Formulation of realistic development plans based on needs as felt by tribal women of the specific tribal groups.
- Need for promoting education among tribal girls and women.
- Healthy nutrition should be encouraged through local produce and local recipes. Nutritional needs should be solved by the tribal women themselves through a better utilisation of their locally available cheap but nutritious food.
- Development of poultry and fisheries are to be encouraged.
- Health education should be imparted by the local tribal women with guidelines provided by health functionaries.
- The nutritional and health status of pregnant tribal women need to be improved by adequate intake of nutritious diet, including iron and minerals and also by hundred percent immunisation.
- The habit of taking alcohol and drugs during pregnancy should be discourages.
- The children should be properly immunised, the harmful practices of discarding colostrum, delayed initiation of breastfeeding an complementary feeds should be discarded and health education aspects should be properly explained to tribal women.
- Tribal girls should be properly trained as "dais"/ nurses. Specific precautions need to be observed at the time of conducting deliveries at home, aseptic conditions need to be followed for cutting the naval cord.
- Primitive practice-s of parturition are to be discarded and Itecessafy health education should and necessary health education should be imparteo by tribal nurses.

NATIONAL RESETTLEMENT AND REHABILITATION POLICY 2007 (NRRP 2007)

OBJECTIVES

- Minimize displacement and promote non-displacing or least displacing alternatives;
- Ensure adequate rehabilitation package and expeditious implementation of rehabilitation process with active particiption of AFs (Affected Families)
- Ensure that special care is taken for protecting rights of the weaker sections of society, especially SCs & STs, and to create obligation on the State for their treatment with concern and sensitivity;
- Provide a better standard of living, making concerted efforts for providing sustainable income to AFs;
- Integrate rehabilitation concerns into the development planning and implementation process; and
- Facilitate harmonious relationship between the requiring body and AFs

NRRP

NRRP applies to all projects where involuntary displacement takes place;

- Principles may also apply to APs displaced due to any other reason;
- Recognizes directly and also indirectly affected persons and admits plight of non-title APs;
- Threshold: A new project or expansion of an existing project, which involves involuntary displacement of 400 or more families en masse in plain areas, or 200 or more families en masse in tribal or hilly areas, DDP blocks or areas mentioned in the Schedule V or Schedule VI to the Constitution of India; and
- NRRP-2007 provides the basic minimum requirements for R&R. State Govt., public sector undertakings or agencies, and other requiring bodies may place greater benefit levels for R&R.

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R&R Procedures

- SIA(Social Impact Assessmaent) is to be conducted by the Govt;
- State Govt shall appoint an Administrator (DC) for formulation, execution and monitoring of the R&R plan, and the Commissioner for supervision;
- R&R Plan-Survey and Census of AFs, draft R&R scheme or plan, wide publicity and consultations with gram sabhas or panchayats, estimated cost, timeframe, etc;
- Land Acquisition Options: (i) Land earmarked for project;(ii) Govt. land; (iii) Land available for purchase or acquisition; or (iv) Combination of one or more;
- Compensation award: the market value of the property, including the location-wise minimum price per unit area fixed (or to be fixed); as per the intended land use category and its conversion in advance; and
- Conversion charges, stamp duties, fees, registration of land or house allotted to AFs borne by requiring body.

R&R BENEFITS FOR AFs

- All the eligible AFs, house site (250/150 sq.min R/U), land-maximum irrigated (1 ha)or un-irrigated (2 ha);
- Land development allowance (Rs.15,000 per ha); agriculture production assistance (Rs.10,000 one time); build a cattle shed (Rs.15,000); shifting allowance (Rs.10,000); construction of working shed or shop (Rs. 25,000);
- Employment to 1 person per nuclear family subject to availability of vacancy& suitability of AP, skill development, scholarships, preference to groups and cooperatives of APs in awarding outsourced contracts, other economic opportunities and labor for construction;
- Rehabilitation grant, Shares or debentures (20 % to 50%), Subsistence allowance, annuity policies pension for vulnerable APs(min.Rs. 500 pm);
- If land alienation under urgency clause transit and temporary accommodation, monthly subsistence allowance and other R&R benefits;and
- In case of linear acquisitions for projects, each khatedar(account holder) shall be given an ex-gratia payment of Rs. 25,000, in addition to the compensation or any other R &R benefits, provided the land-holder becomes landless or a small or marginal farmer.

R&R BENEFITS TO ST& SC AFs

- Where displacement of 200 or more ST families occurs restoring titles on alienated land, development of alternate fuel, fodder and non-timber forest produce resources on non-forest lands to be taken up;
- Gram Sabhaor Panchayats or TAC in Scheduled Area consulted for all cases of LA notification under the Act;
- Additional one-time assistance for loss of customary rights or usages of forest produce; and
- Preference in allotment of land-for-land, and reservation benefits in the resettlement areas to ST followed by SC families;
- Amenities & Infrastructural facilities to be provided in Resettlement Area.

GRIEVANCE REDRESSAL MECHANISM

- Where large no. of DFs, R&R Committee at the Project level under the Chairpersonship of Administrator;
- Members include Govt. officials, and representatives of women, SC,ST, Lead Bank, Chairperson (Panchayat and Municipality), MP, MLA of the affected area, LAO of project, and Requiring Body;
- Standing R&R Committee at the District level under the Chairpersonship of DC or Deputy Commissioner;
- Functions: Monitor and review the progress of implementation of R&R scheme or plan and carry out post-implementation social audits;
- Ombudsman:appointed by Govt for time-bound disposal of grievances of AFs;
- Ombudsman empowered to consider and dispose of complaints relating to R&R against the decision of the Administrator, and the Committee; and
- Disputes of compensation award for land or other property acquired will be disposed of as per the LAA,1894 or any other Act of the Union or a State and will be outside the purview of the Ombudsman.

MONITORING MECHANISM

- Gol to constitute the National Monitoring Committee: Chairperson Secretary DOLR, and Secretaries of other ministries/depttand special invitee (s) as members;
- Functions: To review and monitor the progress of implementation of R&R schemes or plans;
- National Monitoring Cell for servicing the committee;
- Information Sharing: All information on displacement, R&R in public domain on Internet as well as shared with Gram Sabhas and Panchayats by Project authorities;
- States & UTs to provide information to National Monitoring Cell;
- Internal Oversight by an Oversight Committee in the Ministry/Dept;and
- External Oversight by a National Rehabilitation Commission to beset up by Gol.

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THE HUMAN RIGHTS AND THE ABORIGINES : THE PROBLEM OF FUTURE SURVIVAL

– V. L.N. Dash & T.S. Naidu

The term 'human right' was introduced in the United States Declaration of Independence in 1776 and the U.S. constitution embodied a Bill of Rights. French Revolution gave birth to the declaration of human rights and duties. In 1945, the inter American conference Passed a resolution seeking establishment of an International forum for the furtherance of human rights of man kind.

The Purpose of the United Nation is 'To achieve international cooperation in solving international problems of an economic', social, cultural or humanitarian character and in promoting and encouraging respect for human rights and for fundamental freedoms for all without distinction as to race, sex, language or religion. (Subramaniam. 1997).

Human rights as defined in the Protection of Human Rights act 1993 is as under: section 2(d) of this Act state Human right means "the rights relation to life, liberty, equality, dignity of the individual guaranteed by the constitution or embodied in the international covenants and enforceable by courts in India".

About half of the total population of world's indigenous people referred to as tribal groups or Scheduled Tribes live in India. "Original" or "Native Inhabitants" of a country are, otherwise, known as indigenous people. The aborigines in Indian language are known as "Adivasi"- "Adi" and "vasi" standing for orginal and Inhabitants respectively., Constitutionally, these human groups are known as "Scheduled Tribe (ST)" or "Anusuchit Jati", "Vanabasi", "Pahari". "Adimjati" etc.

Aboriginal tribes are defined "as a social group, usually with a definite area, common dialect, cultural homogeneity and unifying social organisation". The Tribal India lives in the forest hills and naturally isolated regions knows as a rule by different names meaning either the people of forest and hill or the original inhabitants, and so on. Tribals are an integral part of the Indian civilization. The tribals contributed various elements in the ancient civilization of India. It is believed that they were the earliest among the present inhabitants of the country.

Anthropologists have identified the following characteristics of tribal communities, i.e. (1) smallness (2) Distinctiveness (3) homogeneity (4) isolation and self-sufficiency (5) sensitivity (6) anxiety to retain their identity and (7) fear of extinction etc.

(a) They were considered to be primitive in economy and social organization till the recent past, and

(b) They were considered to be different from the rest of the population. India has the largest tribal population in the world. As per the 1991 Census the tribal population of in India was over 67.8 million constituting about 8.1 per cent of the country's population. According to article 342 of the Constitution, the Scheduled Tribes are the tribes or tribal communities, which may be notified by the President. The Census enumerates only such tribal communities as are scheduled under the relevant Constitutional order in force at the time of the Census.

The tribal economy is differing from tribe to tribe and region to region. Most of the tribal communities in India are between primitive extensive cultivation to intensive irrigated agriculture. Forest gives substantial support to maintain tribal economy through collection of minor forest product. Some of the aboriginal communities depend on nomadic or semi nomadic. They depend on sheep, cattle rearing and cultivation. Todas in Tamilnadu are pastoral tribe who live in small habitation and some are still doing hunting and food gathering economy.

Human rights are a powerful tool for development provided for the aborigines. The duty of human rights is to protect the life of the people, particularly the aborigines. The aboriginals and tribals usually live in less developed, hinterland areas of the States. History is witness where by indigenous or aboriginal peoples lost their land, resources, culture, tradition and even their history and identity. Thus, the original inhabitants (adivasis) not only lost their property and resources, but also were forced into compulsory labour little different from slavery. They were discriminated in the ways of law in an obvious manner and sometime, even exterminated.

Majority of the tribals in India are illiterate and live below poverty line-that means this sad reality that they can't afford to find one whole some.

The caste system also plays a role for suppression and exploitation. In Indian context the caste dominancy is very particular such as the dominant castes are often the perpetrators of violation of human rights. The tribals always wanted to escape from dehumanizing people. Question arises what is the situation after 55 year of independence of these aborigines. Is it essential to protect these aborigines?

Economy also has a great role to accelerate the violations of human rights. For example the Jamindari (land lord) system exploits these tribals from occupying the tribal land after giving loan and the innocent tribals are not repaying the debt amount and these Jamindars cultivating their lands and some time after repaying the loan also the Jamindars are cultivating the land. There is a link between the Jamindars and businessmen.

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After following British policy, the Central Government nationalized the forest without thinking of the tribals' future. Thus the tribals have been deprived of their centuries old forest wealth. They have been displaced from their lands where they maintain harmony for ages with the forest. They became slaves or labour, migrant labour so on. The landlords, industrialists for their enjoyment, trap their women folks. In the name of 'development' many crimes or exploitation are being caused to the aborigines. The system imposed on the tribal people in the name of development either directly or indirectly responsible for restricting the tribals' freedom, survival and the human rights violation for the tribals.

Many studies documented, that tribal people, in all parts of the world have for centuries suffered from the adverse effects of the expansion of the civilization into their traditional territories. Tribal suffering as the result of European colonial expansion and later, incorporation into modern nation states, has ranged from habitat despoliation to disease and malnutrition to the decline of traditional cultural practices to outright tribal extinction. The literature on these processes is voluminous Turnbull 1972; Wagel 1977; Von-Haimendorf 1982; Naidu 1998 Davies 1977; Bodley 1982; Goodland 1982).

It is observed that tribals are in serious adaptive difficulty because of many problems. Adaptive failure would presumably occur when a peoples solution for dealing with life's problems were no longer "valid", it is not readily apparent how to assess validity or how to distinguish problem solving for living. The emphasis on adaptation as successful coping with life's problems was defined by 'Baker' can be considered in this situation.

"An adaptation is simply a biological or cultural trait which aids the biological functioning of population in a given environment. Thus, it includes such aspects as a populations' health, ability to feed it adequately, functional capability in its physical environment and reproductive performance. This definition encompasses the more precisely defined forms of adaptation used in genetics and adaptability responses which are denoted by such terms as acclimatization. However, it stops short of encompassing socio-cultural adjustments which do not have demonstrable effects on human biological function." (Barker 1984).

This definition has the advantage of implicitly specifying what will be taken as evidence of adaptive of adaptive of adaptive failure presumably, it occurs when a population's biological and cultural traits are inadequate to support its "biological functioning". That is to maintain its health, its subsistence, and its reproductive performance. These are the criteria by which one can able to assess how well the Jarwas, Sentinels, (Andaman Island) Cholanayakans (Kerala), Kattunaikans (Tamilnadu) population is functioning, furthermore, specifically juxtaposes against the concept adaptation the important concept stress.

Treating the aboriginal primitive tribals as victims of the changes going on around them obscures their frequent simplicity in the de tribalisation process. Numerous case studies and well documented studies of tribal destruction following establishment on tribal lands of homesteads, logging or encroachments, poaching, killing of the tribes or large scale projects in clearing the forests where such intrusions brought land expropriation, habitat destruction, epidemic disease, or even genocide, tribal peoples literally are victims (for such a perspective on the difficulties of tribal Philippine peoples, see Mcdonagh 1983).

It is a matter of experience that the tribes have been collective and they, become of their rights and well aware about their life that they have been less victimized by the societal pressures or police harassment. Therefore, steps should be taken to organise them as far as possible. The crime rate is increasing day by day due to the people's socio-economic condition; it is true that the tribals they are poor and ignorant, superstitious. Steps should be taken to improve their economic conditions.

The constitution of India was adopted on 26 November 1946, based on which its people solemnly resolved to constitute India into a sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic republic, and to secure to all citizens justice, social, economic and political; liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship; and equality of status and opportunity, and to promote fraternity among all, assuring the dignity of the individual and the unity and integrity of the nation. Our fundamental rights are embodied in part III of the Constitution, as describe below.

Article-14 -guarantees the rights to equality before the law;

Article-15 -prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth;

Article-16 -provides for equality of opportunity in the matter of public employment;

Article-17 -stands for abolition of untouchability;

Article-18 - gives the right to citizens of freedom of speech and of peaceful assembly and to form associations or speech and of peaceful assembly and to form associations or union or to reside and move freely throughout the territory of India, and to practice any profession or to carry on any occupation. Trade or business;

Article-19 -offers protection of citizen against conviction except for violation of the law in force:

Article-20 - guarantees protection of life and personal liability:

Article-21 -offers protection against arbitrary arrest and detention in certain cases;

Article-22 -prohibits traffic in human beings and forced labour;

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Article-23 -prohibits employment of children below the age of 14 years in factories etc.

Article-24 -allows freedom of conscience and the free profession, practice and propagation of religions;

Article-25 - offers citizens freedom to manage their religious affairs;

Article-26 -guarantees to minorities protection of their interests; and

Article-27 -gives the right to minorities to establish and' administer educational institutions of the choice.

The right to development is one of the most important basis human rights and it constitutes the culminating point of the evolution of the concept of human rights. This super-right transcends the differentiation of civil and political rights and socio-economic cultural rights. It includes within its ambit both sets or rights. It correctly links the both because with - hunger and ill health freedom can have no meaning.

THE INDIAN CONSTITUTION AND THE NEHRU'S VISION OF TRIBAL CONSERVATION

The Indian Constitution, adopted on January 26, 1950, visualized a policy of progressive acculturation for the tribal communities of India. The government promoted development, education and health care for tribal peoples. Their rights were to be respected by integrating them into the national government. Those tribes, such as the Andamanese, Cholanayakans, Kattunaikans, Sentinels, and other tribes who were considered "backward" would receive special attention for their development (Fuchs, 1973). Tribes designated for this plan were placed under the heading of "scheduled areas." There was no specific definition for what constituted a scheduled area or scheduled Tribes. Under article 341 and 342 of the Indian Constitution, the President has the power to list the scheduled tribes in each union territory and state. Policies towards these Scheduled areas, carried with them two objectives. The first was to allow tribal people to maintain their rights, and the second was to promote the development of these areas through education and economic assistance.

The Indian Government, no doubt, felt that its policy towards tribal peoples was, and is, enlightened and in their (the tribals') best interest. Politicians like former Prime Minister Nehru had clear ideas on how tribal groups would be treated in independent India. In the following quote, Nehru outlines his philosophy for the foundation of tribal policies:

1. People should develop along the lines of their own genius and we should avoid imposing anything on them. We should try to encourage in every way their own traditional arts and culture. . .
2. Tribal rights in land and forest should be respected.
3. We should try to train and build up a team of their own people to do the work of administration and development. Some technical personnel from outsider will, no doubt, be needed, especially in the beginning. But we should avoid introducing too many outsiders into tribal territory.
4. We should not over-administer these areas or overwhelm them with a multiplicity of schemes. We should rather work through, and not in rivalry to, their own social and cultural institutions.
5. We should judge results, not by statistics or the amount of money spent, but by the quality of human character that is evolved (Chaudhuri 1982: 312)

CASE STUDIES

CASE-I: GOVERNMENT POLICIES AND TRIBAL SURVIVAL

Population ecology or the measure of adaptation is the ability of a population to persist that is to reproduce itself in numbers equal to or exceeding the rate of mortality. Estimated Jarawa population is 250 to 300 in the Andaman Islands. And similarly sentinel also 200 to 300 numbers (Naidu-1999,). These two endangered aborigine population are disappearing at a faster rate. There are several factors involved, the close examination shows that the fertility and mortality are not the reasons for depopulation. The major factors involved in depopulation are:

(i) Indiscriminate killing of the Jarawas (especially males) by the Burmese and Thailand poachers. Many Jarawa men were killed by the Burmese and Thailand poachers in the areas of Middle Andaman. It is noticed one fourth of the women (out of 23 women examined 6 women are widows) are widows.

(ii) Jarawa men were also killed by the crocodiles while crossing the creeks.

(iii) Many Jarawas were killed by the local settlers (poachers).

(iv) Food poisoning is also an important factor for the death of the Jarawas.

(v) The health problems, the terminal illness often cited is the stomach with dysentery or loose bowels, amoebic dysentery to severe infestations of intestinal parasites. I was told some of the deaths are because of high fever. During my stay with Jarawas I noticed all the above-mentioned diseases. (Naidu 1999).

There is a great need to conserve 'the present existing Jarawa and the Sentinel; These two populations are biologically, genetically and culturally distinct population in the world. The main occupation is fishing and food gathering and hunting, the wild boar, monitor lizard are the main game for both the groups. The poaching of the wild boars by the migrant settlers has resulted shortage of food for these aborigines. Illegal occupation of land or resources by the non-tribals is giving very difficult to get their food.

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CASE II: LAND ALIENATION TRIBAL PROBLEMS

Based on the reports Mr. Kuldip Nayar recently highlighted that the Kerala study group in Delhi has brought out the excesses committed to Kerala adiuasis in July-August, 2001. That was the time when people in the districts of Wayanad, Palakhad and Kannur died and thousands faced hunger and even death. In most cases, the transfer of land has been allowed without any valid documents. At some places the signatures of adivasis have been forcibly taken on the blank documents. The officials indulged in large -scale embezzlement of funds meant for their development. The most recent case is that of gross misuse and misappropriation of the Rs. 230 crores. Tribal Welfare Scheme aided by Japan. Fifty per cent of the land taken over by the Government under the Kerala private Forest Act, 1972 was meant to be distributing to the adiuasis. Various department and projects to rehabilitate bounded adivasis hold more than 40,000 acres of land, but as admits government itself the land is in possession of corrupt officials. The Government acquired land from private persons whose holdings were in excess of the land ceiling - thus, inspite of availability of land for distribution among the landless adivasis, government has failed to do so.

In Madhya Pradesh the situation is still worse. The construction of steel plant at Nagarnar brought the original inhabitants survival very difficult. As authorities are aware of the necessity of getting prior approval of the Adivasis, (a) formal notices for this purpose were sent around the end of may, 2001; (b) the consultation with the Gram Sabha of five villages was ordered to be held on June, llth and 13th, 2001. The land Acquisition Officer, through the Tahesildar, dispatched booklet each to the Gram Panchayats on June 7th, 2001. The meetings commanded as ordained. The Gram

Sabha, as expected, rejected the Governments proposals. But the officials did not hesitate to replace the previous records with the new version of records incorporating therein to the effect that the gram Sabha had given their consent with their substantial majority. The rot in the system is total, resulting in gross violations ofadiuasis rights to live. Their transfer of land cannot be affected without their consent. The constitution protects their rights. The state is committed to consult the community (gram sabha or village assembly) before acquiring land for a "public purpose". Most importantly, the people affected directly or indirectly, have to be assured of an honorable place in terms of equality in the new environment. (Nayar 2000).

CASE III: FORESTS POLICIES AND TRIBALS

In India rehabilitation of adivasis cannot be separated from the national objective of the development of forest and wild life regulation.

Four years back, a police-firing incident was occurred at Mehindikheda of Madhya Pradesh. The aim of firing was to remove the tension between adivasis and forest department. The adivasis came to develop a close relationship with their immediate environment. They were getting their necessity product form the forest, such as food, fodder, fodder, fuel, medicines and timber for construction work. This relation ship is their customary right. But today their existence is very difficult and threat in this forest. The National forest policy of 1988 recognized that .domestic requirements of local people for fuel wood, fodder, minor forest produce and construction timber should be the first charge on forest resources. It emphasized that while safeguarding their customary rights; the adivasis should be closely associated in the protection, and development of forest.

After independence the adivasis are being forcibly pushed out an atmosphere with the close relationship in the name of 'development' for this type of exploitation the human rights commission should give direction or instruction to Government and Non-governmental agencies to protect the aborigines and their rights.(K. Kanakaiah, 2002, 38).

CASE IV: POLICE ATROCITIES AND THE TRIBES

The Secretary of the Visakhapatnam district Unit of the Andhra Pradesh, Civil Liberties Committee sent a complaint to the Commission in May 1994, alleging that police official's raided Vasapanda village in the agency area of Visakhapatnam district on 27th April 1994, rounded up a group of tribals and beat them supposedly because they have provided food and shelter to naxalities. It was further stated that, as a result, one of the tribals, namely Korra Satya Rao, received severe injuries to his head and shoulders and he succumbed to these injuries on 5th May 1994. Inquiries conducted by the Sub-collector and Assit-Supperintendent of police confirmed the complicity of a Sub-inspector and three police constables in the action leading to the death or Korra Satya Rao.

The commission in its proceedings of 17th February 1995, recommended that the police officials concerned be prosecuted under section 304 of the IPC and that Rs. 1 lakh be paid in compensation the next of Kin of the deceased.

The Government of Andhra Pradesh subsequently confirmed complains with the commissions' directions. (Subramanyam, 1995).

CASE V: FOOD INSECURITY AMONG THE TRIBALS OF ORISSA

Orissa is a tribal dominant and most backward state in India. Every year Orissa is facing with natural calamities, such as flood, drought, and cyclone 22 percent of tribals are living in Orissa. Poverty rate is more comparatively other states. 72 per cent of adivasis are below the poverty line. (Hindu-6th Nov. 2002).

Every year there is a hue and cry over starvation death in Orissa-in Kalahandi, Koraput and Bolangir. These adivasi-

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dominated districts have long been known for endemic poverty. The latest addition to this list-is Kashipur block of Rayagada district, from where there have also been reports of poverty-induced sale of children. Whenever incidents of starvation deaths are reported, Orissa's adivasis are in the news. The state government has not been taken any permanent action. Year after year, reports of starvation deaths in Orissa are publicized. Earlier these were associated with the most backward Kalahandi district, but now in Kashipur ,block of Rayagada district after eating the mango kernel more than 20 people were died. (Hindu 6th Nov. 2001).

This remote block in Orissa's Rayagada district falls prey to human deprivation. But in tandem with human misery, ironies too sweep the rugged terrain. Even as a controversy rages over the alleged starvation deaths in the area, what is clear is that the plight of the people, mostly tribals, has only worsened over the years. The State Government godowns are overflowing with grain but the people have no money to buy it. Because they are not getting any work. Health care facilities too are almost non-existent.

Since June-July 2001, when the monsoon struck, the people have gone without work. The tribals supplemented their meager rice supplies with mango kernels, ragi and tamarind seeds. (Hindu-September 9th 2001) Drinking boiled mango kernels juice is their traditional food with ragi, and tamarind. After eating mango kernels people were died due to some food poison. According to Rayagada district collector 21 deaths that took place between July 27th and August 28th, he claims the first of the seven deaths in Panasaguda village were due to food poisoning and the four deaths in Bilamal village were due to consumption of poisonous mushrooms. Four deaths in Pitajodi village were also due to food poisoning, and six in Badamaribhatta, Tikiri-Jhadia, Upar Jhari and Tala Hjiri villages were due to various diseases.

Government always tries to cover up by saying the deaths were due to food poisoning caused by eating mango kernels or some other traditional food or drink. It may be true that the adivasis, who live in very primitive conditions, may not be able to maintain high standards of hygiene; but this is not the whole story. In this situation Human Rights Commission should examine why-they are driven to eat mango kernels. Even if for arguments sake one were to grant that mango kernels are a traditional delicacy, how can selling their children be passed off as a matter of the adivasis' tradition of culture? What is needed is a close look at the general economic condition of the adivasis.

Kashipur of Rayagada district of Orissa was also in the news for many reasons. In the year 2001 January three adivasis were killed in police firing. The tribals were protesting against the mining of bauxite from this region and setting up of industries, which they felt would adversely affect their livelihood.

Since 1992, the adivasis have been protesting against the attempts by a consortium known as Utkal Alumina International Ltd (UAIL) to mine bauxite ore at Baphlimali and process all of it into ready-for-export alumina at a plant to be erected in fertile valley at the foot of these hills. There have been several ups and downs in the struggle by the tribals to preserve their way of life against the onslaught of 'civilization' (Hindu.6th Nov. 2001).

Malkanagiri district 700 km away form state capital Bhubaneswar. This district is tribal dominant district. Peoples war Group (PWG) has won the trust of the tribals and has been instigating them saying that the Government has not provided them water, medical facilities, schools and good roads. Basically, the PWG found Malkangiri a'safe haven for them. This district is twin language formula, Oriya and Bengali, is a spill-over the Nehruvian Dandakaranya Project to resettle refugees from the erstwhile East Pakistan, and another wave after Bangladesh was born in 1971. This Malkanagiri town is dominated by the Bengalis, each and every business they are doing. Tribals walk down from their enclaves once a week to sell their wares. "Tribals are not good traders. They cannot bargain and will accept what you offer. So they are cheated by the Bengali refugees." The interface between the Bengali settlers and the tribals is a keg of explosives. Few months back in Malkanagiri there was clash between Bengali refuges and Tribals for land occupation. The Revenue Minister, Sri Bishwa Bhushan Harichandan said that there were reports of tribals being alienated from their land. He said that both the Bengali settlers and tribals were encroaching on Government land. The firing in Raighar tehsil on October 30th 2001 in which three tribals were killed was a result of tension between Bengalis and tribals. (Hindu 24th February 2002.). For this type of incidents the National Human Rights Commission should interfere and take necessary steps to protect the tribes.

CASE VI: ALLEGED DEATH OF 125 CHILDREN IN PHULBANI DISTRICT, ORISSA TO MALNUTRITION, MALARIA AND CHICKEN-POX

The Commission took cognizance of a complaint field by an advocate, A.C. Pradhan, alleging that some 400 children had died in Phulbani district as a result of acute malnutrition, accompanied by repeated attacks of malaria, chicken pox and various water born diseases. It asked for a full report from the state Government.

That report stated that a medical team headed by the Chief Medical Officer of Phulbani had enquired into the matter and found that the number of deaths was an exaggeration. However, the report admitted that, "in Daringbadi block, 125 children below 10 years of age died in August and September 1993".

The commission, in 'its direction on 25th October 1994 commented that adequate and satisfactory arrangements

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had not been made to prevent the calamity. Unimpressed by the state governments claims concerning the opening of health sub-centers and the deployment of paramedical staff in the area, the commission observed that the fact that persons belonging to the Scheduled Tribes preferred to treat their children with witchcraft and by village quacks was no encomium to the State I Government indeed, the commission fact that the tragedy reflected on the inability of the State Government to adequately educate the tribes, which was an obligation of the State Government under the Constitution. The commission, therefore, recommended that the State Government pay, within a month, a sum amounting to Rs. 6,52,000 to the 125 tribals families whose children had died.

In a letter to the commission dated 19th January 1995, the State Government advanced five reasons requesting the commission to reconsider its recommendations regarding the payment of compensation.

Reviewing the matter the commission to its view that to negligence had occurred, while it understood the stand of the State Government that compensation need not be provided in every case of death, it continued to believe that, on the facts available on record in the instant case, there was no justification for the commission to take a different view. It therefore decided not to interfere with, or alter, its earlier recommendation in any way and called upon the Government of Orissa to workout ways of implementing its recommendation within an extended period of one month. (Sinha 2000 p. 264).

CASE VII: UN IDENTIFICATION OF SCHEDULED TRIBES IN PONDICHERRY

In Pondicherry Union territory five tribal communities inhabit form generations. The State Government is not in a position to recognize them as tribes. These indigenous people are living in different regions in the Union territory, such as Pondicherry, Karikal, Yanam. Since last three decades these tribal people are fighting for their tribal status. Even after the submission of the reports on "Identification of Scheduled Tribes in Pondicherry Union territory" by (Naidu 2002) Department of Anthropology, Pondicherry University. Before the survey the tribal federation had given memorandum to the Union as well as State Government, but they have not been taken any major steps. Many representations have been given to the Union and State Government Officials for consideration of the tribals to include in the list of communities. But till date they are not recognized as tribes.

Though there is demand from as many as 5 communities from Pondicherry Union Territory for inclusion under Scheduled Tribes list, in the very preliminary screening itself some of them were disqualified for want of any tribal features in their way of life. While, the others were short listed for being merely the synonyms based upon certain unique features^ of their way of life. As such the consolidated list retains only seven distinct tribal groups such as, IRULAR (along with the sub-tribes VILLI and VETTAIKARAN), MALAIKURAVAN, KATTUNAYAKAN, YERUKULA and KURUMANS who have been living in the Union Territory since time immemorial and hence be treated as original inhabitant. The groups are not getting any benefits from government. Their living conditions are very poor and no one listening to their voice, so humanitarian ground the Human Right Commission should interfere and take necessary steps for the development of the indigenous tribal people in the Union Territory.

CASE VIII: ISSUE OF DEVELOPMENT AND DISPLACEMENT

The tribals are exploited for the minerals and forest products etc. The exploitation of this wealth through the damming of rivers and mining of the land has led not only to a large scale displacement of the tribal population but also to degradation of the environment. This type of works has been increased in recent years. In the name of development the government is displacing the tribals form their original habitation.

A report of the Central Water Commission indicated that less than one-forth of 32 dams of over 50 meters height constructed between 1951 and 1970 were in the tribal areas. However, between 1971 and 1990, out of-the 85 additional dams of similar size completed or under construction, around 60 per cent were in tribal areas. Mining not only displaces the local population but also causes severe environmental damages such as pollution of surface water sources, damage of agricultural land through dumping of overburden, destruction of forest cover and air pollution. In a letter to Baba Amte on August 1, 1984, Smt Indira Gandhi said, "I am most unhappy that-development projects displace tribal people from their habitat especially as project authorities do not always take care to properly rehabilitate affected population." In Rajsthan the 'Narmada Bachao Andolan' is also a part of displacement and rehabilitation problem. The revolution headed by a social activist Medha Pattkar, and Arundhati Roy are protesting against the Narmada Dam project. For which thousands of acres of land will submerge in water and thousands of tribal people will displace from their main land. Displacement of tribal population from their habitat is only one part of the story. There has been large-scale movement of non-tribals into development project areas, as work contractors, shopkeepers, transporters, labourers' etc. many of them over a period of time have got permanently settled in the project sites and at times places beyond, which are in the midst of vast tracts of tribal habitation. Reports of socio-economic exploitation of tribals by these settlers are legion.

The National Human Rights Commission has been receiving the complaints in this regard, whether they are in

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relation to Sardar Sarovar Project or the Tehri dam, are a clear indication of the continued lack of care in comprehensive planning for mega-projects and rehabilitation of affected tribal people. The role of human rights organizations and activists in the sensitization of Government functionaries is of great importance in this regard. (Pillai, 1999/p. 160-162).

The Rengali Dam Project in Orissa has submerged 265 villages and displaced 10,847 families in two districts, three sub-divisions and nine blocks. The Upper Indravati Hydroelectric Project located in Southern Orissa has affected 97 villages with 67 villages fully submerged, 34 villages from Kalahani, 18 from Nawarngpur and 13 from Koraput districts. Only 5448 families have been assisted with rehabilitation. Majority of the affected are tribes.

The existing scenario is far from satisfactory. Those evicted from Sardar Sarovar Project have not been provided proper rehabilitation at all. In the Rengali Dam Project not even half of the ousters were provided with rehabilitation packages. The Upper Indravati Hydroelectirc project while displacing 10,847 families has assisted 5448 families with rehabilitation. While the rehabilitated are not provided with proper rehabilitation package, major sections of the evicted become refugees in their own country. This is a major human rights violation. (Vijapur, 1999 p. 236).

DISCUSSION

Tribals from the various segment of the weaker section are with their traditional skills and resources. They are the most vulnerable sectors of the population and they are exploited by the most age-old social and cultural handicaps coupled with environmental factors. It is important to note here that in India we have 75 primitive tribal populations who are in small number this indigenous population are under threat for their survival, the Great Andamanese, Onge, Jaraw, Shompen, sentinel of Andamn and Nicobar Isalnds, Cholanakians, Kadars of Kerala, Kurumbas of Tamilnadu, Parangi Poraja of Andhra Pradesh are some of the population who are facing the survival problems, if these populations are not protected they are going to be extinct soon from the planet.

To save these aborigines human rights are essential for full development of aboriginal population for their happiness. Human rights movements as global phenomenon. The human rights activists should join together to work effectively to save the aborigines history of human rights situation in India, over the years shows that the role played by the State is not good account in the country. The country people are conscious to their rights. So there is an urgent need for the Human Rights Commission to do justice for the future survival of the aborigines.

HUMAN RIGHTS AND DEVELOPMENT CAUSED DISPLACEMENTS

A Study of Sonbhadra Tribals by H.S. Saksena

The Indian Constitution has provided an expansive set of human rights called therein as Fundamental Rights to all the citizens of this country. These are justiciable rights and guarantee equality of opportunities in matters of public employment, certain rights regarding freedom of movement, speech, etc., and to reside and settle in any part of the country, right to protection of life and personal liberty, freedom to manage religious affairs and cultural and educational rights to ensure the preservation of distinct languages and culture. These rights are further buttressed by the framework of Directive Principles of State Policy, which, in substance, are in the nature of social and economic rights. These too are "fundamental in the governance of the country and state that it shall be the duty of the state to apply these principles in making laws". Sorabjee (1995) comments, "Early judicial thinking took the view that Directive Principles were subordinate to Fundamental Rights. Subsequent decisions of the Supreme Court have ruled that there is no conflict between them and the courts must widely read the collective Directive Principles of Part IV into the individual Fundamental Rights guaranteed by Part III".

The Directive Principles particularly cast on the state a responsibility to strive to promote the welfare of the people by securing... "a social order where justice - social, economic and political, shall inform all the institutions of national life (Article 38) and direct its policy towards securing...the right to an adequate means of livelihood". Article 21 guaranteeing that no person shall be deprived of his life except according to procedure established by law is a Fundamental Right. The Supreme Court has ruled that 'life' means more than mere physical or animal existence...and includes "the right to life with human dignity and all that goes along with it". Thus began the process of incorporating socio-economic rights enumerated in the Directive Principles into the Fundamental Rights. The Supreme Court has further ruled that the right to life in Article 21 includes the right to livelihood that is the means of livelihood. The Court reasoned that if the right to livelihood were not treated as a part of the constitutional right to life, the easiest way of depriving a person of his right of life would be to deprive him of his means of livelihood to the point of abrogation. "Such deprivation...would make life impossible to live" (ibid.). The Directive Principles also assure rig it to adequate means of livelihood and right to work.

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Our Constitution also guarantees safeguards to certain categories of citizens particularly the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs). These safeguards include a right to development and providing them protection from "social injustice and all forms of exploitation" (Article 46). Thus, the economic interests of the SCs and STs are to be protected more than others. In pursuance of these safeguards, the state in India has created a massive socio-economic welfare structure subsequently subsumed under planned development efforts, through Five-Year Plans.

THE PROBLEM

This paper endeavours to examine the enforcement of the above rights or their blatant denial in the context of certain communities who are being dispossessed of all their means of livelihood, ironically due to the process of development. The country's era of planned development initiated in the early 1950s had higher productivity, better infrastructure and greater equality as its objectives. However, the foci for the developmental efforts, particularly infrastructural, are the resource rich regions, many of which are hilly and forested areas inhabited by the tribal people. Some of the tribal regions are extremely backward and subsist at a pre-agricultural level of technology while some of the more advanced areas compare favourably with the general rural scene. However, the exigencies of development have acted as strong currents to push the tribals from many such areas into the 'mainstream' of industrial activity without much concern for their levels of skills and technology. In fact, a special model of development of tribal economy has not been attempted. Moreover, in its aftermath, the exploitation of such natural resources has correspondingly led to the most massive involuntary dislocations. However, the full impact of all such projects on the people around them is difficult to assess due to a lack of comprehensive data about the quantum of displacements, quality and durability of the resultant rehabilitation effort, little inclination to evaluate these measures along with reluctant correctives and incomplete date relating to the SC/ ST people forming part of the Project Affected Persons (PAPs). An official assessment puts the figure of the ST PAPs at 40 per cent. Fernandes and Thukral (1989) has examined the situation of displacement and rehabilitation on an all-India basis during 1951-1990 and found the problem of the project affected persons enormous - over 1.85 crores displaced including an incidence of about 30 per cent belonging to the tribal communities. The rehabilitation effort is estimated to have taken care of only about 25 per cent of these PAPs.

The Sonbhadra district of Uttar Pradesh (previously the southern part of Mirzapur district) has been the theatre of a large number of projects during the period 1960-1990. These include the Rihand Reservoir, two thermal power plants of the U.P. State Electricity Board, two super thermal power projects of the National Thermal Power Corporation (NTPC), extensive pit mines of the Northern Coalfields Ltd (NCL). and one irrigation project of the U.P. Irrigation Department. The displacement caused by these projects has been massive. A recent estimate puts the displaced families at 36,000, about 10,000 of whom have faced multiple displacements - four or five times. The record is six displacements in 25 years (EDF, 1990). Nearly half of the people of the affected areas are' SCs/STs. This estimate does not include with any exactness the ;heavy displacement by the Rihand reservoir in 1960-61 for which no data is traceable. The entire area (south of Kaimur) used to be a partially excluded area under the Government of India Act, 1935. Subsequendy, the area did not qualify for being declared a scheduled area under our Constitution as the Presidential Order of 1950 declared the tribal communities residing in the area as SCs. Thus, the protective umbrella allowed to the Partially Excluded areas was withdrawn and the area came to be governed as per the laws and system in the rest of the state. In other words, suddenly placed at par the mainstream of the state. According to Hasan (1985), this "normal administration is causing havoc in their life style, culture, customary laws and above all to their economy and the application of all the laws to the area, which would not have happened if these were Scheduled Areas". The most significant impact of this step has been on tribal landholdings. In an area which had no land records - most of the area had been settled on the basis of *nazri paimayash* and actual possession on the pattern of other tribal areas. This position was compounded in the 1950s by declaration of large tracts as reserved forests, leaving the cultivators without proper records of rights at the mercy of the forest officials.

Majumdar was the first anthropologist who studied these tribal people and highlighted that they had reached different levels of acculturation but they retained their tribal way of life, organization, leadership and economy, mixing agriculture of a primitive type with other traditional pursuits and dependence on forests. The villages, as units, shared some other sociological characteristics - no sharp differences in economic conditions among castes/tribes, absence of dominant caste leadership as seen elsewhere, fluid inter-community relations and a symbolic dependence of die castes/ tribes on each other (1960). These features are significant for an insight into the events and conditions, which developed among these people after and in the course of displacements. The characteristics of the communities in this area are very similar to the definition of the 'tribal people' as developed by the World Bank (Morse and Berger, 1992). In such circumstance a presumption was that the plight of these tribals and the SCs, because of displacement single or multiple, would be of excessive deprivation, marginalization and powerlessness.

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THE STUDY AND ITS FINDINGS

A study was undertaken by us in 1992-94 (Saksena and Sen, 1999) with a view to gauging the extent of the displacements and their impact on the economic base and pattern of living; examine the rehabilitation measures as incorporated in the laws and policies of different agencies and evaluating their effectiveness, suitability and adequacy of the delivery of the rehabilitation measures. In the course of this study 1,038 families were surveyed in 57 villages and colonies set up for PAF's. In addition, in-depth interviews were held with nearly 80 disp laced persons in order to know how their life had been affected by the displacement. Many rehabilitation areas were visited for a few months so as to ascertain the conditions therein.

Prior to the location of the projects the area was covered with dense forests and undulating land with hill streams. The people had an economy based on a combination of agriculture, generally of a primitive type and dependence on forest for various types of food and income from sale of minor forest produce collected by them. Thus, land either as a resource of the community or under individual ownership was their sole means of life and livelihood. Those who had no land also depended on land through a system of *jajmani,* crop-sharing or agricultural labour. The condition of the people started changing after the construction of the Rihand Reservoir.. This reservoir displaced a very large population estimated by some to be about two lakhs in the early 1960s. Since alternative lands were available for cultivation the people were encouraged to move in their own communities and settle in the forest areas north of the reservoir. Even though they faced many difficulties (Heuze-Brigant, 1991; EDF, 1990), they were able to settle down in homogenous rural-communities similar to those disrupted. A sizeable section though moved to Sarguja and other parts of Madhya Pradesh where they were able to adjust with their tribal brethren.

The subsequent projects started coming 20-25 years later and the rehabilitation approach of these projects was characterized by the following features:

(i) There was no land for land dispensation, which has meant a complete loss of the economic base of the oustees.

(ii) Compensation was entirely in cash strictly within the framework of two laws, viz., the Land Acquisition Act, 1894 (LAA) and the Coal Bearing Areas Act, 1957 (CBAA). This meant that no relief of any kind were available to any persons who were a part of the agricultural base but without a landholding.

(iii) While the concerned public sector undertakings (PSUs) and others in the Government of India gave assurance about giving one job to each oustee family; the fulfilment of the assurance was a different matter.

(iv) In respect of the PAPs being provided some employment or vocational opportunities through the intervention or initiative of the project authorities, again, certain assurances were given. Generally the PAPs were made to believe that opportunities for a change in and the widening of their economic base would be ample once the work on the project started. But the fulfilment of these assurances varied from situation to situation and at different times in the process of the project. After the end of the construction phase few such opportunities came, and no worthwhile efforts to create skills among PAPs were made.

(v) A policy of providing developed plots for housing 60 by 40 feet or 50 by 30 feet - was followed in all cases except the irrigation project. But the PAPs started getting plots several years after they had physically shifted or forced to shift from their houses and a sizeable percentage did not get plots even now.

(vi) Full development of plots and all the basic amenities in the rehabilitation colonies were unequivocally promised. Here again the development of colonies has been extremely tardy. The conditions varying fron one colony to another due to inadequate resources, insufficient even for the modest objectives which had been set; the promises about schools, roads and dispensaries have rarely been kept..." The majority of these colonies are situated in locations best suited for garbage disposal rather than for accommodating human beings" (Heuze-Brigant, 1991). Even an approach road with a safe railway line crossing has been denied to Chikand, one of the largest rehabilitation colonies, for all these 15 years. "Families (between 4 and 25 people) have been allotted plots of 50 by 30 ft and encouraged to build their houses on land which is liable to flooding ... away from the city, job sites and markets, under high tension lines or located on high and rocky grounds in the vicinity of blasting mines" (ibid.).

(vii) The attitude of callousness and the almost inhuman approach in dealing with the PAPs was noticed in the case of Shaktinagar or the project of the NTPC where "the administration backed by the PAC, was warning the people with the blare of a mike, in the dead of night, in the midst of the monsoon season, to move out to a near site whece some makeshift sheds had been put up..." (Commissioner, 1989). Subsequently, the other project managements too have handled matters in still worse ways. Anpara oustees reported bulldozing of their houses and forceful ouster in the rainy season. NTPC Bijpur, also acted similarly while (NCL) emerged as a topper among them all. Bulldozing was noticed in several locations in January and June 1992," and some oustees employed by the NCL were pressurised by their officers that their services would be terminated if they did not induce the people in their villages to shift. Further, the

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use of dynamite often in close proximity of some of the rehabilitation areas or still-existing parts of old villages has endangered the lives of the people and their cattle and damaged their houses.

(viii) The economic base of the PAPs has undergone a total change. Generally speaking the extent of landlessness has become near-universal. In Singmuli area, 77.4 per cent having land before displacement were reduced to 14.6 per cent, in Anpara 88 per cent landholders were reduced to 20 per cent and other assets like milch cattle, bullocks, fruit and timber trees, etc., have also been reduced to almost the same extent. An overwhelming majority of these people have no regular employment and depend only on casual wage-labour work. Even this is available only for a few days in a month and the wages being paid by the employers like the labour contractors, etc., are much below the fixed minimum wage. Impoverishment and a loss of nerves is to be seen everywhere and the people variously expressed it in words like "we have been ruined" or "we have become beggars" or "nobody is prepared to listen" to us. There is an overwhelming (psychological) feeling of marginalization among the people who widely expressed their 'helplessness' through comments like "no one cares for us" or "listens to us". Their attachment to their land is so overwhelming that some still go on to describe themselves as 'agriculturists' though they might have lost their entire land holdings.

(ix) Large joint families which were found to be the rule in the rural areas occupied by the Rihand. oustees have started disintegrating into nuclear families mainly, flue lo change in the economic base. This trend has been furthef encouraged by the rehabilitation policy of providing small plots, which are strictly of urban standards.

Cernea (1991a, 1991b and 1990) has analyzed vast evidence from resettlement processes. He has presented his analysis as a 'model of impoverishment risks' or taxonomy of adverse consequences'. The pattern of recurrent characteristics reveals seven dimensions of this impoverishment risk model which were all too obvious in our area of study:

(i) ***Landlessnessr :*** Compensation in cash does not ensure the replacement of the lost land and the oustees remain landless for ever. Landlessness is higher for families who have only customary rights rather than formal deeds for example tribal groups in India. Loss of land is the single most important cause of impoverishment.

(ii) ***Joblessness:*** Risk of the oustees becoming permanently jobless sometimes after displacement or after construction works drop are high (in Sonbhadra since the oustees were all agricultu ists there was no question of losing any formal job). However, with the loss of land the sharecroppers, agricultural labourers and the beneficiaries of the *jajmani* all lost their 'jobs' in one go. The weakest tribes like Baiga were almost starving.

(iii) ***Homelessness:*** The loss of snelter through displacement is temporary for most of those displaced. But for some families it remains a permanent condition, since compensation for acquired dwellings is paid at their assessed rather than their replacement value. To quote an example from our experience the compensation paid for a dwelling by the NCL was Rs 147. Can the oustees now have any kind of a dwelling for the family by-spending this amount?

(iv) ***Marginalisation:*** Project affected families cannot fully restore their prior economic strength and human dignity. The state ager cies accept as a matter of course that those displaced cannot be guaranteed reinstatement to their prior standard of living. It implies that, a majority of resettlers who were in the poverty group, or just above it, would face further en masse marginalization and impoverishment.

(v) ***Morbidity :*** The adverse health effects of forced displacement are commonly seen. There is a higher degree of exposure to illness and to comparatively more severe disease. These may be caused by poor hygienic conditions in resettlement colonies, inadeqüate supply of potable water, etc. Most of our informants emphasized that they and their families had become prone to many diseases like asthma and TB due to pollution (thermal power projects), coal dust (open pit coal mining), poor supply of potable water and similar factors. Even Rihand Reservoir is now polluted with ash-dykes of the NTPC and ash was getting washed into the reservoir. Disintegration of the traditional system of medicine due to the non-availability of competent Baigas and their herbal pharmacopoeia and absence of facilities of modern medicine in the rehabilitation areas/colonies are adding to the morbidity levels. M.P. Lokayan Evam Lokhit Samiti has called attention to pollution of Rihand water by Hindalco, lack of potable water for casual labour in NCL and the diseases caused by increasing flesh-trade.

(vi) ***Food insecurity:*** Uprooting increases the risk that a larger number of people will fall into the strata affected by chronic food insecurity, defined as calorie-protein intake levels, due to discontinuation of food production by themselves, decrease in purchasing power and non-availability of food stuffs at reasonable price. (Our informants universally complained of their inability to get adequate food due to their poor incomes and high prices, absence of fair-price shops under government/ public distribution system in rehabilitation col(mies and the gradual disappearance of forest and/or restrictions on their access to the forests from where they were obtaining several items of nutritious diet and herbal medicine.)

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(vii) ***Social disarticulation:*** This aspect of impoverishment is not so blatant and yet it commands a great disturbing force. It may include disturbance or disintegration of kinship and social networks, break-up of authority system, loss of leadership and mutual help, etc. These had provided the oustees in the past with production oriented organizations, stable marriage and ritual arrangements and other kinds of support and guidance. (Our study brought forth many dimensions of this loss of network and other imponderables of culture with serious consequences for the oustees. Further, the feeling of powerlessness, alienation and even disorientation was found to be overwhelming among the oustees at all the three levels explored by the study - individual, family and community.

THE DISCUSSION

We cannot but agree with Cernea (1990) that "impoverishment is not inevitable"... and the "theoretical possibility to take policy and programme actions that could counter the risks" is very much there. "But failure to recognize the risks inherent along these lines will allow such risks to unfold unimpeded, causing pervasive impoverishment". What has happened in Sonbhadra has been a totally insensate assertion of the state without any serious efforts to supplant the 'means of life' that it had snatched from the people. Whatever was done in the name of rehabilitation was inadequate, without comprehensive planning and lacked transparency on the part of the implementing agencies. The law and its due process have to be seen in the context of the backward, remote and isolated condition and the level of awareness, literacy and economic resources of the community in the area. Majumdar (1960) found them to be lea.ding a 'fringe existence'.

In this scenario the various steps of the acquisition procedure such as 'public notifications in two newspapers and filing of objections questioning' public purpose within 21 days, declaration under Section 6 and notice to persons under Section 9 of the Land Acquisition Act (LAA) 1894 seem to assume rather hypothetical dimensions. Do the common Scheduled Tribe or Scheduled Caste persons residing in a remote village in the former Singrauli state really have the wherewithal to enter the arena against the mighty state? Can they ever challenge a declaration of 'public purpose' and properly place the grounds for the infirmity of such a declaration or bring up the various determinants of compensation before the prescribed authority. In the areas where NCL is interested, the land of the same person may fall under the provisions of the Coal Bearing Areas Acquisition and Development Act, 1957 (CBAA) and under the LAA for being required for any other purpose. In such cases the people have to deal with two sets of authorities: Our sample of oustees threw up many cases of people not being served the notices prescribed by the two laws.

The very bases of the LAA 1894, its legal premises, its apparent incompatibility with our constitutional frame of Fundamental Rights, Directive Principles of State Policy and Special Provisions for Scheduled Casts/Tribes and weaker sections has been widely questioned. Further, LAA's failure to provide any compensation excepting cash and its not being applicable to a large category of weaker people in the rural polity who obtain their livelihood from land but who are not regarded having any 'interest' in that land has also been strongly criticized by the Commissioner for SC/ST (1990), Fernandes and Thukral (1989), Morse and Berger (1992), Roy Burman (1992) and Dhagamwar (1989), among many others.

Commissioner for SC/ST (1990) is of the view that during the British period when the state started establishing its authority over the natural resources, the authority of the community prevalent till then was extinguished. The tradition in our country to regard natural resources as 'means of livelihood and not property' was ignored and 'and was treated purely as property belonging to the people to the validity of 'public purpose' in respect of land to be acquired or disposed of by the authorities in a roi tine way. Moreover, the objections under this provision cannot be raised by the people in general or the community but only by those who have interest in the land and the definition of interest in the land is quite narrow as discussed earlier. Our sample of oustees brought out many cases of people not being served even notices regarding the acquisition of their lands.

What has happened after the independence was that anything and everything was given the title of development. Therefore, it has been possible to use LAA, 1894 for almost all sorts of programmes including even tourist resorts for the affluent. EDF (1990) quotes the example of 'and acquisition for an "over sized airport" in Sonbhadra. Dhagamwar (1989) points out that the 1984 amendments to LAA, 1894 have made it much easier for land to be acquired and the private sector can do so through the government. Earlier they had to purchase it at market prices. Land can even be acquired for residential colonies. Under LAA 1894 the only entitlement for the persons whose land is acquired is cash compensation. The determination of compensation is also not equitable particularly in respect of tribal and backward areas where 'and cannot be freely sold.

"Therefore, when in pursuance of these incongruous principles and in a depressed psychological frame, the entire land of a farmer which is 'life personified for him' so much so that he is prepared to die or kill even when a field boundary is disturbed by someone, is snatched away under the shadow of the authority of the state, merely by throwing at him some rupee coins, numbering a hundred or two, he is hurt to the core, but cannot express-his anguish. In a state of utter helplessness he may get deeply disturbed and prefer to end his life. But the powers that be, do not see in'this 'even a

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shadow of injustice ?nywhere around them. Everything appears to be proper and equitable when looked at with spectacles of formal justice and the transaction may even be considered to be in his interest" (Commissioner, 1990). We heard some strajjtge comments from three officers responsible for assessing the property for rehabilitation. A very senio : officer of the NTPC said that, "we have civilized them and given them electric lights" (there were none in the colony houses)-or "it's very good of the government to pay you anything" and we did come across compensations as low as Rs 147 for a person's entire dwelling. And particularly to low-caste people, "why do you have such fine houses (permanent homes) - do you need such things?" (EDF, 1990). One wonders as to what this law is about and what is this system for?

The LAA, in a way, functioned like an indomitable and inanimate instrument of the transformation of the agriculture based traditional systems. In this process it is snatching away from the poor those meagre resources which have formed the very bases of their life so far and abruptly depriving them of their means to livelihood, totally. The law is so designed that the share cropper, agricultural labourer, the shepherd, the hunter and food gatherer, etc., do not even exist in its eyes. Even the owner of the land himself is given compensation simply for his ownership right, following the principles of market price and capitalization of net annual income and it is not even realised that land to a farmer is the source of making a living. The objections regarding validity of 'public purposes' in respect of land to be acquired are disposed of by the authorities in a routine way. Moreover, the objections under this provision cannot be raised by the people in general or the community but only by those who have interest in the land and the definition of interest in the land is quite narrow as discussed. Borger points out that the "planning process in India, however, betrays the spirit of the Indian constitution... acutely ... in the decisions concerning large, medium and small irrigation projects".

THE ISSUES

The findings of the study in Sonbhadra and the comments on our displacement and rehabilitation laws and industrial policies throw up several issues for consideration. The foremost is the basic dissonance between the human rights incorporated in the Constitution and the approach to compensation contained in the LAA, an archaic law, and the CBAA modelled similarly. The LAA enacted in the early colonial time took care of land acquisition, which was definitely on a limited scale then, for such public purposes as government buildings, roads, railway lines, etc. Now, extensive acquisitions are made under it in the garb of all the state action being for 'public purposes' including the commercial undertakings of the state or even private concerns. Most of these acquisitions were far in excess to requirement and some were sold at huge profits to other companies. The situation is critical and Mendelson and Baxi (1995) see it as 'subordination' of the people through "internal colonisation of India (relative to 'the tribals')". The PAPs are being denied their rights to life and to live with human dignity through a process of law in which they have all the handicaps - lack of even literacy what to say of education, information relating to its provisions, dire financial difficulties, no legal aid, a callous state machinery which will hit them at the most vulnerable moments/points, inaccessibility, of the decision makers, exploitation by outside elements, etc. Examples of inhuman attitude, some of which were mentioned here, abound. The PAPs have often been cowed down through sheer show of strength.

Another issue which become prominent is the multiplicity of directives/guidelines and approaches of different agencies of the state to a situation which is basically the same wherever displacements take place and whosoevei acquires the land. The Government of Uttar Pradesh and the Uttar Pradesh State Electricity Board (UPSEB) have different norms for rehabilitation measures. The state Government was quite generous to the PAP of, say, Tehri Dam when compared to the Sonbhadra projects. Is it because the tribal oustees in the latter area are not organized enough to pressurize the state and are a 'subordinated 'people? The PAPs are promised electricity and irrigation by no less a person than Nehru but none is given. The promises of employment reach only to about 10 per cent persons and no worthwhile efforts to create alternative skills or provide financial help to take up other vocations were seen. Similarly, in so far as the Government of India is concerned the guidelines given'by the Ministry of Welfare (relating to the SC/ST PAPs) are all different and almost none is followed. The most important of these measures - providing employment to one person per family - also drawn up by the World Bank (which financed NTPC projects) for the PAPs and the ST PAPs in particular have not been, followed by the NTPC in respect of the two Sonbhadra projects. Only the directions of the Supreme Court in the case of the NTPC Bijapur Thermal Power Project oustees are being implemented to a certain extent but in a tardy manner. No other project, however, regards it as a 'guideline'. So, do the PAPs in every projects have to go through public interest litigation in the apex court, just to get their 'right to life' vindicated and rehabilitated?

Lastly, how and why have the basic contradictions between the protective frames relating to tribal lands as contained in the constitution and the sweeping provisions of a mainstream central law like the LAA 1894 been allowed to continue and to be used extensively. While the British policy of keeping the trioal areas in isolation and their limited acquisitions of land often avoided the worst oppression of

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this law, in the sphere of development planning after 1950s there were all the reasons to restrict/modify its use among the tribals. On the other hand our hurry to industrialize without planning to bridge: the mismatch between tribal life and modern industrial stream has led to disastrous consequences, aptly termed as 'internal colonization'. In fact, the primitive agriculturist or the hunter-food gatherer with the sudden acquisition of agricultural land and/or deforestation of forest tracts for industrial purposes is suddenly pushed into the mainstream of industrialization. As Sharma (1976) candidly states:

> the objective of bridging the gap between the tribal areas and the more advanced areas and the desirability of the tribal communities joining, as early as possible, the mainstream of national life without indicating even broadly the possible growth paths is highly disastrous. Therefore, it is not surprising that the growth of industrial sector in tribal areas has been ubiquitous and is influenced by other considerations rather than being a part of an overall strategy of development of these areas. The industrial process is also essentially inward looking having little concern for its impact on the tribal economy.

The Government of India have been criticized by the World Bank and by legal experts, researchers, activists and social workers for not spelling out a comprehensive national policy on rehabilitation even when India is almost at the top of developing nations for the size of its projects and the number of PAPs. In spite of various declarations and assurances no such policy has come. Two states - Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra - have enacted laws incorporating some norms for rehabilitation. A model national policy had beer attempted by a group of NGOs (Dhagamwar, 1989). A recent workshop in which 60 representatives participated, again raised this question and they were told that a new draft had been made and submitted to the government after the Environment and Forests Minister asked them to do something *(Times of India,* 1995). However, just a policy or a statement of intent will rr,ake little improvement over the present day guidelines. The policy must be suitably enacted, thereby translating it into a legally justiciable document so as to effectively carry out the constitutional obligations of the Indian State. This document should also be devised as an instrument to move beyond a jurisprudence of mere individual rights to the collective rights of the oustee communities and also ensure their effective participation and involvement in the rehabilitation projects.

An excellent strategy has been spelt out by Sharma (1976) for planning industrialization of varying scales in these areas. But it has yet to receive any life. Only when it seriously applies itself to calibrating the path of painless integration of willing sections of the tribal communities into the modern industrial 'mainstream' and avoid imposing anything on them (Nehru, 1959) will it be useful to the tribals.. To quote Mendelson and Baxi (1995) "the process of overcoming subordination of whole communities entails recognition of the collective right of these people to order their own affairs". The National Human Rights Commission too, taking note of this area can push through a policy and legal frame which does not overlook the individual and collective rights of the PAPs, particularly the Scheduled Tribes.

ETHNIC PROBLEMS AND INTER - STATE BORDER PROBLEMS IN NORTH – EAST AND SOLUTIONS

– N. Changkakoti

Out of about 7 crore tribal people in the whole of India, belonging to around 360 tribes, North-East India comprising the seven sisters, namely, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland. Manipur. Tripura, Mi/.oram and Arunachal Pradesh is the home of around 1.3 crore ethnic people. Incidentally, India's tribal population is the highest in the world. Our Constitution has not defined the term "Tribe". But Article 342 of the Constitution empowers the President, in consultation with the Governors of concerned States, to draw up a list of the tribes inhabiting our country. Thus Scheduled Tribes are those tribes as the President may by public notification specify. However, Encyclopaedia Britannica explains the word 'tribe' as a group of people speaking a common la iguage. observing uniform rules of social organization and working together for common purposes such as agriculture, trade and warfare. Other typical characteristics are a common name, a contiguous territory, a relatively uniform culture or way of life and a tradition of common descent. Encyclopaedia Americana defines the term "Tribe" as a group of families who have a feeling of community through occupying a common territory and following similar custom. It also says that tribe and tribal are covenient terms for indicating that a people still follow custom rather than state law.

ETHNIC PROBLEMS AND LEGAL PROVISIONS

Our First Prime Minister Pandit Jawaliarlal Nehru displayed great understanding when he made the observation regarding the tribal people that "they possess a variety of culture and are, in many ways, certainly not backward. There is no point in trying to make them a second rate copy of ourselves.....The tribal people should be helped to grow according to their genius and tradition".

Accordingly, many special provisions have been

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incorporated in our Constitution to enable our ethnic minorities to grow according lo their genius and tradition and to protect their interests. Thus,

(i) Measures for the advancement of the Scheduled Castes and Tribes are exempted [Art. 15(4)J from the general ban against discrimination on the grounds of race, caste and the like contained in Art 15.

(ii) While the rights of free movement and residence throughout the territory of India and acquisition and disposition of property are guaranteed to every citizen, in the case of members of the Scheduled Castes and Tribes, special restrictions may be imposed by the state as may be required for the protection of their interests. [Art. 19 (5)]

(iii) The claims of the members of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes shall be taken into consideration, consistent with the maintenance of administration, in the making of appointments to services and posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or of State. [Art. 335]

(iv) Article 338 of the original constitution has been substituted by the Constitution (65th Amendment) Act, 1990 to set up a National Commission for Scheduled Castes and Tribes (in place of a special officer) to investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for the Scheduled Castes and Tribes under the Constitution and to enquire into any related complaints and to report to the President. The President shall cause all such reports to be laid before each House of Parliament along with a Memorandum explaining the action taken or proposed to be taken on the recommendations relating-to the Union. Similar action will be taken by the Governor of a - State if it is concerned with any matter relating to 'a' State.

(v) The President may at an.y tithe, and shall, at the expiration of ten years from the'commencement of the Constitution by order appoint a commission to report on the administration of the Scheduled Areas and the Welfare of the Scheduled Tribes in the States. The order may define the composition, powers and procedure of the Commission and may contain such incidental or ancillary provisions as the President may consider necessary or desirable. [Art. 339(1)].

(vi) The executive power of the Union shall extend to the giving of directions to any such state as to the drawing up and execution of schemes specified in the direction to be essential for the welfare of the Scheduled Tribes in the State. [Art. 339 (2)]

(vii) Financial aid for the implementation of these welfare schemes is provided for in Art. 275 (1) which requires the Union to give grants-in-aid to the states for meeting the costs of schemes of welfare of the Scheduled Tribes and for raising the level of administration of the Scheduled Areas in a State to that of the administration of the general areas of that state.

(viii) Special provisions are laid down in the Fifth and Sixth Schedules of the Constitution read with Art. 244 and 244 A, for the administration of areas inhabited by Scheduled Tribes.

Over and above these, there is a general Directive in Art. 46 that the state shall promote with special care the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections of the people and, in particular, of the Scheduled Castes and. the Scheduled Tribes, and shall protect them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation.

Besides, there are temporary provisions for special representation of and reservation of seats for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in the House of the People and State Legislative Assemblies. Further, there are also many state laws, rules and regulations for fulfilment of the same objective.

REASONS OF TRIBAL DISTRUST OF NON-TRIBAL PEOPLE

(a) The tribal people of North-Eastern India, particularly inhabiting the hills feel that their language, way of life, customs, ethos etc. are quite different from those of the people of the rest of India and they have no emotional links with them. They were also not under any Indian political set up before Britishers forcibly merged their land in British India. Therefore, when the Britishers left India, a large section of them felt that their communities should be free to decide whether it would be advantageous for them to remain within India or to become independent countries outside India.

(b) Because of the routine and generally apathetic approach of the Government towards the problems and grievances of the tribal and all other common people and also the condescending behaviour of Government officials towards the common men, the Government failed to w,,n the hearts of these simple people and make them feel that the quality of governance in free India will be better than the administration during the British rule. One example should suffice. During the period when present day Mizoram was a part of Assam in the name of Lushai Hills District, a big famine called Mautam' in Lushai

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language, had struck the District in 1959-60. As, in those days, there used to be no Superintendent of Police in the District and Deputy Commissioner used to be in charge of Police Department also, I was sent by Government to assist the Deputy Commissioner in maintaining law and order in those difficult days. I had (bund that the flow of relief materials like rice etc. from the Government was very slow and intermittent causing considerable suffering and resentment among the local people. Not to speak of any Minister of the Government of Assam, no senior officer of the Government visited the District during the crisis period to help the Deputy Commissioner in mitigating the suffering of the people. Goverment thus lost a golden opportunity to demonstrate its compassion and empathy for the Mizo people. On the other hand, lots of relief materials like milk powder etc. arrived from abroad which was highly appreciated by the people.

(c) Government of Assam adopted certain short-sighted policies taking into account the interest of the majority Assamese speaking people, ignoring the susceptibilities of the tribal people. Let me give one example. In I960, Government of Assam passed a bill making Assamese the state language of Assam, brushing aside the objections of the tribal people and other non-Assamese speaking people. Though even today, English is continuing to be used as the official language of Assam, the passing of this bill became another strong reason for a number of ethnic communities of the state to intensify their agitations for achieving for their territories separate political status outside Assam.

(d) The tribal people discovered that the Governments led and manned mostly by non-tribal people are not sincere in preserving their primary status in any particular area and in protecting tribal land, whatever may be the lofty provisions in this respect enshrined in the Constitution and therefore they felt that they must acquire enough political power to protect their interests. Let me give two examples.

(i) As a sequel to the partition of British India for creation of two independent countries — India and Pakistan in August 1947, lakhs of Hindu refugees from the territories included in Hast-Pakistan and now Bangladesh, migrated to Indian Union and most of them were settled in Tripura, causing alienation of most of the tribal land, reducing the i ndigenous Tripuri tribals to the status of minority and making them pathetically dependent on the mercy of the new settlers for the preservation of their identity and culture.

(ii) In 1947, the then Assam Government under the leadership of Late Gopinath Bordoloi, who was a rare Champion of tribal cause, had amended the Assam Land and Revenue Regulations of ! 886 to incorporate a new chapter (Tenth Chapter) therein, with the laudable objective of protecting the land of all backward classes which included tribal land also. On the basis of the regulations in this Chapter, Assam Government had created altogether 31 belts and blocks within the first five years from 1947 to 1951. At present there are 17 belts and 30 blocks on paper in Assam. As these belts and blocks were formed in the areas predominantly inhabited by tribal people, these are popularly known as "Tribal belts and blocks". However, it is a matter of grave concern that as per the estimate of the Government of Assam itself, more than six lakh bighas of Government land falling within the boundaries of these belts and blocks have been grabbed by non-tribal encroachers and successive Governments, swayed by vote bank politics, have hardly done anything to prevent it.

(e) As corruption increased with the passage of time in the functioning of the Government machinery and more and more developmental funds pumped into the economy did not reach the actual beneficiaries, the economically backward tribal people yearned for more and more political power in their hands as a panacea.

SOME ENCOURAGING TRENDS

Nevertheless, after many a twists and turns in the agitations - some peaceful and some violent - resorted to by different tribal communities in the North-Eastern region for different forms of self-rule, it is encouraging that most of these ethnic groups have given up the demand for secession, from India and have reconciled to some form of self-rule like statehood, district council setup or autonomous councils with varying degrees of political power. Even the most powerful faction of the Naga hostiles, namely, NSCN (IM) group is, nolonger,..'demanding independence and is now negotiating with Governrrfent-'of India for an honourable agreement with the demand 'for greater Nagaland. ULFA. which had been carrying on Guerrilla warfare against the Government since last 25 years, for liberation of Assam, is, most likely, to come to the negotiating table soon and under pressure of public opinion, is also, most likely to give up the demand for sovereign Assam, remaining content with a special status for Assam with some more political and financial powers. In Manipur, however, there is no sign so

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far of People's Liberation Army and other extremist groups giving up their armed struggle for creation of an independent Manipur and the situation needs to be handled with a human face.

SOME SUGGESTIONS TO SOLVE THE TRIBAL PROBLEM

Governments must keep in mind that if they do not back their words with deeds and honour the agreements so far arrived at with the extremist groups, in letter and spirit, they or some other groups may again take up the path of violence. For permanent peace in Nagaland, negotiations with the hostiles are yet to be concluded satisfactorily, without creating new problems. Again, even though many political entities have been created such as tribal states, district councils, territorial councils, autonomous councils to fulfil the aspirations of bigger tribal communities for self-rule, it is certainly not possible to satisfy such demands of all ethnic groups, however small. At the same time, steps have to be taken to ensure that these small tribal groups do not become victims of ethnic cleansing indulged in by any other stronger tribal group or any non-tribal community. In view of the above, it is also suggested that :

(a) The National Council for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes as provided for in the Constitution should be constituted with a retired Supreme Court Judge as Chairman and it should have a strong monitoring wing to closely monitor the implementation of various schemes for upliftment of different ethnic groups in the North-East strictly as per sanction and without any corruption. The Commission may also be advised to examine and recommend if any new legal or other provisions need to be made in ensure that the interests of other small ethnic communities also get due attention and they can also grow according to their genius and tradition without any hindrance and in every tribal village whichever politico-administrative structure, it may be, shares a sense of participation in self-governance.

(b) Special arrangement should be made for selection of only those officers of different Departments for service in the tribal areas who are not desk bound, have affection and sympathy for the tribals and feel no difficulty in living in an environment without modern facilities. Such selected public servants should be given a special Tribal Area Allowance and should not be posted in such areas for more than live years.

(c) As the tribal people are very much dependent on land for their livlihood and the land at their disposal are becoming insufficient to sustain their increasing population, educational and vocational training facilities for the tribal youth should be increased considerably without delay to enlarge their employment opportunities.

(d) In Manipur, even if the situation does not permit withdrawal of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act, in spite of the recommendation to this effect by the special committee set up for the purpose 2/3 years ago, there is scope for amending the same to reduce scope for misuse of the powers given by the Act. This should be done immediately and urgent steps should be taken to considerably enlarge the scope of employment of Manipuri youth to prevent them from being recruited by the extremist organizations.

INTER-STATE BORDER PROBLEM IN THE NORTH-EASTERN REGION

(a) Assam-Nagaland

At the commencement of our constitution, in parts A and B of the table btilow paragraph 20 of the Sixth Schedule under head "Tribal Areas" two areas inhabited almost entirely by Naga Tribes within the state of Assam were mentioned. These arc :

(i) The Naga Hills District in Part A

(ii) The Naga Tribal Area in Part B

In the year 1957, Government oflndia passed The Naga Hills -Tuensang Area Act, wliich came into effect on 1st December, 1957. Section 2 of this Act says that "as from the commencement of tliis Act, there shall be formed a new administrative unit in the state of Assam by the name of Naga Hills-Tuensang Area comprising the tribal areas which at such commencement were known as the Naga Hills District and Tuensang Frontier Division of the North-East Frontier Agency". The Act also stated in Section 3 that the Naga Hills-Tuensang Area shall comprise the areas which at the commencement of the Constitution were known as the Naga Hills District and the Naga Tribal Area. Subsequently, Government of India passed the State of Nagaland Act, 1962 which came into effect on 1st December, 1963. Section 3 (1) of this Act says that "As from the appointed Day, there shall be formed a new state to be known as the State of Nagaland comprising the territories which immediately before that Day were comprised in the Naga Hills-Tuensang area and there upon the said territories shall cease to form part of the state of Assam". It follows as a logical corollary that the boundaries of the new State is exact. ly the same as was the boundaries of combined Naga Hills District and the Naga Tribal Area which was subsequently known as Tuensang Frontier Division of North-East Frontier Agency.

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There has been no change in the boundaries of Naga Hills District since the erstwhile British Government had issued Notification No 3102 R dt. 25th November, 1925 in supersession of all previous Notifications, defining the boundaries of the Naga Hills District and, therefore, this District of Assam became a p irt of newly created Nagaland State on 1st December, 1963 with this boundary only. The details of this Notification were based on survey oper itions conducted between 1916 and 1923 and the boundaries have been very clearly defined and located with reference to Hill ranges, rivers, streams and boundary pillars.

In 1960, there was a meeting between Government of India and Naga Leaders to discuss sixteen point memorandum submitted by (hem about creation of the new State of Nagaland. The Naga Leaders had laid claims to certain reserve forest within Assam, on the plea that these forests had in the past formed part of the Naga Hills District, Government of India, however, had made it c)ear that it was not possible to go beyond the 1925 Notification and had pointed out the provisions in Articles 3 and 4 of the Constitution prescribing the procedure for the transfer of areas from one state to another. Soon after the creation of Nagaland State in 1963, Government of Nagaland started claiming some territories of Assam, particularly Reserved Forests in the then Sibsagar (now Jorhat, Sibsagar and Golaghat) District and also the North Cachar Hills District of Assam. Simultaneously, encroachments on the reserved forests of Assam increased in accordance with the claim. This created considerable tension in Assam Nagaland border areas, endangering the lives and properties of innocent people. In the year 1971, Government of India, in consultation with the Government of Assam and Nagaland, appointed Shri K.V.K. Sundaram, the then Chairman of the Law Commission as Adviser in the Ministry of Home Affairs and was given the following task : "'Hie Adviser will ascertain the facts regarding the Assam-Nagaland boundary and the need for any adjustment, having regard to all the facts of the situation, including the provisions of Section 3 of the State of Nagaland Act, 1962. He will consult the Chief Ministers of the two State Governments, and such other persons as he considers necessary. He will try to bring about an agreed solution likely to promote the welfare and interests of the people of the two states and to create faith and goodwill between them. He will also put forward suggestion, if necessary, to maintain peace and tranquillity in the border areas pending his final- advice."

Shri Sundaram, after detailed survey of the border areas of Assam claimed by Nagaland, through scrutiny of the justifications put forward by Nagaland Government in support of their claim of Assam's land and ineeting all concerned persons of both sides, submitted his report in 1978. In his report, except Nagaland's claim on Desai valley reserve, Shri Suridaram rejected all other claims of Nagaland for inclusion of 'North Cachar Hills, Mikir Hills, Sarupathar Thana elaka of Golaghat District, and all other Reserved Forests of Assam in erstwhile Sibsagar District as unjustifiable. On the other hand, he observed in his report that "although the plains area around Dimapur was rightly taken out of the Naga Hills district in 1898, it was put back in that District in 1913 for no good reason. If the boundary question was allowed 1o be reopened on purely historical grounds, Assam would be justified in asking for the retransfer of this traditionally Mikir-Cachar tract."

While Assam Government accepted the report, the Government of Nagaland rejected it. As Government of Indiahas not put its feet down for honouring the report by Nagaland Government, encroachments continued unabated. At present, total area of Assam's land encroached from Nagaland side is 54150 Hectares of Forest land and 1030 Hectares of Revenue land. Further. Nagaland Government have established three of their sub-divisions, namely, Tizit in!984-85 in Abhoypur RF, Newland in 1987 in Rengma RF and Kohoboto in 1991 in Diphu RF within trie territory of Assam.

It is unfortunate that Government of India has not taken a-firm stand on the issue and meanwhile many innocent people have lost their lives and a number of clashes between Nagaland Police and Assam Police have also taken place and the relations between the two states have become very much strained. If necessary. Government of India may constitute another boundary commission with prior commitment of both Governments to aceept the findings of the commission to resolve the issue. This is such an issue that Hon'ble Supreme Court's intervention can be sought through a Public interest litigation petition.

(b) Assam-Meghalaya

The State of Meghalaya came into existence on 21 st January, 1972 on the basis of the Noith-Eastern Areas (Reorganisation) Act, 1971. It comprises the erstwhile United Khasi and Jaintia Hills District and Garo Hills District of Assam. The state has common boundary with the following Districts of present day Assam :

(i) Goal-para District
(ii) Kamrup District
(iii) Nagaon District
(iv) Karbi Anglong District
(v) North Cachar Hills District and
(vi) Cachar District

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Soon after Meghalaya State was formed differences between the two State Governments regarding some stretches of the Inter-state boundary came to the fore. As the differences could not be resolved at lower levels, a meeting was held on 26th May, 1983 in Shillong between the Chief Ministers of Assam and Meghalaya, in which the following decision was taken :

"It was decided that a Joint Official Con.mittee be formed with the Chief Secretary, Assam, and the Chief Secretary, Meghalaya as joint convenors to identify the areas of differences on the Assam-Meghalaya boundary. The Chief Secretaries will be assisted by such officers as they consider necessary. At a subsequent stage, if necessary, a representative of the Survey of India may also be associated with the Committee. The Committee will submit its report within a period of two months, i.e. by the end of July, 1983.

It was agreed between the two Chief Ministers that instructions will be reiterated to all the concerned authorities to maintain peace on the border and not to take any action to precipitate matters."

The Committee met four times and finalised its report on the 16th November, 1983.

The Joint Official Committee identified the areas of differences and classified them sector-wise as follows : –

Sector 1 - Boundary between Garo Hills district of Meghalaya and Goalpara district of Assam.

Sector 2 - Boundary between Jaintia Hills district of Meghalaya and Karhi Anglong district of Assam.

Sector 3 - Boundary between Hast Khasi Hills district of Meghalaya and Karbi Anglong district of Assam.

Sector 4 - Areas where the question of retransfer is involved, viz., retransfer of Block I and Block II of the Karbi Anglong district of Assam to Meghalaya.

Sector 5 - Boundary between Cacliar district of Assam and Jaintia Hills district of Meghalaya.

Sector 6 - Boundary between the districts of tvost and West Khasi Hills of Meghalaya and districts of Kamrup and Novvgong of Assam."

Except for the differences in Sector 4 and Sector 6. differences in the other sectors could be resolved through demarcation on the ground of the common boundary by joint survey parties with the assistance of Survey of India, where necessary in accordance with the relevant Notifications regarding which there was no dispute. As regards Sector 4, the difference between the two Governments about whether the two blocks should remain in Assam or transferred to Meglalaya has not ended. The matter can certainly be settled on the basis of whether Khasi-Jaintia population or the Karbi population were in the majority on the date of creation of Meghalaya. For resolving the differences as regards Sector 6, the Government of Assam and Meghalaya, by two idential resolutions dated 19th October, 1985 referred the matter to a committee headed by Mr. Justice Y.V. Chandrachud, former Chief Justice of India. The committee after examining in detail the representations of both the Governments and after hearing the counsels of both the Governments submitted its report on 27th July, 1987 wherein the committee rejected all the claims of the Government ol Meghalaya to certain Khasi inhabited areas inside Assam. There is no further efforts on the part of Meghalaya Government to include: these areas in Meghalaya. Though the situation in the entire border is normal at present, the two Governments should sort out the remaining differences urgently with a spirit of give and take and meanwhile retrain from doing anything illegal to alter the status quo so that no untoward incident recurs as had happened earlier.

(c) Assam - Arunachal

Section 7 of the North-Eastern Areas (Reorganisation) Act, 1971, by virtue of which Arunachal Pradesh was first created as an union territory with effect from January 20, 1972 and which was subsequently upgraded as a full-fledged state on February 20,1987, mentions the territories of this state as follows : –

"On and from the appointed day, there shall be formed a new Union Territory, to be known as the Union Territory of Arunachal Pradesh comprising the territories which immediately before that day were comprised in the tribal areas specified in Part B of the table appended to Paragraph 20 of the Sixth Schedule to the Constitution (but excluding the areas covered by Notification No. TAD/R/35/50/109 dt. 23rd February, 1951 issued by the Governor of Assam under the proviso to sub-paragraph (3) of the said paragraph 20 and known as the North-Eastern Frontier Agency and thereupon the said territories shall cease to form part of the existing state of Assam." Part B of the table appended to Paragraph 20 of the Sixth Scheduled to our Constitution mentions the following territories :

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1. North East Frontier Tract including Balipara Frontier Tract, Tirap Frontier Tract, Abor Hills District and Mishmi Hills District.
2. The Naga Tribal Areas.

Notification No. TAD/R/35/50/109 dt. 23rd February, 1951 issued by the Governor of Assam under the provison to sub-paragraph (3) of Paragraph. 20 to the Constitution of India, covers a clearly specified area in the plains portion of the Balipani Frontier Tract, Abor Hills, Mishmi Hills and the Trip Frontier Tract and these plains areas thus do not form part of Arunachal Pradesh. In North-East Frontier Area-(Administration) Regulation, 1954, the NagaTribal Area mentioned in Part B of the Table appended to Paragraph 20 referred to above, was renamed as Tuensang Frontier Division and this area was transferred to the new administrative unit known as Naga Hills-Tuensang area in 1957, which became the separate state of Nagaland on 1-12-1963. Arunachal Pradesh has a common boundary with Dhemaji, Lakhimpur, Sonitpur, Darrang, Tinsukia and Sibsagar Districts of Assam.

While the Notifications specifying different sections of the boundary of Arunachal Pradesh are quite clear, there could be differences here and there as regards exact ground location. To avoid any misunderstanding over this matter, as early as in 1969, at an official meeting between the Chief Secretary, Assam and the Adviser to the Governor of Assam for erstwhile North-East Frontier Agency, it was decided that the boundary should be surveyed by the Survey of India and the ground demarcation by Survey of India was to be on the basis of sets of maps showing the Assam-Arunachal boundary signed by both the Governments. Upto 1973-74 field season, a total length of about 396 -kilometres of the boundary was demarcated, out of which Assam did not accept pillar positions in about 25 kilometres and Arunachal Pradesh did not accept demarcation in about 111 kilometres. Of the total length of about 308 kilometres of the undemarcated boundary, only 93 kilometres could be demarceted by Survey of India till 1984 and work could not proceed further due to violent resistance from local Arunachalis to prevent the eventuality of their coming under the Assam administration. In fact, though there were violations of Assam territory by the Arunachalis since long, a series of encroachments by Arunachalis and Arunachal administration inside Assam territory, intimidation and harassment of people living on the Assam side of the border by the Arunachalis took place in quick succession since rhe beginning of 1978, disturbing the peace and tranquillity in the border area. Such encroachments were very noticeable in Kimin, Dirpai, Likabali, Dullungmukh and Jonai areas. Arunachal Administration established a circle office, PWD and Forest offices in Kimin well inside Assam, constructed a Health Centre and Staff quarters at Telem in lonai area and built a Anchal Samiti House at Likabali without any permission from Government of Assam.

Without going into further details, it needs to be stated that the situation demands urgent intervention by Government of India to undo any illegalities committed by any of the Governments involved and to enable the Survey of India to complete the work of ground demarcation of the boundary in the next field season itself by providing required security and logistical support from the resources of Government of India. On the other hand, any village of Arunachali tribals which will fall within Assam boundary after ground demarcation, should be given due facilities by Assam Government to develop according to their culture and tradition in conformity with the constitutional and other provisions for development of scheduled tribes.

(d) Assam-Mizoram

Mizoram had become a full-fledged state of the Indian Union on 20-2-1987 as a sequel to the signing of the historic memorandum of settlement between Government of India and Mizo National Front in 1986. Earlier Lushai Hills District of Assam was renamed as Mizo Hills in 1954 and after the promulgation of North-Eastern Areas (Reorganisation) Act, 1971, it had become a Union Territory by the name of Mizorum with effect from 21-1-1972. Thus the Assam Mizoram inter-state boundary is the same as the old inter-district boundary between old Cachar District and Lushai Hill District of Assam. This boundary was notified under Notification No. 2106 AP dated March 9, 1933. This boundary has not been changed after our country became independent and Mizoram State Act accepted this boundary Notification. Actually, therefore, there can be no boundary dispute betweer the two states. But the problem arose because of encroachments in the Reserve Forest areas of Cachar district by people from Mizoram and the efforts made by Mizoram Government on its own to change the border in their favour on untenable historical, ethnic and such other factors. The problem will be over once, Government of Assam extends its -effective adminisjrauon in the border areas and Mizoram Government, re.rrain from dishonouring the legal provisions as regards its boundary with Assam. At present, there is, of course, no fresh encroachment and tension in the border areas.

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FOREST (CONSERVATION) ACT, 1980 WITH AMENDMENTS MADE IN 1988

An Act to provide for the conservation of forests and for matters connected therewith or ancillary or incidental thereto.

1. Short title, extent and commencement.

(1) This Act may be called the Forest (Conservation) Act, 1980.

(2) It extends to the whole of India except the State of Jammu and Kashmir.

(3) It shall be deemed to have come into force on the 25th day of October, 1980.

2. Restriction on the dereservation of forests or use of forest land for non-forest purpose.

(i) no reserved forest (within the meaning of the expression "reserved forest" in any law for the time being in force in that State) or any portion thereof, can be dereserved;

(ii) no forest land or any portion thereof may be used for any non-forest purpose;

(iii) no forest land or any portion thereof may be assigned by way of lease or otherwise to any private person or to any authority, corporation, agency or any other organisation not owned, managed or controlled by Government;

(iv) no forest land or any portion thereof may be cleared of trees which have grown naturally in that land or portion, for the purpose of using it for reafforestation.

In this context, "non-forest purpose" means the breaking up or clearing of any forest land or portion thereof for-

(a) the cultivation of tea, coffee, spices, rubber, palms, oil-bearing plants, horticultural crops or medicinal plants;

(b) any purpose other than reafforestation;

but does not include any work relating or ancillary to conservation, development and management of forests and wildlife, namely, the establishment of check-posts, fire lines, wireless communications and construction of fencing, bridges and culverts, dams, waterholes, trench marks, boundary marks, pipelines or other like purposes.

3. Constitution of Advisory Committee.

The Central Government may constitute a Committee consisting of such number of persons as it may deem fit to advise that Government with regard to any matter connected with the conservation of forests which may be referred to it by the Central Government.

3A. Penalty for contravention of the provisions of the Act.

Whoever contravenes or abetes the contravention of any of the provisions of Section 2, shall be punishable with simple imprisonment for a period which may extend to fifteen days.

3B. Offences by the Authorities and Government Departments.

(1) Where any offence under this Act has been committed-

(a) by any department of Government, the head of the department; or

(b) by any authority, every person who, at the time the offence was committed, was directly in charge of, and was responsible to, the authority for the conduct of the business of the authority as well as the authority; shall be deemed to be guilty of the offence and shall be liable to be proceeded against and punished accordingly.

4. Power to make rules.

The Central Government may, by notification in the Official Gazette, makes rules for carrying out the provisions of this Act.

THE SCHEDULED TRIBES AND OTHER TRADITIONAL FOREST DWELLERS (RECOGNITION OF FOREST RIGHTS) ACT, 2006

The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 is a result of the protracted struggle by the marginal and tribal communities of our country to assert their rights over the forestland over which they were traditionally dependent. This Act is crucial to the rights of millions of tribals and other forest dwellers in different parts of our country as it provides for the restitution of deprived forest rights across India, including both individual rights to cultivated land in forestland and community rights over common property

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resources. The notification of Rules for the implementation of the Forest Rights Act, 2006 on 1st Jan 2008, has finally paved the way to undo the 'historic injustice' done to the tribals and other forest dwellers.

The livelihood of perhaps 100 million poorest of the poor stands to improve if implementation can succeed. The Act is significant as it provides scope and historic opportunity of integrating conservation and livelihood rights of the people.

This Act can be seen as a potential tool

- To empower and strengthen the local self governance
- To address the livelihood security of the people, leading to poverty alleviation and pro poor growth
- To address the issues of Conservation and management of the Natural Resources and conservation governance of India.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE ACT

For the first time Forest Rights Act recognises and secures

- Community Rights or rights over common property resources of the communities in addition to their individual rights
- Rights in and over disputed land
- Rights of settlement and conversion of all forest villages, old habitation, unsurveyed villages and other villages in forests into revenue villages
- Right to protect, regenerate or conserve or manage any community forest resource which the communities have been traditionally protecting and conserving for sustainable use.
- Right to intellectual property and traditional knowledge related to biodiversity and cultural diversity
- Rights of displaced communities
- Rights over developmental activities

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CONSTITUTIONAL SAFEGUARDS FOR STs

THE CONSTITUTION PROVIDES various safeguards in favour of Scheduled Tribes. These may be broadly divided into two parts, viz., (1) Protection and (2) Development. Protection of interests of Scheduled Tribes is very essential for their development. The protective provisions are contained in Articles 15(4), 16(4), 19(5), 23, 29, 46, 164, 330, 332, 334, 335 and 338, 339(1), 371 (A), 371(B), 371(C), Fifth Schedule and Sixth Schedule. Articles 15(4), 16(4) and 19(5) are exception to the fundamental rights of equality and freedom guaranteed under Part III of the Constitution. Provisions relating to development of Scheduled Tribes are contained mainly in Articles 275(1) first provision and 339(2). A brief mention of these provisions is given below.

PROTECTIVE PROVISIONS

ARTICLE 15(4) : PROMOTION OF SOCIAL, ECONOMIC AND EDUCATIONAL INTERESTS.

Article 15 prohibits any discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth. But clause 4 of this Article provides an exception to this. It empowers the State to make any special provision for the advancement of socially and educationally backward classes of the citizens or for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. This provision is in accordance with the policy envisaged in Article 46 that the State should promote with special care educational and economic interests of the weaker sections of the people and protect them for social injustice. This clause has been especially incorporated to prevent any special provision made by a state for the advancement of socially or educationally backward classes of citizens from being challenged in the law courts on the grounds of it being discriminatory.

The object of this clause added in 1951 through an amendment of the Constitution, is to bring Articles 15 and 29 in line with Articles 16(4), 46 and. 340, and to make it constitutional for the State to reserve seats for citizens belonging to backward classes, Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in the public educational institutions as well as to make other special provisions as may be necessary for their advancement, e.g. provision of residential accommodation. It enables the State to do what would otherwise have been unconstitutional. The special provisions may be made not only by the Legislature but also by the Executive. Such special provisions may, thus consist of :

(a) reservation of seats for members of backward classes in educational institution,

(b) relaxation of qualifications required for admission into such institutions,

(c) providing housing accommodation to members of such classes, and

(d) confessional treatment for them in the matter of settlement of Government lands.

The test of backwardness under Article 15(4) is "Social and Educational"

ARTICLE 16(4): RESERVATION IN POSTS AND SERVICES

Article 16(4) is another exception to the right of equality of opportunity in the matters of public employment laid down in clauses 1 and 2 of Article 16.

SCOPE OF CLAUSE (4)

Clause (4) of Article 16 only permits reservation for backward classes of citizens, who are not in the opinion of the State, adequately represented in the services of the State. This clause empowers the State to reserve appointments or posts in favour of any backward class of citizens in the services under it.

The words 'appointments' or 'posts' used in Clause 4 are very significant. A question arose as to whether the word 'posts' referred to posts within the regular service under the State or to posts outside the regular services, which are known as ex-cadre posts. The Supreme Court in General Manager Vs Rangachari case (1962) held that both the words appointments and posts refer to the services in respect of which the State is of opinion that the backward classes are not adequately represented. The Court, further held that the word posts was inserted in order to provide for the reservation of selection posts so that, Clause 4 would enable the state not to reserve posts of the lower grade but also posts to which appointment is made by selection on the basis of merit.

LIMITS OF RESERVATION

Article 335 provides that the claims of the members of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes as regards appointments in services shall be taken into consideration "Consistently with the maintenance of efficiency of the administration", but there is no such limitation in Article 16(4). That makes it evident that the Court cannot interfere with any particular reservation or the quantum of aggregate reservation in a State on the ground that it is not consistent with the efficiency of the administration. Though the State cannot reserve unreasonable percentage of the posts for

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the backward classes, a member of a backward class can be appointed to non-reserved posts if found eligible by merit after such competition.

ARTICLE 14 AND 16(4)

The two provisions should be so construed as not to render nugatory either of them. If the reservation made under Article 16(4) is kept within reasonable limits, there would be no contravention of Article 14. But there may be a denial of equality before the law of members of the more advanced classes if the reservation is excessive i.e., over 50 per cent of the posts.

ARTICLE 15(4) AND 16(4)

Both have provisions for safeguarding the interests of backward classes but while Article 15(4) enables the State to offer protective discrimination. to the backward classes in all its dealings, Article 16(4) specially provides for protective discrimination in the matter of employment in the services under the State. Article 15(4), would govern the other matters, such as admission to the State educational institutions.

ARTICLE 19(5): SAFEGUARD OF TRIBAL INTEREST IN PROPERTY

While the rights of free movement and residence throughout the territory of India and of acquisition and disposition of property are guaranteed to every citizen, special restrictions may be imposed by the State for protection of the interests of the members of the Scheduled Tribes under Article

The Scheduled Tribes are economically backward and unsophisticated class of people who are liable to be easily deceived by shrewd and designing persons. Hence, there are various provisions disabling them from alienating even their own properties except under special conditions. In their own interest and for their own benefit, laws may be made restricting the right of the ordinary citizens to move freely or settle in particular areas or acquire property in them.

The specific mention of the Scheduled Tribes, along with "the interests of the general public" indicates that restrictions made for the protection of the Scheduled Tribes would be upheld under clause 5 even though such restrictions may not be in the interests of the general public.

Though the Clause is silent about the Scheduled Castes, restrictions can also be imposed for their protection. As they are a backward class, prevention of their exploitation would be in the interest of the general public.

ARTICLE 23

Article 23 prohibits traffic in human beings, begar and other similar forms of forced labour. This is a very significant provision so far as Scheduled Tribes are concerned as many of them are employed as bonded labour.

ARTICLE 29 : CULTURAL AND EDUCATIONAL RIGHTS

Article 29 (2) is controlled by the Clause 4 of Article 15, incorporated in the Constitution by the First Amendment Act, 1951. This has brought Articles 15 and 29 in line with Article 16(4), 46 and 340 and made it constitutional for the State to reserve seats for the backward classes of citizens, in public educational institutions.

According to Article 29 a cultural or linguistic minority has right to conserve its language or culture.. This Article provides protection to Scheduled Tribe communities to preserve their languages, dialects and cultures. The State would not by law enforce upon it any other culture or language.

ARTICLE 46

This Article provides for promotion of educational and economic interests of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and other weaker sections.

SCOPE OF THE ARTICLE

Under this Article the State is at liberty todo anything to promote the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections of the people. But this Article is subject to limitations imposed by fundamental rights.

Articles 15 and 29 relating to fundamental rights have been amended by the Constitution Act, 1951, in order to give effect to this Article.

Article 46 is a Directive Principle. It does not confer any justiciable right. A member of a backward class cannot obtain relief from the Court if he is denied any concession in matters of education relating to school fees, etc.

OBJECTIVE OF THE DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES

The Directive Principles lay down the policy guidelines on which the State should work under the Constitution.

LIMITS OF THE DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES

The Directive Principles contained in Article 46 enjoins the State to "promote with special care" the educational and economic interest of the weaker sections of the people, including theJScheduled Castes and Tribes. However, the

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State's action is limited by provisions "such as "maintenance of efficiency of the Administration" or the maintenance of a minimum standard in educational institutions, etc. But a temporary relaxation of the qualifications and tests for recruits from the Scheduled Castes and Tribes would not militate against any of the national interests or the provision of Article 335. (State of Kerala Vs Thomas, 1976 SC).

ARTICLE 164

This Article provides for a Minister in charge of tribal welfare in the state of Bihar, Orissa and Madhya Pradesh. Where states have substantial tribal population and special provision of a Minister looking after tribal welfare is an evidence of the concern of the framers of the Constitution for safeguarding the interest of Scheduled Tribes.

ARTICLE 320(4)

Article 320(4) provided that Public Service Commissions need not be consulted as respects the manner in which any provision referred to in Clause 4 of Article 16 may be made or as respects the manner in which effect may be given to the provisions of Article 335.

ARTICLES 330, 332 AND 334

Seats shall be reserved in the House of People for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Article 330). Seats shall also be reserved for the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes in the Legislative Assembly of every State (Article 332).

Such reservation shall cease to have effect on the expiration of a period of 40 years from the commencement of the constitution i.e., in 1990 (Article 334). It was originally for a period of 10 years from the commencement of Constitution but, by an amendment of Article 334, has been extended by another 30 years i.e., upto the end of 1990.

ARTICLE 335: LIMITS OF RESERVATION

The claims of members of Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes shall be taken into consideration in the matter of appointment to the services and posts under the Union and the States as far as may be consistent with the maintenance of efficiency of administration.

ARTICLE 338 : SPECIAL OFFICER

There shall be a Special Officer for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes to be appointed by the President. It shall be the duty of the Special Officer to investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes under the Constitution. He shall report to the President upon the working of those safeguards at such intervals as the President may direct. The President shall cause all such reports to be laid before each House of Parliament. Such an officer has been appointed and designated as Commissioner for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

ARTICLE 339(1) : APPOINTMENT OF A COMMISSION

The President may, at any time and shall, at the expiration of 10 years from the commencement of the Constitution, by order appoint a Commission to report on the administration of Scheduled Areas and the welfare of the Scheduled Tribes in the States (Article 339) (1). Only one such Commission, namely, Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes Commission, was appointed on 28th April 1960 and it submitted its Report in October 1961.

Although the Constitution has made elaborate provisions for safeguarding the interest of Scheduled Tribes, the enforcement of the same has not been of desired level. Provisions made under Articles 371(A), 371(B), 371(C), Fifth and Sixth Schedules of the Constitution have been mentioned elsewhere.

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

Provisions relating to economic development of Scheduled Tribes are mainly contained in Articles 275(1) and 339(2). Briefly, it may be stated that Article 275(1), first proviso envisages provision for grants-in-aid for meeting the cost of such schemes of development as may be undertaken by a state with the approval of the Government of India for the purpose of promoting the welfare of its Scheduled Tribes or raising the level of administration of the Scheduled Areas therein to that of the administration of the rest of the areas, of the state. In pursuance of this Article, provision of special central assistance has been made to the states having Scheduled Tribe population. As per the provision, the grant is to be made against such specific schemes as are necessary for the welfare of Scheduled Tribes and are undertaken with the prior approval of the Union Government. But this is not done. The grants are released without specific schemes.

Article 339(2) goes still further and empowers the Union Executive to issue directive to a State as to the drawing up and execution of schemes specified in the directive to be essential for the welfare of the Scheduled Tribes in the state.

Despite poor performance by State Governments the powers vested in these provisions have not been utilised so far and no directive has been issued.

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TRIBAL DEVELOPMENT

THE FRAMERS OF the Constitution while taking note of the centuries old injustice perpetrated against the tribal communities, have adopted two-pronged strategy of tribal development which seeks to provide them protection from exploitation and assist them in their economic development. Protection is prerequisite to development, particularly during the transition period until they came up to the general level and joined the mainstream of the nation. Protective discrimination has been provided for in favour of Scheduled Tribes in the Constitution, particularly under Article 15(4), 16(4), 19(5), 46, 33.0, 332, 335 and the Fifth and the Sixth Schedules. Similarly, provisions have been made for the economic development of these communities, under Articles 275(1) first provision and 339(2). These provisions assign-special responsibility to the Government not only for drawing up of special schemes of development but also for providing them financial assistance.

DEVELOPMENT EFFORTS SINCE INDEPENDENCE

Various planned efforts have been made since independence for economic development of the tribals. The first attempt was made in 1954 when 43 special multipurpose development projects each with an additional outlay of Rs. 27 lakhs for five years were started to supplement the Community Development Programmes which aimed at comprehensive development of rural areas. Since these projects were in the areas which comprised sparsely populated hill and forest regions, with poor communication and limited institutional infrastructure they called for greater investment and personal attention by extension workers. The efforts, therefore, did not achieve the desired success.

The situation was reviewed in 1956 by Elwin Committee which recommended a cautious approach in the introduction of multiplicity of schemes in tribal areas. On review, the projects were substituted by a less intensive model of tribal development blocks in 1957. The norm for a tribal development block was confined to an area of 150 to 200 sq. miles and a population of about 25000. The blocks were supposed to work for tribal population under intensive development programme. They were to concentrate on the following four main activities, viz., economic development, education, health and communication and were to have specific targets.

The tribal scenario was subjected to comprehensive review by the Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes Commission, generally called Dhebar Commission, in April 1960 and it submitted its report in October 1961. The Commission noted that the pace of development in the tribal areas was slow. Investment and other protective measures were also inadequate and needed urgent attention of the Government. It called for comprehensive legislation to cover all tribals living within the Scheduled Areas and outside, and a simple administrative system for tribal areas. It recommended a scheme of tribal development blocks for all areas with more than 50 per cent tribal population.

The recommendations of the Commission were accepted and the block approach was continued. By the end of Third Five Year Plan, the scheme was implemented in about 500 blocks covering about 40 per cent of the total tribal population. It precluded a large section of the tribal population from the development programmes. The tribal situation, so far as protective measures and developmental programmes are concerned, remained almost unchanged. In 1969, a Committee under, the Chairmanship of Shilu Ao was appointed to review the tribal development programmes. It observed that most of the recommendations of the Dhebar Commission had remained unimplemented and urged that they should be implemented without any further delay. It disapproved the block approach as inadequate. The block was too small to function effectively as a basic unit of planning and implementation. It pointed out that the main problems of the tribals related to indebtedness, land alienation, economic backwardness and inadequate communication and suggested that those should be tackled on priority basis by formulating a comprehensive programme of development.

During the Fourth Plan, six tribal development agencies were started as pilot schemes in four states, viz., two in Madhya Pradesh, two in Orissa and one each in Bihar and Andhra Pradesh. Subsequently, two more agencies were started in Orissa by the end of the Fourth Plan. Each agency covered a group of blocks and was expected to take up various programmes and protective measures on integrated basis by pooling up the resources. In the Fourth Plan, about Rs. 44 crores were allotted to these agencies. The allocations were in addition to the normal outlays. In actual practice, however, the agency approach practically remained an agricultural development programme and failed to achieve the desired results. This approach was not extended to other areas and the blocks continued to be the unit of development.

TRIBAL SUB-PLAN

The tribal situation was again reviewed on the eve of the Fifth Five Year Plan by a task force on "Development of

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Tribal Areas" constituted by the Planning Commission. It opined that the deficiencies and shortcomings pointed out by the earlier Commissions and , Committees had generally remained unattended. It observed that one of the important factors for the failure of the development programmes, is that the Scheduled Tribes and tribal areas have been looked upon as a 'welfare' problem as distinguished from "development" problem. The welfare of Scheduled Tribes has continued to depend on small outlays under the Backward classes sector and not on general sector outlays. The administrative structure in tribal areas lacks simplicity. It is beyond the comprehension of the Tribals and therefore it does not evoke any response from them. Such a structure of administration may not therefore be suitable for carrying out integrated development of tribal areas. The Task Force recommended that to ensure balanced socio-economic development of the tribal areas a policy of integrated development would be necessary for the Fifth and subsequent Plans. Therefore, a Tribal Sub Plan strategy was evolved in 1974-75. This strategy emphasized area development with a focus on improving the quality of life of the tribal communities. Its immediate objectives were elimination of exploitation in all forms, speeding up the process of social and economic development, building up inner strength of people and improving their organisational capabilities. It observed that any developmental activity for benefiting the tribal population will not succeed unless exploitation in various forms is prevented. For protecting the tribals from exploitation it recommended integrated credit- cum-marketing service, marketing of agricultural and minor forest produce, supply of inputs and essential consumer commodities, credit for production purposes, consumption of social needs, redemption of past debts through legislative and executive measures and adoption of suitable measures for dealing with resultant liability. It also emphasised that the programmes for prevention of land alienation, restoration of land already alienated, termination of practices like bonded labour, solution of the problems created in the zones of influence of modern industrialised areas and review of excise and forest policies needed special attention.

For development of tribal economy, the Tribal Sub-plan strategy recommended giving high priority to agriculture, land reforms, irrigation, improved methods of cultivation and completion of land records; special attention to vulnerable groups like shifting cultivators and forest villages; generation of employment opportunities for better utilisation of available manpower through programmes in the fields of horticulture, animal husbandry and allied occupations; development of cottage industries based on the local raw materials so that the proportion of semi-processed and processed goods is maximised in the export mix of the region and development of basic infrastructure including legal, institution and physical aspects for speeding up the socio-economic development.

While preparing the Tribal Sub-plan which aimed at area development with a focus on tribal families, a thorough review of tribal problems was made which included:

(i) identification and demarcation of areas of tribal concentration;
(ii) identification of socio-cultural barriers and promoters of change in development;
(iii) assessment of - potentialities, special problems and felt-needs of the jrjbal areas;
(iv) assessment 'of-the resources available for Sub-Plan;
(v) formulation of sectoral programmes and
(vi) devising suitable administrative set-up.

AREAS OF TRIBAL SUB-PLAN

The Tribal Sub-Plan approach has been applied to certain identified areas in 17 States and two Union Territories. These are Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Gujrat, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhaya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Manipur, Orissa, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu, Tripura, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Daman and Diu. This approach has not been applied to four tribal majority states of Arunachal Pradesh, Mizoram, Meghalaya and Nagaland and two Union Territories of Lakshadweep and Dadra and Nagar Haveli as their entire plans are directed towards the development and welfare of the tribal population.

The main components of Tribal Sub-plan strategy are Integrated Tribal Development Projects (ITDPs), Modified Area Development Approach (MADA) and Pockets and Primitive Tribal Group Projects. For implementation of Tribal Sub-Plan strategy, 191 Integrated Tribal Development Projects have been carved out in the aforesaid States and Union Territories. Each ITDP comprises blocks/Taluks/ Tehsils or even whole district with 50 per cent or more tribal population. In delineating the project areas, the main factors viz., predominance of tribal population, contiguity of area and administrative viability have been kept in view. In certain States like West Bengal, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu where concentration of tribal population is not in contiguous belts, a flexible approach has been adopted in delineating ITDP areas. Besides, 285 Modified S Area Development Approach (MADA) pockets have also been carved out in 9 states, covering about 50 lakh tribal population. These areas comprise smaller pockets of tribal concentration having minimum population of 10000 with Scheduled Tribe

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population of 50 per cent or more. In these areas, the emphasis is on family development by taking up family-oriented income generating programmes. By the end of the Sixth Plan, The Tribal Sub-Plan approach covered about 75 per cent of the total tribal population in the seventeen States and two Union Territories to which it was applicable.

It was later decided to extend the benefits of Tribal Sub-plan strategy to the remaining 25 per cent dispersed tribal population in various states. Thus, 100 per cent tribal population has been brought within the fold of Tribal Sub-Plan. Economic assistance to families living below the poverty line is also being continued during the 7th Plan. During the Sixth Plan about 39 lakh tribal families were economically assisted against the target of about 28 lakh families. During the 7th Plan, the target of providing economic assistance has been fixed at 41.56 lakh families. During the first four years of the Seventh Plan, about 42.58 lakh families have already been assisted. The quantum of assistance varies from programme to programme and is not sufficient enough to raise the family above the poverty line.

Keeping in view the precarious condition of certain tribal communities and groups who are still in the primitive stages of economy and need special care both at the planning and implementation of programme stages, 74 primitive tribes have been identified in 14 States and Union Territories. They constitute about 13 lakhs of the tribal population. For these groups, special Micro Projects have been formulated.

FINANCIAL RESOURCES AND OUTLAYS

The Tribal Sub-plan is being financed through the resources drawn from:

(a) flow of funds from State Plan outlays;
(b) sectoral outlays in the Central Ministries for tribal areas;
(c) special Central Assistance allocation for tribal areas; and
(d) institutional finance mainly from banks.

Flow of funds from the State Plan to the Sub-plan forms the resource base for the tribal 'development programmes and the outlays from other sourc.eS are Supplementary. The quantum of the outlays in the State Plan for the purpose is arrived at keeping in views

(i) the total population,
(ii) the geographical area,
(iii) the comparative level of development, and
(iv) the state of social services.

The State Plan outlays comprise a divisible and a non-divisible portion. Those investments whose benefit does not confine to any specific region constitutes the non-divisible portion. Quantification and utilisation of resources should be reviewed to ensure accrual of due benefit to the tribal region. For the disbursement of funds within the divisible portion a weightage should be given to the tribal areas on the basis of their level of social and economic development. The institutional finance should take into consideration the total ceiling for the State and special problems, if any, in inducing its flow to the tribal region. The likely flow of benefits form each programme to the tribal areas Should be quantified. The special central assistance for the Tribal Sub-plan should attempt to supplement the total resources which can be mobilized by the State Plans, Central Ministries and the financing institutions.

From the above statement it would appear that after introduction of Sub-plan strategy there has been substantial increase in flow of funds to Tribal Sub-plan areas. But most of the funds have remained notional and as a result commensurate benefits could not accrue to tribal areas and tribal communities. For instance, investments made on major and medium irrigation, power, industrial and other projects merely on location basis accounted for about 50-60 per cent of the Tribal Sub-plan but the proportionate benefits have not accrued to the tribals. In fact, such projects have benefitted mainly the non-tribals. In individual sectors the flow of funds from State Plan to Tribal Sub-plan has also been notional. Even in divisible sectors, allocation has been made on sectoral basis for the State as a whole and not for individual Integrated Tribal Development Projects. It has rendered the monitoring of physical benefits to Scheduled Tribes virtually infructuous.

Special Central Assistance Funds have not been utilised as gap/ filler against specific schemes to supplement the efforts of the State Governments. The disaggregation of these funds is made sector-wise and not ITDP-wise by the State Departments of Planning and Finance. The Project Officer of the ITDP does not exercise any control over such funds. Thus it becomes difficult to monitor its utilisation in the family oriented schemes.

CENTRALLY SPONSORED SCHEMES

Division of responsibility between the Union and State governments is an important aspect of the centrally sponsored schemes in the development of the Scheduled Tribes. Each Central Ministry and Department" -is a nodal ministry or department concerning its sector." In the Ministry of Welfare there are some schemes common to both Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, such as award of post-matric scholarships, coaching and allied facilities like pre-examination training centres and educational facilities like book banks, etc. A separate provision for Scheduled Tribes has also been made under three schemes namely.

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girls hostel, research and training and aid to voluntary organisations. The construction of boys hostels has also been taken up under the centrally sponsored schemes since 1988-89.

CRITICAL APPRAISAL OF TRIBAL SUB-PLAN

The Tribal Sub-plan strategy is in operation since the Fifth Five year Plan, but it has not been able to bring about any perceptible improvement in the situation in tribal areas. It has remained a mere conglomeration of sectoral schemes under the State Plan. The general schemes and programmes under the State Plan have been applied to tribal areas some of which do not cater to the needs and aspirations of the local people. The sectoral flow of funds for the Tribal Sub-plan has not been able to solve the problem of imbalance in the investments in tribal areas. In the absence of area specific programmes, it is difficult to identify the physical achievements of investments. The basic information about the infrastructure development relating to health, education, drinking water, sanitation, communication, agriculture, productivity, horticulture, industries etc. in respect of all tribal ares has not yet been tabulated. Such information is basic to a planned strategy for development of the tribal areas within a time frame.

Integrated Tribal Development Projects (ITDPs) were devised as viable administrative units for accelerating the balanced development of tribal areas. Each ITDP is headed by a senior officer but he has hardly any role to play either as an agent of development or as a co-ordinator. There is no uniformity in administrative pattern so far as Tribal Sub-Plan areas are concerned. In some states the ITDP is a subordinate organisation to District Rural Development Agency (DRDA). In some states no distinct ITDP administrative set-up has been evolved. The Union Government i.e., the Ministry of Home Affairs and now the Ministry of Welfare has adopted a persuasive approach for the execution of the Tribal Sub-Plan strategy to achieve the desired results.

In order to ensure rapid development of tribal areas and to improve the quality of life of the Scheduled Tribes the following suggestions merit consideration:

(i) Instead of Tribal Sub-Plan, a separate plan for tribal areas in each state (already identified as ITDPs, MADA, etc) should be formulated. It would amount to delinking of the Tribal Sub-Plan from the State Plan and may be termed as Tribal Area Plan.

(ii) Separate allocation of funds should be made for the Tribal Plans. This could be done by the Planning Commission itself at the time of annual allocation of funds keeping in view the population, geographical area and backwardness, and need not be left to the discretion of respective State Governments as under the existing system. On the basis of the allocation of funds, area specific and people specific Tribal Plans may be formulated.

(iii) In each ITDP, single line administration has to be introduced for execution of the schemes and programmes. At the State level, Tribal Welfare Department should be made a nodal Department for implementation and coordination of ITDP schemes and programmes.

(iv) For the Centrally Sponsored Schemes the concerned Central Ministries or Departments should allocate funds under a separate budget sub-head of tribal areas. The funds should meet the entire outlay of the schemes. The schemes have to be carefully identified keeping in view the local needs of the tribals. In order to ensure strict enforcement of policy and programmes in respect of tribal areas, it should be clearly laid down as a policy that the Planning Commission should not approve the Plan of the Ministry concemed'iinless and until specific provision for the development of Scheduled Tribes has been made. Annual Central Plan for tribal areas may also be formulated by pooling up resources which may incorporate the schemes sponsored by various Ministries and Departments. The Ministry of Welfare which is the nodal Ministry for policy, planning and coordination of all tribal matters may be assigned the task of formulating the Central Tribal Area Plan. It would enable it to have a total view of the efforts made by various Ministries and Departments. The progress of implementation and achievements of all the centrally sponsored schemes' may be annually reviewed by the Planning Commission. There should also be a separate monitoring cell in each Ministry and Department.

The tribals have been treated as mere receivers of the benefits and they have not been involved either in the decision making process or in formulation or implementation of the plans and programmes. As the problems of the tribals are unique, it is essential that they are actively involved in planning as well as in the implementation of the programmes. Effective participation of the tribals in decision-making would not only bring about successful implementation of the programmes but also create confidence among them in the policies of the Government. Such an approach would make the planned efforts of the Government more meaningful. ■

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TRIBAL UNREST

TRIBAL AREAS ARE still identified as islands of extreme poverty, illiteracy and exploitation. About 85% of tribal people are living below poverty line and 48% are still illiterate. Most of them are living mere subsistence economy.

The framers of the Constitution were fully seized of the situation and therefore, provided for a comprehensive network of compensatory provisions to undo the centuries old injustice perpetrated on the Scheduled Tribes and to enable them to join the mainstream of the nation. These provisions were the result of unwritten assurance given to the weaker sections for joining the national struggle for freedom and making it a mass movement. The freedom was the result of united efforts of all the sections of the society including the weaker sections. The Constitution had originally laid down a time frame of ten years to bring these people at par with the general population. The period has been extended thrice by amendment of the Constitution. But that has not helped to improve the lot of the tribals. About 85 per cent of the tribal families are still living below poverty line. They are still victims of various exploitative methods. The gap between the targets and the physical achievements of various tribal development schemes is widening beyond control. The tribal feels that he is being blackmailed in the name of welfare. The achievements are generally assessed in terms of financial investment rather than the goods delivered. Major share of investment has been of notional nature quantified in major and medium irrigation, power, industrial and other projects purely on locational basis. The wide publicity given to the tribal welfare schemes have aroused their aspirations. And their failure to deliver the expected results has created social tension.

The discontent among the tribals surface time and again in one form or another; either in the form of a demand for a separate state, such as the agitation for a separate state of Jharkhand or the demand for better deal of development. The situation is susceptible to exploitation by anti-national forces. The reasons for their discontentment may be broadly divided into seven heads:

i) inadequate implementation of Constitutional safeguards;
ii) denial of participation to tribals in development process;
iii) lack of accountability;
iv) lack of tribal leadership;
v) land alienation and displacement without adequate rehabilitation;
vi) exploitation in forestry and other economic activities; and
vii) socio-cultural factor.

(I) INADEQUATE IMPLEMENTATION OF CONSTITUTIONAL SAFEGUARDS

The Constitution envisages a comprehensive and well designed scheme of action for tribal protection and development. The Governor of a State having Scheduled Areas has been given regulation making power for development of Scheduled Tribes and good administration of Scheduled Areas in consultation with the Tribes Advisory Council. He is required to keep the President informed of the tribal situation in the State by submitting annual report. In order to protect the tribal interest, the Governor has been given power to exclude the application of any law of part thereof made by the Parliament or the State Legislature. These vast powers vested in the Governor by the Fifth Schedule are limited by Article 163 which says that the Governor will be aided and advised by the Council of Ministers in the exercise of his powers. According to judicial opinion, the Governor is bound by the advice of the Council of Ministers in the exercise of powers granted to him under the Fifth Schedule. Thus, it is the responsibility of the State Government to make effective use of the provisions in the Fifth Schedule.

The Union Executive has been vested with vast powers of giving directions under para. 3 of the Fifth Schedule and Article 339(2) for preparation and execution of schemes of tribal development and for good administration of Scheduled Areas. Financial provision has been made under first proviso to Article 275(1) to meet the cost of such schemes out of the Consolidated Fund of India. So far no directive has been issued by the Union Government to any of the State Governments. The Union Government's persuasive approach with the State Governments regarding the measures to be taken for the protection and development of the tribals has not been very effective. The provisions contained in the Fifth Schedule have virtually remained non-operational. Land continues to pass out of the tribals to non- tribals Money-lenders continue to exploit them by charging exorbitant rate of interest. Prescribed minimum wages are yet to be enforced in tribal areas. Condition of migrant tribal labour particularly women continues to be vulnerable.

The Special Central Assistance is released to the State Governments in a ritual way without any area-specific or people-specific schemes. In fact, it is a critical gap-filler in the planned efforts "oFState Governments and should be utilised for schemes which are undertaken by the State Governments with the prior approval of the Union Government.

The Tribal Sub-plan strategy launched in 17 States and 2 Union Territories since the Fifth Five Year Plan as a new 'package deal' for integrated development of tribal areas

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with specific focus on development of tribal communities has not been a success because of lack of orientation of the administrative machinery.

The economic assistance given to family oriented programmes is inadequate to lift a family above poverty line. No scientific data has been collected about the extent of impact of the programmes.

In recruitment of services and posts under the Government of India and the States, the Scheduled Tribes are still under-represented Their representation in Central Government posts and service is below 2 per cent in Group 'A' and 'B' and below 5% in Group C & D, as against 7 1/2 per cent prescribed for each of these categories.

In the wake of development process, there has been heavy influx of outsiders in the tribal areas; who have not only grabbed most of the resulting job opportunities -but'- also settled down in those areas and have increased pressure among others, on the land resources. The power of imposing restrictions on the movement or settlement of outsiders in tribal ares as envisaged in Clause 5 of Article 19 of the Constitution has never been exercised. As a result the tribal population in certain tribal majority areas has been reduced to minority. This trend is conspicuous in industrial areas where the tribals face a serious challenge to their existence in general, and to their culture in particular.

(II) DENIAL OF PARTICIPATION IN DEVELOPMENT PROCESS

There has been no effective participation of the tribals in decision making and developmental process affecting them and administration of their own affairs. The policies and programmes have been formulated without consulting them. It has resulted in fixation of wrong priorities and failure in achieving the desired results. This is one of the important causes of discontentment among tribals. Participation of tribals in both formulation and implementation of policies and programmes affecting them is imperative to ensure that interest of these people are properly safeguarded.

Various consultative agencies in the states with a large number of tribal representatives on them such as State Legislature Committees, District and Project level Committees, Tribes Advisory Councils in all the eight states with Scheduled Areas and two non-Scheduled Area states of West Bengal and Tamil Nadu are not very effective.

Effective participation of the tribals in their affairs may be brought about by

(1) instituting procedures to ensure regular consultation between the Government agency and the representatives of the tribals.
(2) supervising the activities of the Government agency by a consultative body comprising elected/nominated representative of the tribals.
(3) inducting the tribals as officials at various levels of the Government.
(4) setting up of bodies with elected/nominated tribal representatives within legislative and executive branches of the Government with guaranteed participation in development process and
(5) guaranteed representation in Panchayat Raj institutions in proportion to tribal population.

The introduction of elective Panchayat Raj system in the tribal areas has replaced the traditional tribal institutions and it has generally resulted in annexing the positions of power by influential and powerful non-tribals. The law establishing the Panchayati Raj institutions generally provide for unit area representation on population basis like wards/villages at the base. The expectation that this mode of representation would ensure satisfactory tribal representation in the Panchayats in tribal majority areas is belied in the absence of specific legislative stipulation in most of the States that only tribal candidates must be fielded. There is also no provision that Panchayat Raj bodies in tribal majority areas should be headed by the tribals at all levels.

Nominated bodies including Regional Autonomous Development Authorities, Project Implementation/Advisory Committees are also handicapped by the absence of statutory reservation in favour of the tribals. For instance, in Bihar, 3 Regional Autonomous Development Authorities, namely

(i) North Chhotanagpur
(ii) South Chhotanagpur and
(iii) Santhal Parganas

Autonomous Development Authorities have been established by law for ensuring effective implementation of programmes in tribal areas. The Act which set up the Regional Autonomous Development Authorities does not stipulate that the Chairmen or Vice-Chairmen or majority members of these bodies shall be nominated from among the Scheduled Tribes. As a result, key positons in many of the nominated bodies and elected bodies under Panchayat Raj namely, Zila Parishad, Panchayat Samiti, Taluka Mandal, Gram Panchayat are captured by the influential non-tribals.

Some of the states have amended their laws to provide for reservation in favour of Scheduled Tribes both in the Panchayat Raj Institutions and nominated bodies. In Andhra Pradesh, six per cent of the total number of the offices of Presidents of Mandal Parishads, Chairmen of Zila Praja Parishads have been reserved for Scheduled Tribes. This is in proportion to their population in the state.

The co-operative laws/bylaws should be amended and if necessary, new laws should be enacted to ensure fair representation and effective participation of* the Scheduled Tribes on the Board of Management of co-operatives particularly in the Tribal Sub-plan Areas.

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(III) LACK OF ACCOUNTABILITY

Absence of any specific provision of legislation regarding the administration of the affairs of the Scheduled Tribes in the Constitution is one of the major shortcomings. The legislative powers of the Parliament and State legislatures are defined under Article 245, 246 and 248. None of the three lists i.e. the Union list, State list and Concurrent list includes in it the tribal affairs exclusively. Therefore, the State legislature has no power to make any laws in respect of tribals. Only the Parliament in exercise of its residual powers under Article 248(1) read with entry 57 in the list of the Seventh Schedule can legislate on the affairs of the Scheduled Tribes.

At present there is no provision to assign the responsibility for the failure to achieve the targets set by the Union and the State Government. Statutory provisions should be introduced for assigning responsibility for such failures and for taking punitive actions against those responsible for failure.

There are a number of agencies to oversee the implementation of tribal welfare programmes and schemes. At the Government of India level, there are at least five agencies, viz., Welfare Ministry, Commissioner for Scheduled Tribes and Scheduled Castes, National Commission for Scheduled castes and Scheduled Tribes, Secretary in Cabinet Secretariat and Planning Commission. Besides, according to the Allocation of Business Rules, 1961, as amended, the development and administration of tribal affairs is spread over a number of Ministries and departments. Each Central Ministry is a nodal Ministry for implementation of its schemes and programmes concerning the welfare of Scheduled Tribes. Such multiplicity of agencies divides the responsibility and divided responsibility is often nobody's responsibility. Only one Department under the Ministry of Home Affairs should be made responsible for the Tribal Welfare development Programmes. Similarly in the states, one nodal Department should be made responsible for policy, planning and overall co-ordination of the implementation of the tribal welfare programmes. It should exercise effective control over the financial outlays earmarked for the tribal development. Any mechanism required for redressal of grievances should also be evolved under this Department. The Seventh Schedule of the Constitution should be amended to incorporate clauses clearly defining the functional responsibility of the Union and the state Governments. Similarly, laws may be enacted for defining the responsibility of various departments and sectors. Separate administrative apparatus must be evolved for execution of the programmes.

(IV) LACK OF TRIBAL LEADERSHIP

Leadership vacuum has adversely affected tribal development. Vested interests have not allowed tribal leadership to emerge. This factor is one of the important causes of discontentment among the tribals.

(V) LAND ALIENATION AND DISPLACEMENT WITHOUT ADEQUATE REHABILITATION

Despite protective land laws, the tribal land continues to be alienated to non-tribals for private purposes. This is mainly due to loopholes in the existing laws. The extent of land alienation varies from state to state, but is more intense in the States of Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Orissa, Maharashtra, Gujrat, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Assam, Tripura, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh.

In the wake of developmental process, a large chunk of fertile tribal land has been acquired by Government for industrial, irrigation, power, mining and other projects in lieu of meagre compensation which the tribals frittered aw'ay in no time.

The tribals are thus deprived of the agricultural land which was the main source of their livelihood. But they did not get the benefits of the development projects. Only the non-tribals got the benefits in terms of availability of irrigation facilities and power as well as job opportunities. The displaced persons were hit hard by the withdrawal of provision in February 1986, which provided employment to one member of each displaced family in the project constructed on their land. Had the Government acquired alternative land for rehabilitation of the displaced tribals, their culture and community living would have been preserved. For the centrally sponsored schemes, the concerned Central Ministries and Departments should allocate funds, under a separate budget sub-head of tribal areas. The funds should meet the entire outlay of the schemes.

The unrestricted influx of outsiders into tribal areas also reduced the tribals to minority. For instance the tribal population in the districts of Ranchi, Singhbhum and Santhal Parganas has sharply decreased from 70.02 per cent, 58.41 per cent and 50.56 per cent respectively as per 1941 Census, to 56.41 per cent, 44.08 per cent and 36.79 per cent as per 1981 Census. Such trend which is also manifest in many other tribal areas poses a serious challenge to their very existence.

(VI) EXPLOITATION IN FORESTRY OPERATIONS

The traditional symbiotic relationship between tribals and forests has been completely shattered due to drastic policy changes. Their traditional forestry rights have been reduced to mere concessions. Due to incomplete survey and settlement operations and records of rights, lands traditionally held and cultivated by the tribals have been claimed as forest lands under the new forest policy. Consequently, a large number of tribals occupying forest land have been turned into encroachers on their own lands.

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The traditional protectors of the forests have been branded as the destroyers of the forests.

The tribals are not paid fair price for the minor forest produce by the agents and middlemen. They are not involved in various forestry operations. Collection and transportation activities are handled by the contractors. In many states royalty has also been levied on various items of minor forest produce, which reduces the income accrued to the tribals from the fair price of the minor forest produce. The tribals could be involved in a number of forestry operations but that is not encouraged. The existing arrangements in most of the states are biased in favour of contractors and middlemen.

(VII) SOCIO-CULTURAL FACTOR

The Scheduled Tribes are distinct ethnic groups without any stigma of untouchability or hierarchical inferiority. Some Indian writers, however, have presented a very distorted account of their social status. They have not only denied and independent social status to the tribals but have described them as "Backward Hindus". This amounts to assimilation of tribals into dominant Hindu Society. Such an approach will lead to extinction of tribal culture, religious beliefs, traditions and life style and obliterate all distinctions between castes and tribes. The tribals are very much agitated over such an approach. They are fully aware of the plight of the untouchables even though untouchability has been abolished and would not like to become one of them.

The tribals are integral part of Indian civilization and possess a very rich cultural heritage. It has stood acid test of time. The first Prime Minister of India, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru while addressing a conference in 1952, had said, "I am not at all sure which way of living is better, ours or theirs. But in some ways, I am quite certain theirs is better. A great deal of things could be learnt from their culture."

Pt. Nehru was opposed to imposition of anything on the tribals. In one of the five fundamental principles, generally called 'Tribal Panchsheel', he mentioned, "Tribal people should develop along the lines of their genius and we should avoid imposing anything on them. We should try to encourage in every way their own traditional arts and culture."

The national government has, undoubtedly, the primary responsibility of protection and development of tribals but too much of paternalism is dangerous and becomes counter-productive. It presumes that the tribals are incapable of expressing opinion about their own interest; that they are incapable of safeguarding their own interest; that they cannot identify their needs and that they are incapable of managing their own affairs. In brief, it presumes that the tribals have no administrative capability and the best course of their survival and development is to follow the policies decided by others for them.

THE REMEDY

Objective of justice, social, economic and political can be realised by unfettered participation of tribals in power. Denial of participation means denial of justice. In fact, democracy means people's participation in power in all spheres and at all levels.

There is need for careful review of the situation. Loopholes in various existing laws have to be plugged. However, enacting a law alone is not a solution of the problem. Appropriate steps have to be taken for its effective enforcement Administrative procedures should be simplified. There should be no intermediaries or middlemen between tribals and the Government Loan and credit facilities should be made available on easy terms and concessional rate of interest so as to reduce dependence of tribals on private money-lenders. Measures for their economic upliftment should be formulated keeping in view their needs.

In order to ensure development of tribals, it is necessary to eliminate their exploitation. This can be achieved if the tribals are ensured participation in decision making process and implementation of programmes. For this purpose, it is essential to extend the provisions of the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution to all the Fifth Schedule areas as well as other tribal majority areas already identified within or outside the Tribal Sub-plan. This experiment has already proved very successful in North-Eastern States. The funds for the proposed Sixth Schedule Areas should be earmarked separately and released directly by the Union Government to such areas so as to avoid delay by respective State Governments in timely release of funds.

Extension of the provisions of the Sixth Schedule to Tribal Sub-plan areas will go a long way in eliminating exploitation of tribals in land, forest, labour, mining, money-landing etc. and would ensure their balance development in social, cultural, economic, educational and political spheres. It would also ensure effective participation of the tribals in the management of their affairs. Since the tribal Councils function under the overall control of the State Government, streamlining the administration of the tribal areas should nor be a problem. Such a step will assuage tribal sentiments and create an atmosphere of mutual trust and understanding. The tribals have been and are aninlegral part of India. They have to be trusted. There is need of closer understanding of their ethos. Tribals are simple and honest people. They are conscious that whatever be the demand of change, the cultural foundations of tribal society must be safeguarded. They are averse to any kind of imposition. They may be poor, but they are persons of dignity and self-respect. There is need of change in approach and attitude towards the tribals. Instead of working for them, we should work with them. ○

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OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES

The Constitution of India recognizes three categories of backward segments of Indian society i.e., Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes. The categorization of the first two has been fairly clear from the beginning. The third segment, that is, the other backward classes carried lot of ambiguity, But it was generally assumed that this category of OBCs was meant to include the whole of middle bands of caste and communities situated above the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes excluding only prominently well-advantaged groups at the top. In simpler and popular terms, the agde (forwards) are the dwija castes like the Brahmins and the Kshtriyas but the Kayasthas (north India), Vaids (Bengal) and Nayars (Kerala) have.also joined this division on the strength of their economic, political and bureaucratic power. ThePichhade (backwards) are lower castes, other than untouchables, who do not exercise control over sources of power- political, social and economic. The Scheduled castes and Scheduled tribes are clearly listed in the constitution. The non-dwija, non-scheduled castes not listed in the constitutional order are the OBCs. They comprise a little over 3,700 castes in all.

The framers of the constitution, instead of using the term Castes', applied the term 'Classes' for this segment of backward population. There may be several reasons for this. First, they followed the old historical process (whereby the term 'depressed classes' was used even for the untouchable castes, now scheduled castes). Secondly,- the word 'Caste' sounded obscurantist and outdated arid- the torchbearers of modern India wanted to banish this word from new and modern India. And thirdly, the usage might have created problems visa vis the placement of the non-Hindu counterparts of the other backward castes in the list. This is certainly true in the case of Muslim community which, despite embracing the egalitarian ideology of Islam, has also developed caste like stratification under the social impact of the Hindu society.

The non-dwija intermediate castes or lower castes other than scheduled castes have also been victim of caste system. Most of these have been small peasants or artisans. They also come under the category of disadvantaged groups suffering in poverty. For the peasant segment of OBCs agriculture is the chief means of economy. But they have little land except for castes like Yadavas and Kurmis in parts of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar and such other castes in different parts of the country. Quite a substantial number of OBCs in different parts of the country have no land at all. The second category of OBCs are mainly artisans and their plight is really miserable. Because of growing industrialization, their traditional skills and crafts are in ruined state. The socio-economic condition of weavers, potters, carpenters, fishermen/boatmen, blacksmiths, vegetable vendors, butchers and a host of other castes in village India is there for all to see. Educational deprivation has worsened the situation further. The organized Industrial Sector enjoys subsidized credit, infra-structural support and other advantages at the cost of the tax-payer, the handicrafts and artisans hardly get all these benefits. The net result of this state of affairs is that they are always trapped in the vicious cycle of poverty and deprivation. As a number of surveys and studies in different parts of the country indicate that the OBCs have little access to employment and education, enjoy low rates of literacy and are trapped in indebtedness. The high incidence of indebtedness is attributed to illiteracy, poverty, social customs etc.

In order to help the OBCs come up in socio economic development, the first Backward Classes Commission was set up by a Presidential Order under Article 340 of the Constitution of India on January 29th, 1953 under the chairmanship of Kakasaheb Kalelkar, It submitted it's report on March 30th, 1955. After sorting out the facts the commission formulated the following criteria for identifying socially and educationally backward classes:

(i) Low social position in the traditional caste hierarchy of Hindu society.

(ii) Lack of general educational advancement among the major sections of a caste or community.

(iii) Inadequate or no representation in Government services.

(iv) Inadequate representation in the field of trade, commerce, and industry.

The commission could not present an unanimous report. The majority of members including the chairman were opposed to the view of linking caste with backwardness. They were also opposed to the reservation of posts on the basis of caste. While rejecting the main recommendations of this commission the central government ultimately took a decision that no all India list of backward classes should be drawn up, nor any reservation made in the central government service for any group of backward classes other than scheduled castes and scheduled tribes. However, the central government informed the state governments that they were free to draw their respective lists of backward classes on the basis of criteria worked out by them and take whatever further action they deemed necessary in the matter. Consequently, a number of state governments set up their own commissions or committees for defining criteria for backwardness and recommending measures for its removal. So far eighteen states and union territories have set up commissions and have notified lists of Other Backward Classes for the grant of various educational, employment

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and other benefits. These are Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Karnataka, Kerala, Maharasthra, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Assam, Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Orissa, Pondicherry and Bajasthan.

The new commission, the Second Backward Classes Commission is popularly called the Mandal Commission. It's chairman B.P. Mandal was appointed by a Presidential order under Article 340 of the Indian Constitution on 20th December 1978. It was required :

(i) to determine the criteria for defining the socially and educationally backward classes;

(ii) to recommend steps to be taken for the advancement of the socially and educationally backward classes of citizens sq'identified;

(iii) to examine the "desirability or otherwise of making provision for the reservation of appointments or posts in favour of such backward classes of citizens which are not adequately represented in Public Services and posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or of any State; and

(iv) to present to the President a report setting out the facts as found by them and making such recommendations as they think proper.

The commission was required to submit it's report by 31st December 1980. In view of the enormity of its task and paucity of time at it's disposal, the commission worked with speed. To begin with, it conducted a countrywide socio-educational survey, covering 405 districts, with the help of the Bureau of Economics and Statistics of various states. The data gathered from the Survey were computerized and thirty-one primary tables were generated from this data in respect of each State and Union Territory. Then, on the basis of these tables, 11 indicators or criteria for social and educational backwardness were derived under three heads-Social, Educational and Economic. These are as follows: -

A. SOCIAL

i) Castes/classes considered as socially backward by others.

ii) Castes/classes which mainly depend on manual labour for their livelihood.

iii) Castes/classes where at least 25 % females and 10% males above the state average get married at an age below 17 years in rural areas and atleast 10% females and 5% males do so in urban areas.

iv) Castes/Classes where participation of females in work is atleast 25 % above the state average.

B. EDUCATIONAL

v) Castes/classes where the number of children in age group of 5-15 years who never attended school is at least 25% above the state average.

vi) Castes/classes where the rate of student drop-out in the age group of 5-15 years is at least 25% above the state average.

vii) castes/classes amongst whom the proportion of matnculates is at least 25% below the state average.

C. ECONOMIC

viii) Castes/classes where the average value of family assets is atleast 25% below the state average.

ix) Castes/classes where the number of families living in Kuccha houses is atleast 25% above the state average.

x) Castes/classes where the source of drinking water is beyond half kilometer for more than50% of the households.

xi) Castes/classes where the number of households having taken consumption loan is atleast 25% above the state average.

Weightage was given to the indicators in each group for evaluation. The social indicators were given 3 points each educational indicators, 2 points each and economic indicators one point each. This came to a total score of 22 points All these 11 indicators were then applied to each one of the castes covered by the survey in each state. The castes obtaining a minimum of 11 points on this scale were listed as socially and educationally backward. Thus, the Commission identified 3,743 castes as backward. After this, the commission computed the strength of the OBCs which was little over 52% of the total population of the country.

A Research Planning Team of sociologists-anthropologists was also constituted to help the commission in the identification of the deserving backward castes. This team, consisting of some top sociologists and anthropologists of the country, in order to gauge social-educational backwardness of the castes in the present times, suggested a number of ways and means and used existing studies/ literature. It also emphasized upon the importance of trends of upward mobility of a number of traditionally backward castes before reaching any firm conclusions. The team further suggested that while designing empincal studies extent of prevalence of the following variables may be taken into account.

(a) Socio-ritual services extended by other ethnic groups

(b) 'Low' status of occupations of the category concerned.

(c) 'Low' self-evaluation compared to other ethnic groups in the region (Gram Panchayat/Block/Taluqa).

(d) Literacy rates in relation to other neighbouring groups 'in (Gram Panchayat/Block/Taluqa).

(e) Occupations requiring investment of child labour (upto 15 years)

(f) Economic levels of castes and communities.

(g) Representation in public or private sector services or in profession.

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Beside the research planning team an expert panel was also constituted consisting of sociologists, political scientists and geographers. When the Mandal Commission submitted it's report containing a number of recommendations of far reaching importance, some of these social scientists disowned the findings and recommendations on the ground that the criteria, modus operandi and variables suggested by them were not employed by the commission while finalizing the findings and recommendations.

Undertaking this massive exercise, the Commission came out with a number of recommendations, of which some were found most important for upliftment of the socioeconomic conditions of the OBCs.

i) The OBCs are not properly represented in public services and hence they should be accommodated there through reservations

ii) There is a legal obligation to keep the reservations under Articles 15(4) and 16(4) of the constitution, below 50%, so the reservation should be 27 %.

iii) Special educational facilities designed at upgrading the cultural environment of the OBC students should be created in a phased manner in selected areas containing high concentrations of OBCs.

iv) Special emphasis should be placed on vocational training of the students belonging to the OBCs; separate coaching facilities should be provided in technical and professional institutions for them to enable them to catch up with the students from open quota.

v) Special programmes for upgrading the skills of village artisans should be prepared and subsidised loans from financial institutions granted to them for setting up small-scale industries.

vi) To promote the participation of OBCs in the industrial and business life of the country, all state governments should create a separate network of financial and technical institutions.

vii) Under the existing scheme of production relations, Backward Classes comprising mainly small land holders, tenants, agricultural labour, village artisans etc., are heavily dependent on the rich peasantry for their sustenance. In view of this, OBCs continue to remain in mental and material bondage of the dominant castes and classes. Unless these production relations are radically altered through structural changes and progressive land reforms implemented rigorously all over the country, OBC's will never become truly independent. In view of this, highest priority should be given to radical land reforms by all the states.

Through the Memorandum of Action, vide it's circular issued on 13th August, 1990, the Govt. of India accepted the recommendations of the Mandal Commission. This was followed by violent and sustained movement by different sections of' Indian society against the acceptance of Mandal Commission Report by the government of India. Writs were filed in different courts and after prolonged hearings the Supreme Court of India decided in favour of the recommendations and held these constitutionally valid excluding the so called 'creamy layer' of the socially and educationally Backward Classes (SEBC). In pursuance of the Supreme Court verdict, an expert committee under the chairmanship of Justice R.N. Prasad, Former Judge, Patna High Court was set up for specifying the criteria for identification of Socially Advanced Persons among the Socially and Educationally Backward Classes. This expert committee submitted it's report on 10th March, 1993. The Government of India accepted the criteria formulated by this expert committee and announced a reservation of 27% of the vacancies in Civil Posts and Services in the Government of India for SEBCs subject to the exclusion of the socially advanced persons/sections known as the 'Creamy Layer'. Thus reservation was applied to all vacancies for which recruitment commenced from September 8, 1993.

CREAMY LAYER

The rule of exclusion of 'Creamy Layer.' is applicable to the son(s) and daughter(s) of

- Persons holding constitutional positions;
- parents either of whom is a Class-1 Officer;
- parents both of whom are class II officers;
- parents either or both of whom is or are in the rank of colonel and above in the Army or hold equivalent positions -in the Navy, Air Force and the Para Military Forces;
- Families owning irrigated land which is equal to or more than 85% of the ceiling in term of irrigated area as laid down by the State Land Ceiling Laws;
- Persons having gross annual income of Rs. 1 Lakh or above or possessing wealth above the exemption limit as prescribed in the Wealth Tax Act for a period of three consecutive years.

Income from salaries or agricultural land shall not be clubbed. The benefit of reservation is extended, in the first phase, to the castes and communities which are common to the lists of the Mandal Commission Report as well as the State Government's lists.

OBCs AMONG NON-HINDU COMMUNITIES

Since the caste system with all its concomitants have been replicated by Muslims, Sikhs, Christians and Buddhists their backward sections have also been included in the list of OBCs in Mandal Commission. After giving a good deal of thought to the obvious problems of categorization, the commission has evolved the following and ready criteria for identifying non-Hindu OBCs.

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(i) All untouchables converted to any non-Hindu religion; and

(ii) Such occupational communities which are known by the name of their traditional hereditary occupation and whose Hindu counterparts have been included in the Other Backward Classes list of Hindu OBCs.

(Examples: Dhobi, Tell, Dheemar, Nai, Gujar, Kumhar, Lohar, Darzi, Badhai, etc.)

IDENTIFICATION OF SOCIALLY AND EDUCATIONALLY BACKWARD CASTES (SEBCs)

On analysis of the judicial decisions, the Indian Law Institute noted the following points relevant to the identification of the SEBCs:

1. In the matter of their backwardness the SEBCs are comparable to SCs and STs.
2. The concept of Backward Classes is not releative, in the sense that any class which is backward in relation to the most advanced class in the community must be included in it. Hence the division of Backward Classes into 'backward' and 'more backward' is unconstitutional.
3. Backwardness must be both social and educational and not either social or educational.
4. A classification based on caste without regard to other relevant factors is not permissible under Article 15(4). However, if a caste was wholly socially and educationally backward its inclusion in the Backward Classes by their caste name is not violative of Article 15(4). The state should have sufficient data to show this fact.
5. Social backwardness, which is the offshoot of poverty, will be aggravated by caste considerations of the poor people: this only shows the relevance of both caste and poverty for determining the backwardness.
6. The occupations followed by certain classes of people, which are looked down upon as inferior or unclean, and the place of habitation may contribute to social backwardness.
7. In order that the reservations could benefit the really needy ones among the Socially and Educationally Backward Classes of people, the fixing of income limit for family (meaning, natural family) is valid.
8. Rural population as a whole cannot form a Socially and Educationally Backward Class. However, the population in hilly, backward areas from such a class.
9. This inclusion of a class in the list of Backward Classes should not be perpetuasl.
10. Educational backwardness determind on the basis of state average of the lasttwo or three high-school classes per 1,000 people of thq community has been held to be valid. However, the'class to be eventually backward must be well or substantially below the state average. For instance, the class below 50 per cent of the state average would obviously be backward.

A perusal of this summary of judicial decisions indicates that the occupational and territorial basis of social and educational backwardness, apart from the community basis, has been held to be valid by different courts. But Mand.al Commission has either failed to take notice of the same or has made use of the court decisions only in a tangential manner.

Mandal Commission had associated several social scientists in honorary capacity in preparing the frame of its investigation and the analysis and presentation of data. But it has only partially implemented the same and has published the minutes of discussions at various stages in a selective manner. Besides, it has treated ad hoc indicators, which were formulated to interpret the pilot-survey data in a specific cultural-ecological context, as the criteria for determination of SEBC, ignoring the other types of data recommended to be collected and considered by the social scientists panel. While this has caused some communication gap among social scientists (Sheth 1991), it raises a more fundamental issue of ethical norms to guide the association between experts and the public bodies seeking their cooperation.

THE OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES : COMPOSITION, CHARACTERISTICS AND EMPOWERMENT

Among the many problems, which the OBCs as a collective entity suffer from, the foremost is the confusion which has continued to exist regarding their exact composition and precise identification and scheduling. To answer the question as to who are the OBCs one has to wade through the ritual, legal/ constitutional, socio-demographic and political cobwebs which have remained largely intact and uncleared. It is proposed to clarify this confusion and ambiguity, have a closer look at their present day composition and decomposition, and indicate the emergent tasks for their empowerment.

AMBIGUITY IN THE USE OF TERM AND DERIVED STATUS

The OBCs are a legal-constitutional category, which in the postIndependence period has been striving to obtain acceptance of the identity of an independent social category. The term OBC itself was not used in the Indian Constitution until amendment of Article 338 where it came to be used for the first time. Until then, even legal-constitutional designation-wise, the OBCs had only a derived status either as a part of 'Weaker Sections' (Article 46) or SEBCs? (Article 15(4)- or (BCCs - Article 16(4). Also their inferior status is visible in the nature of provisions made for the clearly denned BC categories of SCs and STs. All the provisions in their

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case are mandatory. In case of the OBCS, all the provisions have been left to the discretion (and convenience) of the governments of the day at central and state levels. This derived status has continued even through the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendment Act - Article 243D (6) and 243T(6) in reservation of seats in the Panchayati Raj Institutions and urban municipal bodies.

Marc Galanter indicates that the term backward classes had a less fixed and definite reference. It had been there but had a variety of references,, it had shifted rapidly in meaning and it had come to mean different things in different places (Galanter 1991). He goes on to specify ten such denotations of the term backward classes. These include: depressed classes, untouchables, SCs, aboriginal and hill tribes, criminal tribes, all communities deserving special treatment excepting the untouchables, all communities above the untouchables but below the most advanced ones, communities other than the highest or most advanced, communities meeting non-communal tests of backwardness (Galanter 1991). Galanter proceeds to provide historical examples in different states at different points of time in the pre-Independence period to conclude that the term had never acquired a definite meaning at all-India level. There had been no attempts until then to define it or employ it on the national level. The term had definite meanings in local contexts although these differed somewhat. After separating SCs and the STs, he states, two major species emerged : i) as the more inclusive group of all those who need special treatment; ii) as a stratum higher than the untouchables but nonetheless depressed. This double usage continues even today : the former in the usage of BCs in the wider sense (including SCs and STs): the latter in the usage as equivalent to OBCs (Galanter 1991).

THE INTENT OF THE CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY: REFERENCE TO COMMUNITY IDENTITY

Analyzing the debates of the Constituent Assembly, Galanter and majority-concurring judgements of the Indra Sawhney case, two definitive treatises on the issue came to the conclusion that the term OBCs, by whomever designated and according to whatever tests they were chosen, were expected to be a list of castes or communities. In fact the most authoritative statement on the issue is that of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar given on 18 May 1951 at the time of First Constitutional Amendment Lwhich inserted the Article 15 (4)J "what are called backward classes are..... nothing else but a collection of certain castes". This has remained so in so far as the OBCs under Articles 15 (4) and 16 (4) are concerned. In operational terms, those listed as SEBCs [15 (4)] or BCCs [16 (4)] are specified in their affiliational terms through listing of communities in the OBC (and also SC, ST) lists but benefits are available to them as individuals, as entitlements of Fundamental Rights guaranteed by Articles 14, 15 and 16.

While the foregoing is indeed the legal-constitutional position, it is not the whole truth. The law also permits other species of BCs under Articles 15 (1) and 16 (1). Reservations are also available to these BCs although they may or may not be the members of the SCs, STs and OBCS. These BCs are special situation cases and benefits are granted to individuals in exceptional cases to redress a specific situation (ie. physically, mentally impaired, remote/inaccessible areas, ex-armymen, dependents of freedom fighters, etc,). The point involved is elaborated in Indra Sawhney vs Union of India (Malik 1992):

> .. all reservations are not of the same nature. There are two types of reservations, which may, for the sake of convenience, be referred to as Vertical reservations' and 'horizontal reservations'. The reservations in favour of SCs, STs and OBCs under Article 16 (4) may be called vertical reservations whereas reservations in favour of physically handicapped [under Clause (1) of Article 161 can be referred to as horizontal reservations. Horizontal reservations cut across the vertical reservations; what is called interlocking reservations. To be precise, suppose 3% of vacancies are reserved in favour of physically handicapped persons; this would be a reservation relatable to clause (1) of Article 16. The persons selected against this quota will be placed in appropriate category; if he belongs to SC category he will be placed in the quota by making necessary adjustments; similarly, if he belongs to open competition category he will be placed in that category by making necessary adjustments.

ARE ALL MIDDLE COMMUNITIES OBCs?

Several considerations have created a mistaken impression that communities above what are called the SCs/ STs and below the so called 'twice born' in the ritual hierarchy among the Hindus and similarly placed communities among other religious denominations generally termed Sudras in Varna categorization are all OBCs. First, the debates in the Constituent Assembly (Verma 1998) quite clearly indicated that the middle tier communities were socially and educationally backward and that they had very little share in the services under the State and that they were backward class of citizens. Second, the language of the First Constitutional Amendment, which inserted Article 15 (4), also reinforced this impression. Court rulings in several important cases specified such tests for listing of the OBCs (i.e. low educational, occupational status, and inadequate representation in the services under State) which were mostly found among the middle communities, Third, in most of the States where reservations were in place from the pre-Independence period, all middle communities were indeed included in the OBC lists. A critical examination of the OBC lists of different States would, however, disprove the assumption that all so-called Sudra castes/communities are

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OBCs. The Reddis, Kammas in Andhra Pradesh, the Patels and Pattidars in Gujarat and Kayasthas all over India, although all Sudras under Varna classification, are not listed as OBCs. Thus, whereas it is true that most middle castes in most of the States are indeed scheduled as the OBCs, it is not the case universally in all the States/Union Territories for all Sudra communities.

COMPOSITION AND DECOMPOSITION OF THE OBCs

The reports of the Kaka Kalelkar and Mandal Commissions have been criticized for recommending OBC lists, which contained as many as 2399 and 3743 communities respectively. This is considered to be quite a large number. However, the lists recommended by Kalelkar and Mandal Commissions never came to be officially accepted and OBCs have continued to be identified and scheduled by the States and Union Territories until 1992 and thereafter also by the Union Government. An authorized total number of OBCs listed by different States and Union Territories is not available conveniently. A recent compilation by Sharma (2002)1 yields a total of 2176 and 2551 communities which have been scheduled as the OBCs by the Government of India and the States/ Union Territories respectively. There are several factors involved in this large listing. First and foremost, there are quite a few pan Indian OBC communities called by the same name across the country. Kurmis and Ahirs are two OBC communities, which are scheduled in quite a few states. Most other communities generally pursuing the same occupations are known by different names in different States/ Union Territories. The broad occupational profiles of the OBCs in North and South India are not comparable given differing socio-cultural-demographic characteristics in these areas. Even if they were comparable, local tradition mandated including different caste, sub-caste names, giving their different cultural identity. Consequently, the number of OBCs of the same occupational and other cultural traits has come to be counted many times over, swelling the numbers in the lists. The upper castes on the other hand have a pan-Indian character and although they do not marry in the gotra of the same communities going by different cultural names in different states, they are identified as single communities. Their numbers do not, therefore, get magnified because they are not counted several times.

The second consideration is that listing of the OBCs in the state and central lists is not using a minimum population threshold for listing as was, for example, used in the Peoples of India Project (PoIP) of the Anthropological Survey of India. The number of OBCs got considerably reduced in case of the PoIP since they insisted on a minimum population and presence in different states as eligibility criteria. The sequence of listing communities in different States and Union Territories has been somewhat divergent. In many States/ Union Territories OBC lists did not exist until the Indra Sawhney milestone judgement came along and ordered establishment of a permanent institutional mechanism for listing. In such states, the lists have emerged through the recommendations of State Commissions for Backward Classes (SCBCs) and predictably the number of OBC communities is relevantly not as expansive as in such states which have a long history of reservations. The number of OBCs listed in the state lists and central lists varies, in some cases (i.e. Assam, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat) quite appreciably. The number of OBC communities in such cases is appreciably larger in the state lists in comparison to the central OBC lists. There are some exceptions however where the number of OBC communities is larger in the Central lists. However, these differences are minor. This indicates that the tendency to include communities in post-Indra Sawhney case period has been more controlled at the central than at the state levels.

LISTING ANOMALIES

Apart from the foregoing anomalies of numbers, there are other listing drawbacks. First and foremost is the existence of only one set of OBC lists, which are being uniformly used for the purposes of both Article 15 (4), and 16 (4) although it has authoritatively been delineated by the judgement in the case of Indra Sawhney in 1992 that the two classes of OBCs are not the same. Perhaps the ironical approval of only the single set of OBC lists by different state governments by the same Special Constitutional Bench for both 15 (4) and 16 (4) in the Indra Sawhney Case (Paras : 851-852) has facilitated continuation of this practice.

The states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Bihar have subdivisions of the OBCs. However, this sub-division is not of the same variety. In Bihar, the list is sub-divided into (i) OBCs and (ii) Most Backward Classes (MBCs). Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka OBC lists are sub-divided into A, B, C. D. Group A comprises Aboriginal Tribes, Vimukta Jatis. Group B comprises occupational skill groups such as toddy tappers, weavers, carpenters, iron smiths, goldsmiths, kamsalins, etc., Group C pertains to SC converts to Christianity and their progeny. Group D comprises all other classes/ communities/groups which arc not included in groups A, B, and C. Reservations are apportioned among the categorized sub-gro'ups -in proportion to their respective population among-the OBCs. In the remaining States, the entire OBC list is one and, therefore, all of them are treated at par officially although a few among them corner a larger share of benefits which Articles 15(4) and 16(4) confer on them. The foregoing sub-division in the referred three states makes it very clear that categories of communities which should have logically gone into the lists of SCs and STs have actually been included among the OBCs. This has been done in an entirely ingenuous manner under entry 24 of Assam OBC list which has 96 sub-entries under the title 'TeaGarden Laborers/ TG Tribes/Ex-TG Tribes" many of which are either SCs or STs.

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Third, quite a few state OBC lists include some such communities, which in the opinion of many experts, are not socially and educationally backward and are adequately represented in the services under the state. However, their population size and their political importance has enabled them to gain entry into the lists and they continue to remain there. These instances include entries, which were made before 1992, and also entries, which have been made subverting the mechanisms of the SCBCs after 1992. The case of Vokkaligas in Karnataka belongs to the first category whereas the inclusion of Jats in Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, belongs to the second category. The petition of Jats to be included among Central list of OBCs for Uttar Pradesh was rejected by the National Commission for the Backward Classes whereas their petition in the State OBC list of Uttar Pradesh was under the consideration of the SCBC Uttar Pradesh. The Government of Uttar Pradesh scheduled the Jats in the Uttar Pradesh OBC list without obtaining recommendation of the SCBC. Uttar Pradesh had earlier on also declared the entire hill region as OBC without obtaining the recommendation of the SCBC. Whereas the hill areas of Uttar Pradesh now constitute the new State of Uttranchal, the inclusion of Jats disregarding the mandate of the SCBC is under challenge before the Supreme Court. However, since there is no stay granted in the case so far, the Jats are enjoying the benefits.

DECOMPOSITION: OCCUPATIONAL SUB-CLASSIFICATION OF THE OBCs

The Working Group for the Development and Welfare of the Backward Classes set up by the Planning Commission to recommend measures for the empowerment of the OBCs during the Tenth Five Year Plan in its report of May 1996 grouped the OBCs into the following five occupational sub-categories:

(a) Castes/communities of poor peasantry including poor peasantry of former zamindar and other intermediary tenures.

(b) Castes/communities providing traditional services (i.e. hair-cutting and grooming, washing of clothes, scavenging, etc).

(c) Castes/communities of artisnal producers (i.e. fisher folk, toddy tappers, stone-cutters, earth workers, etc).

(d) Artisan castes/communities with traditional skills engaged in various traditional crafts providing a variety of goods at family/ cottage scale (i.e. potters, weavers, blacksmiths, carpenters, etc.). These are the original and true manufacturing classes of Indian society who were engaged in secondary production even at a time when many of the major industrial houses of today were money-lenders and hundi operators.

(e) Communities without resources or skills: a good number of castes/communities are indigent and their traditional occupations has been (and still is) begging, sometimes with religious overtones. Many of them are nomadic (N) or semi-nomadic (SN). These communities comprise of people who follow different religions, speak different languages, live in different socio-cultural-geographical locales but they share the same traditional occupations.

PROBLEMS OF THE OBCS AND EMPOWERMENT TASKS

Peasantry forms the largest bloc of the five sub-groups of the OBCs. Sheth and Pratap (1997) categorize them into two groups: the numerically large but socially and educationally backward communities of owner-cultivators of small landholdings and those of tenant-cultivators and landlessdabour. Subsidies for their agricultural inputs have Teen unremunefative for the last five years. Under the World Trade " Organisation protocol, agricultural commodities are being imported and offtake of foodgrains from the government stocks is not being lifted by the state governments since the unit cost of PDS items has gone up and the lowest stratum of the society is not able to afford it. Thus, there is a contradictory situation where the hungry are starving to death as foodstocks remain piled up and at the other end peasants in relatively better developed states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Maharashtra are committing suicide due to unbearable debt burdens. If the thesis propounded by Manvinder Singh Banga of Hindustan Lever of reducing the cost of production and its packaging and distribution, outlined in 2001 is accepted, this segment of the OBCs is going to experience additional difficulties. Artisans and artisanal communities have been through a great deal of ordeal during the last 55 years of post-Independence period. Sheth and Pratap (1997) very rightly state that these are the communities, which have preserved and developed in our society a variety of skills and specialization for millennia. A large number of such communities (i.e. oil pressers, potters, iron smiths, carpenters, etc.) have virtually lost their occupation due to the introduction of mechanised and large-scale system of production and changes in the life styles of the population. Only a few enterprising individuals among them have adapted themselves to the requirements of the time and changed market and tastes. Some have changed occupations with the help of education and outmigration. However, the fact remains that a large majority among them are being dispossessed from their traditional occupational moorings and being marginalized or pushed to become casual labour in urban settings and landless labour in rural zones.

Some of the occupations of OBCs service communities (i.e. washermen, fishermen) have been taken over by others belonging to the upper strata. They were socially backward

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to begin with but economic dispossession has pushed them downwards even in economic terms. They are 'rejected men' in the liberalized economy. This tendency is best illustrated by the dhobi, fishing, leather processing, weaving and spinning communities. Mechanized laundries have replaced traditional Dhobis. Similarly mechanized trawlers have pushed out the fishermen. Communities engaged ir these occupations have been pushed to a state of destitution and ruin. The greatest loss is to the society which is losing their skills which had been preserved, honed and refined for centuries.

TASKS OF DEVELOPMENT AND EMPOWERMENT OF THE OBCs: THE OFFICIAL APPROACH

For the first eight Five Year Plans, no specific mention of the tasks of development and empowerment of the OBCs was made by the concerned agencies of the Union (i.e. the Planning Commission and the Ministry of Social Welfare). It is only in the Ninth Five Year Plan that some semantic attention was paid to this requirement. Very few specific schemes addressing specific problems of specific sub-strata of the OBC categories were included in the plan. Financial allocations for these skeletal few schemes were meagre and some secured no allocations at all. In ways more than one, the studied neglect of the OBCs fell into the overall pattern of deliberate indifference to the task of development and empowerment of the OBCs by the ruling elites.

When the NBA government was formed in 1999, it framed a National Agenda for Governance (NAG). Its Para 30 dealt with the BCs:

The interests of SCs, STs and BCs will be adequately safeguarded by appropriate legal, executive and social efforts and by large scale education and empowerment. We will provide legal protection to existing percentage of reservation in educational institutions at the State level. We will continue to offer assistance to the SCs, STs and BCs to ensure their speedy socio-economic development. We will remove the last vestiges of untouchability from the society. Further, we will present a National Charter for Social Justice based on principles of social harmony.

SIMILARLY PARA 7 OF THE NAG IS ALSO RELEVANT TO THE OBCs:

We will constitute a comprehensive study of the financial, technological and social security requirements of the self-employed and unincorporated sector also constitute a Development Bank to promote this largest segment of national economy which too has great employment and self-employment potential. Further, in addition to financial support institutions we will bring into being othefv.institutional systems for providing services, technology and marketing facilities for artisans, the small scale, village, khadi, powerloom, handloom, handicrafts and such other industries. This and agriculture sectors are an untapped source with unlimited scope for generation of employment.'

Viewed carefully, it is clear that the NAG does not differentiate the complexities and differences in development and empowerment tasks of the SCs, STs and the OBCS. Second, it merely reiterates continuation of the meagre efforts, which the Centre have been undertaking for the OBCS. Third, the specifics which Para 7 offers leave out the largest substrata of the OBCs (i.e. the farmers) from its purview. Fourth, the two concrete specific measures it promised (i.e. formulating a NAC, and incorporating a Development Bank) have not been acted upon till now.

DEVELOPMENT AND EMPOWERMENT OF THE OBCs : TENTH FIVE YEAR PLAN

In many respects, the Working Group (WG) Report (India 2001) is a qualitative departure in viewing the problematics. It stated that the development of the OBCs cannot merely mean some alterations here and there or some humanistic ameliorations. It considered it necessary to start with an integrated vision of Indian society and within that frame the future of the OBCs in Indian society and with a clear understanding of where the OBCs have reached after centuries of India's socioeconomic history, five decades of independent existence and nine Plans of development. In so far as the attitude of the central government towards the OBCs was concerned, it termed this period of history as 'eight Plans of non-development and one Plan of marginal development'. The Working Group undertook the exercise of framing a vision for the development and empowerment of the OBCs. Keeping both the Constitutional and egalitarian human traditions in view, it. felt that the OBCs represent still, as in the past, the unfreedom of Indian society in different forms. In the economy, they substantially include a large number of castes and communities who were required to produce a variety of goods and services on terms unfair to them, thus constituting different forms and degrees of exploitation.

They were and still are engaged in a very wide and rich variety of economic activities, and possessed considerable traditional technical skills pertaining to their spheres of economic activities. Different sub-strata of the OBCs face different types of threats and the development and empowerment strategy for them has to follow differentiated approach which is sensitive to different economic and social needs of communities placed at different levels of social and educational backwardness. As indicated earlier, the WG categorized them into five sub-categories. The Working Group felt that the OBCs should secure economic self-reliance in their traditional activities or in other diverse activities according to their choice, given full benefit of modern technology, access to finance, control over raw material resources, marketing facilities, etc. on terms which are fair to them. Facilities for education, health and housing

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have to be provided so that they cease to be placed at a disadvantage in the process of development. The objectives and elements of development and empowerment of the OBCs as indicated by the WG are

i) Removal of social backwardness.

ii) Creation of educational parity at each stage, phase, and course of education.

iii) Removal of economic underdevelopment, dependency, : inadequacy and exploitation by (a) strengthening the OBCs in their traditional occupations and securing for them control and mastery over their respective traditional fields of economy; (b) training and helping the OBCs to shift from stigmatized occupations; (c) to help the OBCs to diversify into a variety of modern occupations in proportion to their population; and (d) creating conditions in which the OBCs occupy due proportion in all types of occupations including those of social prestige.

PROCESS AND APPROACH OF EMPOWERMENT

Empowerment, according to WG has two aspects - the outcome and the process. The outcome would consist of the realization of the objectives listed earlier. The process consists of the role to be accorded to the groups of the OBC communities in conceptualizing, formulating, planning, designing, implementing, supervising, monitoring and where required, timely course-corrections of the spheones for and programmes of their own development. Whdt^tMis requires is that the agencies of the state like the National Backward Classes Finance and Development Corporation (NBCFDC) and its counterparts in the states should take up groups of communities instead of individual applicants and dialogically evolve schemes appropriate to each of them. In turn, this requires association of the concerned OBC groups in the entire decision-making process of problem identification, formulating areas of intervention including strategy and instrumentalities as equal and active participants in a democratic and transparent manner. Genuine and democratic occupational associations of the OBC communities should be associated in this dialogical process by all levels of state agencies. Quite a few of these associations require training and capacity building to delineate their natural and expected role. In actualizing this process, the services of the national and state level commissions for the OBCs and the competent and professionally endowed citizens from amongst the OBCs who would only want functional facilitation, functional empowerment and functional equipment should be used. The government at the center and the states can divest themselves of inappropriate work like processing and sanctioning individual applications of NGOs for funds and transfer this function to existing or new bodies.

Different OBC communities are at different stages and levels of backwardness in different socio-cultural-geographical locales. At one end of this continuum are the Vimukta Jatis (VJs), nomadic, semi-nomadic (NSN) and non-SC Safai Karamcharis (SKs). Small in numbers, these have been ignored in terms of empowerment measures. At the other end are peasant communities having land resource base and skills. The traditional economy kept them at a disadvantage but they do retain a certain amount of local initiative and freedom. Irrigation and power have enabled them to make greater progress tha'n the other sub-categories of the OBCs but they remain distinctively backward socially and educationally. Within this category one sub-group may consist of regionally/ locally populous and possessing relatively more of land resources whereas the other may not possess the advantage of numbers and command over land resources. The latter also includes tenant peasants.

The artisan castes/communities of artisanal or artisan-like producers are located between the VJs and NSN and the peasant subcategories of the OBCs. They provide various traditional services to the general community. This sub-category has no resources but possess only the skills. This category has two sub-categories: artisans like goldsmith, silversmith and other metalsmiths, etc. A peculiar form of occupational nomads characterizes some of them like the stonecutters and marine fisher-folks. Even the water-related and river-bank communities like Nishads though not occupationally nomadic also represent a socially less esteemed and educationally more backward.

Since even the most advanced category of the OBCs are still backward, there is need for state support for their further advancement to reach the level of socially advanced sections of the Indian society. To the extent financial resources are a limitation, WG recommended first preference and total coverage (or as close to total coverage as possible) for the most backward sub-categories of VJs and NSNs, followed by the middle or more backward sub-category of artisan, artisanal and service providing castes. WG recommended consideration of empowerment measures subject to the priority justified for the most and more backward sub-categories. The Group did not indicate that the peasant communities which constituted in some States as much as 70-80 percent of the OBCs and left their empowerment subject to availability of scarce funds. This amounted practically to no viable empowerment measures at all. This is the technique, which has been used against them by the Indian ruling classes in the post-Independence period. ■

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CASTE IDENTITY AND SOCIAL BOUNDARIES OF BACKWARDNESS : THE MUSLIM OBCs

Muslims in India constitute the largest religious minority and a significant segment of Indian society. They constitute about 12% of the total population and in terms of numbers they are about 12 crores. Thus, they constitute the second largest Muslim population in the world next only to Indonesia.

The distribution of Muslim population in India today is the result of a process extending over, almost a millennium. They have been living for ages as .aft. Inseparable part of the rural and urban social milieu and bound together by the age-old ties in economy, customs and traditions. Significantly, Muslims in India are neither a 'cultural community' nor a compact ethnic population. They live through layers of identities in a complex society.' At some places they may be seen through a provincial-linguistic/ ethnic category as in Ladakh (Jammu and Kashmir), a tribal biradari/kinship group as in Lakshadweep and through such tribal groups as Gaddi and Bakrewal in Jammu and Kashmir, through a sectarian perspective such as Sunni, Shia, Ismaili, Bohra, Ahmedia, etc., or through various Islamic schools such as Deobandi and Barelvi.

The socio-cultural/ethnic heterogeneity of Indian Muslims as described above has at least one thing in common and that is social stratification by and large on the lines of Hindu society with whom they have been living and interacting for more than a thousand years.

ISLAM, MUSLIMS, CASTE AND SOCIAL STRATIFICATION

The question whether the concept of caste can be applied to the system of social stratification of a community professing a faith other than Hinduism has often been posed. It is true that the egalitarian social order of Islam stands in sharp contrast with the ideology of caste yet the 'Indian Islam' and 'Hindu Caste System' have been able to achieve a substantial compatibility. Hutton (1951) sounds convincing when he says that when Muslims and Christians came to India, the caste was in the air and the followers of even these egalitarian ideologies could not escape the infection of caste. Moreover, the overwhelming majority of Indian Muslim population comes from the lower Hindu castes who have been coming into the fold of Islam to escape from social persecution and the oppressive socio-economic disabilities. They were also attracted and lured by the social egalitarianism of Islam but the search for equality proved a mirage. In many cases there were improvements in their socio-economic condition yet the goal of social equality remained elusive. Moreover, in most of the cases the people embracing Islam gave up their religious faith but not the caste that was brought forward even to a new socio-religious milieu. Thus, it would be apt to say that while Islam may not be having castes or caste-like groupings, the Indian Muslims do have. Thus, the interface between ideology and social structure in the context of caste may be full of academic issues requiring discussion.

But here an attempt is being made to stay clear of the issue whether the model of social stratification among the Indian Muslims is the replica of the Hindu caste system or not. The author shall be using the term caste and caste system among the Indian Muslims in a conveniently loose manner. It is undisputedly true that there are groups of people among the Muslims who are organized more or less like the Hindu castes but this is also true that they are less rigid because Islam, theoretically at least, permits marriage between different classes of believers. Nazir (1993:2898) takes a fresh look on this whole issue:

.... It is necessary to make a distinction between a caste system and caste labels: the former refers to a local system of hierarchically ordered corporate groupings involving social division of labour, occupational specialization, unequal dependence, and recruitment by birth only; the latter refers to a set of non-local, noncorporate named groups which provide a ranking hierarchy, and which do not involve occupational specialization, unequal dependence, and recruitment by birth only.

Perhaps, the 'caste system' and 'caste like groupings' among the Indian Muslims with all its fluidity may be better analysed and better understood through this observation. Even within this framework, as Harjinder Singh (1977) remarks, "there might be regional variations in the nature of Muslim stratification in India."

Ghaus Ansari (1960) in his pioneering study on caste and social stratification among the north Indian Muslims places Muslim castes into three categories:

(i) Ashraf
(ii) Ajlaf
(iii) Arzal

Ashraf includes the Muslim nobility that claim to be the descendents of early Muslim,; immigrants, either Sayyad, Shaikh, Mughal or Pathari and may also include descendants

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of higher Hindu castes such 'as Muslim Rajputs. In the category of Ajlaf (mean) clean occupational castes were included, such as Julaha (weaver), Darzi (tailor), Qassab (butcher), Hajjam (barber), Kunjra (green grocer), Mirasi (bards, singers and musicians), Manihar (bangle trader), Dhuniya (cotton carder), Gaddi (grazier, milkmen), etc. While in the third category of Arzal (literally very mean) the unclean or ritually polluting castes such as Bhangi or Mehtar (sweepers and scavengers) may be included.

With the establishment and acceptance of caste/caste-like social hierarchy among the Muslims with its own norms and patterns of behaviour, space for upward mobility also emerged among the Muslim castes. Thus the process of Sanskritization among the Hindu castes has also subsumed the Muslim castes. When Ahir (the Hindu milkmen caste) trace their origin to the Chandravanshi Yadava and Krishna the Muslim Julaha (weavers) add Ansari with their name referring to the Ansars (highly revered companions of Muhammad); Qassab/Chikwa (Muslim butchers) add Qureshi with their names referring to the tribe Quraish - the tribe Muhammad came from. Certain other middle level Muslim castes add Khan with their names extending their claims to a Pathan or Afghan ancestry. So, in the process Julaha (weavers) became Momin Ansaar, Hajam (barbers) became Salmani, Kunjra (vegetable vendors) became Raeen, Darzi (tailors) became Idrisi, the Bhishti (drawer of water) called themselves Abbasi, Lohar (ironsmith) and Badhai (carpenters) became Saifi and so on. As a result of welfare and development programmes several such occupationally specialized castes attained some prosperity and with heightened political consciousness organized themselves into caste-based organisations orjamaatslbiradaris. This in turn promoted social solidarity among them. Thus, on the lines of the Hindu castes, the Muslim castes too, in the process of Sanskritization, have adopted the lifestyle and behaviour pattern of their higher castes such as Sayyed and Shaikh.

MUSLIM BACKWARD CASTES, COMPENSATORY DISCRIMINATION AND RELATED ISSUES

With the advent of independence and subsequently the Constitution, three backward segments of Indian population were identified and targeted for special treatment. These were Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes (OBCs). Various compensatory discrimination policies are directed at these categories, related to job, education, welfare and development. If we try to situate Muslim population in these categories we fiiid that Scheduled Castes cannot be Muslims as this category is restricted to Hindus, Sikhs, and Buddhists only. The Scheduled Tribes can be Muslims but Muslim tribes are few such as microscopic population of small tribal groups of Lakshadweep, Gaddi and Bakrewal of Jammu and Kashmir. This obviously means that only the third category of OBCs seems open to them. For a long time the Muslims despite their social and economic backwardness could not take advantage of this category mainly because it remained a vague category and criteria for inclusion in this category were not specified in the Constitution. Although some states had implemented reservation for OBCs on the basis of the recommendations of the state level backward classes commissions, the reservation issue for OBCs attained centrality only in 1990 when V.P. Singh government decided to implement the Mandal Commission's recommendations for government jobs at the national level. The Mandal Commission had declared 82 Muslim groups to be backward.

Dwelling upon the status of OBCs among the non-Hindu communities (mainly Muslims) the Mandal Commission (1980)' observed:

There is no doubt that social and educational backwardness among the non-Hindu communities is more or less of the same order as among the Hindu communities. Though caste system is peculiar to Hindu society yet, in actual practice, it also pervades the non-Hindu communities in India in varying degrees. There are two main reasons for this phenomenon: first, caste system is a great conditioner of the mind and leaves an indelible mark on a person's social consciousness and cul tural mores. Consequently, even after conversion, the ex-Hindus carried with them their deeply ingrained ideas of social hierarchy and stratification. This resulted in the Hindu con verts' inadvertently acting as Trojan horses of caste system among highly egalitarian religions such as Islam, Christianity, Sikhism, etc. Secondly, non-Hindu minorities living in predominantly Hindu India could not escape from its dominant social and cultural influences. Thus, both from within and without, caste amongst non-Hindu communities received continuous sustenance and stimulus.

After giving a good deal of thought to these difficulties the Mandal Commission evolved the following rough and ready criteria for identifying non-Hindu OBCs:

(i) All untouchables converted to any non-Hindu religion.

(ii) Such occupational communities which are known by the name of their traditional hereditary occupation and whose Hindu counterparts have been included in the list of Hindu OBCs (examples: Dhobi, Teli, Nai, Kumhar, Lohar, Darzi, Badhai, etc.).

Though we do not have any separate census

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enumeration for Muslim OBCs, those engaged in advocacy for them claim their population to be of the order of 80-85% of the total Muslim population of India. In sociological terms, in the ashraf-ajlaf-arzal categorization, all the Muslim castes/ groups coming within ajlaf-arzal social categories qualify for the status of OBCs.

MUSLIM OBCs, EMPOWERMENT AND COMMUNAL QUOTA

Though a majority of Muslims are already covered under the existing provisions of reservation for the OBCs there has always been a grouse among them that they would not be able to compete with the educationally and economically advanced Hindu OBCs like Yadav, Kurmi, Koeri, etc. who are able to swallow their share of the common cake just as what they have done in relation to the Hindu Most Backward Classes/ Castes (MBCs). On the other hand there has been a general hostility among the relatively more advanced Hindu OBCs to the idea of a separate sub-quota for either the Muslim OBCs or the Hindu MBCs. Significantly, for sometime now, a section of Muslim leadership has been demanding a separate quota in reservation for Muslims as a whole despite the fact that the Muslim OBGs, constituting the overwhelming majority of the entire Muslim population of India, is already covered under the existing provision for the OBCs. The liberal-secular Muslim opinion is opposed to this demand on two grounds: it will provide a , ready issue and handle to the aggressive Hindutva forces to promote hostility towards the Muslims and it is unjust because some groups within each religious community are traditionally 'forward' and socially, educationally and economically advanced as compared to the rest of their population as well as in the absolute sense of the term. The Sayyed, Sheikh, and other Ashraf castes of north Ir iia, the Thangal, Arakkal, Koya and Keyi of Kerala Muslims, the Khatri and Jat among the Sikh, the Syrian among the Kerala Christians and so on are the advanced higher castes. Thus, the argument that an entire religious community is socially and educationally backward negates the sociological reality and goes against the principle of social justice.

The response of the leadership of Muslim OBCs is also very meaningful and significant. They are strongly apprehensive that if Muslims as a whole, as a religious community, are extended reservation, the relatively better off caste groups shall be cornering and gobbling up most of the opportunities for educational and economic advancement. This provides a fertile ground for intra-community competitiveness leading to bickering and social conflicts. Moreover. this also goes against the very objective and rationale of empowerment of relatively weaker and backward segments of Indian society. Thus, the demand for a communal quota finds hardly any takers among the Muslim OBCs and this has also contributed to the mobilization of Muslim OBCs against the upper strata of Muslims.

The efforts for the empowerment of Muslim OBCs alongwith Hindu, Christian and Sikh OBCs has exploded the myth (perpetuated largely by the Muslim elite) that the entire Muslim community is a monolith devoid of any economic, social and cultural complexities. The report of Mandal Commission has also contributed to the politicizatiori of the internal social classification of the Indian Muslims. One of the significant fallouts of this phenomenon is .the. decreasing political power of the higher caste Muslim, leadership who enjoyed a virtual monopoly over Muslim leadership. As the.trend indicates, the Muslim OBCs.shall produce their own leadership not only at the grassroots level but also at the provincial and national level encompassing all the institutions of Indian society. However, the present scenario of growing ascendancy of miliant Hindutva forces and its fallout such as the recent Gujarat carnage and state-sponsored terrorism against the Muslim minority seems to be the last hope of the Muslim elite. Obviously an overriding sense of insecurity leads to ghettoization at both physical and mental levels and the entire population tends to close down their ranks and the leadership is usually grabbed by the traditional elite. Incidentally, the separatist-communalist-fun-damentalist leadership among the Indian Muslims has always come from the feudal and elite segments playing the 'politics of identity.'

In a booklet published by the Centre of Backward Muslims of India (no date), Sheth in his article rightly points out :

"The proponents of reservation for all Muslims should in the interest of intellectual honesty and political candour make their demand as a 'religious minority' but not as a backward class".

Even this would mean a major amendment to the constitution, one which would violate the secular spirit of the constitution.

India's constitution recognizes the cultural rights of minorities as fundamental rights and forbids discrimination on ground of religious affiliationjdbut it is foundationally opposed to any idea of 'communal quota'. The new demand of Muslim reservations is simply a strategy to introduce through the backdoor the principle of communal quotas into the constitution.

Even if the allegation of some of the Muslim leaders about some discrimination and bias against Muslims in the

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recruitment in some areas of government jobs is true, the remedy seems to be more detrimental to their interests than the problem.

POLITICAL MOBILIZATION OF MUSLIM OBCs

In the socio-political mobilization of today's Muslim OBCs, Muslim weavers' movement seems to be the first attempt by any such Muslim group. Although the origin of this movement is shrouded in controversy and difference of opinion, Ansari (2000) in a richly documented work on Momin Ansars and their movement writes that some leaders founded, informally, in 1912 in Calcutta a forum which was largely a welfare oriented organisation. The first convention of Momin Conference was formally held in Calcutta in 1928 and from this year onward the Momin Conference gained an all-India stature and became the representative organisation of 3-4 crore Momins of undivided India.

Since handloom industry was first to be hit in the Indian cottage industry sector by the East India Company, weavers were threatened by impoverishment. So, social humiliation and struggle for existence seems to be the prime motivating forces behind this pioneering movement. It mobilized not only Momins but also other Muslim artisan castes. It used to hold an all-India convention every year in major cities of India and for the first time, perhaps, Muslim weavers alongwith some other artisan castes started looking to the future with hope and motivation for empowerment.

Commenting on the changing profile of Momin Conference, Anwar (2001) points out that upto 1937 its activities were confined to promoting social consciousness and welfare among the Momins. The turning point came in 1938 when it started assuming political overtones. When the Muslim League came out with the demand for a separate homeland for the Muslims, the backward Muslims adopted an aggressively nationalist posture and opposed the demand for Pakistan. Right from its very inception the Momin Conference was convinced about the caste/class character of the Muslim League and its leaders and it had no doubt that the League and its demand were promoting the feudal and elitist vested interests and the lower strata of Muslims were only being harnessed as 'cannon fodder'. The feudal lords, capitalists, nawabs and jagirdars felt threatened by the mass upsurge of Indian masses and they knew that the Congress Party had not much in its socioeconomic and political agenda for these vested interests. Its corollary in the post-independent Indian polity may be seen in the form of promotion of Ayodhya issue to blunt the impact of implementation of Mandal Commission's recommendations. It was an intelligent diversionary tactic. Together .' With the nalionalist Jamiate-Ulema-e-Hind, the Momin Conference exposed the claim of the Muslim League of representing the entire Muslim population and promoted the nationalist-secular agenda of the Congress Party. With the partition of the country the Momin Conference aligned with the Congress Party along with the Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Hind backed by the Ulema of Deoband who contributed significantly to the freedom struggle and opposing Muslim League for its divisive agenda. With the passage of time the Momin Conference lost its strength and became almost defunct. Beside the Momin Conference, Raeen Conference representing the caste of vegetable vendors and Mansoori Conference representing the oilseed pressers also played their role in the socio-political mobilization of Muslim OBCs between 1930s and 1950s.

The period between 1950s and 80s witnessed hardly any notable movement of Muslim OBCs. Commenting on the post-independence Backward Classes Movement especially among the Muslims, noted political commentator Prafula Bidwai (1996) says:

"The Muslim OBC initiatives go back to the 1980s in activism in Maharashtra inspired by Lohia and Karpoori Thakur. However, as a movement, the initiative has gathered strength only in the last few years, partly under the intellectual impetus provided by the Muslim Marathi Sahitya Parishad, first organized in 1990 and held four times so far. The Maharashtra organizers borrowed heavily from the Bahujan Samaj social reform legacy of Shahu Maharaj and Jyotiba Phule and the modernist views of Ambedkar. The All India Muslim OBC Sangathan held its first convention on August 29, 1996. The convention was a success. Although uneven, the delegates' composition revealed the commonality of interests and concerns between Qureshis (butchers and meat sellers) and julahas (weavers), nais (barbers) and raeens (vegetable growers or malis), and dhobi (washermen) and telis (oil pressers). The convention's demands include, predictably, extension of Mandal Commission recommendations to all Muslim OBCs, more scholarships, etc; and less predictably, land reforms, funding for small entrepreneurs, and restoration of concessions to scheduled caste (i.e. non-OBC) Muslims which were withdrawn in 1984".

There also seems to be a conscious effort to relate to Dalit Muslims and Hindu OBCs and to create bonds of solidarity across religious divides. The trans-religious subaltern solidarity could be the nemesis of the religion-based identity politics pursued by the communal and fundamentalist organizations of Muslims such as Jamat-e-Islami.

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In this series of political mobilization of Muslim OBCs, the latest is the establishment of Pasmanda Muslim Mahaaz (Backward Muslim Front) in a convention on 25 October 1998 at Patna. Though its activities, till date, seem to be confined to Bihar it has set in motion the efforts by the politically conscious Muslim OBCs in other states.

MUSLIM OBCS AS ETHNOGRAPHIC CATEGORIES: A BRIEF OVERVIEW

It is now historically established that most of the Muslims in India did not come from Arabia or other regions from where the message of Islam came. The earliest phase of Islam in India was represented by Muslim traders and nomadic Sufi saints who were instrumental in attracting the oppressed and exploited lowest strata of Hindu society into the fold of Islam. Making a very interesting and significant observation on the transformation of a lower Hindu caste into a lower Muslim caste. Eijaz Ali (1997) reveals that:

"Most of the religious conversion among the Hindus occurred in Harijan castes and not from such backward castes as Yadav, Kurmi or Koeri. The converted castes/ biradaris changed their names from Ju 'aha to Momin, Khatik to Kunjra, Pasi to Dhuniya, Charriar to Qasai and so on. But the names of occupations and structure of settlements still provide enough evidcncj of this phenomenon. Julaha are found in both (Hindu and Muslim) communities, Kunjra are still known us Khatik in some regions. Qasab or Qasai (butchers) have come from the Chamar caste. The fact of the matter is that it is the Chamars who had a great expertise in skinning and butchering. Those who embraced Islam discovered that the dead animal was forbidden and then they started butchering live animals except pig. They were already expert in other related nuances. Even today, at several places, the settlements-of Chamars and Qasai are adjacent to each other" (Translated from Hindi).

When we look at the occupationally specialized backward castes of both Hindus and Muslims we can identify three categories This has also been substantiated by Ghaus Ansari (1960) and others.

(i) Castes which are now entirely Muslim.

(ii) Castes which have larger Muslim than Hindu sections.

(iii) Castes which have larger Hindu than Muslim sections.

In the first category come those occupational castes, which are now entirely Muslim, their corresponding Hindu castes either do not exist, or if they exist, they have altogether different names. Some such castes areAtishbaz (firework maker),Bhand (jester), Bhishti (water carrier), Gaddi (grazier), Mirasi (musician and singers), Qasab (butcher), Momin Julaha (Muslim weaver), etc.

In the second category, which have larger Muslim than Hindu share, come castes such asDarzi (tailor)Dhuniya (cotton carder), Kunjra or Kabariya (green grocers, Manihar (bangle/ bracelet maker),Saiqalgar (metal sharpner) andRangrez (dyer and cloth printer).

The third category may contain those castes which have a larger Hindu than Muslim share. In this category of clean occupational castes come Kumhar (potter), Nai or Hajjarn (barber), Teli (oil presser),Dhobi (washerman), etc. The Muslim Bhangi IMehtarILal Begia (sweepers and scavengers) constitute perhaps, the only untouchable section of the Muslim population.

A significant aspect of the occupational castes among the Muslims is the disappearance of certain caste groups due to social or techno-economic change. The Rangrez (dyer and cloth printer), Bhatiyara (innkeeper) and Saiqalgar (metal sharpner) have almost disappeared as social units.

The Peoples of India Project, recently completed by the Anthropological Survey of India, gives brief but rich and reliable ethnographic accounts of all the caste and communities of India including tfte Muslim OBCs.

A notable fact about the Muslim OBCs, especially the relatively larger caste groups, is that though some members may have moved out of the traditional occupations, most still follow their forefathers. This lack of occupational mobility has been detrimental, yet it has another dimension which is equally important. Like their counterparts in the Hindu population they have been hardworking from the beginning. Many of the enterprising members of different caste groups made the best of their professions and attained prosperity. The Ansari and Qureshi of Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan are the obvious examples. Some other artisan groups among them who upgraded their technology and adopted new marketing strategies and showed competitive entrepreneurial skills also prospered such as the artisans/entrepreneurs of Meerut, Moradabad, Aligarh and Ferozabad from western Uttar Pradesh and Bhadohi and Varanasi in eastern Uttar Pradesh. Yet, at the same time we find a vast multitude of masses living in impoverished conditions in rural as well as urban areas of the country. These 'technological communities' of India and their Hindu counterparts deserve a better deal from the society and the state. ■

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TRIBE IN INDIA : A PROBLEM OF IDENTIFICATION AND INTEGRATION

Thanks to welfare department, Government in India, which is committed to treat equally all sections of the country's population (and treat with privilege those which have been social underdogs), not only administrators and anthropologists but the average English-knowing man in the street knows who are the people in India referred to as 'tribes' or its Hindi counterpart of the 'Adivasi'. The governmental publicity machinery in the past twenty years has successfully aroused the interest of the people in this section of the country's population.

Besides the commitments of a welfare state, developmental and strategic considerations have drawn the tribal people to the fore of the national front. The 'tribal areas' of the country happen to be the richest in resources – minerals, forest-produce, water power and labour. Many of them like Nagaland, Lushai Hills, and Tarai in U.P. and Bihar, are strategically located and have witnessed considerable activity particularly in the past six years since the Chinese aggression. Of course, the Naga, Mizo and Jharkhand problems have been with us for about two decades now. The entire set up in the country today makes it necessary for us to sit up and re-examine the very basic concept of tribe, which is the core of the problem.

Added to this is the administrative problem of the identification of tribes for purpose of scheduling and consequent grant of privileges guaranteed to the Scheduled Tribes under the Constitution. Well-meaningly, the constitution-framers guaranteed certain privileges to the Scheduled Tribals and Scheduled Castes in matters of representation, services, education, and so on. Before Independence the general tendency was for 'lowly' castes and tribes to make effort to elevate their social position and try to get recognition (formally from the government at the time of the decennial censuses) as 'upper' castes. During the Censuses of 1931 and 1941, there was agreat deal of such activity. After 1947, the trend was checked and even reserved for the sake of the politico-economic privileges. The larger number of applications for scheduling entertained in the offices of the Commissioner for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes are evidence of the desire on the part of the people to claim recognition as 'lowly' and 'down-trodden'.

We could pose the problem like this: are the 'tribal' people in India ethnically and culturally distinct from, the fest-of the population so as to deserve a distinct social category or is the gap between them and us a merely political gulf, which was created by the Imperial colonial power and which has widened in recent years after 1947? If they are found ethnically and culturally distinct from their non-tribal neighbours, the demands for distinctive treatment and even autonomy could be valid and would have to be sympathetically endorsed by the anthropologists. If not, we shall have to look out for the causes of discontent among them and, if possible, suggest a remedy.

Ethnologists have classified the tribes of India into four major groups: the tribes of NEFA and Eastern India belong to the Mongoloid ethnic stock, the tribes of 'Bihar and Orissa are Proto-Australoids, the tribes of Western and Central Himalayas are Mediteranean-Nordic, and the tribes of South India have strains of Australoid, Negroid and Alpine. What is significant in this connection is the fact that none of these constitutes a pocket by itself but shares the ethnic traits in some measure with its neighbouring non-tribal populations.

The officers of the Census of India before 1931 were emphatic about the religious distinction. They designated the tribals as 'animists', a term brought into currency by E.B. Taylor and used to indicate ghost cults in ancient and primitive societies. The implication was that tribals were animists and the non-tribals were not. The evidence provided by authorities on Indian folk religion like Baines, Risley and Crooke differed from such a conclusion; in 1931, J.H. Hutton added a note to this problem by demonstrating that tribal religions in India could be best understood as "raw material yet to be built into the temple of Hinduism". Obviously, this has reference to the age-old historical process in India by which the aboriginal tribes entered the universe of caste Hinduism without either a formal conversion or any significant change in the cultural religious life.

On the cultural and linguistic plane, the 'tribes' have never been markedly different from the neighbouring non-tribes. Ghurye's theory that the so-called 'aborigines' in India share the culture and language of the non-aboriginal Hindu rural communities of the respective regions they live in is shared and substantiated by field scholars like Majumdar and Aiyappan.

It looks as if these 'aboriginal' or 'tribe' people have all alone been living in harmonious co-existence with their more civilized neighbours. From time to time, groups from them moved out of their semi-isolation in more remote hills and jungles and entered plains, villages and the caste system, at

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their periphery. The large number of social reform movements among them, such as the Tana Bhagat movement among Oraon, are evidence of their desire to get absorbed in the Hindu caste system and Hindu civilization in a formal way. They used their 'tribal' names to identify themselves, like Gond, Santal, Korku, Kerwa, much in the same way as castes identified themselves by their caste names and *vama* statrus. It is noteworthy that in India before it started absorbing western ideas and influences, there was no all-India consciousness of kind either among the caste Hindu or among the 'tribals', and perhaps for this reason, we do not possess traditional all-India categories for classifying and designating these groups.

Purely for the sake of classification and enumeration, the British Government in India introduced the category of 'tribe' (with occasional qualifying prefixes like 'hill and jungle', 'aboriginal', 'indigenous') to designate these people. The word 'tribe' had been hitherto used by European historians to refer to such distinctive groups of people as the Gauls or the Anglo-Saxons in Europe and such autonomous political groups as Lichchivi, Mulla, Yaudheya and Khasa in ancient India, or such wide descentgroups as the tribes of Israel or the Arab tribes in Western Asia. Social anthropologists like Rivers were using the word in reference to the people of Melanesia where each hill top or valley sheltered groups of people who were politically autonomous and, as if to show that, were constantly at war with each other. It is significant to note that unaffected by its usage in India, British Social Anthropologists like Radcliffe-Brown, Evans-Pritchard, Fortes and Nadel have used the word 'tribe' to refer to an autonomous political unit which lives on its own territory and possesses its own distinctive way of life.

In the Indian context, efforts have been made to find common denominators if not a common definition of the word tribe. The Commissioner for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribals in his report for the year 1952 has listed eight such common features. These are : (i) They live away from the civilized world in the inaccessible parts lying in the forests and hills, (ii) They belong to either one ofthe three stocks—Negritos, Australoids ofMongoloids. (iii) They speak the same tribal dialect, (iv) Profess primitive religion known as "Animism" in which the worship of ghosts and spirits is the most important element, (v) Follow primitive occupations such as gleaning, hunting, and gathering of forest product, (vi) They are largely carnivorous or flesh and meat eaters, (ii) They live either naked or seminaked using tree-barks and leaves for clothing, and (viii) They have nomadic habits and love for drink and dance.

Desai in his comment on the above mentions that of the 25 million described as tribal people in India, only five million possess these features. Personally, I feel it is a typical case of fiction-creation by the government Officers. Perhaps in a romantic mood, exotic aspects of tribal culture were magnified and sought to be perpetuated, thus defeating the very objective the Constitution in providing the safeguards, viz., 'the levelling up ofthe tribes' [so that eventually they become integrated with the Indian population. Majumdar has categorically stated that with the exception ofthe tribes of Eastern India, everywhere ethnic strains have cris-crossed in the sub-continent. "Waves of immigration have disturbed the ethnic structure of the Indian population and it is difficult to say with any degree of certainty what constitutes the race elements in any particular type, tribe or caste". For the rest it can only be said that perhaps with the exception of simple techno-economic culture, the tribes of India have nothing common. Even the simplicity of technology and economy is a factor which was and to some extent is – common to tribals and non-tribal rural communities.

The most important and conscious tribal groups in the country today, viz, the tribes of Assam, Nagaland and NEFA, and to a less extent the tribes of Cho'tanagpur in Bihar, in fact present an altogether different picture. Christianized Khasi, Mizo or Munda are heavily modernized, and many of them would rather consider their non-tribal neighbours as primitive.

In contemporary India, the word 'tribe' has thus little cultural or social implications. It has become the watchword of the political consciousness of a particular group of people in the country. Like caste consciousness, linguistic consciousness or regional consciousness, tribal consciousness is fast developing to be a political tool which has become symbolic of privileged treatment, separatist tendencies and in places a barrier to national integration.

As I said earlier, it was perhaps a well-meaning act on the part of our Constitution framers in 1947-49 to incorporate statutory guarantees of privileges to our backward castes and tribes. The principle no doubt was good. But the way it has been administered by the government and exploited by vested interests-both foreign and Indian-has led to the present situation of unrest in our tribal areas. On the one hand, we have failed to give to our 'tribal' brethren education, health and the basic necessities of comfortable existence. On the other, we have made them dependent upon doles which they have now come to regard as their birthright by virtue of their belonging to a community rather than because of their techno-economic backwardness. We have thus perpetuated a grave error made by the British Government and as such created a barrier to the integration of a significant section of the country's population. ■

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TRIBALS : AN ASSIMILATIONIST SOCIETY AND NATIONAL INTEGRATION

The enclaves of small, formely semi-independent tribal populations in the plains and hilly regions of our country pose some special problems for national development.The problems of these 29 millions (6.8 per cent of the total population) are recognized in Article 46 of the Constitution which promises to promote 'with special care the educational and economic interests of Scheduled Tribes, and makes provision for protecting them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation'. The constitutional safeguards for tribals after having been adopted for about twenty years have recently been further extended. Here it is questionable whether some of the measures currently in vogue have solved or only aggravated the problems of tribal development. I propose to examine the effect of the working of the government policy in this regard having primarily this question in mind. My endeavour would be to assess and analyse the emerging tribal social structure on the current theoretical framework of culture dynamics and synthesis. In doing so I base my propositions on the available empirical researches in this behalf.

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

With the attainment of independence it was realised by the national leaders and the masses of the people that in free India the tribals would not have a different fortune than the rest of the people in the country. The tribal policy of the government is thus a manifestation of the feelings of the general masses. The policy in operation today.can be best understood in its true spirit when we study the debates of the Constituent Assembly along with historical perspectives which portray intergroup relations between the tribals and the rest of the people. The Sub-Committee with A.V. Thakkar as its Chairman, constituted by the Constituent Assembly to make proposals regarding minorities, was predominantly occupied by the humanitarian idiom of protecting the tribal economic interests, safeguarding their way of life and ensuring their development so 'that they might take their legitimate place in the general life of the country. The proposals were based on the past experience looking to the tribals' simplicity and weaknesses and their exploitation at the alien hands'. It was recommended by the Sub-Committee to provide statutory safeguards for the protection of the land which is the mainstay of the aboriginals' economic life, and for protecting their customs and institutions, which possess elements of value. The proposals of the Sub-Committee contain the seminal ingredients of our official tribal policy. The Constituent Assembly released unanimously that the tribal advancement was an integral part of the development of the Indian people as a whole.

The constitutional safeguards, when analysed, convey the concern of the government-in regard to the Scheduled Tribes in terms of their educational and economic betterment, their protection from social injustice, and exploitation as found in various manifestations of discrimination and prejudices; and development of their general way of life. The creation of Scheduled and Tribal areas, preference in admission to educational institutions and public services, are some of the mechanisms which tend to fulfil the objects of the Constitution in letters and spirit. Occasional statements of the Prime Minister and the reports of the Commissioner for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes and other Commissions further ensure implementation of the tribal policy. The programme in pursuance of the policy enunciated above safely leads to an approach which could be termed assimilation of the tribals with the rest of the society.

By and large the Indian tribes are an assimilationist society in as much as both the tribals and the non-tribals accept the idea of the assimilation of the former into the wider Indian community. The problem before us, therefore, is to examine the present trends in integration of the tribals in the Institutional orders of the Indian society and in the light of this integration, to assess the trends in respect of national integration; to suggest remedial measures for removal of the disfunctional traits from among the tribals for achievement of the national goal; and if the level of integration has already been achieved, to examine the dangers arising out of government policy of continuing the special status in various spheres of life granted to the tribals for achieving the above goals.

FRAME OF REFERENCE

The axis of tribal development is their ultimate integration in the main stream of national life. The frame of reference for the analysis of the tribal life in India is, therefore, integration-both social and cultural. It is the resultant process of assimilation, the latter being characterised by 'decreasing differentiation between individuals and between groups as well as by increased unity of action, attitude, and mental processes with respect to common interests of goals'. But then, integration should not be confused with homogeneity. It is 'organization, rather than homogeneity. A group is said to be integrated in the degree to which its members, its social categories and statutes, and its culture are organized for the achieve-ment of common purposes or goals'. With this conceptualization of integration in mind when we examine lhe-Indian scene, it seems that a number of our legislators mis-interpret uniformity for unity. We assess the tribal problem strictly in view of the scientific connotation of the concepts 'assimilation' and 'integration'.

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In the theoretical perspective, the culture of a group is both ethno-histoncal and functional. Epistemologically, 'culture comprises an historically acquired actual ideal forms of behaviour, feeling and thought of members of society, as well as the products of these processes, such as artifacts, socifacts, menti facts and agrofacts'. In the process of culture integration all the aspects of a culture are not assimilated by the alien culture. There emerges a level of integration wherein some of the aspects of the plurality of cultures are integrated. Each culture has its distinctive logical-aesthetic pattern consisting of complementary interests and values. A kind of taleofunctional integration of culture designed with the spirit of harmonization of polar, complementary interests and values can provide both the means and the ends of social being. This has to be done keeping in view the newly emergent cultural institutions and processes, for 'every real or existential culture is an eclectic combination of traditional elements and emergent forms; what varies is the proposition of the old and the new and the effectiveness of the role of rational thought in coordinating them'.

The process of culture integration, on theoretical plane tends to give two types of crises, namely, existential and exiological. The occupants of culture are faced with the problem of the preservation of their social existence and the transformations in the form of system ofvalues. The situation seems to be anormally difficult. In a developing society where there is emergence of new institutional orders along with their goals or ends and the instrumentality of means or norms the chances of various structures falling to an anomic situations, are not, out of question.

The theoretical frame of reference discussed in the foregoing section, helps us better to assess the process of tribal culture integration in the Indian scene. We propose to discuss this cultural transformation on the model of Wirth who distinguishes four types of societies, namely, pluralistic in which a minority desires existence side by side with the majority and other minorities; secondly, assimilation is 'in which a minority desires absorption in the dominant group' and the majority accepts the idea; 'thirdly, secessionist wherein a minority seeks both cultural and political independence; and finally, militant in which a minority goes beyond the desire for equality and seeks domination. Thus, for instance, the Christians in India form a pluralistic society; the tribal of Central Zone are an assimilationist society, and the Nagas constitute a secessionist society.

The Central Zone includes the States of West Bengal, Bihar, Southern Uttar Pradesh, Southern Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Northern Bombay and Orissa. The tribes of this zone have linguistic affinities with the Austric family of languages, though important tribes like the Oraon and the Kolam, the Khond and the Gond speak languages having a Dravidlan affinity". We call the tribals of this zone as an assimila"tianist society because their economic, political, and linguistic assimilation in. the rest of the society seems to have been almost completed and there'is-a satisfactory progress in the religious sphere from animism to Hinduism with their ultimate absorption in the Hindu society; and there remains only cultural variation in the institution orders of family kinship. The other modes of psychological, phenomenological and mythological integration also seem to near-won-over.

ASSUMPTIONS

The integration of assimilationist society, on Indian scene, presupposes some basic assumptions. First, no uniform policy of tribal cultural integration can be followed on all the tribals of the country. For, the tribals in the country are at various stages of development ranging from food gathering to market economy, or for instance, tribals living in compact villages to those living in scattered ones. It thus warrants the designing of different schemes of development for the - tribals of varying strata. Second, the tribal culture, like any other, is an organic whole wherein the different culture elements are integrated in the sense that the elements are interdependent. Change functionally integrated in the sense that the elements are functionally in one element mechanically means change in other parts of the culture. This requires a harmonization or blending of different elements. Third, the axiological factors have a predominance over the existential ones. With these assumptions in mind we proceed to assess the level of integration achieved as a result of the working of official tribal policy. Such an attempt would help us to bring out the consequences of the development processes.

ECONOMIC STRUCTURE

For a very long period of history the Scheduled Tribes lived on bare subsistence economy. As a result of economic protection given to them and the working of the Five-Year Plans the tribals are gradually but surely drawn into the wider economic framework of the country. This results in their economic integration. The tribal economic integration, however, does not mean that they have attained the general per capita level of income. Actually, integration implies that the tribals have shown their acceptance to the broader economic policies of the nation state. They might still continue to remain a little not well-off from the general standard but their involvement in the market economy definitely shows symptoms of economic integration. This can be viewed with reference to the institutional patterns referred to as property, occupation contract and money.

The Constitution gives fundamental right to own private property and this applies to all the citizens of the country. The Scheduled Tribes are bestowed with additional right of property, for their ownership to land is not transferable. This legal protection is vested in all the categories of Scheduled

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Tribes. Similarly, they have a right to profess any occupation like other citizens of the country. Occupation for the tribals, therefore, is achievement - oriented rather than ascription. In the sphere of economic enhancement, the tribals are gradually giving up the Jajmani system and are being drawn in a market economy. The contract system-an agreement involving an exchange, is equally applicable to the Scheduled Tribes. Government loans and the loans taken from the traders are subjected to legal contract. The working of cooperatives among the tribals also deals vigorously on contract basis. This sanctioned pattern of contract involves the tribals in the pattern-maintenance of the economic system of the country.

Prior to the operation of national economy the motivation behind the tribal economic activities was only meagre subsistence to the extent of keeping by body and soul together. This could have been done by hunting, food-gathering or shifting cultivation. But the new economic policy has provided the tribals with a motivation-a definite purpose of action charged with developmental emotions or sentiments. They newly released norms and values of growing more food with skilled and advanced techniques of cultivation, are being gradually working as motivational spring boards for the tribals.

The above generalizations regarding the economic integration of tribals are too broad indeed. This prompts us immediately to refer to some specific data which may tell the exact trends of tribal economic integration.

Among the most important indications of the status and power of a group is its place in the economic structure. The new economy is based on increased farm products including commercial ones and the industrial output The central tribal zone that we have taken for our reference here includes among other tribes the Santhal, Hos, Kols, Bhils, Gonds, Oraons and the Konds. We havecalled these groups of Scheduled Tribes as an assimilationist society. These tribals have been subjected to a continuous extension of their economic frontier to the national economic terminus. F.G, Bailey writing about the Konds of Bisipara (Orissa) reports that the tribe has taken to market economy and grows commercial crops such as turmeric and oil-seeds which are not grown by the caste Oriyas. Bisipara has received modern economy in the form of a traders' frontier. Concluding the economic integrative trends of the Konds, Bailey observes: 'this, in brief, is the effect on agriculture of the traders' frontier, which, in Bisipara, represents the modern economy of India and the world'.

Quite like the agrarian society of the country, agriculture occupies a central place in the economic activity of the tribal people. According to the census of 1961, 68.15 per cent of tribals work as cultivators, 19.73 as agricultural labourers, and 3.42 labourers in mining and forestry, etc., the remaining being occupied in other, services;'

The Santhals who in 1868 were'hpstile to caste Hindus and only tolerated the blacksmith, have now taken to cultivation on the pattern of caste Hindus and they "have during the past been developing and altering, at the present time they are in a transitory stage". The Santhals, therefore, had begun on the journey to economic integration about four decades back. The Hos, as Ghurye informs us, have mooted the modern problem and resolved upon a solution to it. In the same vein Majumdar and Madan talk about the revolution which has taken place among the Hos as a result of the introduction of money economy. Griffiths bestows all appreciation on the Kols "who accommodate themselves better to the modern economic world than the Gonds, and that they are bad mixers; nor are they limited to particular occupation". The Gonds of Madhya Pradesh once known for sacrificing and eating bullocks have taken to new methods of sowing paddy and that they have not only taken to cotton cultivation and adopted improved methods of farming but are also rearing cattle. The Oraons of Chotanagpur, as S.C. Roy describes them, centre round their agriculture. They now grow cotton and their women hand-spin it. The Bhils of Rajasthan and Gujarat among whom I had the opportunity to carry out field work have successfully taken to skilled agriculture. They grow commercial crops such as tobacco, cotton and ground-nut.

The point that I want to make is that the tribals of Central zone have taken to agriculture as a main source of livelihood. The method of cultivation and irrigation is similar to that practiced in the non-tribal villages of India. The forces of modernization released at the hands of Community Development Blocks, Tribal Blocks, and communication links have created a congenial situation in which the tribals are confidently responding positively to improved seeds, chemical fertilizers, improved cattle, pump-ing sets, and commercial crops. This obviously is a positive step towards tribal integration in the wider economic system.

There are, however, some new processes found operating among the tribals. In our country higher status and power are assigned to white-collar jobs where manual labour is at its minimum. The tribals who have received a little education-technical or liberal have chosen to go in for these white-collar jobs. The white-collar jobs being limited and increasingly scarce, the tribals have taken to political life the opportunities for which are simply available with the introduction of Panchayati-Raj. White-collar opportu-nities made available to the Scheduled Tribes on all India basis in the Central Government services for the years 1959 to 1967, in the categories of Class I, II, III and IV (excluding sweepers) is given in the following Table:

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TABLE 1

Progressive Representation of Scheduled Tribes in Central Government for the Years 1959-67

Year	Total No. of employees	Scheduled Tribes	Percentage
1959	17,75,080	30,518	1.71
1960	18,38,928	35,652	1.90
1961	18,66,936	37,704	2.02
1962	19,09,262	38,708	2.02
1963	21,18,599	43,532	2.05
1964	33,06,875	47,377	2.15
1965	23,10,630	51,039	2.21
1966	23,44,960	52,655	2.24
1967	23,57,782	55,178	2.24

The participation of tribals in business, wholesaling and manufacturing is almost absent. A few of them have taken to industrial labour, and farm labour such as in the big plants and tea gardens. Nevertheless, it may safely be said that the tribals have never been compelled to take up low occupations such as weaving and sweeping in the factory.

The tribals of Central Zone, despite their achievement in the sphere of economy, their rising standard of living are faced with some economic problems such as the land-hunger, adequate money-lending facilities and job-opportunities for those who are educated. But then, these are problems which are not particular to the tribals but are characteristic of the agrarian society and the educated unemployed class. This, however, does not mean that the tribal economic integration is at the lowest level. In point of fact, the society is fully equipped with an assimilational atmosphere in which their emotions and sentiments are charged with the economic goals of development.

POLITICAL STRUCTURE

Since the attainment of independence, the tribals have become part and parcel of the general political system of the county. They are the citizens of the nation and are subjected to the Constitution and the legal code. Indian Constitution carries a whole array of political and social life and this is being implemented through modern technology and administration.

Bailey interprets the political system of Bisipara in terms of a person's membership of the village and his being a citizen of India. He considers the village as an impeiium in which 'the social roles of the administrators and the men of the village do not overlap. Even caste is irrelevant'.

The tribal councils which used to be all powerful in directing the behaviour of its members are now soon weakening, for the administration has abrogated the right of the tribal council to sit judgement or criminal cases. The nyaya panchayats have taken over the judgement of ordinary civil cases in its hands. This has reduced the dominance of tribal or clan councils.

The four general elections arid the reservation of seats in Vidhan Sabha and Sansad have created a political awakening among the tribes. Participation in election campaigns and contact with party bosses tend to create frequent inter-group interactions and maneuvering. The introduction of Panchayat Raj has further offered opportunity for an increased involvement of tribals in the political activities. The tribal village like any other village is embraced with its national political system. The first tier of the Panchayat is linked with the Zilla Parishad, the State and the Centre. This appears to be a successful political integration of the tribals, albeit it may be said that the tribal leaders at various levels of party and government have not delivered goods to satisfaction. Nevertheless, the elections in Panchayat Raj hardly go uncontested and the tribals leave no opportunity for the acquisition of power at Panchayat or Samiti level. This is a clear indication of the pervasive spirit of politicization found among the tribals. Effective tribal leadership largely depends on the educational and social development of the tribals.

SOCIAL STRUCTURE

Yet another structural level where tribal integration seems to be successful is the area of social life. The tribals have benefited largely from the scholarships and the hostel facilities for prosecuting higher education. This is event from the increasing number of scholarships given by the government. The expenditure incurred on the award of post-metric scholarships was Rs. 83,80,622 in 1966-67. Tribal students are increasingly taking admission to technical and liberal courses of education. Strikingly enough, there is no separate educational system for the tribals. They are exposed to the same system which is sufficient enough to bring the tribals in vital national fold.

The tribal family pattern in the Central Zone is polygamous, at least theoretically. But the process of modernization has tended to give a monogamous form of family. The Bhils of Rajasthan have a tremendous desire to go for a monogamous family pattern and the practice of polygamy is looked at with contempt. Most of the tribals of our reference who had done without Brahmins in the past now try to secure their services on occasions of birth, marriage and death. There is a tendency to abandon divorce and to replace bride-price by dowry.

The tribals have tried to emulate the symbols, values and norms of the groups which surround them. They have acquired an urge for prestige and this has brought about changes of magnitude in their dress pattern, diet and social

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practices of various kinds. Such an internationalization made by the tribals has a cohesive effect. 'It tends to pull down the walls which in the past segregated the different sections of society.'

RITUAL STRUCTURE

The 19th century intellectuals of Europe who were confronted with the problem of the crises in their age resorted to moral norms which, to them, could reconstruct the society. It is in this context that Emile Durkhiem talked to collective conscience in the primitive society and the moraldensity in advanced one for creating integration in the segmentary social structures. On theoretical perspective this has a bearing on the integration of tribals at the religious plane in India. Religion correspondingly changes the social structure. The secular character of the Indian nation-state can hardly initiate matters in this area but as a result of communication and increasing contacts the tribals, a large majority among them have taken to Hinduism, the other religion being accepted is Christianity. The religion of Scheduled Tribes as given in 1961 census is as under :

TABLE 2

Religion of Scheduled Tribes (1961 Census)

Tribal Group	Persons	Christians	Hindus
Rural	29,107	1,562	26,078
MTR	772	92	632
Total	29,879	1,654	26,710

Source: A Statistical Handbook of Tribal Welfare and Development.

Writing about the Hos of Singhbhum, Majumdar informs that the tribe is definitely inclined to Hinduism and it has begun to observe Hindu holidays and festivals," though there are some rituals which put the Hos to animism. There have been messianic movements among the Hos which have worked to check the inroads of Hindu and Christian cultures.[25] The Santhals seem to have come nearer to the Brahmical culture.[26] Similarly, the Kols recognize the deities of the lower caste Hindus. The Bhils burn the dead body, the cremation ground being anywhere near a shrine or a tank. The Gonds bury their dead, though they recognize the ordinary village deities of lower castes. There have been reform movements among the Gonds which indicate their religious integration with the Hindus. "The ideal which the modern Gond leaders aim at is the ethical standard as envisaged and propagated by Hinduism, a Hinduism in its old and most orthodox form". As a traditional practice. the Konds bury the deal though creation seems to be on increase.

The tribal fasts and festivals are usually associated with their locality. Ancestor and nature appear to be a popular form of worship among the tribals of the Central Zone. The trends of conversion have two directions - Hinduism and Christianity. The consequences of these conversions are discussed in the concluding section of the paper.

LINGUISTIC AFFINITIES

In the Central Zone there are languages of two families - Austric and Dravidian, the former being dominant. On the integrative perspective it may be said that the contacts with government personnel, contractors, traders, etc., have all affected the language of the tribals. Hindustani or the regional dialects, in the situation of increasing communication links, are gradually being taken up as means of interaction. Language in this respect serves as a strong medium of tribal integration.

EMERGING SITUATION : CONSEQUENCES OF GOVERNMENT POLICY

At the outset, I started with the proposition that the tribals of Central Zone are an assimilationist society, for they have shown willingness to come in the fold of national culture. Our assessment of the whole situation shows that the tribals of this zone have more or less been integrated in the broader economic, political, social, religious and lingual system of the country, though it is not without disfunctional consequences in some spheres of national life. Looking to these fissiparous trends there seems to be reason-able ground to reconsider our official tribal policy. We insist on reconsideration because there are dangers involved if we go ahead with the same approach of social security measures.

An assimilationist society when fed with an over dose of integration gets suspicious of the dominant group and in course of time seeks for both its cultural and political independence. The official policy in our country has allowed as a friendlier gesture the existence of the plurality of tribal cultures. The party in power has made compromises and leaders of the rank have preached for the tribals "to develop along the lines of their own genius. We should avoid imposing anything on them. We should encourage their traditional arts and culture". This is precisely eclecticism in our policy. When such a type of friendly plural existence is given to tribal culture, in any event of frustration it may develop a movement dedicated to complete independence. There are indications of emergence of secessionist society. In extreme cases it may take the shape of a militant society such as that of eastern border tribes. We have to be cautious of the emerging situation.

The level of integration that we have achieved so far seems to be satisfactory. At the existential level the tribals of our study have reached a stage where they are soon to lose their social identity or distinctness. What is peculiar in a Bhil to a caste Hindu? Perhaps nothing and this resolves

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the existential crisis. In the exiological premise, the national values, norms and goals have come to near acceptance by the tribals. The problem of tribals in terms of legal safeguards seem to have been solved. The mountain is scaled. But the extension of safeguards for another period often years make us serious to look to the bitter consequences of some of our measures.

The reservation of seats in the Panchayati Raj and the Assembly and Parliament has tended to serve in favour of the dominant party. Actually at the time of Constituent Assembly debates such a fear was expressed by some members. One of the members rejected the reservation provision and said that the person belonging to the group of reservation might be a person whom the majority community backs. 'Perhaps that man may be a man liked by the majority under the guise of belonging to the minority community'.

The government policy of creating separate hostels and rehabilitation colonies for the tribals has also resulted in creating a separatist tendency among the tribals. The tribals seem to have learnt the technique of factional politics and by creating parties such as Jharkhand they have raised demands for separate states or localities. Actually the creation of Nagaland-a compromise made by the Congress Party-is the result of this tendency of tribalism. Recently one of the Bhil members of Rajasthan Assembly threatened to stand for the demand a separate State for the Bhils of Rajasthan-the State to be termed Bhil Pradesh.

The economic benefits advanced by the government have rendered the tribals dependent instead of being self-reliant. If the present policy based on faulty assumptions is carried further, the integration of tribals is fraught with the danger of being dommed altogether. There are positive signals of the stepping up of secessionist society-a society emerging from the peace-loving assimilationist one. The problem, therefore, is to redefine the whole tribal situation in the context of the above emerging consequences.

THE NEW APPROACH

The socio-cultural situations that existed at the time of the formation of tribal policy do not remain the same today. Changes of magnitude have occurred. The policy that we have been pursuing is highly characterized by humanitarian spirit of social security. It seems to have served out its purpose. Looking to the present trends of transformation found among the tribals, the policy seems to be outdated. The postulate of culture integration that we proposed at the outset, that is, taleofunctional integration, takes into consideration the historical continuity of Indian character and culture: it brings a proportionate convergence in the traditional elements of the socio-cultural differences and the emergent forms of institutional framework. The axis of our efforts is the general welfare of the masses. In achieving this goal, the tribal man power should be organized on a rational base keeping aside the political and other vested interests. This being the coreofo'uYnew tribal approach we discuss to seek out a paradigm oftaleofunctiohal integration. This is just a hypothetical consideration which "requires vigorous analysis and testing in empirical reality.

In the present tribal situation we pose the question: What do the tribals expect today from the society? Surely their welfare which is not other than the general welfare of the society. Three alternative paradigms might be discussed in this respect. A section of students of tribal integration may plead for bridging the social distance that we find between the tribals and the rest of the society. Even if there is similarity in the social structures of different groups, this similarity does not bring about social equality. The American white and the negro are similar to one another in regard to their social structure but is not the social distance between the two groups very great? This obviously aggravates the negro-white relationships. Such an approach interprets the official policy in terms of social distance without bringing about any significant change in the old policy. If the policy is redesigned in tune with the perspectives of social distance, perhaps it may serve some purpose of the party in power. Such an approach may further be abandoned on the argument that in view of the basic tenets of the functional theory of stratification, it is well high impossible for any society to reach a stage of equality in social-roles. The approach is Utopian for the literature of "social-scales" carried out in advanced countries indicates that social differentiation remains to a degree in all the socio-cultural groups. It will be ridiculous to think in terms of establishing matrimonial relations between the tribal and the High Caste Hindus. In the caste system itself despite our efforts of decades the inter-caste marriage remains infrequent. Our present official policy both in its seminal and present content hardly conveys the spirit of removing social distance. It does stand for the removal of social discrimination. That purpose is served. And the romantic approach of social distance, now, no more stands any justification.

An second approach may be to allow some of the safeguards, which have not proved to result in dysfunctional consequences, to the tribals. For instance, the enactments of tenancy, land acquisition, and forestry may continue. This may be done after a thorough probe in the whole situation. The safeguards which the tribals should not have any more, in this case, should be withdrawn. Such an approach would alight the over dose of integration and would check the emergence of secessionist society.

Yet another approach which may be called extremist would be to despecify the Scheduled Tribes and treat them at par with the agrarian society which, too, is confronted

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with similar problems. The argument advanced for the acceptance of this policy is based on the ground that the overflow of economic aid and the preferences in service and education have resulted in bitter consequences-encouraged separatist tendency and in view of all this de-specification seems to be the only remedy.

The approaches as discussed above are not without limitations. The emergent tribal situation warrants an immediate solution. The situation is plain but the remedy is not yet clear. In view of the assessment made in the foregoing section of the paper it may be proposed for consideration that a uniform policy for tribals of all the zones may better be abandoned. The tribals of a region have their own problems, they have their own ethno-historical continuity and they cannot be subjected to a blanket policy of all India tribal level.

The Commissioner for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes should examine the level of integration reached by different tribes in different states and de-specify those tribes which in the opinion of the Commissioner are suffering from mere economic backwardness like any other people and include them in the first instance in the schedule of backward class. ■

POLYANDROUS TRIBES IN THE NORTH - WEST

The interaction of social and economic forces, to varying degrees, has been clearly brought out in the various models of tribal development in different situation, discussed in the preceding chapters. When we come to the North-WesternTribal Region extending from the foot-hills of U.P. to the Northern borders of Himachal Pradesh, the social situationassurnes special significance. The most important distinguishing social characteristic in this region is polyandry prevalent amongst all sections of the society. The specific case of the tribal groups in the hills of U.P. will provide the backdrop for theoretical discussion and its practical implications.

The polyandrous region in the U.P. hills extends over the districts of Dehradun, UttarKashi and Tehri - Garhwal. It comprises five blocks viz., Kalsi and Chakrata in Dehra Dun, Purola and Naugaon in Uttar Kashi and Jaunpur in Tehri Garhwal. This region continues into Kinnaur district of Himachal Pradesh.

Although the entire area has the same social structure, only the Jaunsaries of Jaunsar-Bawar Parganas comprising two development blocks of Kalsi and Chakrata have been recognised as scheduled tribes. Jaunsari is not a caste or 'tribe' but is a generic name for all those who are original inhabitants of Jaunsar-Bawar Parganas. This group includes Bralimins, Khasa Kshatriyas and a number of lower castes like Bajgies, Koltas, Domes, Jogies etc. These lower castes are recognised as scheduled castes in the remaining three blocks of the other two districts.:

The total population of the: area according to the 1971 Census is follows:

Name of the Block	S.C. Population	ST. Population	Total Population
1. Kaisi	2,881	28,883	40,189
2. Chakrata	3,248	27,591	32,834
3. Purola	9,584	1	30,845
4. Naugaon	8,428	127	33,123
5 . Jaunpur	6,609	369	33,645

The above polyandrous region can be treated as a unit for development not only because it has the same social system but also because the level of economy in these areas is almost the same. It is also a compact area and can be treated as one small resource region. Since sociological structure in the case of this region is the most important factor in defining the strategy of development, it may be desirable to cut across district boundaries for the purposes of developmental planning.

RELEVANCE OF SOCIAL STRUCTURE IN ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

It may be necessary in the present case to understand, in the first instance, the relevance of social structure in economic planning for the region. It is generally agreed that social and economic activities are not always distinguishable in the more backward areas. Marriage is a social institution. But if a heavy bride-price has to be paid, it acquires an economic dimension. So long as the society is a closed one and monetary system has not penetrated for into such a region, demand for bride-price could only mean transfer of assets from one family to another in the same group. It does not have any implications for the group as a whole. Even loans in kind for such purposes in that situation would be notional and could be forgotten or become inoperative if the economic condition of the debtor does not allow him to pay. With the opening up of the areas and introduction of monetary economy, the appearance of money lender on the scene, not necessarily belonging to the local community, presents another dimension. The bride-price is no longer a transfer of consumable assets but may even mean pledging of capital assets or surrender of their command over sources of livelihood. It has, therefore, been urgec. elsewhere that although direct attempt at social planning is not the right course and may amount to unnecessary interference, economic development has to be viewed in the context of totality of socio-economic processes in the community.

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Besides the considerations noted above, the polyandrous area provides yet another dimension. In the pn icess of social change, different aspects of social life have different propensiities for, or resistance to change. It is well-known that customs or practice s relating to outward behaviour pattern of a community are the easiest to change. These include dress, outward behaviour, forms of amusements etc. Some of these changes may have far-reaching consequence but at the time the society accepts the new mores, they are considered to be on the periphery of their behaviour-structure. The areas of second order difficulty are the customs and practices relating to inter-caste dining, well tried social and economic relationships and rituals not connected with the crisis of life. Institutions like the joint family also fall in this category. It is well-known that with the spread of education this second order changes are also easily accepted. Educated young men generally do not practice untouchabiliry; they will not mind eating with any group; they may break the taboos of vegetarianism etc. The third order of change in the process is connected with the crisis of life. Marriage is not entirely a personal matter. It also determines social cohesion of a group and acceptability of an individual in the group of its origin. Inter caste marriages are not unknown but researches have shown that even highly educated people, who have a very liberal outlook on life, may not like to go out of their traditionally prescribed social field for the purposes of marriage. The last order change is the relationship of individual with the unknown. Here the changes are the most difficult. There are very few cases, where even the most modern families may deviate from the tradition in performing the last rites of one of their members, even if he my happen to be a social revolutionary.

The socio-economic development of the polyandrous society, therefore, has to be viewed in a broad frame. As this area gets opened up and benefits of education begin to reach a larger section of this community, it finds itself isolated in an important rej pect-in a vast ocean of humanity having a different social structure. Even thoughtful people, used to monogamous and polygamous social systems, are unable to adjust themselves to a polyandrous system when they come face to face with it. It may be recalled that a Hindu is very familiar with the mythological case of Draupadi who had five husbands. However, even in Mahabharat, the case was not presented as a part of any prevalent social norm in an area but was treated as an exception for which rationalization was sought in a previous life of Draupadi. Thus, the first contact of the polyandrous society with others makes a direct hit on the most intimate aspect of the social and personal life of its members. There is almost a guilt conscience created amongst them by the new contact and the spread of education, which takes for granted different social mores as the ones sanctified by tradition. The process of social change, therefore, in this case gets reversed, where, the peripheral and less significant aspects continue to be unchanged and uninfluenced whereas the most it intimate aspects are the hardest hit.

SOCIAL STRUCTURE AND PROPERTY OWNERSHIP PATTERN

Economic development necessarily has its influence on the property ownership pattern. In this context, two new developments in the Indian society deserve a mention. The disintegration of the joint family in the rural society in India has not created any dissonance between the prevalent custom and the law. The impact of the new Hindu Code, which gives property rights to the daughter, and thus introduced a legal element not in conformity with the prevalent social practice, has not as yet been fully felt because of a number of other counterweighing social customs and institutions. In a polyandrous society, property ownership can be considered to follow joint family pattern with a further cementing factor of common wife or wives and common legal paternity of all the children. The social unit and economic unit, therefore, run parallel and the notional ownership of property remains with the eldest brother.

The process of change presumes differential growth of different members of a community although the extent of differential could be suitably regulated. The differential growth within a family unit leads to differential claims on the fruits of individual labour. In this context, if the legal base of society is divorced from social reality, tremendous tensions are likely to arise. The whole society may be faced with a crisis situation. Here again, two approaches may be possible. One view could be to let the social structure have full blast of new confrontation and realign itself with the new structures within as short a period as possible. The other view could be not to superimpose a state of confrontation from outside and let the process of change be made gradual and, as far as possible, spontaneous within the society itself. The confrontation and quick change over thesis may result in emotional disruptions and a chaos in their moral moorings. The society may get disintegrated as a living entity. We will have occasion to discuss these aspects in relation to certain sections of the society where such processes are already in evidence.

The super-imposition of a uniform land ownership system of the plains in the poly androus society has already created rights in favour of all adult members of a family and has introduced a new element which is still not within the comprehension of the existing social system and is likely to acquire an autonomous character in deciding the direction of social change. The influence of this provision fortunately so far has been peripheral and earliest opportunity may be taken to review or make suitable amends in these legal impositions on the local social and economic system which appears to have been done without consulting the community or understanding the long-term consequences of the change.

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SOCIALSTRATIFICATION

Another aspect of the social structure in this community is the caste hierarchy. While the rigours ofuntouchability in this area are not the same as in other parts of U.P., the Koltas and other lower communities occupy almost the substratum of the social pyramid. Many members of these communities are traditionally attached to members of the higher castes as bonded labour. The caste panchayats are dominated by the 'Siyanas' who are generally 'Thakws' and some time Brahmins. There are no separate caste Panchayats of the lower communities who, therefore, have to depend on the traditional panchayats, dominated by the higher groups, for decisions even in their internal social matters like marriage, divorce etc. Although the role of these panchayats in many important issues is declining, their hold on social system continues unabated, particularly in the context of vested interests getting involved in the social institutions for ulterior purposes.

ECONOMIC ZONES OF THE REGION

Although the area is economically homogeneous, yet there are some variations which will have to be taken into account for any meaningful planning of the region. Broadly, the region can be divided into 3 parts (i) Fatehparvat region of Purola Block; (ii) the open valley areas scattered throughout the region; and (iii) hilltop areas.

The Fatehparvat area has got a distinctive economy mainly centered around sheep keeping. Agrlculture is subsidiary. The open valley areas have good cultivation. Some of these areas are getting the benefit of new communication network as well. They are attracting or are likely to attract modern economic activity. The hilltop areas depend on terraced cultivation and forest produce for the livelihood.

The economy of these three regions is very much interdependent. Those rearing sheep in Fateharvat depend on the open valley areas for bulk of their food supply. The Fatehparvat area is also under siiow for about six months. They have barter with the open valley areas and exchange their wool for grains,

RELIGIOUS COMPLEX

The economic and social structures in this area is also linked with the religious complex of the region. The village deities are greatly honoured and Mahasu, Duryodhan and Kama are very much feared. The livelihood of certain castes like Bajgies has been dependent on their traditional role of drummers and musicians.

ECONOMIC SPECIALISATION

There is also considerable economic specialisation. For example, Baggies are also traditional barbers and tailors. Koltas have also a tradition of sewing with hand. There are some communities which do leather work. Spinning of wool and weaving continues to be a universal household craft in those areas where sheep is reared. The lower communities also provide the farm labour. Majority of land is under the ownership of higher castes. Most of the vacant land is also under their effective control and used by these communities for grazing their cattle. Trees on vacant lands, particularly those which are used for providing fodder to sheep during winter, are owned individually. The capacity of an individual to own sheep depends on the number of trees wliich he owns bee, tuse it is the quantity of fodder available during the leanest period that determines the maximum number of sheep. The pastures are owned jointly by the community.

GUJJARS

One extraneous group, which is becoming an important economic factor, particularly in Fatehparvat area, is that of Gujijars. They are nomadic people who mainly depend on rearing buffialoes. During summer they take their cattle to the vast pasture lands in the hilltop areas and during winter they go back to the forests around Saharanpur, Meerut, etc. The number of Gujjar groups moving up and down has increased manifold in the last two decades. There is a competition for command of pasture land between the Gujjars and the local communities part cularly because sheep does not graze where buffaloes graze. Thus, the effective carrying capacity of pasture lands in Fatehparvat areas has been reduced because of a larger seasonal influx of cattle herds owned by the Gujjars.

NEW ECONOMIC ACTIVITIES AND LABOUR PRICE

In past two decades, the area has been considerably opened up. There is substantial road construction activity going on and smell shops and market centres have sprung along the roads. There has been considerable in-migration particularly of traders and contractors who have settled on strategic points in the new road network. Some of them have also moved into interior areas and established trading centres. Some other economic activities, particularly fruit plantations, have also been stimulated around certain points along the roads. However, the activization of dormant resources in the undulating areas even with, a substantial road network has not been appreciable. The benefits have reached a very small strip on either sides of the roads.

The forest resources in the many areas are quite rich. The rivers provide transportation channel for logs during winter. The forests, therefore, are worked just during the rainy season and for sometime thereafter. When the current of streams becomes negotiable, logs are transported through them. The working of the forests is through contractors and much of the labour appears to be from Nepal or from the plains of U.P. Another important forest-based activity is

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extraction of resin. Here again, labour is generally brought from the plains. It is reported that average income per labourer per year in the forest contracts is between two to three thousand rupees. The work on roads is ah o quite remunerative and here a mixed work force is employed. The bigger contractors are from outside; the petty contractors are from within the area generally belonging to higher castes. The wages on the road work may be between the Rs. 7 or 8 par days. The rates of farm labour, particularly nearer the roads, is quite high and the wages even in the interior open valley areas may be about Rs. 5 per day. Reference has already been made of the system of bondage which is prevalent in the area. The wages of the bonded labour are fixed according to the custom and in most cases they are not more than Rs. 200 to 300 per annum. Many of the local young men are reported to be employed in the plains in petty menial jobs as domestic servants and in restaurants. The number of such out-migrants appears to be sizeable.

Thus, a very complex labour force flows and counter-flows have got established in this area. The modern activity is also changing the earlier power equations. On the one hand, wef and that because of the inability of local resources to carry more persons, the population of the region has remained static and sizeable numbers have to find their way for employment in the plains. On the other hand, the tempo of economic activity has increased considerably at least in some of the regions with large investments finding their way in this area. This has resulted in two consequences. A large labour force is finding its way into this an a along with contractors. These jobs, in a way, can be said to be more skilled or require work habits or seasonality which may not be suitable to the local population. Although the new activity gets reflected in a higher wage structure in the rural areas also, particularly open valley areas, the condition of those who are suffering from adverse economic relationships has not improved. It appears that the equation of mutual dependence between the master and the serf has been disturbed and the owners of land find better remunerative openings of the modern activity. Perhaps, polyandry is also helpinn in strengthening of their economic base. In the traditional system, one member of the family could go with the sheep while the other members could look after the fields. In the new context, one member can go on a higher skill job while the other continues in the village.

This has given the families from higher social strata greater economic strength and makes the serf much more dependent on the master. It is reported that sometimes even when a bonded labour is employed on the modern higher remuneration jobs, the proceeds are taker: away by the master and the serf has to be content with his traditional wage.

There is a perceptible slide back of skilled communities with recent opening up of areas by the road network, inundation of the region by machine - made goods and introduction of modern skills. With the plastic shoes finding their way in the region, some of the shoemaking communities are finding it difficult to survive in their traditional professions.

They are becoming landless labourers or serfs in the traditional social structure. The Bajgies and Koltas are losing their skills of hand-sewing in the face of new sewing machines. Here again, it is the advanced communities which are moving up the skill spectrum and taking to tailoring and, thus, effectively competing with the poorer sections who are getting out of their traditional jobs and becoming landless labourers. The Bajgies still continue to be official singers and drum beaters but that does not sustain them fully as their traditional remunerations are not moving up and their side-incomes are getting eroded.

Basically the situation in open valley area emerges as a disequilibrium between the demand of man-power in the new economic sectors and availability of man-power with appropriate skills, v/ith adequate mobility without serious constraints. It would suggest that the total investment in the area is appreciable because there is a net demand of additional manpower. Yet the polarization within the local community is becoming clearer with higher investments. The model of development in this region, therefore, must concentrate on removing the disequilibrium and countering the processes leading to polarization. If this is not done and additional investments are planned in the modern sector, tension may get generated which may lead to social disruption.

SPECIAL ATTENTION TO THE UNDER-PRIVILEGED

The first important question, therefore, is to make the new job opportunity available to the underprivileged sections of the community. Since the region has overall shortage of manpower for the economic programme, this would require suitable administrative measures. It may be possible the planning authorities to guarantee a job to each underprivileged family in this area. Such undertaking may help in evolving unorthodox method of work and search for opportunity of investment in different sub-regions within the overall resource ceilings. For example, in any organised work a preference clause could be inserted in the favour of landless or poorer sections of the community. Similarly, the programme-content could be related to the availability of work force on the one hand and the available work force could be suitably trained for the new work opportunity on the other.

It will be necessary that the existing constraints on the poorer sections of the community in various forms, like bondage and adverse service relationships, are terminated simultareously. Mere legal termination will not be adequate. It must be accompanied by systematic field work in the area where the members of affected community are explained the new approach and are simultaneously provided with suitable

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job opportunities. It may be necessary to caution at this stage against superimposing elitist concepts of mobility of labour where a mere arithmetical matching of number of jobs and the number of men available is considered to be adequate. While dealing with poorer sections of the community and persons belonging to more backward areas, the world-view of these communities and groups is an important factor. Anything beyond a few miles is unknown to an average villager. The fear of unknown is the most inhibiting factor to mobility of labour belonging to poorer sections of the community.

Urgent attention is to be given to those sections of the community who are facing slide back of technological skills in the faee of competition from the modern sector. They should be afforded the opportunity of upgrading and acquiring skills in professions akin to their own traditional professions. Matching of developmental programmes and the skill endowment of these groups will be an essential element of the new planning process!

FATEHPARVAT

In the case of Fatehparvat area, the serious competition for the pasture land from a stronger and articulate group of Gujjars will need to be understood clearly. The economy of this area will continue to be centered around sheep-rearing. Therefore, the rights of local community over the pastures will need to be carefully defined. It will also be necessary to explore the possibility of restoring their rights over earlier pasture in the neighbouring State of H.P. It will not be possible to plan for this group unless the problem of Gujjars is also systematically analysed and alternative solution found. Planning for Gujjars, who visit these areas annually, must be a complementary exercise of the plan of the development of this region.

FORESTS

The forests are an invaluable asset of this region. They can contribute substantially to the development of this area. It appears that whole policy of resin extraction will need to be reviewed. Similarly, the labour contract system will need to be attuned to become an integral part of the total economy of the region. There are large vacant lands which may not be brought under new forests, if problem of forest is viewed in the immediate context of forests economy alone. If it is made clear that the basic objective is to increase the forest wealth, there should be no objection to the local community being allowed to raise plantation crops within the reserve forests. The individual may be given limited ownership rights over plantations.

IN ACCESSIBILITY NEUTRALISATION

One of the most important problems of this area is the inaccessibility of most of the region, notwithstanding a substantial investment on the roads network. The concept of road development needs to be reviewed for sparsely populated areas. In the advanced areas, the development of roads has been gradual and went along with the economic needs of the region. This led to a belief in an invariable cause and effect relationship between road development and economic development. Since road development benefits immediately the elite of the local community and appears to be a necessary facility for flow of social and extension services and for administration, road construction programmes tend to be supported by those who count. There does not appear to be a conscious effort to identify, in time sequence, the benefits which will accrue to the area by the proposed road network and the necessary investment needs of the area in the concerned sectors which are likely to contribute towards the new benefits. For example, it may be vaguely pre sumed that roads will activise dormant economic potential of the region. But there is no assessment of the potential which would get activised by the opening up of the area.

While benefits in marketing from a new road network may be vaguely presumed to start accruing to an area in a specified, plan period the road may actually get completed with a time lag of, say, five years or more. Thus, there may be no synchronisation of the two elements. In such a planning process, what may hap pen often is that inaccessibility may, for a temporary period, get accentuated because the jeepable road may be dug up for conversion to higher standard road. The area which was jeepable becomes inaccessible. Thus, economic benefits from road construction, which may have to been presumed to accrue immediately, may not be available for a considerable time.

PRIORITIES IN PROGRAMMES

Another aspect in road planning is that the alternative uses of investments are not consciously worked out. The total investment on roads is extremely heavy. The question which has to be answered is whether an investment of similar outlay in other sectors would have produced better results. An alternative approach of inaccessibility neutralization, perhaps, could be useful in earlier phases of development. It could include subsidising transportation of local produce, by what ever means practical, up to the nearest collection points. This would provide opportunities to the labour in the most remote area and the investment will activise dormant resources over a much larger area lian what is possible by mere construction of roads whose benefits are limited to a small band. A judicious combination of the extent of road network and its class and inaccessibility neutralization policy would seem to be necessary in the early phases of development of inaccessible area.

TRAFFICKING

The problem of polarisation in the local community arising from the modern economic processes has been alluded to above. It will be necessary here to examine the

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socio-economic consequences of this factor more closely. There are some areas in the region where the members of certain lower communities have taken to prostitution as a matter of course. What appears to have started as a small trickle, in some areas, has assumed a torrential force. There are some villages in which every family has at least one of its members in prostitution rade. This problem has engaged attention of social workers, social scientists and administrators but as yet a comprehensive view appears to be missing. Sometimes, it is vaguely suggested that prostitution has something to do with the weakness of human nature about which nothing can be done. Even serious workers tend to attribute propensity for taking to this profession to the polyandrous structures of the society where relation with more than one man is accepted as natural. It appears that such judgments arise from attempt at superimposing one's own value judgment on a different social structure. It also shows a sort of haste in arriving at certain conclusions with which one can be at ease and an attempt to rationalise. Two important points have to be kept in view. Polyandry is the characteristic of the entire social structure of this region but it is only the women from lower communities who are taking to prostitution. Also, the disease is not evenly spread in area and, as yet, is rampant only in selected pockets whose size is increasing.

The analysis of economic situation in the earlier section clearly shows that the opening up of these areas has clearly resulted in the condition of these communities getting worse. The entire upper strata of the society has got strengthened. The traditional panchayat are dominated by the higher groups. The absence of any caste panchayats of the lower communities has led to a situation "where stronger groups use these panchayats to advance with impunity their own interests. Studies clearly show that the sequence of events leading a woman to the brothel invariably is through accrual of a debt, may be, for a marriage, loss of control on the means of livelihood, bondage of the family to a member of a higher community, the master or some other strong man of the area getting interested in trafficking of a member of the indebted family, contriving of dissolution of marriage actively supported by the traditional panchayat leaders for a share in the booty and, finally, migration of the woman or the whole family for prostitution.

It is, thus, clear that in the face of new economic stresses and strains, the lower communities are losing their nerve. The modern contact has further led them to a sort of guilt consciousness that polyandrous relationships are something to be despised. Thus, when a group under adverse economic conditions comes to lose faith in its own social ethic, the disruption is complete and individuals are like withered leaves of a tree fallen apart which could be carried away by the slightest breeze in any direction. Here the vested interest of the stronger communities comes into play as motive force contriving their path to the brothels of the plains.

Having lost faith in their social mores as also the cohesion of social structure, prostitution in the final stages, becomes a respectable profession. Therefore, in those areas where a large number of families have been forced into this profession, prostitution is now socially acceptable and has acquired its own force and logic. It is now feeding on itself and may engulf the other areas as well.

The state of loss of nerve in a community cannot be contained for long to a small section. It is clikely to spread; it is, therefore, necessary that this cancerous growth is checked at the earliest. An all out effort will be necessary where underprivileged sections of the community are pitched against the pressure from the stronger sections of the community. We have already discussed in an earlier section that in the context of the economic situation in this area such steps are within the realm of feasibility for which the only constraint appeal's to be proper planning and effective implement itcn.

SOCIAL SERVICES - EDUCATION

We have earlier referred to the problems arising from the opening up of this area and their confrontation with a different social structure. The sociological dimensions of this new contact are not clear as yet. Education is perhaps the most important input for influencing the world-view of any group. However, the content of education in tliis area is the same as for other areas in the State. A proper reorientation of the socioloical content ofthe curriculum in the primary stages would be necessary. It should be possible to help the community to view its own social structure as something arising from the needs of the area in a particular historical setting. Any super imposed institutional compulsions, leading to disintegration of the social system, may have to be removed and proper educational programmes could help them in the transitional period. It may be emphasised here that even a final goal must not be set for the group by outside intervention. Let the local leadership consider the situation and decide about the process of change which it would like to adopt. It is not necessary to contemplate once and-for-all decisions. Effort should be made to get the local community involved and become conscious of the new situation, about the possibilities of change and initiate a process whereby they are enabled to take necessary lead in this regard.

HEALTH SERVICES

The first requirement of every group is its very survival. Although detailed studies have not been made, it appears that population of this community has been constant over the past many decades. The population may have been limited by the total carrying capacity of the habitant of this

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community. If the zero-growth is result of migration, there should be no cause of concern. However, if there are other reasons which are basic to the health of the community, they need to be looked into on a priority basis. It appears that venereal diseases and T.B. have a high incidence. Leprosy is also prevalent in some areas The opening up of the area and higher incidence of trafficking present a health hazard to the community. Problem-oriented health services appear to be the urgent need.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, it appears that the planning of development of the sparsely populated hill areas of U.P. will call for an unorthodox approach. As the level of investment is quite appreciable in this area, it is the inter-sectoral and intra-sectoral priorities which need to be clearly defined. Neutralization of inaccessibility will bring larger areas within zone of influence of modern economic activities and activise dormant resources. Heavy investments on roads need to be reviewed. The most important immediate step will be to attend to the socio-economic polarisation and suitable measures have to be taken to strike a new balance in the social system. A conscious effort to remove constraint on the labour force belonging to the underprivileged sections through suitable administrative and legal measures will have to be undertaken. It may be possible, in the condition of this area, to guarantee a job to each family of the under-privileged sections. The sociological dimension in planning will be an important aspect. Whereas the stranglehold of the traditional panchayat on the lower community has to be broken, the attention and assistance of the very same panchayats will have to be sought for involving the community as a whole to stand to the new challenges and arrest it from sliding down the path of social disruption, which is already in evidence with reference to poorer sections in the area. A direct attack on trafficking will not be a symbolic gesture but, if taken seriously and in all its facets, it will hit on the socio-economic problems of the region at their most vital point and may mark the beginning of a new period in the socio-economic history of the region. ■

WHAT AILS INDIAN AHTHROPOLOGY?

by R. Siva Prasad

Anthropology, like the other disciplines, has its peaks and troughs. Unlike the others, its peaks are more undulating and this may be attributable to its growing divergence or gulf between its subdivisions (read physical/biological, social/ cultural, archaeoK gical/pre-historical and linguistic anthropologies). We have a tendency to identify our glory with either some eminent personalities or always try to bask in the glory of the past and hide behind the reality. This attitude of ours does not take us anywhere. Instead, we slide down in the estimation of our peers elsewhere. Therefore, it is essential for us to take a critical look at the troughs that the discipline is undergoing and take corrective steps well in time; otherwise, we will be in pits.

II

One might take comfort in looking at the spectrum of anthropologists who were, and are, employed in divergent disciplines or public spaces at both national and international levels. This gives us some pyrrhic satisfaction but will not lead us anywhere to strengthen the course of development of the discipline. Scholars point out the growth of anthropology was slow as compared to sociology (Sarana and Sinha 1976: 212). Why was it so? We need to find the answers for this lagging behind. One of the prominent reasons being, unlike anthropology, the sociologists have only one all-India professional body or association. We have not one but a handful of them. There is a need for a single unifying all-India professional forum or body for the anthropologists with a number of research committees (RCs) dealing with its subdivisions as well as interdisciplinary concerns. People should be "free to join the RCs and can organise their own regional or national conferences, and each can report to the all-India body. We need to start somewhere like this to rejuvenate and rekindle the spirit of anthropology.

When we talk of anthropology, we are always reminded that 'holism' is its hallmark. We are, however, not clear about how the holism operates within or between or across its subdivisions. Many a times, it is not even properly understood. Even if it was stated in terms of its linkages, it is always at a very superficial level or only in a general sense it is discussed. In fact, there are only a handful of scholars who have really tried to work it out in the past. However, such attempts are only countable and they were largely in the early stages of the founding of anthropology departments in India.

Every anthropology student is taught about what is anthropology-it is a science of man (read human); it studies about man and his works; or it deals with all that is related to human beings. Then they are told about anthropology and its several branches and also its relationships with other sciences (natural as well as social sciences and humanities). Every anthropology student in India studies the basics of physical/ biological, social/cultural and archaeological/ prehistoric anthropology, and afterwards a student gets into specialising in any of its subdivisions. The problem actually arises here and afterwards when the linkages are given a

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complete go by. Instead, some kind of one-upmanship takes place at this stage and each tries to vie against the other as rival disciplines, though they actually are not.

It is true that any growing discipline, like a family, tends to branch off and establish its independence from the other members of its family. It is also natural that each branch evolves its own course of events and direction (Srivastava 2000). Integration across its subdivisions can only be of a limited value and cannot sustain only on sentiments. The acrimony between its subdivisions is due to suspicion and lack of mutual respec ' towards each other. Each tries to score points over the other In fact, we do not need enemies from outside. Subdivision feuds like factional feuds, are its nemesis.

III

We have different approaches to look at anthropology and there are wide agreements and disagreements ?bout them. When we talk about British anthropology, biological or archaeological anthropology are never taught along with social anthropology. In most of Europe, it was social anthropology which was taught as anthropology. In this context, we find the influence of British anthropology, especially that of A. R. Radcliffe-Brown and E. E. Evans-Pritchard on Indian sociology through M. N. S 'inivas much more. Srinivas used to state that Indian culture does not permit the division of social anthropology and sociology (this he reiterated more emphatically in his key note address to the XI International Sociological Congress held in Delhi way back in 1986; see also Kolenda 2001). He believed that Indian sociology is more of social anthropology than sociology in the American sense. As the last student of Srinivas, I used to have discussions on this and he used to explain why Indian sociology and social anthropology are not very different. On the contrary, the Indian anthropology is shaped more on the lines of American anthropology, which encourages an integrated anthropology consisting of physical or biological, socio-cultural, archaeological and linguistic anthropology.

When we attempt to understand the state of anthropology in India we need to look at it at five levels: 1) the theoretical or conceptual; 2) of integration, or lack of it, across its different branches (emotive level); 3) the methodological; 4) of competence (level of meeting the challenges of reality); and 5) of leadership. A stock-taking on these levels, which are interdependent, will really enable us to understand the situation that we are in today and throw us opportunities to take corrective steps to espouse the cause of anthropology as a discipline to surge ahead.

At the theoretical or conceptual level, we have a handful of native anthropologists who have made some noteworthy contributions. By and large, we still continue to analyse our society and culture from a western theoretical vantage point.

The point is not to argue against the western theoretical perspectives but to look more inwardly. Why we were unable to develop our own theoretical or conceptual perspectives is really the one that we need to ponder over. Is it something to do with our curriculum or training? Or, is it something that we were not motivated to focus on? Is it that we doubt our capabilities of evolving our own perspectives to reflect on our society and culture? Where does the problem lie?

In India, physical or biological, socio-cultural and archaeological anthropology are prominent in their presence in the curricula of anthropology departments. Only a handful of departments teach linguistic anthropology in the country. Integration is really problematic even in those departments with all the branches operating. Some branches get more priority over the others in recruitment as well as in their operation. Physical or biological anthropologists claim that they can handle socio-cultural anthropology papers (Srivastava 1999, 2000), while the socio-cultural anthropologists will not be able to do justice in teaching physical or biological anthropology *as* it is science.

The problem is one of attitude. The physical anthropologists think that they are scientists and are superior to social anthropology, which they do not regard as a science. I witnessed this tendency in a number of contexts. As a matter of fact, archaeological anthropology is relegated by both physical and social anthropologists to a lower position, sometimes to the point of no relevance. When recruiting teaching faculty, preference is given to physical or social anthropology, in that order, and only when there are 'adequate' representations, archaeological anthropology gets a chance, otherwise it will be taught by any tone. In case of physical anthropology, the physical anthropologists would want that only specialists should teach the subject, and they claim the scholarship to teach social or archaeological anthropology. So the contrary should also be true in a logical sense, as social as well as archaeological anthropologies also require some proficiency and also they can teach the other papers as well. It is this attitude of some that comes in the way of real integration of the subdivisions. How can we talk of integration under such prevailing mental frameworks? An emotional talk of integration does not cut ice any longer. How do we overcome this to achieve a harmonious relationship?

We need to be more practical and have to work out the areas of integration which can be taught as such by persons from the subdivision areas together. In other words, we need to democratise our teaching and development of the discipline. This can be a beginning for the development of a more integrated discipline of anthropology with its core concerns more focussed, while the rest branch out and also develop linkages with the other sister disciplines. So there

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is really a need for an honest soul searching amongst us the anthropologist to whatever ilk that we belong to. Srivastava places some propositions before us in his writings on 'The Future of Anthropology' (1999) and 'Teaching anthropology' (2000), which merit some serious consideration.

This invariably leads us to the question of methodology and depth of enquiry in our quest of anthropological knowledge of our society and culture. Compared to all the other disciplines, anthropological method is more holistic, intensive, participative, and anthropocentric. For a socio-cultural anthropologist, intensive ethnographic fieldwork is the patented trademark. How much of it is in vogue today is a question mark. We hardly find any intensive fieldwork undertaken by students (Srivastava 1999, 2000) as well as most of the faculty today, who indulge in writing theses, articles, and books prolifically without undertaking any intensive fieldwork. To our horror, many publish articles with a week's, or less than that, fieldwork. With this kind of academic contributions how can we take anthropology forward? Some Indian journals do not even edit the articles, leave aside peer reviewing.

Let us face it. The quality of works is an important concern and so long as we do not give credence to it we cannot arrive in the competitive international horizons. The quality of some of the journals and the articles or bocks coming out from the Indian anthropologists of calibre are really far and few. Most of the publications are publications only on paper and are hardly referred to. If reviewed very strictly, they will get screened out at the entry level itself. Publishing today has become an industry. Editing volumes or plagiarised publications have become the order of the day. I am not against those who are making sincere attempts to bring out edited volumes with some focus and also not against those brining out anthologies of conferences. Under these conditions, where there are hardly any people concerned about the quality and depth of information, how can we expect anthropology to lead the other disciplines in methodological rigour? In fact, the others have taken to anthropological method while the anthropologists have completely forgotten about their own methods. In turn, now anthropologists make use of the short-cut methodologies and claim that they have in-depth information about the culture or society that they have studied. We need to introspect whether the same rigour of intensive fieldwork is also missing among the other subdivisions of anthropology.

This leads us to the fourth level, the level of meeting the challenges of reality or the level of competence. It is a truism that the level of competence is dependent on the depth and thoroughness of knowledge that we possess about the issues at hand, which implies that we need to have a holistic perspective of the problem and look at it from the point of view of the natives for discovering better understanding of the issues that are being investigated. The tendency to adopt some models evolved by someone else in a different socio-cultural milieu does not require any level of competence. This does not add anything to the anthropology of knowledge. The level of competence gets reflected only when we deal with the problems that are at hand rnor^ reflectively and conceptually. The level of competence is not dependent only on whether one is well versed with quantitative and qualitative methodologies but on the level of unchrstanding and evolving critical theoretical or conceptual points of view. The tendency among some Indian scholars is to find whether one has used any theoretical perspective, be it structural-functionalism, structuralism, Marxism, cognitive anthropology, postmodernism, or whatever you have, to qualify a work to be worth looking at. They forget the fact that there can be many other perspectives that one can have or may adopt a ctncoction of diverse perspectives or may have something new tried by the scholar that can merit for competency. We have evolved long ago from the apes and we do not need to copy anymore the others but use our minds to evolve better. Let us be different from Xerox machines.

Why Indian anthropology is in such a mess? The answer invariably will lead us to the question of leadership or lack of it. In other word's, there is a crisis of enlightened leadership that can rise above partisan and narrow considerations. Let us not forget that mediocrity breeds mediocrity. Let us take the bull by its horns.

IV

There are no shortcuts for a healthy development of anthropology. There is; need for serious introspection and we need to identify the problems and their solutions collectively. There is an urgent need today for capacity building at the level of the departments, updating curricula, reinforcing the fieldwork trädition and evolving collective responsibility. Anthropology is a science of democratic learning and sharing, and it is a humanising science. Therefore, there is no place for autocratic leaders at any level of its operation. Together we sail and divided we sink. No one, I am sure, is interested in sinking and, therefore, let hundred flowers bloom than have Strobilanthes kunthiana (kurinji, in Tamil), which blooms once in twelve years or a monocarpic plant which blooms once in its lifetime. ■

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WHAT IS NOT ANTHROPOLOGY?

by Binod C. Agrawal

In over a century of field based anthropological researches and later teaching have five high growth points. These dates are independent of European and American anthropological traditions though often influenced by intellectual fervour of both continents. There could be other milestones in Indian anthropology that I might have missed. These are:

(a) Inclusion of "Caste and Tribes" ethnographic description in 1881 Census of India leading to publication of People of India by Herbert Risley (1915).

(b) Starting of anthropology teaching at Calcutta University (1920), publications of anthropological journal -Man in India (1921) and world's first Cultural Anthropology text book (J929).

(c) Setting up of Department of Anthropology by Government of India (1945), later renamed as the Anthropological Survey of India.

(d) Setting up of Ethnographic and Folk Culture Society and starting of publication of The Eastern Anthropologist (1947).

(e) Holding of Tenth International Congress of Anthropological and Ethnological Sciences at New Delhi and in a dozen other cities (1978).

These five high points have had profound influence on the perception and performance of the emerging "colonial discipline" of anthropology until 1947 followed by independent India's anthropology that some of us have witnessed after 1947. The first three dates are reminder of "colonial anthropology" whereas the last two are symbols of strength and eclectic progress of Indian anthropology. The event of International Anthropological and Ethnological Congress in India highlighted the growing recognition of Indian anthropology.

PASSAGE OF SOCIAL TO SOCIAL-CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY

The second significant point relates to shift in i.he use of "Social Anthropology" on the pattern of British social anthropology to social-cultural anthropology under the influence of American anthropology without qualitative changes in the content and approach in teaching and research oi anthropology.

For the first time, Sarana and Sinha (1976), while reviewing Indian social anthropology, coined hyphenated term "Social Cultural" as prefix to anthropology. Both had American Ph.D. after having M.A. degree in Social Anthropology from Lucknow University. Since social-cultural anthropology has been accepted by anthropologists, the Indian Council of Social Sciences Research continued to review "Sociology and Social Anthropology" without serious efforts to recognize the new developments in anthropology. I have indicated this point to emphasize continual lack of understanding and integration of British social anthropology and American cultural anthropology in spite of several serious intellectual discourses by a number of Indian anthropologists, the latest being in the 2007 issue of The Eastern Anthropologist.

In retrospection, whether Indian anthropologists have benefited from social and cultural anthropology in improving the understanding of the Indian civilization or society is yet to be realized. I fumble in answering the question, as I do have fragmented and partial understanding of multilingual, multi-religious, cases and tribes of the Indian civilization.

LITTLE CONVERGENCE

Teaching of anthropology remained largely devoid of Indian ethnographies carried out by Indian anthropologists. I read T. N. Madan (1965) and K. S. Mathur (1964), excellent studies in the United States during 1964-66, while in India I read Evans-Pritchard (1940) and Mayer (1960) during 1961-63. Incidentally, Mathur and Mayer both had conducted their village studies in Central India as a part of their Ph.D. thesis (Mathur from Australia and Mayer from U. K.).

A bitter truth is that social or cultural or social-cultural anthropologists remained under the hegemony of British or American anthropology in spite of over hundred years of first hand field work, knowledge and experience of the village, caste, tribe, religion and topics they had chosen to study. In this context, it would be important to point out that intensive extended field work often has been absent in the research studies of the Indian anthropologists as compared to non-Indian anthropologists who carried out field work in India. Most of the field work was carried out by the Indian anthropologists as if the anthropologists were "non-Indian" or "outsiders". Very few could carry out field work as one being "native" who was studying his/her own caste, religion or region.

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In spite of this these glaring theoretical and some time methodological problems, anthropological field research flourished and expanded in the country though uneven and highly "personality focused" or "individual centred" programmes under the leadership of a few eminent anthropologists. Depending upon the individual interest, opportunity and research fundings, a range of studies were carried out spanning rural, urban, industrial, tribal, women, children and weaker sections in a number of geographical regions covering national spectrum. What was anthropology then could not be deciphered.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL RESEARCH

Today, in India, multiple research agencies like Anthropological Survey of India, State Tribal Research Institutes, Ministry of Tribal Affairs, university departments, privately and government funded social science research institutes, development departments to mention a few are all involved in anthropological researches, training and teaching. These institutions have diluted both theoretical framework and methodological rigour of fieldwork. The fashion of "in-depth studies", focus group discussions" and "qualitative research" all have replaced the serious intensive field work.

I have often fumbled and felt sad in front of the so-called qualitative researchers, who would like to have quick-fix answers to their problems whether in "market research" or "media research" or problem solving studies. I must confess, I do not know, what kind of anthropological research, I am asked to carry out? I often feel everything that relates to human beings, if studied, is anthropology. At the same time, I question myself: What is not anthropology?

SOCIAL AND CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY: THE INDIAN BRAND

Anthropologists due to lack of opportunities within anthropology continue to migrate into a variety of applied fields like health, family planning, media, communication, design, architecture, planning, rural development, management, information technology to mention a few. Each of these anthropologists has tried to expand -the scope of anthropology.

For example, a dozen anthropologists participated in anthropological field work spanning eighteen months period in seven linguistic regions of India during 1S74-1976. Since these studies involved evaluation of satellite television effects on rural cultures in 1976, Agrawal coined the term "Communication Anthropology" taking clues from Majumdar's anthropological study of caste and communication (1958 and 1958a). In order to support my view, I took shelter from the writings of Sapir (1936). Now, I find that a number of anthropology departments are teaching courses like "anthropology of communication" and "communication and anthropology". I now wonder "what is not anthropology", based on my personal experiences.

Similarly, a dozen anthropologists carried out anthropological field study of one year CLASS (Computer Literacy in School Studies) project in 1984-85. The computers were installed in urban school to understand adoptive behaviour and impact of computer literacy on the students in the school. Since then anthropologists have been carrying out a number of studies in the country during the last few years. The findings of these studies have influenced the educational policy and helped policy formulations of computer education.

I have been asking myself: What is not anthropology after spending over two decades in carrying out a series of research studies related to India's space programme. I have been able to use four major anthropological premises (namely, "holistic view", "process analysis", "emir approach" and "participant observation") in these evaluative studies of the impact of satellite television, computer and other technologies on the rural viewers, students and urban population of India (Agrawal 1978, 1981 And 1986)

TEACHING OF SOCIAL AND CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY-THEN AND NOW

Over forty years ago, in 1966, I got an opportunity to teach an introductory anthropology course to undergraduate students in an American university. I prescribed the then available text book (Sol Tax 1964) and supplemented it with a few other reading materials. After forty three years, in 2002, I again taught a course on introductory cultural anthropology which I have been teaching for three years since then as "summer course" in an American college. This time I have been using a text book by Kottak (2008).

During these forty three years, the anthropology that I studied and taught during my formative years, seemed to have changed so much that often I feel I am studying and teaching a new discipline. At the same time, when I think of some of the fundamental premises of anthropology I feel comfortable and at peace since these continue to be unchanged in social and cultural anthropology.

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At this juncture, it would suffice to say that both Social and cultural anthropology share common fundamentals to a large extent about the scope and methods of the subject matter. I have do doubt that social and cultural anthropology evolved two distinct approaches to understand humankind to fulfil different historical, administrative and intellectual needs in their respective countries. Since Indian anthropologists came in contact with these two countries, leaving a large body of anthropological knowledge of other European and Asian countries and followed these two traditions, exception being Karve (1961 and 1953) who had her education in Germany.

Since I left the American university department of anthropology about four decades ago, I have been involved in teaching anthropology in various institutions of professional and technical education. I have been deeply involved in the teaching and research schools of agriculture, architecture, planning, design and interior design. In all these schools, I have been offering courses of cultural anthropology and have guided diploma and degree theses.

The need to offer such courses emerged from the realization that art, design and architecture are material manifestations of cultures shaped by production technology and available raw material in a given environment. Architects and designers have been using anthropological theories and methods in their research over several decades.

My first course outlined for architecture students was titled "Architectural Anthropology". Similar courses are being independently offered in Europe and the United States of America. These courses are seriously taken by the students of architecture and design schools. Rappaport (1969) provided a cultural explanation for explaining the variation in house type/. Urban designers followed anthropological route to design growing needs of urban spaces in Asia and Africa. The closest explanation found in the anthropological literature is objectification of culture in artefacts and architecture which was thought to be the result of human behaviour and material. "That is, material artefacts were the material residue of culture, but not culture itself (Taylor 1948: 100).

Since Majumdar's publication of A Tribe in Transition (1937) having several editions with a new title (Majumdar 1950), no text book of Social Anthropology until Majumdar and Madan (1961) and collection of essays in the memory of D. N. Majumdar entitled Indian Anthropology were published in 1962 (See Madan and Sarana 1962).

Madan and Sarana (1962) made a pioneering attempt to bring together "Prehistoric Archaeology", "Physical Anthropology" and "Social-cultural Anthropology". In this book, the editors for the first 'ime used the term "social-cultural" anthropology which Sarana has been using in his writings since then (Sarana and Sinha 1976).

A number of text books in anthropology specially social and cultural anthropology have been published in Indian languages which are literally translations of some of the American text books. Recently, I reviewed a Gujarati text book in cultural anthropology which was trans-literation of. Man and His Works by Herskovits (1952). Similarly, a whole lot of anthropolojy books specially prepared for competitive examination are available. These books are collections of papers or chapters from various books. These books are prepared by Indian anthropologists and several unknown ghost authors with or without the acknowledgement of original authors. Several Indian anthropologists have been quite energetic and enthusiastic in preparing such books along with other social scientists. Without doubt these books are highly focused, examination oriented and edited as per the prescribed syllabi of national and provincial civil service examinations.

The content analysis of anthropology syllabi of selected universities support my observations vividly. However, these syllabi continue to reflect the unresolved issue of social or cultural or social-cultural anthropology. For example, Lucknow and Hyderabad Universities continue to teach social anthropology and not cultural anthropology though in outline of the course cultural anthropology is mentioned. Other universities call it social anthropology and continue to follow what was designed half a century ago at Lucknow University, Department of Anthropology. Since many professors were trained at Lucknow, they have continued to teach Social Anthropology and carried out field work with the help of Notes and Queries.

Since Majumdar's students went to several continents for higher studies in anthropology, they brought back with them both social and cultural anthropology. Social and cultural anthropology today as it stands is a unique combination of British and American academic thought processes. A critical examination of these unique combinations has been discussed in an article, "Culture" in Wikipedia, the free encyclopaedia.

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On the other hand the text book, Cultural Anthropology (Kottak 2008), which I used, reflected the Cultural Anthropology tradition of United States of America. This book takes the American perspective of anthropology and illustrates American cultural experiences and demonstrates cultural diversity both from biological and social perspectives. The topics discussed in the book based on the historical experiences of the Americans like "ethnicity and race", "language and communication" and "gender", "modern world system", "colonialism and development" and "cultural exchange and survival" have also been described and elaborated.

Cultural Anthropology in America since the very beginning included anthropological linguistics as a part of cultural anthropology. A full length chapter is devoted to "language and communication" which is generally ignored in India (Misra 2007). Cultural anthropology in American universities is context specific and is ingrained in the American way of life, whether it is marriage, family or religion.

On the other hand social and cultural anthropology in India is largely devoid of context specificity and Indian perspective. The Indian anthropology can be contextualized by prescribing The Nuer (Evans-Pritchard, 1940) along with The Dhurwa of Bastar (Thusu 1968).

This discussion clearly indicates anthropology continues to evolve and redefine its scope. Hence, it is difficult to indicate "What is not Anthropology". But certainly being an experiential and reflective knowledge, it has to respond to the contemporary needs in context specific situations. One example of "What is not Anthropology" was recently discussed by Dunleavy who in consultation with an anthropologist Anne Chambers felt that photo-journalism is not anthropology as it is not reflective and photo-journalists do not take time "to understand what the act of producing pictures would mean for them as well as for their subjects prior to the act of making images" (Dunleavy 2007).

I continue to wonder 'What is not Anthropology?'

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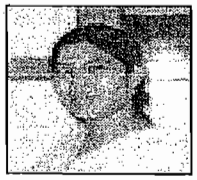
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